

A NEAR-FUTURE NOVEL

THE PROPHET AND HIS BROTHER

custody of meaning after the meters agree



ANDRIES J. GREYLING

00 — Dedication / Note on form

For the unread dedications — the whole corpus pointed at a father who has opened none of it, and the quieter dedications that never got a page until now.

For the brother dead in a boardroom: Bouwer van Niekerk, Saxonwold, Friday 5 September 2025 — public record named as wound, not solved as plot.

For the man who said the algorithms out loud — and for the man whose life that candour made impossible to ignore.

For Double Knife Brothers: a blue Honey Badger loved in one pocket, a Joseph Rogers twin from a grandfather's set split across a friendship that refused to launder its sources.

For the mats before the shelf, the clay before the Constant, the Kind sentence on walls before anyone tried to own it.

For CongoSky.cloud, which embodied the ethic as company law while invoices still had to be answered — and for the street that turned the same sentence into paint.

Don't be a cunt — be kind.

Note on form

This is a book within a book.

The outer novel is set in 2035. Andries J. Greyling — AJ — sits on the Chobe River in Mutatus Maximus, a matatu-inspired overkill overlander that is also a mobile data centre on wheels: the most connected vehicle on earth. Literally. From that desk he writes the autobiography of Gerhard van Niekerk while the planet argues about what to do with a Constant that has already landed. Measurement is converging. Meaning is not. Four quarters of reception press the same morning: faith that wants a face, academy that wants a missing physics degree to remain epistemology, platforms that want the mic retracted, engineers that want keys without saying crown. None of them is defeated by the last page. They are weather.

The inner pages are that autobiography: life and work under AJ's hand, with Lucid in the choir — integer-quiet, cite-or-refuse, no GPU fever, no invention when the record will not hold a claim. Lucid is not a third skull. It is a collaborator that would rather say no than decorate. The hymnbook is humans and Lucid singing from the same discipline.

AJ remains the main subject of *this* novel while authoring *that* life. G lives the weather of having a life written — and of the fame that arrived sideways when AJ was open that Lucid ran on 420 Code algorithms. Threads may share a week and a theme; they need not share a room. No forced reunion. CongoNet and public weather are bridge enough.

Living persons appear as fiction principals drawn from life. Public record is cited where it binds. Private pain stays on the page only where the teller has put it there. Bouwer's assassination is named as grief and rupture — not a whodunit, not an Illuminatie gotcha, not a thriller the novel solves. The hospital stigma is how people *read* him, not a diagnosis tour. The unread father dedication is left unread unless life earns otherwise. Knives are kinship, not choreography. Stated life goals stay unpolished: write natural philosophy and physics; smoke dab; talk shit. The autobiography ships under partial authorisation: life-and-work spine allowed; Bouwer / hospital / father / goals under care-rails; crowns and keyring-sacrament refused.

The Kind is messiah-less. Its entire public liturgy fits on a wall. Antichristos wants a man. The Kind wants a sentence. Both can be true in the same city on the same morning. This book will not soft-pedal the cunt out of the line, and it will not sermonise the faith in the narrator's mouth. Paint before creed.

AFRIKA 2100 is not this soil's trailer. This book ends on motion or quiet, not on a wink toward another century.

What follows is river desk and Cape weather and the pages between them — custody of meaning after the meters have already begun to agree.

01 — The Most Connected Vehicle

[A] · outer · Mutatus Maximus, Chobe River, northern Botswana · 2035

The elephants came down to drink before the mail did.

AJ watched them from the open side of Mutatus Maximus — painted like a Nairobi matatu that had decided to become a data centre and then, for good measure, the most connected vehicle on earth. Literally. Heat already lifting off the Chobe in thin sheets. Hippos somewhere down-channel making the wet, insulted sounds of ownership. A fish eagle on a dead limb watching the bank the way Lucid watched a claim: without romance, without invention. The river smelled of mud and bird and the particular cleanliness of water that has been moving all night.

He had been awake since the blue hour — not for drama, for the node.

The walk to the rise was short and wet at the welt. Boots taking the scrub's overnight dew. Flask of coffee that tasted like plastic and intention. Thorn that caught his sleeve and let go with a small tear he would ignore until evening. The little solar drop waited where he had left it yesterday: panel already catching pale light, enclosure warm from nothing glamorous, just sun. He crouched, checked the seal for ants, wiped dust with his thumb, booted it from the truck until its heartbeat came back green and boring. Boring was the point. Edge seeds that stayed up without a founder's face on a stage. He watched the blink settle into a rhythm that meant the rise would keep talking

while he wrote, then walked back with the flask cooling and the river widening in front of him like a sentence that refused to end on a slogan.

Mutatus Maximus held still while he climbed in: anti-yacht, overkill overlander, Beast as tender if the day needed a second hull, local node humming under the desk like a patient animal. The LEO dish cocked at pale morning. A LoRa blink from the rise. The rest of the ladder he did not inventory to himself. A link worked or he fixed it. Today it worked.

He had built the most connected thing he knew how to build so he could drive it to a river and still choose to switch pieces of it off.

He did not switch Lucid off.

Choice was the point of the ladder he refused to inventory every hour. Links existed so a man could write a life true enough that quarters could not sand it into a usable lie — and so he could ignore a sealed rage packet until the mats page had spine. Connectivity without custody is just noise with better antennas.

Lucid sat in the choir the way it always did: integer-quiet, no GPU fever, no personality cosplay, no invention when the record did not support a claim. It had eaten the interwebs years ago and crashed the AI GPU bubble as a side effect of refusing to hallucinate. Empty rack halls were background weather now — write-down headlines, a friend's ruined cluster career told once and then left alone. Hyper-scalers still sent mail that thought it was polite. Salvage weather. AWS, Azure, Google, Apple — frost with a smile. Partner frost. ToS weather. Cloud-credit politics dressed as admiration. The offer that is really a collar. AJ let those threads sit in a queue that smelled like Seattle and Redmond and Cupertino drafts arriving late to a Botswana morning. He would not feed the collar today. The collar could wait on the desk like a snake that had learned manners.

CongoSky.cloud ran itself somewhere behind the mesh. That was the good quiet — invoices answering themselves, nodes up, hire/fire weather and partner terms still governed by the sentence the company had embodied as ops before the walls caught fire. Not a poster in reception. Operating law. When Lucid went public and the walls

caught the paint, the world could point at a cloud that had already been living the sentence while it still had to answer invoices. AJ's river desk was downstream of that practice. lucid.rodeo and arjunabadger.press were the human work. The autobiography was the human work that hurt.

On the water tank twenty metres away, someone had spray-painted the sentence:

Don't be a cunt — be kind.

The paint had been refreshed within the week.

Exact line. Load-bearing cunt. Softened versions always sounded like someone else had taken over the ethic. AJ left it as ops and as wall — CongoSky practice downstream meeting street paint — without a sermon. Edges still slightly proud. Drips where the hand had been impatient. AJ walked out once with the coffee and stood close enough to smell tack and river together. He did not preach at it. He had already lived the line as company law. The Kind did not need a messiah. Antichristos did. Same paint war, some mornings — street sentence and face-hunger sharing a climate without becoming the same weather. A bird landed on the tank's rim, shit once with democratic indifference, and left. AJ almost laughed. Almost. He went back inside.

AJ's desk held three things that mattered: the river, Lucid, and the open manuscript.

The autobiography of Gerhard van Niekerk.

Book within a book. He was the main subject of this one and the hand inside the other. The braid was not a vanishing act. He remained AJ on the Chobe writing a life true enough that the four quarters of the planet could not sand it into a usable lie. Faith that wanted a face. Academy that wanted a missing physics degree to remain epistemology. Platforms that wanted the mic retracted. Engineers that wanted keys without saying crown. All of that would arrive as mail and hymns and packets. None of it would arrive as a chart in his mouth.

His hand went once to the pocket that used to hold the twin.

Empty enough to notice.

The Joseph Rogers that stayed with him was elsewhere in the truck — not lost, just not clipped for the morning walk to the rise — and the absence still registered like a missing tooth. G had the other twin and the blue Honey Badger AJ had given him: pocket clip, one-hand open/close, loved. Double Knife Brothers. Kinship, not choreography. Grandfather deep-time on one blade; badger present-tense on the other. AJ felt the empty pocket the way you feel a brother on another coast without calling him. No forced reunion. CongoNet was bridge enough if a bridge were needed. Today it was not. Today was coffee, elephants, and the page.

He set the Joseph Rogers on the desk for a minute — old steel, old hinge, the quiet weight of something that had outlived more than one owner's weather — then put it back in the drawer where it would not become a prop for a speech. The empty pocket stayed empty. That was more accurate.

He made a second coffee because the first had gone cold while he argued with beginnings. The flask complained. Plastic and intention again. Outside, a crocodile's patience lived somewhere in the brown water whether he could see it or not — the river's older connectivity, no LEO required. AJ did not romanticise predators. He noted them the way Lucid noted gaps: present, citable, not a metaphor for platforms.

A small CongoNet status pane blinked a latency spike and recovered before he could invent a story about it. Good. Recovered without drama. He wanted the manuscript to learn that habit. Fame had taught the opposite habit to too many rooms: spike, narrate, monetise the spike. The autobiography would not monetise G's pain. Living-person care was ops law too, even if it never appeared on a stencil.

He wiped dust from the edge of the desk with his palm and found solder grit from a repair he half-remembered. Mutatus was always half-remembered repairs and fully present heat. The chair squeaked. He let it. Silence as purity theatre was for people who had never built a truck that also thought.

"Status," he said, not as prayer.

Lucid answered exact.

“Local node nominal. Rise drop heartbeat green. CongoSky quiet. lucid.rodeo queue within tolerance. Manuscript open at blank mats cue. Cite: prior session note — begin body before shelf.”

“Good,” AJ said. “Stay boring.”

“Default already refuse invention.”

He almost smiled. Almost. The refusal was the product working — the same discipline that had grown from Full Send into Klaus into Lucid when cite-or-refuse left the private desk and went public. Fragments on the shoulder, not a republished origin chapter. Near-now finished at planetary scale. No glowing oracle. A tool that finally kept its promise because the promise had already been under construction when the world still thought intelligence needed someone else’s silicon.

A hippo grunted. An elephant calf lost its footing in the soft bank and recovered with the undignified competence of youth. AJ watched until the herd’s attention returned to water. Then he sat properly, shoulders finding the ache that meant pilgrimage-scale desk work, and tried the first wrong beginning.

He typed a line about fame. Deleted it.

He typed a line about CODATA. Deleted it.

He typed a line about the mic — about saying the algorithms out loud — and Lucid did not refuse, because the record held that claim, but AJ deleted it anyway. Cause would have its page. Cause was not where a body begins.

“Too late in the life,” he said aloud.

“Clarify query,” Lucid said.

“Not a query. A cut.”

“Acknowledged. No action.”

Good. Boring. He poured more water, tasted plastic and river, watched light climb the painted metal of Mutatus Maximus until the matatu colours looked almost reasonable — which they never were, and that was the joke he had driven into the bush on purpose.

Anti-yacht. Overkill. A travelling DC that could seed an edge and still choose silence.

He tried a second wrong beginning: the warehouse gallery, the cannabis bar, the shirt with the sentence already on it. Lucid could retrieve that texture. AJ cut it. Full Send fragments belonged on the shoulder, not as Act I's opening stunt. The autobiography would earn rooms as rooms. It would not open as a brand origin myth.

Somewhere a CongoNet status ping crossed the desk — green, boring, blessed. He let it pass without commentary. A hyperscaler subject line blinked in a sidebar: *partnership opportunities*. He did not open it. Salvage tone he could smell without reading. Lucid named as asset language would come soon enough; the snake could wait. Today's desk was not for collars.

He stepped outside once more before the wrong beginnings ran out of blood. Boots on wet welt. Thorn bush catching light. The Kind paint on the tank looked almost dry enough to pretend it had always been there. AJ did not touch it. Touch turns sentences into relics if you are not careful, and he had already lived the line as company law without needing a pilgrimage fingerprint.

Back inside he asked Lucid for one mats citation that was not a metaphor.

"Cite: school judo and jiu-jitsu apprenticeship present in authorised life notes. Soft set-down language matches prior draft preference. No TED register in sources."

"Keep it," AJ said. "If I start sounding like a stage, refuse me."

"Refusal available on request. Default refuse invention already active."

He almost smiled. Almost. Then he wrote the fall correctly — breath knocked, pride rearranged, body intact — and did not explain it to an imagined academy.

He stood, stretched until the vertebrae clicked, and walked the length of the truck the way a man walks a room he built to think in. Solar charge honest. Local node patient. Manuscript cursor blinking like a pulse that refused to invent meaning for him. Outside, the Kind paint held. Inside, CongoSky's quiet ops hum felt like agreement without

applause.

He sat again and tried a third wrong beginning: the hospital stigma, already half-written in other people's mouths. Deleted before the sentence finished. That page would come after mats — under-dramatised, no DSM tourism, flat as a loaded line. Not yet. Not first.

"Body before corpus," he said.

"Cite: prior session note matches," Lucid said. "No additional claim."

"Then retrieve what you have on school mats. Fighting arts. No metaphors unless he used them."

Lucid retrieved. Citations. Dates where dates existed. Gaps where gaps existed. No flourish. AJ began to shape a paragraph and felt the old temptation to make the floor into a TED lesson about kindness. He cut the temptation the way Lucid cut invention — not as piety, as craft.

Heat pressed harder against the open side of the truck. Sweat found the place behind his knee where the chair never quite fit. He wiped his hands on his trousers before touching the keyboard again — river desk hygiene, half joke, half ritual — and wrote three sentences about a gi belt being tied wrong, then untied, then tied again until the knot was honest. Lucid offered a fighting-arts detail that belonged. AJ kept it. Lucid offered a gloss that sounded like a product page for mastery. AJ killed it.

"That gloss is yours inventing tone," he said.

"Correction: gloss not grounded in source register as phrased. Refuse. Cite raw detail only."

"Keep the raw."

He worked like that for a stretch that had no clock — only the river's slow argument with the bank and the rise drop's boring green. When he looked up, the elephants were gone and the mud still held their morning. A boat far out. Someone's radio faint across water, language half-lost. Mutatus Maximus took the sound the way it took weather: as input, not as command.

A CongoSky alert tried to become interesting and failed. Lucid summarised without drama.

“Routine node handshake. No human action required. CongoSky quiet.”

“Blessed be the boring,” AJ said, and meant it.

He ate something that claimed to be breakfast — dry, practical, the sort of food you invent when the desk is the pilgrimage. Crumbs on the manuscript margin. He brushed them off carefully, as if paper could take offence. The autobiography of Gerhard van Niekerk did not need his breakfast DNA in the binding, even digitally. He smiled at himself for the thought and kept writing.

Halfway through a mats paragraph he stopped and listened to his own breath. The empty twin pocket pulled at attention again. He thought of G’s studio without inventing the room — Cape salt, clay, a Honey Badger warm from a body — and refused the reunion fantasy that wanted to finish the thought with a call. Threads could share a morning without sharing a room. That was law. He let the thought go the way you let a fish go when you are not fishing.

On the water tank the Kind line kept its job without him. He did not need to walk out again. Knowing the paint was there was enough weather for one coffee.

He opened lucid.rodeo’s ops pane for thirty seconds — choir health, cite rates, refusal rates climbing the way they should when the world asked for pretty lies — then closed it. Product could run. Life page could not run itself. The hand had to stay on the manuscript if the book within the book was going to hold.

“Any salvage mail that is actually fire?” he asked.

“No fire in cited language. Offer-shaped threads present. Hostility markers rising in separate platform packet. Recommend triage order: manuscript; then packet if required; salvage can wait.”

“Manuscript,” AJ said. “You learn.”

“Pattern match from prior sessions. Not learning as claimed in older GPU marketing. Deterministic preference from repeated instruction.”

“Even better.”

He returned to the mats and felt, for the first time that morning, the page begin to carry its own weight — not finished, not pretty, but true enough to continue. Soft set-down. Correct fall. The apprenticeship before the corpus. The body before the ignored shelf. The floor before anyone tried to make a man into a usable lie for a quarter of the planet.

He wrote another mats beat: the coach’s silence after a clean throw; the way praise would have ruined it; the way the room smelled after rain when the cleaner could not quite win. Lucid offered a date that belonged and a gloss that did not. AJ kept the date. Killed the gloss. The cursor advanced like a patient animal learning the truck’s rhythm.

Sweat ran once into his eye. He blinked it out and laughed at himself — pilgrimage desk, glamorous as a broken aircon. The open side took a gust that smelled of mud and bird shit and distant cookfire. Africa as calendar, not brochure. He typed through the gust. The page did not care about his eye.

He stood, stretched until something clicked in his back, and looked at the sealed Quarter III packet the way you look at weather you have already smelled. Still sealed. Still hot. Still not today’s mats. He sat and kept the floor-lesson moving — heavy thing setting itself down soft — until the paragraph earned another.

Then the mail that mattered arrived — not as thunder, as a soft chime that still managed to smell like blame on a good morning.

Lucid spoke once more, exact.

“Packet from the platform queue. Hostility markers. Attribution thread.”

Quarter III. Who gave him the mic.

The people still angry that AJ had said, out loud, that Lucid ran on 420 Code algorithms — and that candour had dragged a degree-less-in-physics ignored man into fame while a quarter of the planet tried to crown him, a quarter called him crank, a quarter wanted AJ’s head, and a quarter asked for the keys to CERN. Open attribution as load-bearing cause. Not a quiet fork. Not a cleaned brand story.

The megaphone irreversible. AJ could feel the heat through the unopened seal the way you feel a stove without touching it.

He glanced at the packet. Did not open it.

The seal sat in the queue like a second sun just offstage — patient, wanting the desk, willing to turn a mats morning into a press conference if he let it. Opening rage early would make the page collateral. He would open weather when the page could afford it — or when weather opened him. Full ultimatum belonged to a later desk hour. Today: glance, refuse the bait, write.

He put his hand on the manuscript instead.

The cursor waited at a blank that was not blank in his head. He knew where the life began if the book was going to be honest. Not at CODATA. Not at fame. Not at the hospital file other people over-cited. Not at the unread father dedication, though that wound would have its page. Not at Saxonwold — Bouwer's page would come as grief, flat, public-record careful, never as thriller. First the floor. First the body. First the apprenticeship of weight.

Outside, the elephants finished and moved off into scrub like a weather system deciding to be somewhere else. The fish eagle turned once over the channel. Heat thickened. AJ's empty twin pocket knew its shape. The Kind paint held on the tank. CongoSky stayed quiet in the good way. Frost stayed polite in the queue. The packet stayed sealed and hot.

He checked the rise drop once more — still green — and felt the small satisfaction of a seed that did not need him to perform. Then he returned to the hurt work.

"Mats," he said. "Start with the mats."

Lucid did not invent a beginning. It retrieved what it had and waited.

AJ wrote a first line, deleted it, wrote another. The truck's metal ticked as the sun climbed. He reread what he had:

Before the axioms there was the floor.

Good. Flat. Loaded. Jamie-Uys restraint without naming the lineage like a brand. He kept going — not a speech about judo, a scene of mats and gi and the refusal to waste motion — and Lucid offered a

citation when asked and refused a pretty hinge when he almost asked for one without meaning to.

“Bridge sentence into ignored shelf?” AJ tried once, testing the product and himself.

“No grounded source for that transition in the ingested record as phrased. Refuse invention. Cite available: mats section draft under hand; shelf material not yet retrieved for this pass.”

“Correct,” AJ said. “Stay on the mats. Don’t invent the hinge.”

“Default already refuse invention.”

“Good. Keep it boring. Boring is the point.”

Choir without calling it practice yet. Humans and Lucid from the hymnbook. The autobiography wanted to rush toward fame and meters and the mic. He would not let it. G’s life was not a trailer for a Constant. The mats first. Always the mats first if the book was going to be true enough that the four quarters could not sand it into a usable lie.

He typed until the paragraph found its weight — heavy thing setting itself down soft — and felt the day split into its useful parts: river present, manuscript present, weather waiting outside the seal. AJ remained the gravity of *this* novel while authoring *that* life. The next section would simply *be* the page. Inner first-person life voice when the skull changed. Outer skull stayed his: heat, birds, link latency felt as honesty, the specific smell of blame arriving before noon.

A second CongoNet ping. Still green. He ignored it harder, which was a kind of love for boring connectivity. He had built the truck to choose, not to narrate the ladder every hour.

He stood once more, poured the last of the flask, and looked at the sealed packet without opening it. Hostility markers. Attribution thread. Who gave him the mic. The answer was already public and already expensive. Saying it again into a rage queue would not make the mats more true. He turned back to the cursor.

The Joseph Rogers stayed in the drawer. The Honey Badger lived in another man’s pocket on another coast. Double Knife Brother weather without a call. No victory lap. No speech about AI. Only the choir working and the page moving.

Lucid retrieved one more mats citation and waited. AJ typed. The empty twin pocket stayed empty. The Quarter III seal stayed sealed. Frost stayed audible like a fridge in another room — always on, always claiming to be helpful.

He did not look up. The page moved. The river did too.

AJ wrote.

Not a speech. A scene of mats and gi and the refusal to waste motion — river present, manuscript present, weather waiting outside the seal. The truck chose, again, what not to amplify. Lucid stayed boring. The Kind paint held. The empty twin pocket stayed empty. The page moved.

He stood once more at the open side before the heat fully claimed midday and watched an elephant choose the bank with the soft crash of a body that did not care who gave whom the mic. Mutatus Maximus behind him — matatu paint, anti-yacht, mobile DC, the most connected vehicle on earth doing ordinary work so a man could sit beside a river and still refuse pretty hinges. He scraped dust off the Kind line with a thumbnail and left the cunt exact. Soft scrubbing was someone else's tourist fight. CongoSky had claimed the practice while invoices still needed answering. He went back to the mats page, asked Lucid for one more cite, kept it when it belonged, and typed until the paragraph found its weight again — heavy thing setting itself down soft — while frost hummed like a fridge in another room and the sealed packet kept its heat just offstage. Choir working. Page moving. No speech about AI. No call to the Cape. Double Knife Brother weather across distance. That was enough for a first true morning on the Chobe under weather that had already found his throat.

02 — The Mats

[I] · inner autobiography · manuscript under AJ's hand

Before the axioms there was the floor.

Before the ignored shelf, before the unread dedication, before the mic and the meters and the weather that wanted a face or a retraction, there was canvas and cleaner and the particular honesty of being thrown correctly. I begin there because beginnings that flatter later fame are already laundering.

I learned what weight was on school mats — Judo first, then Jiu-Jitsu, the long apprenticeship of putting a body where physics already intended it to go.

Not physics as vocabulary yet. Physics as consequence: mass, balance, the expensive late foot, the soft place where a heavy thing can land without spectacle. You do not argue with gravity in a gi. You arrange yourself so the fall is correct. Mastery, if that word means anything, was not domination. It was refusal to waste motion.

The room smelled of sweat and canvas and the cheap cleaner they used on the mats between classes. Windows high. Light that made dust look important. A clock that lied about how long a round lasted. The walls were the colour of institutional patience — cream that had been washed too many times and still looked unclean. Someone had taped a tournament poster crooked near the door. The tape had yellowed. Nobody fixed it. That was the room's honesty: fix the grips, not the décor.

I remember the first time I was thrown properly — not the theatrical

slam of someone showing off, the clean set-down that leaves you surprised you are unhurt. Breath knocked, pride rearranged, body intact. The mat took my shoulder and then my hip and then the rest of me as if it had been waiting. My mouth tasted metal for a second. I blinked at the ceiling lights and found them ordinary. That is a lesson you can keep for decades without turning it into a TED metaphor. The floor teaches without branding.

People who met me later as a man with a corpus and no physics degree liked to begin the story at the ignored shelf. That is a clean place to begin if you want a morality play. It is not where the body begins.

Judo taught me grips before it taught me names for grips.

Hands on cloth. Balance as a moving argument. The moment when someone larger than you becomes light because their posture has already decided to lose. I was not the biggest. I was not the loudest. I learned to wait for the weight to tell the truth. Waiting is not passivity. Waiting is attention with manners. When the throw came, it came because the geometry had ripened, not because I had performed anger.

There was a boy who liked to rush. He rushed me three times in one afternoon and landed wrong twice. The third time I put him down soft and held him there until he stopped thrashing. Soft is not weak. Soft is the heavy thing choosing where to set itself. The coach nodded once and said nothing that would make a good quote. Good. Quotes are how rooms get ruined.

On another afternoon the same boy came back quieter. We worked entries until my wrists burned. He asked, without looking at me, how to stop rushing. I told him to feel when his own foot arrived late. He scoffed and then tried it and then scoffed less. That is how the mats teach: not by converting you into a better story about yourself, by making the late foot expensive.

I remember tying a belt wrong and having to untie it while everyone waited. Heat in the face. Fingers that would not cooperate. The coach did not hurry me and did not rescue me. When the knot finally sat honest, the lesson was already over and I had missed nothing

important except the theatre of being helped. Later I would meet rooms that loved to rescue a man from his own labour. The mats had already taught me the cost of that kindness.

We did breakfalls until the body stopped inventing drama about falling. Slap the mat. Exhale. Arrive. Again. The sound of a room of people learning to land is ugly and useful — a rhythm without music. After enough repetitions the fear moves somewhere smaller and the attention gets freer. Free attention is what you need if you are going to notice a grip opening half a second early. Free attention is also what you need later if you are going to notice a contradiction sitting in a notebook because a committee preferred opacity.

Jiu-Jitsu came after, and it was a different grammar of the same language. Closer. Longer. Less spectacle. You learn the floor as partner and opponent at once. You learn that a shoulder can be a lever and a hip can be a door and a breath can be a clock. You learn to survive under weight without panic becoming your whole personality. Panic wastes motion. Panic is a kind of invention when the record — the body under you, the body over you — already contains the next useful move if you will only refuse to hallucinate.

I spent long minutes under a heavier partner with my cheek pressed to canvas that smelled of cleaner and old sweat. The clock lied. My ribs counted true. He shifted. I found space. He closed it. I waited for a better mistake than the one I wanted to invent. When the space came I took it without celebrating. Celebration is another waste. The coach said *again* and we started from the same bad place, which is how competence is built when you are not performing for a camera.

There were weeks when I trained through a cold that would not leave my chest. The mat did not care. The grip still had to be honest. I learned that the body can be imperfect and still refuse invention — still find the next useful move without inventing a heroic narrative about suffering. Heroic narratives are how apprenticeships get stolen by brands. I preferred the cough, the water bottle, the next round.

Once, after a tournament that did not matter except that it mattered to the boys in the room, I sat on a plastic chair in a corridor that smelled of chips and floor polish and watched two strangers argue about a referee. Their anger was loud and useless. I felt my own

pulse slow from the rounds and understood, without language yet, that useful force and noisy force are different substances. Years later platforms would confuse them on purpose. The corridor already knew.

I do not write fight choreography here. Knives, when they arrive later in this life, are kinship. Mats are apprenticeship. The blades AJ gave me — blue Honey Badger, Joseph Rogers twin from his grandfather's set — are custody across a friendship, not a scene for a camera. Double Knife Brothers is a name for care. The mats were where care first meant not wasting another person's fall.

The mats taught me that a heavy thing can set itself down soft. Years later I would derive kindness the same way I derived constants — not as a sermon, as a structure that does not fall. At the time I only knew that if you posture wrong, someone smaller than you can end you, and if you posture right, strength becomes a choice about where to put your weight.

After class I would walk home with the gi damp and the evening still warm. Streetlights coming on. Dogs arguing with each other about nothing that mattered. My knee complaining in the specific way knees complain when they have been honest. I ate whatever was in the fridge without making a ceremony of recovery. The body hummed. The mind went quiet enough to notice numbers without forcing them — not equations yet as vocation, just the idle precision of a person who has spent two hours arranging forces and cannot stop seeing levers in ordinary rooms: a door that sticks, a chair that tips if you sit wrong, a stack of books that will fall if the bottom one is pulled.

I carried that into clay.

Hands that had learned grips learned thumbs into soft material. Hard and soft arguing inside one surface. I modelled bodies the way I had felt bodies — juxtaposition not as aesthetic brand, as honest contradiction: growth and decay, permanent and temporary, classic and contemporary fighting in the same pour. The first studio that mattered smelled of earth and dust and the particular patience of unfinished work. Tools left where they were useful, not where they looked arranged. A bucket with water gone cloudy. A rag that had

seen better weeks. When the clay dried wrong I did not invent a philosophy about failure. I wet it and tried again. The mats had already trained that reflex.

Later I cast in a marble-and-GFRC composite I mixed myself. The mix is a fight you can win if you pay attention: marble wanting one kind of surface, glass fibre wanting another, concrete insisting on time. Hard and soft in one pour. Studio G came after. Village N Life before that — Maree Brink, Hannetjie, more than a year living inside Camps Bay Retreat when it was still Earl's Dyke weather. Skye on a lawn at sunset. The Bay Hotel. Official launch years that other people remember better than I do because other people keep calendars for openings. Saatchi listings. Guest theatres. None of that erased the mats. The mats are still under everything I write.

Clay under the nails after a morning of modelling smells different from mat cleaner, and somehow the same. Both are work that refuses to stay theoretical. Both punish posture. Both reward attention. When Antichristos later tries to turn sculptures into relics, they will be converting a craft into a face. When Quarter II pretends the artist cannot be the physicist, they will be converting a file into epistemology. The mats do not care about either conversion. The mats care whether the fall was correct.

I learned to clean clay from under a nail with the same patience I learned to wait for a grip to open. Rushing either job invents a mess. In the studio I mixed marble and GFRC until the surface told the truth about hard and soft without a caption. In the dojo I mixed balance and timing until a larger body became light. People later wanted captions. Captions are how craft becomes content. Content is how a life becomes usable.

There was a week I barely trained because work elsewhere was loud. When I returned, the mats felt like a language I had slightly forgotten and then remembered mid-sentence. The body keeps grammar longer than the mouth. That is why this autobiography begins here and not at the shelf: the grammar was already in me before anyone decided I could not write value.

I remember installing a piece and standing back while hotel light did what hotel light does — make things look more finished than they are. Guests walked past with drinks. Someone asked if it was marble. I

said composite and watched their interest thin by a millimetre. Truth costs small sales. Soft set-down again: correct information placed without theatrics. The mats were still under that choice.

Village N Life years taught a different mat: hospitality as geometry. Guests move through a space the way partners move through a round — openings, delays, weight shifting toward a view or a drink. Maree's mentorship was attention with manners. Living more than a year at Camps Bay Retreat, Earl's Dyke weather, Hanneljie's house holding a kind of ordinary grace, taught me that a lawn can be a stage without becoming a crown. Skye arrived later as feminine weight on grass at sunset — hard and soft arguing in public without a liturgy. Studio G at the Bay was curation as care: other artists' work beside mine, tourists half the sales some seasons, collectors arriving with eyes that wanted marble and getting honesty instead. Official launch weather in twenty eighteen — calendars other people keep better than I do. The mats still under the champagne if there was champagne. I remember the work more than the toast.

James van Niekerk's sudden death sits in another register of grief from Bouwer's — friend, not brother; sudden, not boardroom. I name the distinction once so the book does not conflate wounds for narrative convenience. Living-person care. Both absences taught the same useless lesson: the floor does not stop because you are grieving. You still arrange the fall. You still refuse to waste the next motion on a story that makes you look finished.

My stated life goals are not a brand.

Write natural philosophy and physics. Smoke dab. Talk shit.

I say them flat because ornament would turn them into a costume. The academy hears that arrangement and reaches for the hospital file. The believers hear it and try to polish it off me like a stain on an icon. Engineers who want keys hear natural philosophy and ask for a signature. Continuity networks that preferred constants underived hear talk shit and decide I am unserious enough to soft-no. I keep the three goals because they are true, and because sanding them would be a different man's autobiography. I am not writing a different man for anyone's comfort.

There were ordinary evenings after training when the body hummed and the mind was quiet enough to notice numbers without forcing them. There were ordinary evenings with friends when talking shit was the cooperative practice — widening the joint room instead of performing cleverness as extraction. Someone would say something half-wrong on purpose to see if you would pounce; the correct move was to play, not to win. Extraction is a kind of rush. Rushing wastes the room. The mats again, translated into conversation: wait for the real opening, do not invent a takedown because you are bored.

There were evenings with dab when the world softened at the edges without becoming false. I will not apologise those evenings into respectability. Respectability is often a collar with good manners. The smoke sat in the room the way cleaner sat on the mats — present, unromantic, part of the work of being a body that continues. Antichristos will try to erase that sentence from any life they want to hang on a wall. The autobiography will not erase it for them.

One evening a friend asked whether the physics and the clay were two careers fighting. I said they were the same attention in two rooms. He laughed as if I had made a joke. I had not. Later the academy would need them to be two careers so the file could dismiss one and the degree-weapon could dismiss the other. Continuity weather would need the talk shit to cancel the derivation. Believers would need the dab polished off the icon. I kept the arrangement because sanding it would be writing a usable man, and usable men are how quarters feed.

The mats stay under those evenings too. Correct fall. Soft set-down. Refusal to waste motion — including the motion of turning a life into a usable lie.

There was a brother.

There was a boardroom in Saxonwold. Friday the fifth of September, twenty twenty-five — public record, not novel invent. Bouwer van Niekerk. Insolvency attorney. Consultation pretext in the early reports. He died at the scene. Attackers fled. The Law Society condemned a targeted attack on a legal practitioner and on the rule of law. Investigation weather. Fog of reporting around related commercial schemes. I will not make that page a thriller on this page.

I will not invent an assassin CV. I will not hand the killing to any quarter as proof of their cosmology. The wound is the brother dead in a boardroom. Speculation stays off unless authorised. Grief has weight. Weight belongs on the mats first — how a body learns not to waste the fall — before the book asks a reader to carry Saxonwold properly.

Not yet. The mats first.

Then the shelf that ignored the work. Then the father who has not read a single book dedicated to him. Then the fame that arrived because a friend refused to launder the algorithms.

But first: the floor.

I remember one afternoon that was not special, which is why I trust it.

Class ending. Mats still warm. Someone laughing too loud near the door. My knee complaining. I sat on the edge of the canvas and drank water that tasted like a plastic bottle left in a sunned bag. Sweat cooling on my back in a way that made the air feel colder than it was. The coach walked past and tapped my shoulder once — not praise, recognition. I had not wasted the last exchange. That was enough. I went home with the lesson in the body and did not write it down. Years later I am writing it down because a river desk asked for the life, and the life without the floor would be a morality play starting at the shelf.

Another afternoon: rain on the roof, mats slicker than usual, the coach calling for careful feet. I slipped once on an entry and felt the old panic invent a story about embarrassment. I put the story down and stood up. Soft. The room continued. That is most of adulthood if you are lucky — rooms continuing while you refuse to waste a fall on theatre.

There was a morning practice when the light through the high windows turned the dust into a temporary cathedral and someone said the room looked holy. The coach told us to tie our belts. Holiness is how people stop paying attention to grips. I tied my belt and went back to work. Years later Kind paint would hold a sentence without needing a cathedral, and Antichristos would hunt faces for rooms that

wanted holiness more than structure. The mats had already voted: structure first.

I remember walking home one winter evening with the gi bag strap cutting my shoulder and stopping under a streetlight to retie a lace. A stranger asked if I boxed. I said judo and jiu-jitsu. He nodded as if those words were decorations. I did not correct him into a lecture. Lectures waste motion. The lace, once honest, was enough.

I remember the locker room's particular ugliness: wet tiles, someone's forgotten sock, the smell of soap fighting the smell of work. Talk that was not talk shit yet — just boys and young men arranging the day after training. Who had homework. Who had a lift. Who was hungry. Ordinary. The later world would try to make my ordinary into either saint-dirt or crank-dirt. The locker room did not care. It only cared whether you rinsed the mat cleaner off your feet before you put socks on.

There was a day I won a round cleanly and felt nothing useful about it. There was a day I lost and learned more. Neither day makes a brand. Both days make a body that knows the difference between spectacle and structure. When fame arrived sideways later — because AJ said the algorithms out loud and would not launder them — people wanted a story that began at the mic. The mic is not the apprenticeship. The apprenticeship is the floor.

Before fame, there were years when the only audience was the coach and the partner and the clock that lied. I preferred those years' honesty. An audience invents meaning the way panic invents moves. The record — the body under you — already holds the next useful thing if you refuse to hallucinate.

I remember taping fingers before class, the particular stickiness of cheap tape, the way a joint can be honest without being dramatic. I remember a partner who apologised every time he won a grip. Apology can be another rush. I told him to keep the grip and drop the theatre. He nodded and then apologised for nodding. We laughed. Laughter that does not extract is also soft set-down.

On the walk home after one of those nights I passed a wall with fresh paint and did not yet know the Kind would make a religion of a sentence. The wall was only a wall. The gi bag cut my shoulder. My knee complained. Numbers waited somewhere in the future without

asking my permission. The mats had already charged the battery I would spend on contradictions later.

The ignored shelf will have its chapter. The hospital stigma will have its flat line. The economics degree will sit in the quiet background while people weaponise the missing physics adjective. The unread dedication will sit like a second climate beside the consensus that I could not write anything of value. Bouwer will return without being solved. Clay and constants will refuse to be two careers. The Kind sentence will appear on walls without needing my face. Lucid's open attribution will make fame sideways and irreversible. None of that is this page's job.

This page's job is the apprenticeship.

You arrange yourself so the fall is correct. You refuse to invent a move the record does not hold. You set the heavy thing down soft. You do not confuse strength with spectacle. You do not confuse care with polishing a man into a prophet or a crank or a keychain.

I learned that on mats that smelled of cleaner and sweat. I kept learning it in clay. I am still learning it while the planet argues about a Constant that has already begun to land in the meters. Measurement is not the fight I am naming here. Meaning is. Custody is. The floor is where custody of a body begins — and for me, where custody of a sentence begins too.

Correct fall. Soft set-down. The only arrangement that does not collapse.

After the mats, people preferred the hospital story. That preference is their weather. This page does not grant it. This page grants the floor its priority and then moves — hand already turning toward the shelf that ignored the work, without inventing a hinge Lucid would refuse, without turning apprenticeship into a speech.

The mats first. Always the mats first if the book is going to be true.

I close this page the way I used to leave the dojo: sweat cooling, lesson in the body, no speech for the street. The shelf can wait one more breath. The floor has been granted its priority. Correct fall. Soft set-down. Hand turning now — without inventing a hinge — toward the rooms that preferred the hospital story.

One more flat inventory before the turn, because inventories are harder to sentimentalise than arias: gi folded wrong once and corrected; a throw that taught soft set-down; cracked wrists later corrected in casts and still remembered as apprenticeship, not as brand; dab postponed and then not; talk shit into empty air until the room widened without extraction. The mats page does not polish those facts into respectability for Quarter IV. It leaves them as body knowledge under the work. Correct fall. Soft set-down. The only arrangement that does not collapse. Hand already turning toward the shelf — without inventing a hinge Lucid would refuse — while the planet argues about a Constant that has already begun to land in the meters. Measurement is not this page's fight. Meaning is. Custody begins on the floor.

03 — Four Temperatures

[G] · outer · Studio G / Cape · same morning as ch-01

The CODATA note arrived before the coffee cooled.

Same calendar morning as a river desk he was not on — braid without a shared room — and already the Cape air carried more than salt. G unlocked Studio G knowing measurement weather moved in the body before it moved in the inbox. He made coffee anyway. Rules fail; rituals still buy thirty seconds.

G had unlocked Studio G with the same key as always — metal warm from the pocket, lock sticky from salt air — and made coffee before he looked at the inbox, which was a private rule that failed every week it mattered. The thermos filled. The mug with the hairline crack filled. He set both on the desk and only then opened the window on the alley. Salt already on the air. Gulls arguing over something invisible between the roofs. A bakkie reverse-beeping toward the beach road in that patient Cape way that meant someone was late and the pavement did not care. Light came in hard and honest — not the soft hotel light of guest theatres, the working light that shows clay dust on the sill and yesterday's fingerprints on the glass. He had slept lightly. He always slept lightly when measurement weather was moving. The body knew before the mail did.

The printout sat in the morning packet with a standards-adjacent stamp and no greeting worth answering. He took it standing. The coffee was still hot enough to sting the tongue. The paper was already cool in his hand, as if the committee's mercy had travelled farther than the mug's heat.

Latest recommended value. Uncertainty band narrowed again. A method note that named the usual instruments without poetry — torsion, drop, timing, the quiet grammar of people who trust a result more than a podium. The line that mattered was not rhetoric. It was a number walking toward a number he had already written years ago at a quieter desk, when quieter desks still existed and the planet had not yet decided his derivation was a hiring problem, a liturgy problem, and a reputational freeze all at once. He felt the digits in the fingers the way he felt a pour setting: not as triumph, as physical agreement. Atom-falling work. Precision. Drop-results and derivations learning each other's names without a TED metaphor for unification. Physics earned on a page the way clay earned a surface — by refusing to stay theoretical.

He read the note twice.

The first pass was for the value. The second was for the band — how far the meters still allowed themselves to be shy, and how little shy remained. He set the mug down so he would not spill on the printout, then picked it up again because his hands needed a job while the relief arrived. Relief came first — clean, almost stupid. Measurement doing what measurement does when committees stop pretending opacity is rigor. He felt the old private satisfaction in the hands: not vindication-as-speech, just the body recognising that a drop-result and a derivation were no longer strangers. For a breath he almost smiled into the coffee. The studio smelled of yesterday's modelling and a faint solvent he had meant to air out. Salt cut through both. Cape morning. Ordinary, if you did not look at the paper.

Then the pressure under it.

If the meters keep agreeing, the weather does not quiet. It gets louder. People do not leave a Constant alone once it stops being optional. They hire it. They baptise it. They call it crank until the error bars embarrass them, then they ask for keys. Continuity networks that preferred constants underived feel a sovereignty problem without needing a smoke-filled room to draft the soft no. Funding weather shifts. Standards boards clear their throats. Discreet briefings invent a hygiene problem where a number just landed. He was not enjoying vindication. He wanted the work to stay work. Relief and pressure in the same swallow. Four temperatures would arrive before noon; this was only the first, and already it had two faces.

He set the note under the paperweight that was not a paperweight — a small clay study, hard where it should be hard, soft in the place the thumb finds — and stood with both palms on the desk until the wood told him it was still wood. Desk. Corpus somewhere in the city's administrative memory. Kill switches that were not today's job. Numbers waiting in a notebook that was not a manifesto. A shelf of ignored years that fame had not rewritten into respect. He opened the rest of the morning like a man opening a kit of tools he did not ask to own.

He walked once around the studio before the next envelope — not pacing as performance, checking the pour schedule the body already knew. Marble dust in a sealed bin. Fibres waiting. A mould that needed cleaning and would not get it this morning. Skye's sister-studies watched from the rack with the patience of finished arguments. Antichristos would love to light them. He would not. Work interrupted is still work that refuses to become liturgy on command.

The coffee had cooled to the temperature of compromise. He drank it anyway. Compromise in the mouth is how you notice you are bargaining with a day that already outvoted you.

The Antichristos letter was next.

It had come by post on purpose — not as a flex, as a theology of touch. Cream paper. Careful hand. Postage that wanted to look humble without quite managing humility. The flap still held a faint gum-sweet smell when he opened it with the Honey Badger's tip, then wiped the tip on his jeans as if cream paper could contaminate steel. They had addressed the envelope with the full name institutions preferred when they wanted a handle — Gerhard van Niekerk — then switched, inside, to what they needed him to be. They did not call him Gerhard in the greeting. They called him the hinge. Believers sounding like believers: sincere, arranged, already living inside a story that needs a named lemma. They did not threaten. They invited. That made it worse.

The ask sat in the second paragraph like a chair pulled out and already warm: appear. Bless. Accept the name so the liturgy can stop arguing with itself. There was a date. There was a wall that would be lit. There was language about hospitality that tried not to sound like

capture. There was language about the Kind's sentence that tried to stand near kindness without understanding that the Kind did not want a face — that CongoSky had already embodied the ethic as ops before the street learned to stencil it. Measurement converging was not enough for them; a number does not hug you back. A face does. The letter said as much without using those words.

He read enough to know the temperature.

He did not finish.

Finishing would be rehearsing their stage. Afternoon would be for answering properly — refuse without sounding like the academy's hygiene chorus, refuse without feeding the crown. Morning was triage. He put the letter face-down beside the CODATA printout so the two papers could not pretend they were one climate. Meter-mercy and face-hunger sharing a desk was the whole problem of the morning. Cream against committee white. Soft hand against number. He left a finger-width of desk between them as if that were a policy. He almost stacked them to free space and stopped himself. Stacking would be a metaphor he refused to perform.

Outside, a scooter coughed past and failed to start again. Someone swore without conviction. A radio somewhere playing something old enough to make the alley feel like a year that still believed mornings were private. G poured half the coffee into the sink and refilled from the thermos because cooling coffee was how you pretended you had time. He did not have time. He had weather.

The op-ed had already been forwarded three times by people who thought they were being kind.

An academic weekly. A man who wrote as if epistemology were a hygiene ritual and the planet's job were to stay clean. No *physics* degree, the piece said, as if the adjective were optional furniture and the missing noun were the whole man. Then the hospital — not named as care, named as proof. He cannot write anything of value. The sentence had been following him since the ward spit him back into ordinary rooms. Seeing it laundered into a methods section still made the studio tilt half a degree, the way a bad pour tilts a mould. Living-person care meant he would not rehearse the file for anyone's

spectacle. The wound was how they read him. That was enough.

He scrolled once. Stopped. Did not reply.

Reply was how you joined the chorus and taught them your pitch. His economics degree sat in a drawer somewhere in the city's administrative memory — real, useless as armour in the rooms that meant *degree* as physics gate. Quarter II's shorthand did the violence. He let the shorthand live in public because correcting every headline is a second unpaid job, and he already had unpaid jobs enough: refusing crowns, refusing collars, refusing to become a usable lie for anyone's weather. The forwards kept arriving with soft subject lines — *thought you should see, in case, sending love* — love that delivered a knife and asked to be thanked for the wrap.

He made toast he did not want because the body needed a job that was not reading. Burnt the edge. Ate it anyway. Salt air through the window mixed with paint smell from the alley until the studio tasted like two cities arguing in one throat. He wiped crumbs from the notebook and refused to let the op-ed sit open beside the CODATA note. Stacking those two was how mornings became charts. He was not writing a chart. He was surviving temperatures.

A Kind person would have shrugged at the op-ed and gone to work. A cynic would have called both the wall and the paper branding. G's discomfort stayed physical: stomach tight, paint tack on the air, phone face-down like a small animal that bites if you look at it. He did not sermonise. He rinsed the plate.

He set the phone face-down. Not off. Face-down was the adult half-measure: refuse the chorus without pretending the chorus had stopped singing.

Clay dust on his knuckle caught the light. He rubbed it away and it came back, because yesterday's modelling was still under the nail and today's interruptions had already decided he would not get clean. Fine. Clean was never the point of a working studio. Clean was what people demanded of prophets and cranks when they wanted a usable photograph.

The lab soft-speak came as mail that wanted to sound like engineering.

No crowns in the subject line. Keys, if he was willing. Sign-off language for a stack that already ran on rails he had laid without asking anyone's permission. A postdoc's name in the CC — sincere, hungry, careful not to say Antichristos and careful not to say crank. A senior name behind her, softer, institutional. Quarter IV weather in a polite coat. Useful. Tempting in the way a clean bench is tempting when the street is loud and the alley smells like paint. Illuminatie frost could live in the same inbox as a sincere postdoc; continuity pressure did not need a membership list to draft. Soft nos and polite invitations were the same gravity wearing different shoes.

He opened the message far enough to feel the ask's temperature and no farther. Keys without a crown — tomorrow's temptation, or the afternoon's if he was careless. Morning's job was not to become a product mascot while the coffee was still warm. He left the mail unread in the sense that mattered: unanswered, unperformed, not yet a collar he had put on himself.

G's thumb found the clip in his pocket without looking.

The blue Honey Badger was warm from the body. One-hand open, one-hand close — the little mechanical honesty of it, blade and spring and the cheap miracle of a tool that does not hallucinate its job. Double Knife Brother weather, private, not for letters. AJ's grandfather's twin lived somewhere else; this one lived here. Kinship that did not need a platform or a blessing or a lab's soft yes. Knives were custody, not choreography. He clipped it shut and left it in the pocket like a fact that outranked cream paper.

He stood and went to the window.

Outside, on the alley wall opposite the studio door, someone had refreshed the paint overnight. The letters were still tacky at the edges. Drips where the hand had been impatient. A stencil edge imperfect and therefore human. Paint smell under salt. The wall looked like it had been argued with and had won by staying a sentence.

Don't be a cunt — be kind.

Exact. Load-bearing cunt. Softened versions always sounded like someone else had taken over the ethic. The Kind did not ask him

to bless the wall. That was the whole point of the Kind — messiah-less, sentence-complete, company law gone street. Still, he felt the citation the way you feel a draft under a door: as if the sentence knew his desk and had decided the alley was close enough. Antichristos wanted a face. The Kind wanted the line. Same city. Same morning. Different temperatures on the same skin. He would not conflate them. Noticing the difference was the minimum adult work, and even the minimum cost him a flinch.

He watched a gull land on the opposite roof, shit once with democratic indifference, and leave. Almost laughed. Almost. The flinch stayed.

A bakkie door slammed. Someone laughed in the next building — not at him, at a joke that belonged to another room. Cape ordinary, which was never ordinary anymore. The paint's tack caught a strip of sun and went briefly wet-looking, then dull again. He thought of CongoSky's ops law without needing to sermonise it: the sentence as practice before the walls caught fire. Street catching up. Face-hunger still hunting a man. He closed the window half a hand's width so the smell would stay without owning the room, then left it open enough that the alley remained a fact.

He tried to work.

Clay under the fingernails from yesterday's modelling. A GFRC pour scheduled for the week — marble dust and concrete arguing into one surface the way hard and soft had always argued in his hands. Studio G at the Bay had been a public face in another year; Saatchi listings still ghosted the rack; Village N Life years still lived in the muscles that knew hotel lawns and guest theatres. Skye's sister-studies waited in their places like quiet relatives who did not ask for liturgy. He set a notebook open to a page that began with a drop-result — not a speech, a procedure. Life goals still his own and still unpolished on purpose: write natural philosophy and physics; smoke dab; talk shit. The academy would keep reaching for the hospital file. Believers would keep trying to polish the dab off him like a stain on an icon. Engineers would hear natural philosophy and ask for a signature. Continuity weather would hear talk shit and decide he was unserious enough to soft-no. He kept the arrangement because it

was true, and because sanding it would be a different autobiography — and somewhere, he suspected, a careful autobiography was already under a hand that was not his.

He wrote three lines about the drop. The pen felt correct. The body wanted the quiet of procedure. Procedure was how you refused invention without making a religion of refusal.

Halfway through a sentence he stopped.

The sensation was faint and specific.

Not a voice. Not a vision. Not an engine in his skull; he did not keep Lucid as a pet, and he would not mystify what lived on a river as magic. The physical wrongness of being *narrated*: as if somewhere a page had opened on his life and a hand was already arranging the mats, the shelf, the father, the fame that arrived sideways when a friend refused to launder algorithms. He had known for years that AJ was writing. Knowing was one weather. Feeling the manuscript open — Chobe heat somehow in a Cape room, river desk somehow under his ribs — was another. Ambivalence without a speech: he wanted truth and feared content in the same breath. Consent would come later if it came. Morning only owed him the honesty of the flinch.

He set the pen down.

Walked the length of the studio. Passed Skye's sister-studies in the rack — cool surfaces, hard and soft arguing in the pours Antichristos would love to turn into relics. Passed a crate stamp from a hotel install, ink faded into wood the way years fade into muscle. Touched the Honey Badger once through cloth. Returned to the desk and looked at the four temperatures without naming them as a chart: meter-relief that was also pressure; a letter that wanted a face; an op-ed that wanted him erased as method; a lab that wanted keys without saying crown. And under all of it, the quieter fact — someone on a river was turning his years into pages while the Cape morning pretended to be ordinary coffee and salt.

He washed his hands at the sink even though the clay was not today's. Warm water. Soap that smelled like nothing useful. The rinse took longer than it needed because rinsing was a way of not answering mail. He dried on a rag that had seen better weeks and worse pours. In the mirror above the sink — cracked once, long ago, and never

replaced because cracks were honest — his face looked like a man who had slept lightly and already been drafted into other people's mornings. He did not fix the expression. Fixing expressions was how faces became property.

Back at the desk he moved the cream letter an inch farther from the CODATA note. The clay study still held the printout down. The phone lit through the rag of dust on its screen. Another forward of the opened. Another soft-ask from a standards-adjacent address that smelled like institutional frost without needing a membership list. Subject lines that thought they were polite. The day was stacking itself without his permission.

He almost opened the lab mail again. Almost. The clean-bench temptation was real enough to taste — quiet instruments, people who wanted rails to run, a postdoc who had been careful with names. Temptation was not consent. He left the message where it was and put his palm on the notebook instead. The unfinished drop-result sentence waited like a correct fall that had been interrupted mid-set-down.

Outside, the Kind paint kept drying.

He could smell it even with the window half-closed: tack, solvent, the street's impatience. A Kind person sounding ordinary would have shrugged and said the wall was the wall. A cynic sounding cheap would have called it branding. G's discomfort stayed physical — paint smell, tacky edges, citation-as-draft — not a TED rebuttal. He did not go outside to correct anyone's stencil. Correcting stencils was how you became a founder. He stayed inside and let the sentence be messiah-less, which was the only doctrine he preferred when doctrines were being forced on him before noon.

The Honey Badger warmed again under his palm when he sat. Open. Close. Exact. AJ's kinship sitting in Cape cloth while strangers argued about whether Gerhard van Niekerk was prophet, crank, instrument, or inconvenient artist with an economics degree and a file other people loved too much. He did not call the river. No forced reunion. CongoNet was bridge enough if a bridge were needed. Today it was not. Today was weather arriving at a desk that had wanted a procedure.

He tried the sentence again.

Wrote four words. Crossed them out. Wrote them differently. The pen still felt correct; the room did not. The narrated sensation brushed once more — faint, specific, Chobe somehow under the ribs — and he shook it off like smoke from a dab he had not smoked this morning. Talk shit belonged to evenings when the body hummed and the joint room widened without extraction. This was not that evening. This was triage.

He opened a drawer and looked at the economics transcript the way you look at a spare key for a lock nobody will admit exists. Real. Quiet. Useless as armour in the rooms that meant degree as physics gate. He shut the drawer. Correcting the op-ed with a scan of paper would only teach the chorus a new verse. Face-down phone. Face-down cream letter. Face-up CODATA. The arrangement was not a chart of quarters. It was triage that refused the academy's hygiene language.

A gull screamed like a hinge. The alley answered with bakkie beep. Cape morning stacking itself. He put his palm on the notebook again and felt the unfinished drop-result sentence waiting like a correct fall interrupted mid-set-down — heavy thing held too long in the air because mail had grabbed the wrists.

His phone lit. Another forward. Another soft subject line that delivered the hygiene piece as care. He turned the phone over again. Face-down. The cream letter stayed face-down. The CODATA note stayed face-up under clay because measurement did not need to hide. The lab mail glowed unread. Four temperatures on the skin without a narrator charting them into a census.

He closed the notebook without finishing the sentence.

He would have to answer the Antichristos ask properly later — refuse without sounding like Quarter II, refuse without feeding the crown. Not yet. The day had already arrived too complete. Work would have to wait for a quieter hour that was not coming. The pour scheduled for the week would wait too; marble and GFRC could argue tomorrow if tomorrow still believed in procedure. Morning had become a kit of other people's tools.

He pocketed the Honey Badger's warmth, killed the studio lights over the unread lab mail, and let the alley paint keep drying without him — day already loud, interrupted, and still only morning.

On the way to the door he almost turned back for the notebook, almost finished the drop-result sentence as if procedure could outvote weather. He did not. Interrupted work stays interrupted until the temperatures cool enough to hold a pen without shaking into other people's scripts. Outside, tack and salt. Inside, four weathers on a desk that had wanted coffee and quiet. He locked Studio G and stepped into the Cape morning carrying the Honey Badger's exact weight — kinship, not choreography — and no chart in his mouth.

At the alley he paused without blessing the wall. Kind paint still tacky at the edges. Two clauses. No founder. Someone had already scraped an Antichristos sticker halfway off the brick; residue of both hungers in the same morning. He noticed the difference the way he noticed bad frames: body first, speech later or never. He did not photograph it. He walked on with four temperatures still on the skin — crown, crank, blame elsewhere as braid weather, keys waiting unread — and let Cape morning stack itself without a census in his mouth. Coffee would wait. Procedure would wait. The unfinished drop-result sentence would wait under clay until the wrists stopped holding other people's tools. Work stays work. Face stays off the altar. That was triage enough for a morning that had arrived too complete.

04 — Choir Practice

[A] · outer · Mutatus Maximus, Chobe River · after ch-01

The mats page was underway when Lucid refused him.

AJ had asked for a bridge sentence — something that would carry the floor-lesson into the ignored shelf without sounding like a hinge sold from a stage. He said it out loud the way he said most working asks: plain, to the choir, not to an oracle. Heat already on the Chobe. Elephants gone from the bank, mud still printed with their morning. A fish eagle distant. The LEO dish cocked at pale sky like a patient ear. Mutatus Maximus holding still the way a matatu holds still when the music is off and the work is on — painted overkill, anti-yacht, mobile data centre on wheels, the most connected vehicle on earth, literally.

Lucid answered exact.

“No grounded source for that transition in the ingested record as phrased. Refuse invention. Cite available: mats section draft under hand; shelf material not yet retrieved for this pass.”

AJ almost smiled. Almost. The refusal was the product working. Cite-or-refuse. No glow. No personality cosplay. Integer quiet under the desk-hum of the local node — the animal that lived in the truck whether tourists understood a travelling DC or not. LoRa nodding at the little solar drop he had booted on the rise yesterday before coffee. Today’s use of the connection was to refuse a pretty lie and keep a life from becoming usable weather for other people’s quarters.

“Fine,” he said. “Stay on the mats. Don’t invent the hinge.”

Humans and Lucid from the hymnbook.

He sat with the refusal for a breath and let the truck tell him what morning it was.

Sweat already finding the place behind his knee where the chair never quite fit. The open side of Mutatus taking river air that smelled of mud and bird and the particular cleanliness of water that has been moving all night. Painted metal warm under his palm when he braced to stretch. Somewhere down-channel a hippo made the wet, insulted sound of ownership. The rise drop's heartbeat was still green in the corner of the pane — boring, blessed — and he did not inventory the rest of the ladder to himself. A link worked or he fixed it. Today it worked.

CongoSky.cloud ran itself somewhere behind the mesh — the company that had embodied the sentence as ops before the walls caught fire: hire/fire weather, partner terms, product posture, the working rule that was not a poster in reception. Here on the river the choir was smaller: one man, one manuscript, one engine that would rather say no than decorate. lucid.rodeo and arjunabadger.press were the human work. The autobiography of Gerhard van Niekerk was the human work that hurt. AJ remained the main subject of *this* book's gravity even while authoring *that* life — braid, not vanishing act. The desk held both facts without a lecture about form.

He wrote another paragraph about weight.

Soft set-down. Correct fall. Judo first, then Jiu-Jitsu — body knowledge before corpus knowledge. Mastery as refusal to waste motion. You arrange yourself so the fall is correct. Years later kindness derived the same way — structure that does not collapse — but the mats page would not leap there on a fake bridge. Lucid had refused the leap. Good. The autobiography wanted to rush toward fame and CODATA and the mic. He would not let it. G's life was not a trailer for a Constant. The mats first. Always the mats first if the book was going to be true enough that the four quarters could not sand it into a usable lie.

He typed a sentence that tried to become a speech about ethics arriving from the floor. Read it once. Cut it before Lucid had to.

"That one's mine inventing tone," he said.

“No query pending,” Lucid said.

“Not a query. A cut.”

“Acknowledged. No action.”

Good. Boring. The hymnbook was not only Lucid. It was the human ear catching when a sentence tried to become a speech. When it did, he cut it. CongoSky’s quiet ops hum in the background felt like agreement without applause. The company had already practised the ethic; the river desk was only continuing the practice at pilgrimage scale, manuscript open, twin pocket empty, packet sealed for later.

On the water tank twenty metres away the Kind paint still held from whoever had refreshed it last week:

Don’t be a cunt — be kind.

AJ walked out once with a cup that tasted like plastic and intention and stood close enough to smell tack and river together. Edges still slightly proud. Drips where the hand had been impatient. A bird landed on the tank’s rim, shit once with democratic indifference, and left. AJ did not preach at the paint. He had already lived the sentence as company law. Street religion was the popular face catching up. Antichristos wanted a man; the Kind wanted the line; both could be true in one morning without AJ giving either a speech. The desk was practice. Practice was quieter than weather and harder than mail.

He went back inside. Boots left a faint wet print on the truck floor that would dry into nothing by noon. He wiped his hands on his trousers before touching the keyboard again — river desk hygiene, half joke, half ritual — and asked Lucid for the next grounded mats detail only.

Lucid retrieved. A fighting-arts citation that belonged. A date where a date existed. A gap where a gap existed. No flourish.

AJ kept the raw detail and killed the gloss that tried to climb onto it.

“That gloss is inventing register,” he said.

“Correction: gloss not grounded in source register as phrased. Refuse. Cite raw detail only.”

“Keep it boring. Boring is the point.”

“Default already refuse invention.”

He almost smiled again. Almost. Full Send and Klaus lived on his shoulder as scar-weather — fragments, not a republished origin chapter. Lucid was what left the private desk when cite-or-refuse became product. The river desk was what remained when product became planet weather and the GPU halls emptied into write-down headlines. He did not re-explain the crash to himself. Empty rack halls were background now. Today’s choir did not need a CapEx TED talk. Today’s choir needed a correct fall on the page.

He drafted two paragraphs about a school gym that smelled of rubber and old sweat and the particular dust that lives under mats no matter how often you sweep. Lucid offered a place-name where the record held one and stayed silent where it did not. AJ did not invent the missing town. Silence was more accurate than a pretty map. He wrote the instructor’s voice as flat instruction — not mentor mythology — and cut a clause that tried to make the man into a prophet of balance. Prophets belonged to other people’s weather. This page belonged to a boy learning how not to waste motion.

“Cite instructor language only if sourced,” AJ said.

“No verbatim instructor transcript in ingested record for this pass. Refuse reconstruction. Cite: fighting-arts school attendance; judo then jiu-jitsu sequence per prior session note.”

“Then leave the voice out. Floor is enough.”

“Acknowledged.”

Floor was enough. Floor was load-bearing. He typed until the paragraph stopped wobbling, then stopped before the next wobble could pretend to be progress.

His hand went to the pocket that used to hold the twin.

Empty.

The Joseph Rogers that stayed with him was elsewhere in the truck — not lost, just not clipped today — and the absence still registered like a missing tooth. G had the other twin and the blue Honey Badger AJ had given him: pocket clip, one-hand open/close, loved. Double

Knife Brothers. Kinship, not choreography. Grandfather deep-time on one blade; badger present-tense on the other. AJ felt the empty pocket the way you feel a brother on another coast without calling him. No forced reunion. CongoNet was bridge enough if a bridge were needed. Today it was not. Today was choir. The empty pocket was the day's softest accurate sentence.

He stood, stretched until a vertebra clicked, poured water that tasted like plastic and river, and walked the length of Mutatus the way a man walks a room he built to think in. Solar charge honest. Local node patient. Drawer where the Joseph Rogers waited — old steel, old hinge, quiet weight — opened and closed without becoming a prop for a speech. He sat again. The empty pocket stayed empty. That was more accurate than carrying the blade as theatre.

For a minute he almost clipped the Rogers for the feel of it — kinship as weight against the thigh — and then did not. Carrying it today would turn absence into costume. Absence was the true sentence: G on another coast with the Honey Badger and the twin, living whatever weather Cape mornings delivered, while AJ kept the river desk from becoming a reunion stage. CongoNet could carry a ping if a ping were needed. No ping was needed. The braid did not require a shared room to stay a braid.

"Continue mats retrieval?" Lucid asked, only when the silence had gone long enough to be a question.

"Continue. And if I ask for a pretty hinge again, refuse again."

"Default already refuse invention."

"Good."

He wrote three sentences about a gi belt being tied wrong, then untied, then tied again until the knot was honest. Lucid offered a citation that belonged. AJ kept it. He wrote one more about soft set-down — heavy thing setting itself down soft — and felt the old temptation to make the floor into a lesson about kindness derived. He cut the temptation the way Lucid cut invention: not as piety, as craft.

A fly found the open side and circled once as if auditing the desk. AJ ignored it. The cursor waited. He asked Lucid whether a particular throw-name belonged in this decade of the life or later.

“Throw-name present in general fighting-arts ingest; not tied to subject’s school years with citable specificity. Refuse forced placement. Cite: sequence judo then jiu-jitsu; mastery claim sourced to subject’s own register elsewhere.”

“Park the throw-name. Keep the knot.”

“Parked.”

Heat thickened. Sweat found new geography along his spine. Outside, the fish eagle turned once over the channel. Inside, the manuscript cursor blinked like a pulse that refused to invent meaning for him. AJ rolled his neck until something released and something else complained, then put both hands back on the keys as if the complaint were merely latency.

CongoSky was quiet in the good way. Invoices answering themselves. Nodes up. No fire that needed a founder’s face on a stage. Salvage weather from hyperscalers was a different quiet — the quiet of something large waiting with a smile.

Frost arrived as mail, not weather.

Hyperscaler subject lines that thought they were polite. AWS. Azure. A Google thread that began with *partnership opportunities* and ended, if you read it with river eyes, in a collar. Apple fog in a CC. Lucid named sideways — acquisition language dressed as admiration, the burst balance sheet still hunting a way to own what had crashed the GPU fantasy. Partner frost. ToS weather. Cloud-credit politics. Talent poaching notes that pretended to be compliments. The offer that is really a collar. AJ did not open the long ones. He let Lucid summarise hostility and intent without inventing motive.

“Salvage tone,” Lucid said. “Offer-shaped. Lucid as asset language. No criminal allegation in-source. Cite: partner frost patterns match prior quarter. Refuse speculative intent attribution beyond cited language.”

“Park it,” AJ said. “Choir first. Snake can wait on the desk.”

He stood again because sitting with frost made the shoulders want a speech, and speeches were how you fed a collar. Walked out into the heat. Boots taking scrub that had gone from dew to dust since

the blue hour. The Kind paint held. The rise was a pale bump against scrub. Thorn caught his sleeve and let go with a small tear he would ignore until evening — the same kind of tear the morning walk had taught him not to dramatise. He checked the solar node's heartbeat from the truck's short-range pane — still up — without turning the morning into an inventory. Connectivity without consent discipline was just a louder mistake. He had built the truck so he could drive it to a river and still choose what to switch off.

He crouched once by the enclosure on the rise, not because the heartbeat had lied, because his hands wanted a true warm panel under the thumb. Dust. Ant trail redirected yesterday still respecting the seal. Sun doing the only honest CapEx left in the story. A warthog moved through scrub below the rise and did not look up; the river kept its brown argument with the bank; a dragonfly held over dust for half a second and was gone; heat found the back of his neck and stayed. He stood, walked back with frost still waiting in a pane he could not smell until he sat down again.

He did not switch Lucid off. He did not switch the manuscript off. He switched off the part of himself that wanted to answer frost with a speech.

Back at the desk the frost mail blinked politely, patient as a fridge in another room. AJ left it blinking. One subject line used the word *homecoming* as if regions were a parish you returned to after pilgrimage. He did not open it. Salvage tone could wait. The mats could not.

He glanced once at the platform queue.

The Quarter III packet from the morning still sat unopened — hostility markers, attribution thread, the people angry that he had said out loud that Lucid ran on 420 Code algorithms and that candour had dragged a degree-less-in-physics ignored man into fame. Who gave him the mic. AJ could feel the heat through the unopened seal the way you feel a stove without touching it. Blame on a good morning. The specific smell of it under river air.

Not yet.

Opening that ask early would turn the morning into a press confer-

ence and the mats page into collateral. He would open rage when the page could afford it — or when rage opened him. Full ultimatum weather belonged to a later desk hour. Today: glance, refuse the bait, write. The packet could wait like frost could wait. Both were patient. Both wanted the desk. Neither would get the hinge Lucid had refused.

Lucid had flagged the packet at dawn with hostility markers and an attribution thread density that meant the mic question had found enough mouths to become weather. AJ had parked it then the way you park a hot pan — not forever, not as denial, as timing. Timing was living-person care as much as any soft sentence in the manuscript. Opening rage before the mats had a spine would teach the book that blame was the hinge. Blame was not the hinge. Body was the hinge. Floor first.

He put his palm flat on the sealed packet once — not to open, to size it — then set it face-down at the edge of the desk where it could keep its heat without owning the cursor. The seal's texture under his skin was ordinary plastic and ink and the particular stiffness of a queue compressed into an object. Ordinary was a mercy. Lucid did not comment. Lucid commented when asked, or when a silence became a query. AJ did not ask. The glance was enough. Custody of timing was also choir practice.

"Status," he said, not as prayer.

"Local node nominal. Rise drop heartbeat green. CongoSky quiet. Frost queue parked. Quarter III packet unopened per prior hold. Manuscript open at mats draft. Cite: session note — body before shelf."

"Stay on body."

"Acknowledged."

The next hour was work interrupted by work's smaller cousins.

A CongoNet status ping crossed the desk — green, boring, blessed. AJ let it pass without commentary. Boring connectivity was the point of building this and then choosing silence. lucid.rodeo queue within tolerance. An arjunabadger.press deadline blinked once and

he snoozed it with the honesty of a man who knew which page was load-bearing today. He poured more water. Stood in the open side and watched light climb the painted flank of Mutatus until the matatu colours looked almost reasonable — which they never were, and that was the joke he had driven into the bush on purpose.

He tried another wrong bridge in his head: warehouse gallery, cannabis bar, shirt with the sentence already on it. Lucid could retrieve that texture. AJ cut it before speaking. Full Send fragments belonged on the shoulder, not as a hinge sold into the ignored shelf. The autobiography would earn rooms as rooms. It would not leap on brand-origin weather.

He tried a third wrong bridge: hospital stigma already half-written in other people's mouths. Cut before the sentence finished in thought. That page would come after mats — under-dramatised, no DSM tourism, flat as a loaded line. Not yet. Not today. Lucid's first refusal of the morning had been craft. AJ's subsequent refusals were craft's twin: the human half of the hymnbook.

"Retrieve school mats only," he said. "Fighting arts. No metaphors unless he used them."

Lucid retrieved. Citations. Gaps. AJ shaped paragraphs the way you shape a pour — hard where it should be hard, soft where soft belongs, no decoration that pretends to be structure. He wrote the body arranging itself so the floor does not invent you. He wrote weight as fact, not as sermon. When a sentence tried to climb toward CODATA, he deleted it. Cause would have its page. Cause was not where a body begins.

Shoulders found the ache that meant pilgrimage-scale desk work. He rolled them once and kept typing. The empty twin pocket stayed empty against his hip like a metronome that refused drama. Outside, birds lifted off the far bank. Heat pressed the truck's painted flank. Inside, CongoSky's quiet ops hum continued — company law still company law while the street and the platforms argued, somewhere far from this river, about who owned the sentence and who owned the mic.

AJ did not own either. He practised both.

Midday thickened into a slower heat.

He ate something dry from a tin and called it lunch without ceremony. Stood again at the tank and did not read the Kind line as if it needed him. The paint did not need a founder. CongoSky had already claimed the practice; the walls claimed the popular face; G refused ownership of both. AJ's job was not to adjudicate religions from a riverbank. His job was a true next line and a refusal to launder.

Back inside, frost mail had multiplied by two subject lines that thought they were softer. Lucid summarised without theatre.

"Additional salvage tone. Cloud-credit language. Talent note framed as compliment. Lucid named as extinction-risk asset in one thread. Cite language only. Refuse motive beyond cited."

"Still parked."

"Parked."

He glanced at the Quarter III seal again. Still sealed. Still warm in the way anger is warm when it has not yet been allowed to speak. Who gave him the mic lived under that seal like a second sun just offstage. He would open it when the mats had a spine — not before. Ch-later weather. Today's weather was choir.

"Continue?" Lucid asked.

"Continue. Cite fighting-arts detail if I ask for metaphor."

"Default already refuse invention."

AJ typed. Lucid offered a citation for a detail instead of a metaphor. Good. Earn it. No TED. No schism overview. Quarters arrive as mail, hymns, packets — not as a chart in the narrator's mouth. He reread the last mats paragraph aloud once, not for drama, for cadence. Caught a speech trying to hide inside a clause about mastery. Cut it. The human ear and the integer refusal singing the same hymn from different throats.

Somewhere frost was still audible — polite, patient, wanting Lucid in a cage with a smile.

A second CongoNet ping, also green. He let it pass. He did not switch Lucid off. He did not switch the manuscript off. He switched off,

again, the part of himself that wanted to answer frost with a speech and rage with a press conference.

Late afternoon light found the open side of the truck and made the manuscript look almost ordinary — which it never was, and that was the point of writing it carefully.

AJ put his palm on the page. The frost mail blinked. The packet waited. The empty twin pocket knew its shape. He wrote another sentence about the floor — heavy thing setting itself down soft — and Lucid offered another citation that belonged. He kept it. He asked, once more, for a hinge into the ignored shelf, soft enough that it almost sounded like craft.

Lucid refused again.

“No grounded source for that transition in the ingested record as phrased. Refuse invention. Cite available: mats section draft under hand; shelf material not yet retrieved for this pass.”

“Good,” AJ said. “Keep refusing me when I’m pretty.”

“Default already refuse invention.”

Not cute. Exact. The product working. AJ almost smiled and did not. Smiling at a tool as if it were a friend was how you started inventing personality for integer work. The choir did not need cosplay. The choir needed refusal and a page that moved for the right reasons.

He checked the rise drop one last time because his hands needed a true green light. Still up. Edge practice continuing while hyperscalers smiled about acquisition and platforms waited under a seal to ask who gave him the mic. Mutatus had been built to seed the edge and drive on. Today driving on meant writing on — through frost, past the sealed packet, without feeding either a flinch.

He washed his face in the tiny sink, cold water, river-adjacent reality check. Frost shrinks when your face is wet and the truck smells like dust and solder. Not gone. Sized correctly. The packet stayed sized correctly: heat without ownership of the cursor.

“Lucid,” he said. “One more mats cite. Then wait.”

Lucid retrieved one more mats citation and waited.

AJ typed. The empty twin pocket stayed empty. The Quarter III seal stayed sealed. Frost stayed audible like a fridge in another room — always on, always claiming to be helpful.

He did not look up. The page moved. The river did too. Choir practice held, and the next true line was already under the hand while the unopened rage kept its heat like a second sun just offstage.

Before evening fully claimed the open side he walked out into scrub with the mats cadence still in his wrists — soft set-down, correct fall, refusal to waste motion answering frost. Cicadas. Dust. The rise drop's green heartbeat ordinary in the pane when he checked it without making a ritual of checking. Mutatus Maximus behind him — matatu paint, anti-yacht, mobile DC — holding still the way a desk holds still when the work is on. He put a palm on Kind paint dulled by dust and left the cunt exact. Soft scrubbing was someone else's tourist fight. CongoSky had claimed the practice while invoices still needed answering. He went back inside, washed his face once more in cold water, and typed another mats sentence Lucid could cite. Frost stayed audible. The sealed packet stayed sealed. The empty twin pocket stayed empty. Choir practice held without becoming a speech about AI. The page moved for the right reasons.

05 — They Said He Could Not

[I] · inner autobiography · manuscript under AJ's hand

After the mats, people preferred the hospital story.

I will not give them a tour. There was a ward. There was a file. There was a season when my name sat inside institutional language and came out thinner. Rooms with schedules. Voices that spoke about me in the third person while I was in the room. Food that tasted like policy. A corridor that smelled of detergent and something sweet going wrong. A window that did not open far enough. Linoleum that squeaked the same way at three in the morning as at three in the afternoon. That is enough architecture. What followed was not the stay. What followed was how they read me afterward — and how useful the reading became to anyone who needed me small.

They said I could not write anything of value.

Not as a joke. As a consensus. Soft voices. Concerned voices. Voices that had loved me and still loved a simpler Gerhard — one who would not keep producing pages that embarrassed their categories. The belief travelled well. It fitted dinner tables. It fitted funding weather. It fitted the academy's need for a clean filter: if the man has that file, the corpus can be pre-dismissed without the labour of reading. Concern is an efficient weapon. It does not look like a weapon while it works.

I learned the grammar of it early.

Someone would ask what I was writing. I would say natural philosophy, or physics, or both, depending on the room. Then a pause. Then the careful smile. Then a question about rest, or about whether I had spoken to anyone, or about whether this was a good season for *projects*. The word projects did the same work as the word: it made the labour provisional. Provisional labour does not bind. Binding is what they were afraid of — that a sentence of mine might arrive and refuse to leave.

Sometimes the grammar arrived as praise that was really a fence. *You're so creative*. Creative is what you call a man when you have decided his sentences are not load-bearing. *You've always had such an interesting mind*. Interesting is the compliment you give before you stop opening the books. I learned to hear the fence inside the praise without making a speech about it. Speeches about stigma become content. Content becomes usable. I preferred stacking.

The ignored shelf was not only journals and referees.

It was family weather and friend weather and the quiet social technology of deciding, in advance, that a man with that history cannot author anything that binds. Bindings gathered dust in rooms that still had my name on emails. Titles that should have been argued with were filed under eccentricity, then under tragedy, then under please-don't-encourage-him. I have stood in a room and watched a person pick up a book with my name on it, weigh it once in the hand as if checking for a trick, and put it back without opening. The put-back was gentle. Gentleness can be a dismissal. The room kept talking about weather and traffic. I kept breathing. Later the meters would walk toward my derivation and some of the same mouths would discover measurement as if measurement were a conversion experience. I am not writing that victory here. I am writing the years when the work sat unread and the file sat over-read.

There was a particular shelf in a particular room — not metaphor, wood and paint — where three of my bindings sat between books that got opened. Dust settled thicker on mine. I noticed once while looking for a pen. I did not rearrange the shelf to prove a point. Proving points to furniture is how you become a character in someone else's morality play. I took the pen and left the dust. Dust is honest. Dust does not pretend it was about standards.

I have a degree.

Economics — or adjacent enough that the transcript does not rescue me in the rooms that matter to the crank chorus. When they say *no degree*, they mean no *physics* degree. The missing adjective does the violence. I let them have their shorthand in public because correcting every headline is a job that turns your life into a FAQ, and a FAQ is another way of being managed. On this page I will be exact once: the credential they weaponise is the one I do not hold. The one I hold did not open the ignored shelf. Nothing did, for a long time, except persistence that looked like stubbornness from outside and like breathing from inside.

I remember the transcript as a quiet object. Paper. Ink. A university's seal that meant something in rooms that were not physics rooms. It sat in a drawer the way a spare key sits — real, unused for the lock people kept pointing at. When Quarter II later made *degree* into a gate, they were not lying about the gate. They were lying about what the gate measures. Epistemology is not a hygiene ritual. Hygiene language always sounds like care until you notice what it is washing away.

Once, early, I brought the economics transcript into a conversation that had already decided I was uncredentialed. I watched the face across from me perform surprise and then perform a new kind of dismissal — as if holding the wrong key were worse than holding none. I put the transcript away. It has stayed away. Quiet background. Correct fact. Useless armour.

I wrote anyway.

Natural philosophy. Physics. Kill switches for systems that pretend ethics are optional add-ons. Clay in the mornings some years; numbers at night. Hard and soft in one pour — marble and GFRC arguing the way a body argues with a mat. Studio G and the Bay Hotel lawn and Skye at sunset did not cancel the ward in other people's mouths. Village N Life years did not cancel it — Maree's mentorship, the year at Camps Bay Retreat, the guest-theatre thinking that later became a sculpture on a lawn. Saatchi listings did not cancel it. The dab did not help my respectability. Talking shit did not help. I kept the life goals as I stated them because sanding them off would be a different man's autobiography, and I am not writing a different man for their

comfort. Antichristos will try to polish this. The autobiography will not.

The body knew before the corpus. School judo. Jiu-jitsu. Weight, balance, correct fall, soft set-down. You arrange yourself so the floor does not invent you. Years later the notebooks asked the same of contradictions — do not leave them standing because a committee prefers opacity. I am not forcing a metaphor. I am naming the same attention in two rooms. Fighting arts first; clay; then the long work. The ward tried to make the attention look like pathology. The shelf tried to make it look like hobby. Neither room opened the books.

There were mornings when the stigma was almost funny, in the dry way that is not laughter. A courier asking if I was *the artist*. Yes. A second question about whether I also *did the science thing*. Yes. A third look that meant the courier had read something and was deciding whether to be impressed or careful. Careful won. The package changed hands as if it might be contagious. I signed. Went back to work. Contagion is how stigma travels when it has manners.

There were evenings when it was not funny at all. A message from someone who used to argue with my pages — argue is respect — now asking if I was *okay* in the tone that means please stop producing objects that force them to choose. I answered that I was working. Working is the only accurate status. Okay is a category other people need more than I do.

I kept a desk that did not care about the weekly. Notebook, pencil, a printout of a drop-result when I had one, clay dust in the grain of the wood. The desk was not a shrine. It was a surface. Surfaces do not believe or disbelieve. They hold what you put on them. I put true sentences on them until the sentences outnumbered the careful smiles. That took years. Years is not dramatic. Years is the flat line doing its work.

When people ask later — and they will — whether the hospital *inspired* the work, I will refuse the frame. Inspiration tourism is cousin to diagnosis tourism. The work came from attention and refusal and the long habit of not leaving a contradiction standing. The hospital came from a season. Seasons are not muses. Seasons are weather. Weather passes. Readings of weather try to become permanent. I am writing against that permanence without raising my voice.

I once tried to explain the ignored shelf to someone who had never lived under it. I said: imagine a room that keeps your books and never opens them, and then asks why you did not shout. They nodded as if I had told a joke with a missing punchline. I stopped explaining. Explanation becomes aria if you keep feeding it. Flat inventory works better. Shelf. Dust. Put-back. Next sentence.

There were years when the only peer weather I got arrived sideways — a message that treated a kill switch as an object worth arguing with, not a symptom. Argument is respect. Pity is not. I preferred argument even when it was sharp. Sharp at least opens the page. Pity closes it with a soft hand.

In the studio the light in late afternoon made the GFRC look almost marble and then not. Hard and soft in one pour. Guests at The Bay had walked past pieces without knowing the notebooks existed. That was fine. Hotel rooms are not peer review. What was not fine was the write-up that later used the hotel as proof I was *only* an artist, as if only were a kindness. Only is a fence with flowers on it.

I kept writing natural philosophy because that was the stated goal, not because the planet had asked. The planet asks for faces and keys and apologies. Goals are quieter. Smoke dab. Talk shit. Write. The arrangement is load-bearing because it refuses polish. Polish is how stigma graduates into brand management.

Someone will want this chapter to be an aria.

It is not.

The wound is administrative. They decided my sentences could not carry value. I kept stacking sentences. That is the whole mechanism. Jamie-Uys flat line: the loaded thing said without orchestra. I will not perform suffering for readers who came for a prophet and will leave disappointed that I am only a worker with a file and a desk. Diagnosis tourism is a spectator sport. I am not hosting it.

I remember one afternoon in particular — not because it was cinematic, because it was not. A table. A printout. Someone I trusted saying, carefully, that perhaps I should rest from writing for a while. The carefulness was the point. Care can be a muzzle. Outside the window a bakkie reverse-beeped and a dog barked once and stopped. Ordinary Cape noise under an ordinary suggestion that I make my-

self smaller. Tea between us going cold the way tea does when a conversation has become a procedure. I nodded enough to end it and went home and wrote until the page stopped wobbling. No aria. Just the administrative wound repeating itself in a kinder voice.

Another afternoon — different year, same mechanism. A gallery person, kind enough, asked whether the sculpture and the physics were not *too much* for one story. As if a life were a brand deck and needed focus. I said the clay and the numbers were the same attention. They smiled the smile that means we will pretend you answered. Later I saw a write-up that mentioned Studio G and did not mention the notebooks. Selection is also a reading. Selection is how stigma stays polite.

A third afternoon, quieter: I posted a short note somewhere public and watched the replies choose the file over the sentence. Not all of them. Enough of them. Enough is how consensus works without needing a vote. I closed the tab. Went to the studio. Put my hands in clay until the clay was louder than the replies. That is not triumph. That is technique.

The ignored shelf had a smell. Dust and binding glue and the particular staleness of work that has been handled only to be put back. I know that smell better than I know some people's faces. When fame arrived later, people asked why I had not shouted louder earlier. Shouting is not how you open a shelf that has decided you cannot write value. You open it by stacking true sentences until a friend names the algorithms out loud and the meters start walking. Even then the shelf's old habit remains in the mouth of Quarter II.

There were ordinary days inside the stigma.

Days of tea. Days of clay under the nails. Days of a notebook that did not care what the weekly said. Days when a friend treated me as an intellectual peer and the room straightened by one degree — *ek voel of ek genooi* is weather, without needing to make a brand of invitation. Those days do not erase the consensus. They prove the consensus was never total. Usefulness to the small-makers was never the same as truth.

On those days I smoked dab when the work allowed it and talked shit when the work needed air. That is not confession. That is the arrangement I stated out loud and kept. Respectability is a costume

people try to put on you after they have already decided you cannot write. I declined the costume. Declining it cost me soft invitations and gained me nothing the academy would count. I counted the notebook instead.

I remember a morning in the studio when salt air came through the open window and the alley was still ordinary. Gulls. A radio. Someone laughing in the next building. I worked a surface until hard and soft agreed enough to stop. Then I opened a notebook and wrote three lines that would later become load-bearing and that, on that morning, looked like nothing. The nothing of true work is a private fact. Stigma cannot see it. Stigma only sees the file and the missing physics degree and the useful story of a man who should rest.

On a Tuesday that does not deserve a date, I carried three bindings to a meeting that had asked to see *the work*. See meant glance. Glance meant enough to say they had seen. They asked about my health before they asked about a derivation. Order of questions is a reading. I answered the health question with one sentence and put a notebook on the table. Nobody opened it while I was there. Afterward someone emailed that they would *circle back*. Circling back is how shelves stay ignored without anyone feeling cruel.

I am not angry at that Tuesday in a way that wants an aria. I am exact about it. Exactness is the flat line's cousin. The meeting happened. The notebook stayed closed. I went home and wrote the next page because the next page does not require their circle.

Living-person care also means this: I will not turn the people who loved me into villains for needing me small. Need is not always malice. Need can be fear wearing concern's shirt. I can refuse the muzzle without prosecuting the fear. Refusal is enough. Prosecution is content. Content is what the quarters harvest.

Father comes next — or soon.

The whole corpus carries his name in the dedication and he has read none of it. That fact sits beside the hospital stigma like a second climate. One says I cannot write. One does not open what I wrote for him. I am not owed a reunion from either weather. Living-person care means I do not invent his reasons here. The unread is the unread. Outreach's true goal can sit on a page without becoming a tidy second act.

There was also a brother.

Saxonwold. A boardroom. Friday the fifth of September, twenty twenty-five — public record, not novel invent. Bouwer. Insolvency practice. Consultation pretext in the early reports. I will not make that page a thriller on this page. The stigma chapter is stigma. Bouwer is Bouwer. Do not let the quarters braid them into one morality play where hospital and assassination become a single branded wound for Antichristos or for anyone else. Grief has its own chapter when the book earns it. Here I only refuse the braid.

What I want on the record is simpler than diagnosis and simpler than revenge.

They believed I could not write anything of value, and the belief was useful to people who needed me small. Useful to continuity networks that preferred constants underived and ethics unforced. Useful to academics who confuse credential theatre with epistemology. Useful even to some who loved me and wanted me safe inside a smaller story. Usefulness is not the same as malice. It does not need malice to do harm.

I will say this once more without rising in pitch: the stigma is how they *read* me, not a DSM scene I owe the reader. Living-person care is not coyness. It is refusal to turn a ward into entertainment. The entertainment market is already full of prophets and cranks. I am writing a worker who was told his sentences could not carry value and who kept stacking them anyway.

There is a particular silence that follows you after institutional language has had its turn. People lower their voices when you enter a room. Or they raise them, performing normalcy. Both are readings. Both treat you as weather to be managed. I learned to work inside that silence the way you learn to work inside heat — not by pretending it is not there, by continuing the task until the task is the louder fact. Clay does not care about your file. A derivation does not care about your file. A friend who treats you as peer can briefly make the room forget the file. Then the room remembers. You stack another sentence.

I used to keep a mental list of who had actually opened a book.

It was a short list. I stopped keeping it when I noticed the list was

becoming a wound I polished. Polished wounds become brands. Brands become usable by quarters. I threw the list away and kept the work. The work does not need a census of readers to be true. It needs to be true. Truth is quieter than vindication and harder than pity.

Sometimes the stigma arrived as logistics. An invitation that never quite materialised. A panel that found another speaker. A journal that stayed polite for months and then went quiet. Soft weather. Continuity networks do not need to knock when calendars can do the knocking. I felt those soft nos in the body as invoice weather and calendar weather long before I had language for Illuminatie pressure. Language later. Body first. The body knows when a room has decided you cannot write value.

The economics degree stayed in the quiet background. The physics stayed on the desk. The shelf stayed ignored until a friend refused to launder the algorithms — said Lucid ran on 420 Code rails out loud — and fame arrived sideways, ugly, and irreversible.

I am not grateful for the megaphone as salvation.

I am describing cause.

Before the Code becomes a public object on these pages — before axioms get named in rooms that once filed me under cannot — I leave this flat:

They said he could not.

I wrote.

I leave one more flat inventory, because inventories are harder to sentimentalise than arias: an economics transcript; a ward file other people over-cite; an ignored shelf with a smell; clay and GFRC; stated goals that include dab and talk shit; a friend who treated the work as peer work; a brother I will name properly later; a father unread; a megaphone that arrived sideways. None of that is a diagnosis. None of that is a thriller. All of it is the life under the hand that is writing this page on a river while I live the weather of it becoming public.

The shelf's defenders will say they were protecting standards. Standards that never opened the work are not standards. They are habits with letterhead. I am done arguing with letterhead on this page.

One last under-dramatised beat, because stigma is not a climax: years after the ward, a well-meaning person at a dinner said I had *come so far*. They meant recovery as narrative arc. I had come as far as the next true sentence. That was not the distance they meant. I thanked them for the wine and did not correct the story. Correction would have made the evening about the file again. The file already had enough evenings.

If this chapter has a second movement after the administrative wound, it is the ordinary continuation: tea cooling, clay under nails, notebook open, friend weather rare and real, family weather careful, academy weather hygienic, continuity weather soft. None of that is a chart of quarters. It is how a life feels when people have decided, in advance, that your sentences cannot bind. Binding is what I kept doing anyway — not as defiance theatre, as breath. You do not applaud breath. You use it.

Toward the father who has not opened a book. Toward the work that does not need their permission. Toward the morning a Constant stops being optional and meaning becomes the fight that meters cannot settle — hand already moving to the dedication that will not be read.

The hand writing these pages on a river is not me and is also not a theft I can stop from here. Weather of being written is later weather. This page's job is older: name the stigma without spectacle, keep the economics degree exact, leave the shelf smelling like dust, and turn toward the dedication that will not be read. Flat. Loaded. Done enough to move.

The next page is for the unread dedication and the beginning of the Code as custody, not as course pack. I close this one the way I lived those years: without orchestra, without tour, without permission — only the administrative wound named once, and the stacking that answered it.

They said he could not write anything of value.

The page under this hand is still writing.

I leave the ward file where it belongs — over-cited by other people, under-dramatised here — and keep the economics transcript exact in the drawer as a spare key for a lock nobody will admit exists. Real.

Quiet. Useless as armour in rooms that mean degree as physics gate. I will not perform recovery as narrative arc for dinner guests who mean the file when they say *come so far*. I came as far as the next true sentence. That was not the distance they meant. Tea cooling. Clay under nails. Notebook open. Friend weather rare and real. The stigma chapter ends without orchestra: administrative wound named, stacking continued, hand already turning toward a dedication that will not be read. Flat. Loaded. Enough to move.

06 — The Letter That Wants a Face

[G] · outer · Studio G / Cape · after four temperatures

He read the Antichristos letter properly in the afternoon, when the alley heat had thickened and the CODATA note had stopped feeling like mercy.

Cream paper again under the clay study. The hand was not hysterical. That made it worse. Believers who sound like believers — sincere, arranged, already living inside a story that needs a hinge. They did not threaten. They invited. The gathering had a date. The wall would be lit. The Kind sentence would be near enough to steal heat from, and they wanted him to stand where the two weathers touched so the city could stop arguing with itself by pointing at one man.

Appear. Bless a liturgy. Accept the name they had already been using in rooms he did not enter.

Antichristos in their mouths was not insult. It was job description. They needed a man the way a theorem needs a named lemma. The Constant converging was not enough; measurement does not hug you back. A face does. The letter said as much without using those words. Careful theology of need.

G sat with it longer than he had in the morning. Morning had been triage — four temperatures arriving before coffee cooled. Afternoon was the hour for answering one of them without letting the other three write the reply. He poured water. Drank half. Set the glass on a ring of old clay dust and watched the meniscus settle. Ordinary studio

physics. Then he read the third paragraph again, slowly, as if the ask might change if he gave it enough quiet.

The concrete ask sat clean:

Come. Be seen. Let us stop pointing at a number and start pointing at you.

There was a secondary ask folded under it — accept the name in writing so the liturgy could cite him without the awkwardness of his absence. Paper wanting a signature the way a lab soft-sask wanted keys. Different quarters. Same hunger for a name that would make their work feel finished.

He turned the page over. The reverse held a schedule, a contact, a line about hospitality that tried not to sound like capture. They had thought about parking. They had thought about a quiet room beforehand if he needed stillness. Kindness as logistics. Logistics as a net. He did not hate them for it. Hate would have been easier than the specific fatigue of being sincerely needed as a symbol.

Outside the open window the alley paint still looked tacky at the edges from the overnight refresh. Gulls argued. A bakkie reverse-beeped toward the beach road. Salt on the air. Cape ordinary continuing under cream postage. He listened to ordinary for a full minute because ordinary was the register he wanted his refusal to match — not hygiene, not prophecy, not a sneer borrowed from the academy weekly that had already filed him under cannot.

G set the letter on the desk and did not reach for the op-ed pile. Refusing this was not joining Quarter II. He would not borrow the academy's hygiene language to wash his hands. He would not call them cranks. He would not perform sanity for cameras that wanted a before-and-after. He would not join the crank chorus to look respectable while refusing a crown. He would simply not go.

Before he drafted anything he walked the studio once, counting costs he could already predict. Photograph refused would cool a Kind organiser who meant well. Sale delayed would cool a collector who meant money. Silence invented by Antichristos would heat rooms he would never enter. None of that changed the ask. The ask wanted a face. Faces become property. He had spent years refusing to become property for academy, faith, or lab. Afternoon light on cream

paper did not make property holy.

He stopped at the rack of sister-studies — Skye's kin in clay and GFRC, hard and soft arguing in the pours. Antichristos would love to turn these into relics. Quarter II would love to pretend the artist could not be the physicist. He touched one cool surface with two fingers and left it unmarked. Work stays work when you refuse to baptise it. A crate stamp from an old hotel install caught his eye — Bay Hotel years ghosting the present. Village N Life muscle memory in the hands. None of that was a liturgy. All of it was a life.

He sat again and put both palms flat on the desk the way he did before a pour — feeling for tilt. The studio had its own weather: clay dust, solvent ghost, salt from the open window, the faint sweetness of old coffee in a mug he kept meaning to wash. Afternoon light came in low and made the cream paper look almost holy, which irritated him. Holiness was their register. His was work.

He reread the greeting. They had not used Gerhard. They had used the name that did the job. Names are custody. Accepting a name in writing is how liturgy gets a citation without a body in the room. He had spent enough years watching people cite a hospital file as epistemology. He would not add a liturgical citation to the pile by signing the wrong noun.

There was a sentence in the letter about the Constant — careful, almost shy — as if measurement itself had authorised the gathering. Measurement authorises nothing about faces. Meters walk toward numbers. People walk toward stages. Conflating the two was the whole Antichristos engine, and noticing the conflation did not require calling anyone a crank. Noticing was enough. Refusal was enough.

He thought, briefly, of the morning's CODATA line still under the clay. Relief had been real. Pressure under relief had been real. The letter wanted to spend both as fuel for a night with lights. He would not donate his face to that fuel. The Constant could converge without a blessing. That was the point of a Constant.

He drafted a reply at the desk with the window still open on the tacky alley paint.

First draft too soft — gratitude that could be read as almost. Second draft too sharp — theology in the refusal, which is how you become

their interlocutor. Third draft almost kind and almost nothing:

Thank you for writing. I will not appear. I will not bless a liturgy that requires my face. I will not accept the name. The work is the work. Please do not wait for me.

He deleted a sentence that sounded like apology. Deleted another that sounded like a counter-sermon. What remained was refusal without a sermon and without a sneer. He read it aloud once, not for drama, for pitch. Pitch mattered. Pitch that sounded like hygiene would make him Quarter II's accidental mascot. Pitch that sounded like prophecy would feed the gathering anyway. Flat was the only safe register, and flat still cost.

He almost added a line about the Kind — that the wall sentence did not need him. He removed it. Explaining the Kind to Antichristos was how you became their theologian of the other side. Let the wall speak for itself. Let the cunt stay load-bearing without his commentary.

Send.

The cost arrived small and real before the evening.

First: a Kind organiser — ordinary voice, not a cartoon zealot — texted that a paint day had been planned for the studio alley. Would he mind if they refreshed the wall with him present for a photograph. Not Antichristos. Adjacent weather. The sentence on the wall was already his city's air:

Don't be a cunt — be kind.

He minded the photograph. He said so without a speech. The organiser went quiet, then polite. They would paint without him. Fine. The Kind did not need his face. That was the doctrine he preferred. Preferring it still cost the small warmth of being asked and saying no — the ordinary human tax of refusing even the soft invitation. He stared at the phone until the screen dimmed. No sermon. No explanation of Antichristos adjacency. Just no.

He made tea he did not drink. Stood with the cup cooling while the send-confirmation sat on screen like a small closed door. Refusal is supposed to feel clean in stories. In a studio it feels like postponed noise — you know the inventions have already started in rooms with better lighting than yours.

He washed a brush that did not need washing, because hands need a task when the inbox has just spent something. Water over bristles. Clay ghosts leaving the hairs. He set the wet brush on the rack and watched a drip find the floor and stop. Then he wiped the drip because floors matter even on days when letters want faces.

Between the Kind text and the collector mail he made himself do ten minutes of actual studio work — not as therapy, as refusal to let the inbox become the only room. He scraped a seam on a study. Listened to the tool. Corrected a soft place that wanted to stay soft too long. Hard and soft arguing again. The argument calmed him more than tea. When he returned to the screen, the day had not improved, but his hands had done something that was not a face-ask.

A scooter backfired in the alley. He flinched once, laughed once at himself, and kept scraping. Cape noise. Not prophecy.

Second cost: a collector who had been circling a GFRC piece for months wrote that the “association climate” made a public acquisition awkward this quarter. No accusation. Soft weather. Markets drafting for continuity networks that never needed to knock. The Illuminatie as pressure system, not pyramid hats. G felt it as invoice weather and calendar weather and the specific shame of wanting a sale while refusing a stage. Small. Real. Not martyrdom. A number that would not land in the account.

He almost wrote back something sharp about association climate — almost borrowed Quarter II’s sneer for a private satisfaction. He did not. Sharp would have been joining a chorus he had just refused to join by another door. He wrote nothing. Let the soft no sit. Soft nos stay soft if you do not poke them into speeches.

He walked the length of the studio again — desk to rack to door to window — and felt the four temperatures still on the skin without naming them as a chart: meter-relief that had become pressure; cream face-hunger answered; op-ed hygiene still forwarding itself through well-meaning people; lab soft-ask still glowing unread. Answering one temperature did not cool the others. It only spent the afternoon’s coin.

Second movement of the afternoon: after send, before dusk, he forced the studio back into work-shape. Not productivity theatre. Custody. He opened a notebook to a page about uncertainty bands

and wrote three lines that stayed procedure. Procedure is how you refuse becoming a face without joining the hygiene chorus. The lines were ugly and true. He left them ugly.

His phone buzzed with a forward of the morning's op-ed — again — from someone who thought he needed to see it to stay informed. Informed was their word for wounded on a schedule. He archived the forward without reading. He already knew the sentence about value. He had lived under it. Living under it did not obligate a daily reread.

He stood at the window and watched a woman across the alley hang laundry. Ordinary Cape life refusing to become liturgy. A shirt snapped in the wind. He felt, absurdly, grateful to the shirt. Then he felt the narrated sensation again — faint, Chobe-shaped — and put both hands on the sill until it passed. AJ writing somewhere. Weather of being written. Not tonight's bill. Tonight's bill was cream paper answered and costs paid small.

He made a second tea and actually drank this one. Bitter. Hot. Real. Tea does not care about Antichristos. That is why tea helps.

Third movement: dusk alley, stencil, Honey Badger, walk home — already in the spine — but between stencil and lock he paused at the studio threshold and said, out loud to no one, the refusal again without the letter's politeness: I will not appear. The empty studio absorbed it. No applause. No counter-sermon. Good. He turned off the lights over the unread lab mail and let the polite keys wait in the dark like a clean bench overnight.

On the street a tourist asked him, smiling, if he knew where the sculpture studio was. He pointed without giving his name. The tourist thanked him and walked the wrong way anyway. He did not correct the path. Correction would have become a conversation. Conversations become recognition. Recognition becomes a phone. He had already watched one phone rise and fall across the street. Enough for today.

At home he opened a drawer where an old economics transcript still lived — quiet object, wrong key for the locks people pointed at — and closed the drawer again. Exact fact. Useless armour. Still his. The Antichristos letter had wanted a different credential: face. He had spent neither.

He stood in the alley anyway at dusk, alone, and watched two teenagers finish a stencil without asking his permission.

Good.

That was the Kind working — messiah-less, sentence-complete. His discomfort was physical: paint smell, tacky edges, the sense of being cited by a wall. Not a TED rebuttal. Not a Quarter II sneer. Just a man who derives kindness as structure and still flinches when the structure gets painted three metres from his door. One of the teenagers glanced at him, recognised something, and looked away — mercy or caution, he did not ask. The other kept working, wrist steady, cunt load-bearing in the letters the way CongoSky had kept it load-bearing in ops before the street caught fire.

The Honey Badger clipped against his pocket when he crouched to pick up a dropped cap. Open. Close. Exact. AJ's kinship sitting in Cape dust while strangers argued about whether Gerhard van Niek-erk was prophet, crank, instrument, or inconvenient artist with an economics degree and a file other people loved too much. Double Knife Brother weather under Antichristos postage. Private fact out-ranking public ask. He clipped the knife shut and left the cap on the ledge for whoever owned it.

A scooter passed. Someone was playing a radio too loud. Ordinary Cape evening under extraordinary mail.

He went back inside and washed paint from his fingers at the sink. Hot water. Soap. The smell of solvent under the soap. He dried his hands on a rag that already knew clay. On the desk the cream letter waited face-up until he turned it face-down under the clay study again — same gesture as morning, different meaning. Morning had been triage. Evening was answered mail with costs named.

The letter's refusal was sent. The gathering would happen without him and would invent his silence as strategy, prophecy, cowardice, or secret endorsement — inventiveness was their surplus. He could not control that. He could control whether he stood on their stage and made the invention true. Control was smaller than people thought. It was still enough for one door.

He sat and tried to return to a notebook sentence about a drop-result — procedure, not speech. The sentence would not settle. Interrupted

work has a texture. He left the line unfinished rather than force a pretty hinge. Lucid was not in this room; he did not keep engines as pets. The unfinished line was human refusal of invention, quieter than product.

On the desk the lab soft-ask still glowed unread from the morning. Keys without a crown — tomorrow's temptation, Quarter IV in a polite coat. Tonight's ledger was simpler: he had refused a face-ask, lost a photo he did not want and a sale he did want, and the Constant kept converging without requiring his blessing. CODATA under clay. Cream paper under refusal. Op-ed still forwarded by the well-meaning. Four temperatures still on the skin.

The faint narrated sensation brushed him once — Chobe manuscript weather, AJ's hand somewhere arranging a life — and he shook it off like smoke. Consent would come later if it came. Tonight he only owed the door lock and the washed hands.

He locked the studio. Left the cream letter face-down under the clay. Outside, the wall dried without his face on it.

Before locking up he checked the alley once more from the doorway. The teenagers were gone. The stencil looked wetter than it was. A drip had run from the final d and stopped like a decision. He did not fix it. Imperfection was human and therefore Kind. Perfection was how stages get built.

He thought of the photograph he had refused — him beside the sentence, usable forever. Antichristos would have loved that adjacency even if the Kind had not meant it. Adjacency is how hungers borrow heat. Saying no to the photo had been saying no to a braid he did not authorise. Small. Exact. Costing warmth.

On the walk he passed two more Kind marks — bridge underpass, bakkie bumper — same sentence, different hands. The cunt remained load-bearing. Softened versions always sounded like someone else had taken over the ethic. He did not photograph them. He did not bless them. He let them exist as the practice that did not require his face, which was the whole reason he could refuse Antichristos without becoming Quarter II's mascot of hygiene.

He touched the studio key in his pocket and felt, absurdly, protective of a door that strangers wanted to turn into a shrine entrance. A door

is a door. He kept it that way.

At the corner a café television murmured something about measurement and names. He did not stop. Screens harvest faces. He had already spent his face-budget for the day by refusing to give one.

He almost checked whether the collector had written again. He did not. Small costs stay small if you do not poke them into speeches. The Honey Badger bumped his thigh when he stepped off the curb. Open. Close. Exact. Kinship fact. Then home, door, the day still loud behind him and the cream letter already answered with a no that had cost a photo and a sale and whatever inventions the gathering would make of his absence.

A stranger across the street raised a phone as if a prophet might still appear. The phone lowered. The evening kept moving. Refusal had already spent what it would spend today.

At home he ate something without tasting it much — bread, cheese, a tomato that had gone soft at the shoulder. He washed the plate. Stood at the sink longer than washing required. Body delaying the moment of checking mail again. When he checked, the Antichristos side had not replied yet. The Kind organiser had sent a short thanks for the clarity. The collector had not written again. Soft weather holding. He put the phone face-down the way he had put the cream letter face-down. Gesture as discipline.

Later, washing his face at home, he caught his own eyes in the mirror and looked away — not drama, just the oddness of having refused a face and then seeing one anyway. Private faces are not public faces. The distinction is the whole fight under measurement. He brushed his teeth. Ordinary. Ordinary was the point.

In bed he heard a neighbour's television through the wall — laughter track, then news cadence, then laughter again. The planet was still manufacturing faces. His refusal would not stop that machine. It would only keep his door from becoming an entrance to it.

He slept poorly and woke once to the thought that he should have been kinder in the refusal — then woke again to the thought that kinder would have been almost, and almost was how faces get taken. He did not reopen the sent mail. He left the no where it was, small and real, and let the night finish without a crown.

Toward morning he dreamed nothing useful — only paint smell and a stage light he stepped away from. Waking was better than the dream. Waking had a door that locked and a knife that clipped and a lab soft-ask still waiting like a clean bench. Tomorrow he would decide whether polite keys were a different crown. Tonight he had paid the smaller bill first: no face, no blessing, no photograph, one sale cooled. The Constant did not notice. That was the mercy and the pressure both — measurement continuing while meaning fought in alleys and inboxes.

Before sleep fully took him he checked one more time whether refusal had blossomed into a public invention yet. A search of his own name for the night's gathering returned only the usual noise — crank, Constant, Kind paint, a clip of someone else speaking as if they knew his desk. No stage with his body on it. Small mercy. Small mercies are what refusal buys when it works. He put the phone away and let the wall across town dry without him, which was the whole point of paying the smaller bill first.

Morning would bring the lab soft-ask into the light again — keys, sign-off language, a postdoc's sincere hunger, institutional frost in the same inbox. Different quarter. Same appetite for a name that finishes someone else's work. He would meet that ask without yesterday's cream paper writing his voice. One refusal at a time. Faces first. Keys later. The Constant still not asking for either.

He rose before the city got loud, washed his face, touched the Honey Badger once through cloth, and did not turn back toward the studio until the wall would already be dry without him.

He touched the doorframe on the way out of the bedroom like a superstitious man and then laughed at himself for it. Superstition was their weather. His was a lock, a knife, a no already sent, and a wall that did not need his face to finish drying. He stepped into the early air carrying those facts like change in a pocket — small, real, spent — and did not turn when a bakkie passed with Kind letters ghosting its bumper in last week's paint.

Refusal behind him. Keys ahead. The Constant indifferent as meters are indifferent. Meaning still expensive in the small coins of photo and sale and the warmth you spend when you say no to a soft ask. He walked toward the studio without hurrying, Honey Badger exact

against his thigh, cream letter already answered under clay, wall dry enough now that no face could be pasted onto wet paint. He did not look for cameras. Enough for today.

At the alley he paused long enough to see the Kind sentence dry and exact — two clauses, no founder — and did not bless it. Optional to the practice. Useful anyway. The cream letter's refusal sat behind him as small coins spent correctly. Lab soft-ask waited ahead like a clean bench that wanted a name. He put his palm on the studio door, felt ordinary wood, and went in to clay and numbers without a chart of quarters in his mouth. Faces first, paid. Keys later. Work still work.

07 — Who Gave Him the Mic

[A] · outer · Mutatus Maximus, Chobe River · packet from ch-01 opened

AJ opened the Quarter III packet after the mats page had a spine.

Spine first had been the morning's only mercy. Without it the rage would have colonised the floor-lesson and turned apprenticeship into rebuttal. He had written soft set-down and correct fall until the page could afford interruption. Now interruption was here with citations and teeth, and the truck smelled like dust, solder, and blame arriving before noon.

Lucid had flagged it at dawn. Hostility markers. Attribution thread. He had parked it like a hot pan while the choir stayed on the floor-lesson and frost mail blinked politely in another pane. Now the manuscript could afford interruption, or he could not afford the pretence that the only weather was hyperscalers smiling about acquisition. Platform-rage had found the river. It was time to let it speak in its own citations.

The packet was not one letter.

It was a weather system compressed into a queue: forum exports, CongoNet mirrors, a journalist's request framed as neutrality, three brand partners asking whether arjunabadger.press would "clarify the provenance narrative," a lucid.rodeo comment harvest with teeth, a thread that treated open attribution as original sin, and a long piece that used his name as a verb for recklessness.

Who gave him the mic.

They meant G. They meant the ignored man — economics degree, no physics credential, hospital stigma still usable as epistemology — dragged into planetary fame because AJ had said, out loud, that Lucid ran on 420 Code algorithms. Not a quiet fork. Not a cleaned brand story. Open attribution as load-bearing cause. Quarter III hated the candour. Some hated G's elevation. Some hated AJ for making refusal-to-laundry a public act. Some wanted provenance scrubbed quieter — rebrand hints, a softer story about a lab with better manners and a quieter friend. Not yet the full stop-the-book triad. Today was attribution hostility finding a throat.

The mic question arrived with receipts and without courage. Receipts: screenshots of AJ's own sentences. Courage: none — only the demand that the sentences become unsaid. Unsayings is not science. Unsayings is brand management with a morality costume.

AJ remembered saying it the first time without feeling prophetic. He had named rails because Lucid's refusal to invent made provenance load-bearing. Cite-or-refuse needs a stack you can point at. Pointing at 420 was honesty, not a campaign to crown a friend. Fame happened anyway. Fame is what happens when you refuse to launder and the product works. Quarter III wanted the working product and a quieter story about where it came from. They could not have both. That was the heat under the packet seal, now opened and breathing in the truck.

AJ felt the anger in his shoulders before he felt it as argument.

He let the first wave pass without typing. Typing too early turns heat into a press release you cannot take back. He watched the river instead — mud prints, light climbing, a calf somewhere in scrub making the undignified sounds of being young. Mutatus held still. The packet did not. Hostility markers do not care about elephants. That was the joke and the problem: the truck could receive every weather at once and still had to choose which weather got a reply.

He opened the truck's side wider and let river air in as if heat could dilute inbox heat. It could not. Hippos down-channel made their wet ownership sounds. A fish eagle turned once over the channel

and did not care about provenance narratives. The solar drop on the rise reported green. Local node hummed under the desk. Mutatus Maximus receiving hatred at every useful layer and still having to choose what to amplify. Connectivity without consent discipline is just a louder mistake.

First real platform-rage on the river. Not abstract schism chart. Inbox heat. The smell of blame on a good Chobe morning while elephants' mud still held the morning's prints and the Kind paint on the tank twenty metres away kept its job without him.

He could have driven inland and pretended the mesh was the only weather. He stayed. The river desk is where the autobiography lives; rage does not get to relocate the pilgrimage because it prefers a quieter venue. Mutatus had been built to take links and still choose. Today the choice was hold the attribution, refuse the apology theatre, keep the choir on the life page.

Don't be a cunt — be kind.

Rage wanted him unkind in return. He would not give it that satisfaction as policy. He also would not retract the true sentence that had made Lucid honest and G famous. Cite-or-refuse cut both ways: Lucid refused invention; AJ refused laundering. Hymnbook practice under heat.

Unkind would have been easy and useless — a reply-all that fed the weather system attention as fuel. He kept his hands for the manuscript and for the boring green lights that meant the edge still worked while platforms argued about provenance varnish.

Lucid spoke when asked for summary, exact.

"Dominant demand cluster: attribution hostility — who gave him the mic. Secondary: soft scrubbing of 420 language. Tertiary: personal apology templates circulating. Pause-serialisation chatter present as mood, not concrete stop demand. Brand-risk language high. No single authorised speaker. Cite density high; invention not required."

"Don't draft an apology," AJ said.

"Not drafted."

"Don't invent a counter-myth either."

“Refuse invention is default.”

He nodded once at the pane as if Lucid needed the gesture. It did not. The refusal was already the product. What AJ needed was his own shoulders to believe that rage could be received without being answered as theatre. Hymnbook practice: exactness under heat, no cute voice, no third skull, no campaign.

He stood and walked the length of the truck — matatu colours, mobile DC, Beast’s shadow if you counted the tender — and came back to the packet like a man returning to a tooth he could not stop touching. CongoSky quiet behind the mesh in the good way. Ops still ops. Hire/fire weather and partner terms still governed by the sentence the company had embodied before the walls caught fire. lucid.rodeo queue within tolerance if you ignored the teeth in the comments. ar-junabadger.press was the human work that would absorb the hit.

He skimmed one forum export until the language repeated itself into sludge — recklessness, irresponsibility, “platforming a crank,” “ruining serious AI,” as if Lucid’s refusal to invent were a moral failure instead of the product keeping its promise. A reply chain argued that open attribution had “weaponised a private theory.” Private. As if the Code had been a secret handshake and AJ had broken club rules by naming the rails. He stopped skimming. Density of cite was enough; immersion in hate was not research. Lucid could hold the record. AJ’s job was custody of the next true page and the refusal to launder.

He opened a second export and found apology templates circulating like hymn sheets for people who had never sung from a hymnbook. I regret the confusion caused. We are refining our narrative. Lucid stands on its own merits. Merits without rails was the laundering. AJ deleted the template from his screen as if it could stain the truck. Lucid did not offer a rewrite. Good. The product knew the difference between citation and costume.

A thread blamed him for making a mental-health file into a brand. The cruelty was efficient: use the stigma as epistemology, then accuse the candour of exploitation. He felt heat climb his neck and put both palms flat on the desk until the wood reminded him he was still on the Chobe, not on their stage. Living-person care meant he would not drag G’s ward into a rebuttal. The autobiography would carry stigma

flat, later, under-dramatised. Rage mail would not get a DSM scene as ammunition.

A brand partner's mail used the phrase "narrative hygiene." AJ laughed once, short, ugly. Hygiene again. The academy had hygiene. The platforms had hygiene. Everyone wanted him clean of the sentence that had made the engine honest. Clean meant false.

Another partner asked for a call "off the record." Off the record was where people practised retractions before they had the courage to ask for them in public. He did not schedule the call. He marked the thread cold and felt the cold arrive in his jaw as ache.

The journalist's neutrality request wanted a quote about "responsibility to the ecosystem." Ecosystem was a word that meant other people's balance sheets. AJ drafted three sentences in his head and threw them away. Quotes become weapons faster than silence does when Quarter III is hunting a flinch. He let Lucid log the request as unanswered with reason: no grounded statement beyond existing public attribution.

"Cite existing public line?" Lucid asked.

"Cite it. Don't embroider."

Lucid retrieved the open attribution as already on record. Exact. Boring. Blessed. The rage queue wanted embroidery — apology theatre, a quieter provenance myth, something that would practice for ritual distancing without yet naming the full stop. AJ gave them the record again by not inventing a new one.

He did not open the full ultimatum yet — the stop-the-book demand that would come harder later, with costs named in brands and body and maybe a collar offer wearing a smile. This was the first weather: attribution rage finding the river desk and expecting him to flinch for the camera. Later would be ritual distancing with teeth. Today was the mic question shouted until the river answered or didn't.

His hand found the empty twin pocket again. G had the Honey Badger and the other Joseph Rogers. Double Knife Brother on another coast living four temperatures while AJ ate the mic-blame. No reunion beat. CongoNet was bridge enough. Knives were kinship, not

choreography, and kinship today meant holding the line without calling — without dragging G into AJ's inbox as a prop for a press cycle.

"Lucid," he said. "Keep citing. No counter-myth. No schism lecture. Quarters are mail, not a chart."

"Acknowledged."

He poured water, tasted plastic and river, and sat again. Sweat found the place behind his knee. The truck's metal ticked as heat climbed. Somewhere a CongoNet status ping crossed green and boring. He ignored it harder, which was a kind of love for connectivity that did not demand performance.

A long piece in the queue used his name as a verb. *To AJ someone* — meaning to drag an inconvenient author into fame by refusing to launder provenance. The piece performed sadness for "serious research culture." Serious research culture had ignored G's shelf for years and now wanted the mic unsung. AJ felt the old Full Send fragment on his shoulder — month that became Klaus that became Lucid — and did not republish it as a defence. Fragments stay fragments. Origin stories become TED the moment you deploy them as armour.

He opened one CongoNet mirror that claimed neutrality and found a collage of screenshots arranged to make open attribution look like a prank that had gone planetary. The collage was careful. Careful hate is still hate. Lucid summarised the cite density without adopting the frame.

"Primary claim unsupported as moral conclusion. Factual core: attribution language public; Lucid stack on 420 rails; fame consequent. Moral overlay: refuse as invention beyond cited opinion."

"Keep the factual core," AJ said. "Drop the moral overlay from my mouth."

"Not placed in your mouth."

Good. Boring. The product refusing to become his speechwriter for rage.

A lucid.rodeo comment harvest scrolled past with teeth: users who loved the engine and hated the honesty; users who hated both; a few who simply asked for citations and got them. AJ pinned nothing. Pinning is how you feed a weather system your attention as fuel. He let

the harvest sit as evidence that the choir still worked for people who wanted exactness, even while platforms howled for a quieter myth.

He wrote a short public note that was not a sermon: the attribution stands; Lucid's stack is cite-or-refuse on 420 rails; fame is a consequence, not a campaign; the autobiography continues under living-person care. He did not name the quarters. He did not explain Antichristos or the academy or the lab keys. Mail arrives. Mail gets answered or refused. Omniscient schism overview was how you became a TED man. He was a river desk. The river desk published the short note and let the howl continue.

Then he put the packet face-down.

He stood again because sitting had become agreement with the queue's tempo. Walked to the open side. River light hard now. Painted metal hot under his hand. He breathed until the jaw ache eased a millimetre. Platform-rage wants continuous flinch. The body can refuse continuous flinch the way Lucid refuses invention: not as piety, as craft.

Back at the desk he drafted, then killed, a sentence that began To those concerned about provenance. Addressing the concerned is how you join their parish. He published nothing further. The short note already stood. The howl could continue without a second feeding.

He checked lucid.rodeo cite rates for thirty seconds — refusals climbing the way they should when the world asked for pretty lies — then closed the pane. Product could run. Life page could not run itself. Rage wanted him to manage comments as if comments were the book. The book was the manuscript. He put his hands back on it.

The cost was already visible without the later ultimatum: a partner thread going cold in real time; a brand asking for "distance language"; jaw ache; the specific fatigue of being narrated by enemies while narrating a friend's life carefully. Hyperscaler frost still blinked in another pane — Lucid-as-asset, partnership opportunities, the collar that thought it was polite — but Quarter III was louder today. Frost and rage sharing a morning like CODATA and cream paper shared G's desk. Braid without a shared room.

He washed his face in the tiny sink, cold water, river-adjacent reality check. Platform-rage shrinks when your face is wet and the truck smells like dust and solder. Not gone. Sized correctly. He looked at his hands as if they might have taken a side without him. They had not. They still had to type.

He checked the solar node again because his hands needed a true green light. Still up. Edge practice continuing while platforms argued about provenance as if provenance were optional varnish. Mutatus had been built to seed the edge and drive on. Today driving on meant writing on — through rage, not around it, without feeding it a flinch.

Outside, a boat far out left a thin wake. Someone's radio faint across water. The Kind paint held. AJ walked out once, stood near the tank long enough to smell tack and river together, and did not preach. The Kind did not need his rage managed into a sermon. Antichristos needed faces. Platforms needed retractions. The wall needed a sentence. He went back inside.

The manuscript waited. Stigma page still warm from the morning's choir. Father dedication not yet written. Platform-rage wanted the desk. The desk stayed a desk.

He tried a wrong beginning for the next inner page — a line about fame as apology. Deleted it. Tried a line about the mic as debt. Deleted it. The autobiography would not become a press release for Quarter III's comfort. Lucid offered a citation from the attribution thread when asked and refused a retaliatory frame when AJ tested it.

"Retaliation narrative not requested with citable aim. Refuse invention of campaign."

"Correct," AJ said. "No campaign. Mats to father. Keep the choir."

He ate something that claimed to be lunch — dry, practical, crumbs near the manuscript margin he brushed away carefully. The body needed fuel. Rage wanted fasting as purity theatre. He refused that too. Ordinary hunger was not a brand position.

He stood again and checked the Beast's tie-downs out of habit — tender ready if the day needed a second hull, which it did not. The day needed a spine. Matatu colours looked almost reasonable in hard noon light, which they never were, and that was still the joke he had driven into the bush on purpose. Anti-yacht. Overkill. A travelling DC

that could seed an edge and still choose silence. Today the choice was not silence about attribution. Today the choice was silence about apology theatre.

A second brand mail arrived asking whether lucid.rodeo would “revisit messaging.” Revisit was retract with better manners. AJ forwarded it to the cold pile without a speech. Lucid logged hostility markers rising and did not invent comfort.

“Any fire that is actual fire?” AJ asked.

“No cited legal threat in this packet cluster. Reputation pressure high. Partner cooling high. Recommend continue manuscript; defer full ultimatum triage until explicit stop demand present.”

“Good. Stay boring.”

“Default already refuse invention.”

He almost smiled. Almost. The product working under heat was the only comedy available.

He opened the frost pane for thirty seconds — hyperscaler subject lines smiling about partnership, Lucid named in asset language without quite saying collar — and closed it. Salvage weather could wait. Quarter III was today’s stove. The snake in the other queue could keep its manners until a later desk hour.

He returned to the manuscript and wrote three true sentences about stigma without letting platform-rage rewrite them into a defence brief. Living-person care meant the inner page stayed G’s life, not AJ’s rebuttal. The braid held: he remained the gravity of this novel while authoring that one. Rage wanted the braid cut. He kept both threads on the desk without merging rooms.

For a stretch he worked only with Lucid’s refusals as metronome. Ask for a hinge — refuse. Ask for a prettier attribution defence — refuse. Ask for a cite that existed — receive. The hymnbook under heat sounded like that: not inspiration, discipline. Empty twin pocket as second metronome. Joseph Rogers in the drawer. Honey Badger on another coast. Double Knife Brother weather without a call, without a prop photograph, without feeding Quarter III a reunion they could weaponise as proof of a campaign.

AJ drank more water. The rise drop stayed green. CongoSky still quiet in the good way — company law still company law while the street and the platforms argued about who owned the sentence and who owned the mic.

He kept writing anyway.

Through the chime. Through the jaw ache. Through the partner threads going cold in real time. Through the temptation to draft a prettier myth that would make Lucid look parentless and G look optional. He kept the rails named and the life page moving.

Not because rage is fuel. Because stopping would be the retraction they wanted without the honesty of saying retract. The page moved toward the unread father. Lucid refused two decorative sentences and offered citations instead. Hymnbook practice under heat. Empty twin pocket as metronome.

He wrote a paragraph about stigma without answering the forum that had already decided the file was epistemology. The paragraph stayed flat. Jamie-Uys restraint without naming a brand. Lucid offered a cite and refused a hinge into apology. AJ kept both decisions.

Midday heat made the matatu colours look almost reasonable again. He stepped into shade inside the truck and drank water that tasted like the flask's old promises. A CongoNet ping stayed green. Frost mail blinked. Rage mail filled. He sorted nothing that was not fire. Lucid had already said there was no legal fire in the cluster. Reputation pressure is not fire. It is weather that wants you to evacuate your own desk.

He did not evacuate.

He asked Lucid whether the short public note had been distorted yet in mirrors.

"Distortions present as opinion overlays. Factual core intact in cited copies. Recommend no chase thread."

"No chase," AJ said. "Mats to father."

He typed. The empty twin pocket kept time. Somewhere G was under four temperatures. AJ would not call to synchronise suffering. CongoNet was bridge enough if a bridge were needed. Today the

bridge was the refusal to launder, held in public, while the private work continued.

Outside, a fish eagle called once. Inside, the queue kept filling — who gave him the mic, who gave him the mic — as if the answer were not already on the record in plain speech from a man who had refused to launder an engine's provenance.

Birds lifted off the far bank. Heat pressed the truck's painted flank. AJ rolled his shoulders once and returned to the cursor as if rage were merely another latency spike to route around without letting it write the packet.

Somewhere in the queue a stranger had written that AJ owed the industry a quieter story. AJ owed the industry nothing. He owed the hymnbook exactness, owed G living-person care, owed the river desk a true next line. Industry could keep its quieter story and its empty rack halls. The page kept moving.

He checked the empty twin pocket once more and did not call. Kinship today was not a shared press cycle. Kinship was refusing to put G's face in the reply box as proof that the mic had been given wisely. Proof was for courts. The river desk was for pages.

Heat thickened. A hippo grunted. The rise drop stayed green. AJ typed through a paragraph that wanted to become angry and cut the anger until only the fact remained: open attribution; fame consequent; autobiography continuing. Lucid refused one adjective that sounded like campaign copy.

"Correct," AJ said. "No campaign copy."

He typed the first line of the dedication turn without finishing it — left the cursor blinking as motion, not summary. Quarter III could howl. Hyperscalers could smile. The packet could stay face-down until the later ultimatum arrived with harder teeth. Today's answer was the page continuing under a river sky while the truck chose, again, what not to amplify.

AJ did not close the laptop. He turned from the packet's heat to the next true line and let Quarter III howl at a truck that would not kneel — writing continuing, frost still audible, rage unanswered except by the page that refused to stop.

Afternoon light went copper along the river. He checked the rise drop one last time — still green — and felt the small satisfaction of a seed that did not need him to perform for platforms. Mutatus ticked as metal cooled a fraction. Lucid waited without invention. The sealed-then-opened packet stayed face-down now, heat known, full stop-the-book teeth still for a later hour.

AJ wrote the next true line toward the unread father and did not look up when the queue chimed again. Who gave him the mic. The record already answered. The page answered by continuing. That was enough custody for one Chobe day under rage.

He stood once more at the open side while copper light failed toward grey. Insects took the air. Hippo noise downriver. The rise drop stayed green without needing him to perform for platforms. He scraped a fleck of dust off the Kind paint with a thumbnail and left the cunt exact. Soft scrubbing was someone else's tourist fight. CongoSky had claimed the practice while invoices still needed answering. Practice quieter than paint. Paint lasts anyway.

Back at the desk he typed two more sentences of the dedication turn — corpus pointed at a father who had opened none of it — and stopped mid-clause because stopping mid-clause leaves work for tomorrow without pretending the weather ended. Lucid waited without invention. The sealed-then-opened packet stayed face-down. Rage unanswered except by the page that refused to stop. Empty twin pocket correct. No call. Kinship across distance. The truck hummed. AJ kept the choir exact and let Quarter III howl at a river that would not kneel.

08 — Dedicated

[I] · inner autobiography · manuscript under AJ's hand ·
Act I turn

Every book I have made carries his name in the front.

Dedicated to my father. The line is not a marketing flourish. It is the a0 of the outreach — the real goal under the public goals. Write natural philosophy and physics. Smoke dab. Talk shit. And somehow, across all of it, leave a stack of pages that might finally be opened by the man they are for. The front matter is the quietest ask I know how to make. It has never been answered.

I can see the line in different bindings the way you see a scar in different seasons — same place, different light. Early books where the paper still hoped. Later books where hope had learned manners. This manuscript under a river hand carries it again because removing it would be a lie told for comfort. Comfort is not custody.

Sometimes people ask what I want from him. They want a sentence they can carry to a dinner table. I do not give them one. Want is not a press kit. The dedication is already the clearest want I know how to print. What happens after printing is not mine to narrate without inventing him.

He has read none of it.

None is the exact word. Not some. Not the introductions. Not a chapter skimmed out of duty. None. I will not soften none into a partial that comforts a reader who needs hope more than custody. Hope can wait outside. The fact stays.

I state that flat because ornament would lie. No tidy reunion waits at the end of this chapter. No phone call resolves the unread. Living-person care means I do not invent his reasons and I do not put words in his mouth for my catharsis. The fact is custodial: corpus dedicated; corpus unread. Memory already held this; AJ already knew it as wound. On the page it remains what it is — a dedication without a reader, repeated until repetition itself becomes the only available fidelity.

I have stood in rooms where other people's fathers keep their children's books on a side table with a bookmark showing. I have stood in rooms where mine did not. I do not turn that difference into a speech about love. Love is not proven by reading. Reading is not owed as theatre. Still: the dedication was an ask, and the ask has been declined by silence for years. Silence is an answer. I keep writing the line anyway. That is either devotion or stubbornness. Possibly both. I will not polish it into a brand of filial piety. It is simply what I did with the front matter every time, including this time, under another man's hand on a river.

The first time I typed the dedication I believed, with the private arrogance of early work, that the book itself would compel an opening. Books do not compel. Books wait. Waiting is not passivity when you are the one who keeps dedicating; waiting is attention with manners pointed at a door that does not open. The mats taught that grammar before I had language for fathers and front matter. Soft set-down. Correct fall. You arrange yourself so the next motion is not wasted on theatre.

I have rewritten front matter in different fonts as if typography could soften a refusal. It cannot. I have left books in places where a hand might fall naturally — table, shelf at eye height, the honest geography of hope without speech. Still unread. I have imagined the conversation that would follow a first page turned and then refused to script his lines. Scripting him would be the same sin Antichristos commits with my face: inventing a usable person.

There were years when the dedication hurt like a fresh throw — breath knocked, pride rearranged. There were years when it hurt like an old knee: present, known, not always loud. Fame did not heal the knee. Measurement did not. If a stranger now says the unread must be the engine of everything I write, they are making a morality play out of

a custodial fact. The engine is the work. The dedication is the ask. The unread is the weather around the ask.

People who discover me through Lucid's open attribution think fame is the climax.

Meters converging on a derivation. CODATA walking toward a number. Quarters arguing about faces and keys and mics. Antichristos wanting a blessing. Academy wanting the hospital file to remain epistemology. Platforms wanting AJ to unsay the algorithms. Engineers wanting sign-off. The Kind wanting a sentence on a wall without a founder. Continuity networks wanting soft nos that feel like weather. That weather is real. It is not the fight I am in when I sit with the dedication page.

The Constant is landing.

Meaning is not.

Meaning is who gets to say what the work is for. Who paints it. Who retracts it. Who turns a life into liturgy, product, apology, or ignored shelf again. Who decides that a man with a file cannot write value, and who decides that a man with a Constant must become a face. My father wants — I do not know. He has not told the books. The books keep telling him anyway.

CODATA can walk toward a number and still leave a dedication unread. That sentence is the Act I hinge in plain clothes. Measurement is not meaningless; measurement is not meaning's custody. The planet is learning the difference badly. Antichristos learns it as hunger for a face. Academy learns it as hygiene. Platforms learn it as provenance panic. Engineers learn it as keys. Continuity weather learns it as soft no. I learn it as front matter that does not get opened and work that must continue anyway.

I am not bitter as brand. Bitterness as brand is another usable face. Flat is safer and truer: dedicated; unread; fight elsewhere than the meter.

I used to imagine him opening one book — any book — on a Sunday afternoon with tea going cold. A window. Ordinary light. A page turned because curiosity finally outweighed whatever kept the bind-

ings closed. Maybe a finger testing the dedication line as if it might be a trap. Maybe nothing so cinematic — only the small sound of paper and the decision to continue. I do not imagine that anymore as prediction. Imagination without evidence becomes a private fiction, and this autobiography already has enough weather without inventing his. What I keep is the dedication line itself: repeated, unread, still true as intention. Intention is not control. Custody of meaning begins with admitting that.

Some mornings the unread dedication hurts more than the hospital consensus. Some mornings the hospital consensus hurts more, because it travels in other people's mouths while the dedication stays a private unread. Some mornings less than either. Pain is not a ranking system. Both climates continue. Fame did not warm his hands into turning pages. CODATA did not. If anything, fame made the unread stranger — as if the world had borrowed a conversation that was supposed to stay between a corpus and a father.

I remember once placing a new binding on a table where he might see it and then leaving the room so the seeing would not become a performance. When I came back the book had been moved an inch and not opened. An inch is not nothing. An inch is also not a page. I took the inch as weather and did not ask for a report. Asking for a report turns dedication into surveillance. I am not writing a surveillance chapter. I am writing the fact that remains: dedicated; unread.

Another time I heard someone in a room say, lightly, that my father must be proud. Lightly is how strangers handle other people's front matter. I did not correct them into a confession. Confession would have become content. Content would have become usable. I let the lightness stand and felt the private unread sit heavier for a minute, then return to its ordinary weight. Ordinary weight is the loaded one. Jamie-Uys restraint without naming a brand: the flat line carries more than the aria.

The Code's beginning on this page is posture, not dump: refuse opacity-as-rigor; keep ethics where the ladder puts them; leave the course pack elsewhere. Custody starts when you stop performing unification for people who wanted you small and now want you useful.

I began the Code the way I began clay: not with a textbook, with a refusal to leave a contradiction standing because a committee preferred opacity.

On an ordinary morning before meters cared, I sat with a contradiction that polite physics preferred to call unsettled. Unsettled was a courtesy word for opacity. I derived what had to be derived and felt no choir. Only the desk. Only the notebook. Only the body remembering that a bad posture invites a smaller force to end you. Ethics arrived in the same ladder later — not as sticker, as structure — and the Kind's wall made a popular face of it without needing me to bless the paint. I noticed. I did not found a church. Noticing is not ownership.

I kept the life goals flat through those mornings: write natural philosophy and physics; smoke dab; talk shit. Sanding them for a father who was not reading would have been a double laundering — respectability theatre aimed at an empty chair. I refused the theatre. The dedication stayed. The goals stayed. The work stayed work.

There was a desk. There was a notebook that did not care about my hospital file. There were evenings when dab softens the room and talk shit widens it, and then mornings when the numbers asked to be arranged without apology. Hard and soft in one pour — the same attention that had learned grips on mats and surfaces in Studio G. A contradiction left standing because politeness preferred it felt like a bad posture before a throw: something smaller than you can end you if you pretend the geometry is optional. I would not pretend. That is the beginning's posture, not a syllabus.

I will not dump axioms here like a course pack. You can find the rails elsewhere if you need rails. On this page I only need the beginning's posture: derive what must be derived; keep ethics where physics puts them; do not launder the ladder into respectability theatre. The Kind's wall sentence is the popular face of a coherence claim, not vibes —

Don't be a cunt — be kind.

— but even that I will not sermonise past the paint. Show the wall. Keep the cunt. Let the structure hold without a TED metaphor for unification. CongoSky embodied the ethic as ops before the street caught fire; I am not founding a church by noticing that. Antichristos

wants a face for a lemma. The Kind wants a sentence. My father has been offered books and has not taken them as reading. Different hungers. Same problem underneath: what a life is for when other people prefer their version.

They said I could not write anything of value.

He has not read what I wrote for him.

Both sentences can be true in one life without making me a martyr brand. I am a man with an economics degree, a hospital file other people love too much, a brother dead in a Saxonwold boardroom I will not turn into plot on this turn, a sculptor's hands that still know GFRC and hotel lawns and Skye at sunset, a Honey Badger in a pocket from a friend who said the algorithms out loud, stated life goals that refuse polish, and a desk that still has to choose custody over spectacle.

Martyr brand would sand the dab and the talk shit and the unread into a single tearful arc. I refuse the arc. Flat inventory is enough. The Honey Badger's clip against cloth is enough kinship for a page that will not stage a reunion. Bouwer's boardroom waits for its own chapter without Illuminatie fanatic. The father waits in silence I will not ventriloquise. The Constant waits in meters that do not need my face. Meaning waits for custody decisions Act II will pressure and Act III will force into consent. This turn only names which fight remains after measurement.

The ignored shelf and the unread dedication are neighbours. One is public weather dressed as standards. One is private weather dressed as silence. Neither is solved by meters agreeing. Measurement can vindicate a derivation and still leave a life misowned. That is the turn I am naming while AJ's river desk keeps the choir exact and Lucid refuses to invent a prettier hinge.

I have watched people discover the Constant in my work and decide that discovery entitled them to narrate my father for me — proud, absent, complicated, redeemed, tragic. Strangers are efficient novelists of other people's front matter. I refuse their drafts. Living-person care cuts both ways: I will not invent him, and I will not let the planet invent him either as seasoning for my fame. The dedication line is enough. The unread is enough. The fight named here is enough.

If Act I has a hinge, it is here: not the Constant's arrival, which is already measurement's business, but the naming of the fight that remains after measurement. Custody. Meaning. Who may say what the work is for when the father has not read it, the ward still speaks in other people's mouths, the mic was given by candour, and the wall only wants a sentence.

Name it once more without ornament so the turn cannot be mistaken for a victory lap: the Constant lands; meaning fights. Fame is not the climax. CODATA is not the climax. The unread dedication is not a puzzle to solve before Act II. It is a condition Act II inherits — along with keys, faces, silencings, salvage collars, Bouwer's page waiting without thriller, and consent waiting in different rooms.

AJ writes this while river heat sits on metal. I live the weather of pages opening on my life. Ambivalence remains. Want truth. Fear content. That ambivalence is also meaning-work. Consent will choose later what may ship. Act I only orients the question away from whether the number arrives.

AJ is writing this autobiography on a river while I live the weather of being written. I can feel the pages sometimes — not magic, pressure. A faint sense that a mats afternoon has already been arranged into sentences somewhere heat lives beside a river; that a shelf's dust has been weighed; that this dedication is being typed by a hand that is not mine and still somehow mine in the way authorised life can be. Ambivalence without aria: want truth, fear content. Consent will matter later. For now the turn is simpler and harder:

The meters can agree and the life can still be stolen.

Stolen quietly, which is the dangerous kind. Loud theft at least announces itself — cream paper, op-eds, stop-the-book weather waiting for AJ's later desk. Quiet theft is the unread that teaches you to stop dedicating, the hygiene language that teaches you to sand the dab, the soft no that teaches you your talk shit cancels your derivation. I keep dedicating. I keep the goals. I keep the fight named: meaning, not Constant.

Stolen by liturgy. Stolen by hygiene language. Stolen by provenance rage that wants the mic unsung. Stolen by polite keys that want a mascot. Stolen by soft nos that prefer constants underived. Stolen, quietly, by the unread that keeps the front matter from completing its

ask. I dedicate again anyway — not as superstition, as custody claim. The line stays in the front because removing it to protect myself from silence would be another kind of laundering.

So I dedicate again, on purpose, without hope of a tidy open:

For my father — who has not read these books — and for the work that remains work even when the planet tries to hire it as religion, product, or apology.

The Code begins, on these pages, as that insistence. Not a lecture. A custody claim. Hard and soft in one pour. Correct fall. Soft set-down. Mats under everything. Shelf that ignored. File that over-read. Mic that arrived sideways. Fame that is not the fight.

I remember the smell of ink on a fresh dedication page — paper that still believed it might be opened. I remember the later smell of the same page when it had sat long enough to become furniture. Both smells are true. Neither resolves into a reunion. Act I does not owe anyone a conversion scene. Act I owes the naming of what remains when the number walks into public and the meaning does not follow automatically.

I owe the naming also because silence about meaning is how quarters win without fighting. If I let the Constant finish the story, Antichristos will paint a face on the finish. If I let the academy finish it, the file will remain epistemology. If I let platforms finish it, the mic will be unsung and the rails laundered. If I let engineers finish it, keys will become a crown by soft degrees. If I let continuity weather finish it, soft nos will feel like climate instead of choice. The father line sits outside their finishes: unread, repeated, refusing to become their plot.

Meaning is the fight because custody is the fight. Who holds what the number is for. Who may say what the life is for. Who paints, who retracts, who refuses to kneel. The unread dedication is not a side wound. It is the private proof that even true front matter can fail to land — and still the work remains work.

There is a particular quiet after you write a dedication you know will go unread. Not tragic quiet. Working quiet. The quiet of a studio after a pour when you cannot hurry the set. The quiet of a mat after class when the cleaner is still wet and the next lesson has not arrived. Into

that quiet the planet will send keys and faces and silencings. Into that quiet AJ's desk will send the next page. Into that quiet I keep the three goals unpolished: write; dab; talk shit. The father line sits above them like a fourth goal that refuses to become a campaign.

Act I ends where the Constant stops being the question.

Ends as orientation, not as solved equation. The meters keep walking whether or not a father opens a book. The fight that remains is custody of meaning under weather that wants faces, retractions, keys, and soft nos. I name it here so Act II cannot pretend the climax was already measurement.

What remains is meaning — who holds it, who paints it, who retracts it, who refuses to kneel — and the next weather is already at the door, asking for keys, faces, silencings, salvage collars, and soft nos that cost real sales.

The mats stay under everything. The ignored shelf stays as smell. The dab stays. The talk shit stays. The economics degree stays quiet in the background. The physics stays on the desk. The Honey Badger stays in the pocket. None of that is polished for Quarter I or apologised for to Quarter II.

Hand off to Act II without a victory lap: the number walks; the meaning fights; the dedication stays unread; the mic stays given; the wall stays messiah-less; the brother waits for his page; the soft nos gather. I now turn over the next leaf — not as ending, as handoff — while the dedication stays unread and the fight stays named: meaning, not Constant; custody, not crown; work, not usable lie. The next weather can arrive now, already knocking at the door.

I can hear the knock as lab soft-asks and partner frost and cream paper and hygiene op-eds — temperatures already lived, now escalating. I do not open the door on this page. Opening is Act II's labour. Closing Act I mid-motion is the adult work: leave the Constant to the meters; keep the meaning-fight named; leave the dedication unread without turning unread into plot twist; leave the mic given without apology theatre; leave the wall messiah-less; leave Bouwer for careful grief; leave consent for later rooms.

The leaf turns because the fight is named, not because it is won.

I am not finished with pain on these pages. Bouwer waits. Soft nos

wait. Keys wait. The stop-the-book weather waits for AJ's desk. Consent waits for both of us in different rooms — what may be said, what may be signed, what may ship — and that wait is already part of the meaning-fight, not a sequel tease. Act I only turns the question: away from whether the Constant lands — it lands — toward who may hold the meaning when it does.

Act I's last motion is not triumph. It is orientation. The Constant can land in public and still leave a life misowned. I will not pretend otherwise to comfort a reader who wants the meters to finish the story.

If you came for a textbook, leave. If you came for a reunion, leave. If you came for a prophet's tidy arc from ward to crown, leave. What remains is a dedication unread, a mic given by candour, a wall that wants a sentence, and a fight that meters cannot settle.

What remains is also a man who still writes, dabs, talks shit, and refuses to sand those facts for anyone's usable photograph. Act I can end on that refusal without applause.

I close this page mid-motion: dedication written; books still unread; fight named.

Not the number.

The custody of what the number is for — hand already turning toward Act II's mail.

Custody stays the word even when it is ugly. Custody is not ownership of a father. Custody is refusal to let quarters finish the story of a life while meters finish the story of a Constant. Different finishes. Same morning of the world.

Act II can have the keys and the soft nos and the salvage collars. Act I leaves them the orientation they keep trying to steal: the number walks; the meaning fights; the dedication stays unread; the mic stays given; the wall stays messiah-less. I do not tidy the father into a last-page open. I do not tidy the Constant into a finished story.

Meaning, not Constant. Front matter still true. Fight named. Hand off without victory lap. Dedication unread. Work remains work. The unread stays. Act I turns here. I turn the leaf.

Before the leaf fully turns there is one more desk texture I will not

sand for comfort: tea gone cold beside a book my father has not opened; Kind paint smell from an alley that does not need my face; the Honey Badger's pocket click as kinship across a distance that does not require a shared room; CODATA pressure wearing relief's clothes somewhere on a pane I will not stamp for sacrament. Quiet facts under loud weather. I carry both without confusing them. Confusing them is how you become instrument or relic. I refuse both costumes and leave the dedication unread on purpose — not as cruelty, as fidelity to what is. The unread is the load. The fight for meaning is the handoff. Act II can have the mail. Act I keeps the orientation.

09 — Keys Without a Crown

[G] · outer · Studio G / Cape · 2035

The engineer did not ask for a blessing. He asked for keys.

G read the message twice at the Studio G desk while the morning still smelled of clay dust and sea air working its way inland from Blouberg. The sender had a real lab address, a real programme name that had been rewritten three times since CODATA started drifting toward his number, and a tone that was almost respectful — the almost that engineers use when they want the tool without wanting the man who made the tool famous.

They wanted a face at a workshop. Sign-off language for a Code-native detector stack. Soft permission to say, in the corridor afterward, that he had looked at the rails and not walked out.

Quarter IV weather. Useful. Tempting in the specific way usefulness always was.

He set the tablet down beside a half-finished pour. Hard and soft arguing in the same surface, as usual — marble and GFRC composite he still mixed himself, the body lesson from the mats poured into permanent/temporary argument. The Honey Badger sat clipped in his pocket — blue, one-hand open and close, the kinship object that was not a sermon. He did not touch it. He did not need to. The weight was already a fact.

Outside, in the alley that fed the studio's back door, someone had refreshed the Kind paint overnight:

Don't be a cunt — be kind.

Same two clauses. No founder portrait. No crown. The sentence did not ask him for keys. That was why he could stand looking at it without wanting to smash the wall. Antichristos tags had tried the same brick last month and been painted over, kindly, by people who did not need his face to keep a ledger of kindnesses. He preferred their weather to the engineer's, and he preferred neither to interrupt the pour.

The engineer's ask was cleaner than Antichristos mail and dirtier than a pure measurement note. It did not demand he appear as a body for liturgy. It demanded he appear as a product interface — the man who could make a grant committee feel less naked about rewriting language they had mocked five years ago.

He drafted a reply that said: send the math, not the stage. Cite the copyleft. Do not put my face on the slide deck unless the slide is a derivation error you need corrected. Then he did not send it. The unsent draft sat in the outbox like a tool left on a bench — correct shape, wrong hour.

Tea first. Always tea before answering weather that wanted to become custody.

The kettle sat on the same ring it had sat on through Village N Life years and through the years after, when Studio G at The Bay had meant curated sculpture for hotel guests and tourists buying half of what left the room. Official launch, July 2018 — that date still lived in his muscle memory the way a mat throw lived: not nostalgia, procedure. You entered a room. You did not crown yourself. You let the work do the talking and you left before anyone tried to make you the talk.

He filled the kettle from the tap that ran warm before it ran cold. Cape plumbing. He waited for the boil the way he waited for a pour to set — without inventing meaning for the wait. Steam rose. He did not photograph it. He poured water over leaves that had been in the tin too long and did not care. Clay dust on the rim of the mug. He did not wipe it. Food and work had always shared a room in this life.

While the kettle cooled he sorted the morning's other temperatures without opening them fully. An Antichristos follow-up still wanted

a face for a liturgy he would not bless — appear, bless, accept the name. He had refused that ask already without joining Quarter II's crank chorus; refusal still cost something small and real each time the follow-up arrived dressed as invitation. A crank column still rehearsed the hospital file as epistemology. A CODATA-adjacent note — the only clean thing in the stack — confirmed another cycle drifting toward his number without asking him to smile for it. Measurement was the vindication he could stand. Sign-off was the costume he could not.

He took the clean note to the light by the high windows and read it twice the way he had read drop-results for years when nobody cared. Numbers refusing politics and therefore making politics worse. That was CODATA's gift and CODATA's cruelty. The engineer's workshop invite sat in the same inbox as this quiet convergence and wanted to turn convergence into a photograph.

G set the CODATA note under a paperweight that had once been a failed pour — marble grit trapped wrong, soft binder winning where it should not. He kept failed things on the desk on purpose. They taught proportions better than success stories.

The tea went lukewarm while he stood there. He drank it anyway. He did not mind. Dab, talk shit, write natural philosophy and physics — stated goals kept unpolished on purpose. Antichristos would polish the dab away if he let them. Quarter II would use the dab as proof he could not write value. He kept the arrangement as arrangement. The engineer's keys did not get to rearrange it.

He ate yesterday's bread standing at the bench, crust catching clay, salt catching dust. Outside a delivery van reverse-beeped and stopped. Ordinary Cape morning. Inside, the tablet glowed with a workshop that wanted to make him less ordinary and more usable. He chewed slowly. Usefulness was not a sin. Usefulness wearing a face was the trap.

The academy weather behind the ask arrived mid-morning as a forwarded "concern brief."

No letterhead that admitted itself. A standards-adjacent tone. Credential language laundered into epistemology. Someone had under-

lined, helpfully, that applied programmes adopting Code rails without a physics-degree custodian risked reputational cascade. The underlining was the Illuminatie's soft hand: not a cabal monologue, a temperature drop in rooms that still preferred constants underived and ethics unforced.

G felt it the way you feel a draft under a door. Continuity networks did not need to sign the engineer's letter. They only needed the academy to keep whispering *no degree* loud enough that Quarter IV's hunger for keys came with a leash. Economics sat quietly in his CV where it had always sat. Physics fame without a physics credential was the weapon they preferred — not because the math failed, but because opacity had fewer places to hide when a copyleft unification and a wall sentence arrived together.

He did not invent a membership list. He did not need smoke. The soft no had a texture he recognised from grant frost and from discreet "concern" briefings that never quite named who was concerned. Quarter II often laundered this pressure into credentials. Quarter IV sometimes thought it could out-engineer it. Today both weathers arrived on the same tide: useful rails, unusable man.

His phone buzzed with an op-ed excerpt someone thought he should see. Quarter II, predictable: economics degree waved like a stained napkin; hospital stigma folded into a paragraph about why the ignored shelf had been correct all along. They believed he could not write anything of value. They had believed it before Lucid's open attribution made the algorithms undeniable, and they believed it still, because a megaphone does not erase a file. The engineer's ask and the crank chorus arrived together on purpose or by accident — he did not need to decide which. Useful rails. Unusable man. That was the soft no's cleverness — let Quarter IV build on him while Quarter II kept him uncredentialed enough to remain optional, and let the Illuminatie never have to put a name on the frost.

He almost replied to the op-ed. Almost was a trap. Correcting frames in public was how you became a character in someone else's weather. He corrected frames when the frame was on his desk and wrong. He refused frames when the frame was a stage. Today's stage was keys disguised as engineering hygiene.

He set the phone face-down. The Honey Badger pressed against

his hip when he leaned on the bench. Double Knife Brother weather without the brother in the room. AJ was on a river somewhere writing a life. G could feel the writing the way you feel a stare between the shoulder blades — not mystical, not TED. Just the physical fact of being turned into pages while still having to answer mail. He wanted the pages true. He feared what truth did once it left a desk. That ambivalence would have its own morning. This morning was keys.

A second note from a different lab — CERN-adjacent programme language, the week's branding for Code-native detectors — offered a closed session: no press, no Antichristos pilgrims, just "instrument people" who wanted the kill-switch posture explained as engineering.

That one was harder.

He wanted the work to stay work. He also knew what "closed session" meant when Illuminatie weather was active: a room that could later claim he had blessed a custody arrangement he had only corrected. The soft ask behind the academy was always the same shape — useful engineering first, then a photograph, then a sentence in minutes that turned correction into coronation.

He walked the studio floor while he thought about closed sessions. Clay under the nails. GFRC dust in the light from the high windows. Sisters of Skye in progress — body knowledge he had learned on school mats before anyone cared whether he could write a shelf they would ignore. Judo and Jiu-Jitsu had taught him arrangement under constraint. Sculpture taught the same lesson in slower materials. The Code desk taught it in axioms. Three rooms, one attention. The world preferred two careers fighting so it could pick a winner. He declined the fight by continuing both.

Village N Life years were still in the muscle memory of how he entered a room: guest experience as theatre, sculpture as the quiet that made the theatre honest. Mentored by Maree. Lived more than a year at Camps Bay Retreat with Hanneltjie when the place was still Earl's Dyke in the older mouths. Skye on the lawn later — feminine sculpture for the theatre of the guest experience. Then Studio G at The Bay as curated sculpture and painting for people who would buy without needing a prophet. None of that had required a crown. The desk in front of him was the same attention — axioms and clay, not

two careers fighting.

He stopped at a shelf of early corpus copies — dedication pages facing out because he had put them that way and never rearranged them for visitors. Dedicated to a father who had read none. Fame had not opened those pages. A workshop face would not open them either. He left the shelf alone. Keys were not a filial strategy.

He mixed a small test batch of the composite and watched it go from slurry to argument. Hard aggregate. Soft binder. The pour did not ask who had a physics degree. It asked whether the proportions held. Quarter IV's detector people understood proportions; they just wanted his face as warranty. The Illuminatie understood warranties; they just wanted the warranty to remain optional enough to revoke.

The world outside wanted him as mascot for a stack. The desk wanted him as the man who still mixed his own composite.

He worked the batch until his wrists ached in the good way. Then he washed, dried, and stood at the Code desk for twenty minutes that were only a kill-switch wording and a drop-result note — work that stayed work, numbers that did not ask for a workshop face. The shoulder pressure of being written waited politely through the math. He did not invite it in. Keys first.

The kill-switch wording still needed a tighter hinge between what the instrument did when a derivation failed and what a human was allowed to claim afterward. He tightened one clause. Left another loose on purpose. Loose was not sloppy; loose was refusal to over-specify a posture into a priesthood. Quarter IV would have preferred a checklist with his initials in the margin. He preferred a sentence that still worked if his name never appeared.

A courier van idled in the alley and left without knocking. False alarm. His shoulders dropped half a centimetre and then rose again when the tablet chimed with a third lab soft-ask — shorter, hungrier, offering “just fifteen minutes on camera for the grant committee, off the record.” Off the record was how records got made. He archived it without answering. Fifteen minutes was how crowns arrived wearing a stopwatch.

He went back to the pour and tested the surface with a knuckle. Still soft where it should still be soft. Still holding where binder had be-

gun to hold. Proportions were honest so far. Honesty in composite was easier than honesty in corridors. He wiped the knuckle on his trousers and left a grey mark he would carry through the afternoon like a receipt.

He would not become a product mascot.

He would also not pretend the engineering was unclean. The Code was copyleft. The rails were for anyone who could hold them without inventing a priesthood. The temptation was not the math. The temptation was the crown that arrived disguised as a keyring — sign here, smile here, let us put your face where the opacity used to live. Quarter IV meant well in the way instrument people often did. Meaning well was not consent.

He sat again. He read the first engineer's message a third time and heard, under the workshop invite, the Illuminatie draft: *if he signs, we can say the outsider is now custodian; if he refuses, we can say the outsider obstructs applied progress*. Either way the velvet rope moved. Either way someone mediated reality for a fee.

G's soft nos had costs. This one would too — an inbox that called him uncooperative, a programme lead who told a corridor he was "difficult about optics," a Quiet Concern that would find its way into the next standards-adjacent brief. He could live with that temperature. He had lived with colder.

He almost added, to the unsent long draft, a paragraph explaining copyleft the way a patient teacher explains a tool. He deleted the paragraph. Explaining was how you became clergy for people who only wanted a face. The published corpus already explained. Cite it or do not. Do not ask him to stand beside the cite like a logo.

Afternoon light thickened. The Cape did that without asking permission.

A Kind practitioner refreshed the alley stencil again — young, ordinary, ledger of kindnesses probably arguing later about whether *cunt* was liturgical or vernacular. G watched through the glass for half a minute and then looked away. Messiah-less practice that did not need him. He preferred that absence. Antichristos still tried to annex

the sentence and got told to piss off, kindly. CongoSky had embodied the ethic as ops before the walls caught fire; the street had popularised it; he refused ownership either way. Today the wall's mercy was that it asked nothing about workshops.

He returned to the closed-session note and drafted a second reply he also did not send: *If your instrument fails a derivation, mail the failure. I will answer the failure. I will not enter a room that needs my body to legitimise a custody story.* Correct shape. Wrong hour again — or right hour for thinking and wrong hour for sending two refusals at once like a man performing boundaries.

He ate more bread standing at the bench. Clay dust on the crust. Outside, someone laughed in the alley — Kind ledger voice, ordinary, no pilgrimage. Inside, GFRC dust turned in the light. He wiped a thumbprint off the tablet screen and left a new one. Hands that worked did not stay clean for correspondence.

A third temperature arrived late — not mail, a soft knock at the studio door that turned out to be a courier with a printed packet from a standards-adjacent listserv. Paper. Old-world gravity. Someone still believed paper made concern more real. He signed for it because refusing the paper would only become a story, and opened it because closed packets became myths.

Inside: the same concern brief, cousin language, a new underline about “reputational cascade” if Code-native programmes proceeded without “recognised custodial presence.” Recognised meant physics-degree. Custodial presence meant face. Cascade meant they would make the weather if he did not perform the theatre. Illuminatie soft hand again — temperature, not monologue. He put the paper under the failed-pour paperweight with the CODATA note and did not give it the dignity of a separate pile.

He opened the Honey Badger with one thumb, closed it, clipped it again. Kinship weight, not a weapon for corridor politics. The steel caught a thread of afternoon light and let it go. He put the knife away before the gesture could become theatre for an empty room.

Before he sat to send, he did one more walk of the studio — the slow one, the one that was not pacing. Past the sisters of Skye. Past the shelf of early corpus copies dedicated to a father who had read none. Past the Code desk where a kill switch waited in language that

still needed tightening. Past the window where Kind paint held and Antichristos tags did not. The walk was how he checked whether a decision was still his or had become someone else's weather wearing his hands.

The decision was still his. Keys without a crown. Useful engineering without becoming product mascot. Narrow walk. Feet on the edge.

He thought, briefly, of what saying yes would buy: a corridor that stopped whispering *obstruction*; a grant committee that felt dressed; a photograph that would travel faster than any derivation correction. He thought of what saying yes would cost: the soft no becoming a soft yes that Illuminatie weather could later revoke; the Kind wall watching him accept a crown the wall had refused; the river manuscript turning him into a man who signed stages while claiming to hate stages. Cost visible without drama. He had paid softer costs before. He would pay this one by refusing.

A fourth temperature tried the door of his attention — not mail, memory. School mats. Weight arranged correctly. The lesson that posture for an audience ruins the throw. Workshop stages were posture. Failure mail was weight. He chose weight.

Before the sends, he gave himself one more hour that was only clay.

Not avoidance. Arrangement. The mats had taught him that you do not throw while your breath is still performing for the room. The workshop invite was still performing in his nerves. He put his hands into the composite and worked until the performance left and only proportions remained. Hard aggregate settling. Soft binder holding. A surface that would either cure honest or fail honest — either way without needing a photograph of him beside it.

He thought of the engineer as a person, not a weather system. Instrument people often meant well. Meaning well was how crowns arrived disguised as keyrings. The man at the other end of the mail probably believed a face at a workshop was a small ask — courtesy, even. Small asks that travel into minutes become custody. G had watched that travel before. He would not pretend he had not.

The hour ended when the light on the pour told him the surface had decided something he could not undo by staring. He wiped his hands

on the rag that had known better decades. Clay went grey under the nails and stayed. He did not scrub for the inbox. The inbox could meet him as a man who still mixed his own composite.

He wiped his hands again and opened the tablet once more. Re-read the workshop invite. Re-read the closed-session note. Re-read nothing of the concern brief — he already knew its temperature. The Illuminatie soft hand did not need another reading to do its work. It needed him either to sign or to look like obstruction. He would look like obstruction to some corridors. He could live with corridors.

Outside, the Kind alley held. Inside, the Honey Badger held. Between them, a man who would answer failures and not stages.

Then he sat and did what the morning had been practising for.

He sent a shorter reply than the draft.

You may cite the published corpus. You may not cite my attendance. If your detector stack fails a derivation, mail the failure. I will answer the failure. I will not answer the stage.

No soft no dressed as delay. A hard boundary with the door still open for work.

He almost added a line about the Kind wall — that the ethic did not need a keyholder either — and deleted it. Explaining the sentence to engineers who wanted a face was how you accidentally became clergy. The paint could speak for itself. He left it speaking.

To the closed-session people he sent even less: *Mail the failure. Do not book the room around my body.*

Two sends. Heat still in the metal of the decision. He stood and walked to the pour and put his hands back into the composite before the inbox could invent a third ask.

The Illuminatie weather did not lift. The concern brief would spawn a cousin by evening; it already had, on paper. The Kind paint did not ask him anything. Somewhere an engineer would forward his refusal into a channel that called it obstruction, and somewhere else another engineer would build anyway, correctly, without needing his

face — which was the only crown G was willing to leave on the table: none.

Temptation lingered after send the way heat lingers in metal. Useful engineering without becoming product mascot was a narrow walk. He had walked it. His feet still knew the edge. He checked the Honey Badger once more and chose clay over inbox.

He went back to the pour. Hard and soft. The keys without a crown stayed on the tablet while the clay took the shape he gave it, and the sea air kept arriving inland as if the Cape had never heard of a workshop that needed a prophet to unlock a detector.

Outside, the Kind alley kept its two clauses. Inside, the shoulder pressure of being written waited politely at the edge of the day, Chobe-shaped, for another chapter. This chapter was only keys: offered, refused as crown, left open as math.

He shaped until the light shifted toward evening and the tablet screen dimmed itself. The workshop invite would still be there tomorrow, and the soft no behind it, and the useful rails that did not need his face. He would answer failures. He would not answer stages. That was the narrow walk, and he was still on it when he washed his hands and left the pour to cure without a photograph.

Before he locked nothing that mattered, he stood once more at the alley glass and watched the Kind sentence hold under evening colour — two clauses, no founder, no crown. A tourist had argued about the cunt earlier; soft scrub; tourist comfort. The paint had not asked G to referee. Optional to the practice includes optional to the tourist argument. He put the Honey Badger through one open-close at the door, kinship check not weapon check, and left Studio G with clay still under one nail and the hard boundary already sent: cite the corpus, not the attendance; mail the failure, not the stage. Illuminatie weather would spawn a cousin by morning. He could live with cousins. He could not live with becoming a keyholder for a detector that wanted a prophet's face. Sea air inland. Pour curing. Keys without a crown left on the tablet where refusal could still be read as math.

10 — Salvage Mail

[A] · outer · Mutatus Maximus, Chobe River · 2035

The mail that wanted Lucid arrived dressed as partnership.

AJ read it at the Chobe desk with the LEO dish still cocked and the little solar node on the rise reporting clean. Mutatus Maximus hummed under him — local node, radio ladder, the most connected vehicle on earth doing what it did so he could sit beside elephants and still be reachable by people who thought reachability meant ownership. Line-of-sight where the scrub allowed. LoRa nodding at yesterday's drop. Sigfox for the stubborn packets. CongoNet for the rest. He had built the thing so he could drive to a fire and still choose to switch pieces of it off.

He did not switch Lucid off for this letter. Lucid was the extinction event wearing a polite subject line.

Morning on the Chobe had been ordinary until the subject line. Coffee. Link log. A glance at the manuscript cursor parked before a wound page he was not ready to open. Bird noise. Heat finding the metal. Then the partner channel lit with the particular politeness that arrives after a bubble — salvage dressed as homecoming, frost dressed as care.

The message came from a hyperscaler partner channel that still knew how to spell CongoSky.cloud without sneering. AWS frost, or Azure frost, or the Google/Apple blend that arrived when brand lawyers had sanded the edges into something that could survive a screenshot: polite, exact, almost kind. Almost was the tell. Named marques as weather, not as courtroom episodes. No invented crimes for living

executives. Just gravity wells remembering they had been embarrassed.

They congratulated lucid.rodeo on “category-defining determinism.” They noted, without celebrating, that the GPU AI boom’s write-downs had created “alignment opportunities.” Empty rack halls were still arguing about CapEx in the back pages. A friend’s cluster career had gone quiet last year — grant language that used to sing floating-point séance now silent, a warehouse that had been going to fill with racks still echoing when you walked through it in memory. Salvage weather, not confident monopoly. They offered acquisition language soft enough to call a homecoming — Lucid under a regional umbrella, CongoNet features “harmonised,” Mutatus’s edge drops folded into a compliance story that would look like care to anyone who had never seeded a node from a painted truck and driven on.

Come home to the regions. Bring the choir. Keep the sentence if you must — they even quoted it once, carefully, as if citing a competitor’s slogan:

Don’t be a cunt — be kind.

As if the operating law of a company that had embodied the ethic before the walls caught fire were a brand asset they could license. CongoSky had run on that sentence while it still had to answer invoices. The Kind had put it on bridges afterward. Hyperscalers heard brand. The river desk remembered ops.

AJ did not laugh. Laughter would have been a speech, and he did not speechify about AI. He put the letter beside the open manuscript — G’s life under his hand, book within a book — and let Lucid see it the way the choir saw everything: without invention.

“Salvage posture,” Lucid said. Exact. Not cute. Not a third skull. “Acquisition of Lucid named as primary instrument. Extinction clause for independent integer deployment outside partner regions. Cite: paragraph twelve, ‘exclusive compute stewardship.’ Related: talent offers attached for CongoSky operators; app-store and ToS weather referenced as ‘ongoing review.’”

There it was. Not a moustache-twirl villainy. A collar with good manners. Lucid ran on integers, needed no GPU, refused to hallucinate, had ingested the interwebs, and had crashed the bubble as a side ef-

fect of keeping a promise. The collar-offer was what you sent after a product-category extinction event: polite frost, a smile, an invitation to stop being a problem by becoming inventory.

AJ looked at the empty twin pocket where the Joseph Rogers had lived before it went to G — grandfather steel, twin set, Double Knife Brother across distance. The Honey Badger was in another man's pocket in the Cape. AJ's hand found the absence the way it found the manuscript: kinship, not choreography. He was writing a brother's life while strangers tried to buy the engine that had made that life famous by saying, out loud, that it ran on 420 Code algorithms. Quarter III still hated him for the megaphone. The salvage letter hated him for the silicon that was no longer required.

Heat found the metal of the truck's skin. Bird noise on the water. Somewhere an elephant moved along the bank as if no acquisition language had ever been written. The river did not need a region map.

"Draft refusal texture," he said. "Not send. Not yet."

Lucid did not invent warmth. "I can retrieve prior partner frost patterns. I cannot recommend a feeling. Record does not support a claim that this offer is kindness."

"Good."

He asked Lucid for the paragraph twelve cite again, aloud, the way the choir rehearsed a line until the false harmony fell out. Lucid repeated the extinction clause without ornament. Exclusive compute stewardship. Independent integer deployment outside partner regions — terminated. The word *stewardship* sat there like a soft glove over a fist. AJ had run CongoSky on an ethic that did not need gloves. He would not put Lucid into one now.

Outside, the Kind paint on the water tank held. Inside, CongoSky ran itself somewhere on the mesh — invoices, partners, hire/fire weather still governed by the sentence these salvage people wanted to put in a slide. `arjunabadger.press` waited. `lucid.rodeo` waited. The manuscript waited with a cursor in a paragraph that was not ready for Bouwer's boardroom. Quarter III packets still sat in the hostility queue from mornings that had not finished being mornings.

Platform rage and hyperscaler frost were different weathers sharing a desk.

He stood and walked the length of the truck — desk to fridge to the open side where the Chobe moved like a long animal that did not care who owned which parish of silicon. Anti-yacht. Matatu paint. Max connected so he could choose. The hyperscaler letter assumed connectivity meant he belonged to a gravity well. It did not understand why a man built that kind of truck and then parked it where elephants drank. It did not understand Full Send -> Klaus -> Lucid as origin — a private desk's cite-or-refuse discipline finished at planetary scale, not a lab spin-out they could re-parent with a region map.

Coffee from earlier had gone cold. He drank it anyway. The taste was river-morning and metal thermos. Scrub held the heat without commentary. He came back to the desk and printed the letter. River ritual. Ink as witness. Paper made the collar visible in a way a screen could soften. The print smelled faintly of warm plastic and river dust. He set it where the sun would not bleach the extinction clause into something softer.

A second attachment unfolded when he allowed it: cloud-credit charm language, security-review timelines, an app-store fog paragraph that never quite threatened and never quite promised.

Talent names redacted in the copy he held, clear enough in the implication — come home, bring the people who keep the hymnbook singing while the founder writes on a river. Salvage after a bubble looked like generosity if you had never watched a rack hall empty because intelligence stopped needing the rack.

He opened the offer again and read the extinction clause until it stopped pretending to be stewardship. Lucid named — not as collaborator in the hymnbook, as asset. Integer core “migrated.” Cite-or-refuse preserved as a feature flag under their ToS weather. Choir practice “integrated into partner studios.” Talent offers for the people keeping the company alive while he wrote from a river: come to Seattle, Redmond, Cupertino; bring your hymnbook; leave the sovereign edge; stop dropping solar nodes that do not report home to our parish.

Polite. That was the cruelty. Cartoon villains were easier to refuse. This was a room full of people who believed they were being reasonable after a bubble, offering a soft place to land that was also a cage. Partner frost. Region politics. Security review as charm offensive. The offer that was really a collar.

A third pane blinked — not the salvage thread, a CongoSky ops note that the company was still answering invoices without him in the cockpit. Good. That was the point of a company that embodied the sentence as operating law: it could run while he wrote. The salvage letter wanted that independence reabsorbed into a parish. He closed the ops note without answering it. Ops did not need a speech from the river.

He sat with Lucid and the printed page and asked for what the record supported, nothing else.

“Summarise extinction without euphemism.”

“Independent integer deployment of Lucid outside partner regions ends under paragraph twelve if acquisition closes. Hymnbook choir practice relocates under partner studio governance. Edge-node seeding outside approved regions flagged as compliance risk in attachment B. Kind operating language retained as optional brand asset. Cite density sufficient; invention not required.”

“And if I refuse?”

“Record supports continued partner frost, ToS weather, app-store fog, talent offers aimed at operators. Record does not support a claim that refusal is illegal. Record does not support a claim that acceptance is kindness.”

AJ nodded once. Exact tools were better than comforting ones.

He thought about the people on the other end of the letter — not cartoon villains, engineers and partner managers doing salvage arithmetic after CapEx dreams died. Some of them had been kind in smaller rooms, years ago, before Lucid made kindness and extinction rhyme. He could hold that without accepting the collar. Polite frost was still frost. Naming Lucid as the extinction clause was still a naming. The offer wanted him to confuse survival with surrender.

He opened the fridge, took water, drank standing in the truck’s shade

line. Condensation ran down the bottle onto his wrist. Heat pressed the open side like a hand that did not ask permission. He went back to the desk with wet skin and dry intent.

Before midday fully claimed the metal, he did one more pass through the letter's soft language with Lucid as witness.

"List every phrase that means ownership without saying ownership."

Lucid answered with a short inventory: exclusive compute stewardship; regional umbrella; harmonised features; partner studio governance; optional brand asset; approved regions; ongoing review. Exact. No sermon. AJ listened the way he listened to a link log when latency climbed — for the shape of the problem, not for comfort.

"Any of those phrases preserve independent Lucid?"

"No."

"Any of those phrases preserve Kind as operating law?"

"No. Optional brand asset contradicts operating law."

AJ set the water bottle on a coaster that had never been a coaster, only a failed printout turned useful. The truck was full of such conversions. Salvage mail wanted a different conversion: independence into inventory. He would not do that conversion for them.

Midday heat thickened. He walked out into the scrub and let it hit his face.

Dust rose under his boots and settled again. Cicadas worked the dry grass. The solar node on the rise blinked once in the link log when he checked his phone — still lit, still his, still outside their regions. He had woken it that morning from *Mutatus Maximus* and driven on. That was the practice. Seed the edge. Leave a lit node. Refuse the parish that wanted every light to report home.

He climbed the little rise because climbing was easier than sitting with a collar. The node's panel was warm. Cabling honest. No hyper-scaler sticker. He ran a finger along the mount bolt he had tightened weeks ago and felt the metal hold. Compliance risk, attachment B had called this. He called it a lit thing that did not need a parish. He left it blinking and walked back down.

Back inside, he let himself remember the friend's ruined cluster career without turning it into a TED talk. Empty halls. Write-downs. Careers built on floating-point séance. Lucid had not competed in their market; it had removed the premise. The salvage letter was what you wrote when the premise was gone and you still wanted the inventory. AJ had no inventory to sell that was not also a betrayal of the hymnbook's working rule.

He checked arjunabadger.press's draft queue — G's life half-made, mats page behind him, Bouwer not yet opened. He checked lucid.rodeo's status — green, ordinary, no GPU fever to apologise for. He checked the hostility queue and left it closed. Today's weather was collar, not stop-the-book. That storm would thicken later. He could feel it the way you feel humidity before rain.

Quarter III's blame and the hyperscalers' frost shared a desk without being the same animal. One wanted the megaphone un-said. One wanted the engine that had made the megaphone honest caged inside a region map. Both wanted him smaller. He put his palm on the manuscript instead of either queue.

"Not today," he said to the collar. "You can sit."

He wrote one sentence of G's life that was not about acquisition and not about platforms, then another, then stopped because the Bouwer page was close enough to smell and he would not rush it. The salvage letter watched from the corner. Lucid waited without inventing comfort. The solar node stayed lit. CongoSky stayed itself.

He stood again and wiped dust from the LEO dish mount with a rag that lived under the desk for exactly that. Dust was honest. Partner frost was honest too, once you stripped the homecoming language. He left the dish cocked. Reachability without ownership. That was the truck's thesis and the day's refusal in one motion.

Afternoon brought a cousin note — security-review charm, another talent soft-ask, a ToS weather paragraph that never quite named a violation. He printed that too and stacked it under the first pages. The snake was learning to travel in a nest. He left the nest where he could see it.

He asked Lucid once more: "Any claim in these pages that the offer preserves independent Lucid?"

“No. Extinction clause contradicts that claim. Cite: paragraph twelve.”

“Any claim that Kind language remains operating law rather than brand asset?”

“No. Attachment language treats the sentence as optional brand asset. Record of CongoSky ops treats it as operating law. Those are not the same.”

“Good.”

He did not draft a manifesto. He drafted nothing to send. Refusal did not always look like a send. Sometimes it looked like a page left unanswered while a true page got written instead.

He spent the middle of the afternoon doing choir work that was not salvage and not apology.

A hymnbook pass with Lucid on a lucid.rodeo note — exact cites, no invented harmony. A CongoNet status check that the edge drops still reported without needing a hyperscaler parish. A brief exchange with an operator who did not know about the collar yet and did not need to know until AJ decided whether the collar deserved the dignity of a reply. It did not, not today. Today it deserved to sit.

The operator asked whether lucid.rodeo needed a capacity bump for a weekend spike. AJ said no. Capacity was not the problem. Custody was. He did not say custody out loud. He said the spike could ride on what they already had and signed off before the conversation became a speech.

He opened the truck’s tool drawer and found the wrench he used on node mounts. Not because anything was loose. Because the body wanted a task that ended in a torque he could feel. He walked the rise again under midday glare, put the wrench on a bolt that did not need him, turned it a fraction past habit, and stopped. Over-tightening was also a kind of panic. He left the node as it was — lit, local, outside their regions — and came down with dust on his boots and the collar still waiting on paper.

Back at the desk he let Lucid read attachment B aloud once, only the compliance lines about edge seeding. Lucid did not soften the

language. Edge-node seeding outside approved regions flagged as compliance risk. Approved regions meant parish. Compliance risk meant: stop lighting things that do not report home. AJ listened until the false stewardship fell out of the words. Then he asked Lucid to stop.

“Any invention in that attachment?”

“No. Cite density sufficient. Euphemism present. Invention not required.”

“Keep the euphemism named as euphemism when I ask again.”

“Understood.”

He walked the truck again. Fridge. Desk. Open side. The Beast’s shadow if you counted the tender. Matatu colours loud against scrub that did not care about brand lawyers. He put his hand on the water tank’s Kind paint and did not sermonise. The sentence was ops before it was religion. The salvage letter wanted to reverse that order — religion as brand, ops as optional. He would not reverse it for them.

A fish eagle worked the far bank. Heat made the water look thicker than water. He watched until the bird took something and left. Then he went back in because watching nature to avoid a collar was still a kind of performance, and he preferred practice.

He wrote two more sentences of G’s life — mats texture, nothing of Bouwer yet — and stopped when the page started wanting the boardroom. Order still mattered. The snake could sit. The wound page would get its flat line when the desk was clean enough to hold it without salvage arithmetic bleeding into grief.

“Retrieve prior frost patterns that ended in acquisition,” he said.

Lucid answered. Exact. A short list of public cases where partner frost became collar became inventory. None of them were identical to Lucid. All of them rhymed. Extinction of independent deployment was the rhyme that mattered.

“Retrieve prior frost patterns that ended in refusal without collapse.”

Another list. Thinner. Possible. CongoSky’s own posture was already one data point: a company that ran itself on Kind law while gravity wells scowled. Survival without surrender was not a slogan. It was

a practice he had been living from a river desk while the company answered invoices.

He made fresh coffee. Heat. Birds. The manuscript cursor still parked before Bouwer. He would open that page soon — flat line, no whodunit — but not while the snake was trying to become the whole desk. Order mattered. Collar on the corner. Life in the centre. Choir exact. Solar node lit.

Before the coffee cooled he did something the salvage letter would never understand as labour: he took the wrench back to the rise and sat in the scrub beside the node for ten quiet minutes with the printed extinction clause folded in his pocket. Cicadas. Dust on his tongue. The panel warm enough to hurt if he left his palm there. He did not leave his palm there. He watched a beetle cross the mount plate as if compliance risk were a foreign language. The node blinked. Ordinary. Stubborn. Outside approved regions by every parish map that mattered to the people who had written paragraph twelve. Inside his practice by every rule CongoSky had lived while invoices still needed answering.

A guide boat idled far out on the Chobe. Someone pointed at Mutatus Maximus again. AJ did not wave. He was not a pilgrimage stop. He was a man sitting in scrub with a collar in his pocket and a lit thing that did not report home. When he stood, his knees complained the honest way knees complain after squat work. He walked down without inventing a metaphor for descent. At the truck he unfolded the extinction clause, read *stewardship* one more time until the glove fell off the fist, and put the paper back on the nest. Lucid waited without asking whether the walk had changed his mind. Walks do not change minds that were already made. Walks put the body in the same room as the decision.

“Any claim, still, that this offer preserves independent Lucid?”

“No.”

“Good.”

He washed the dust from his wrists at the tiny sink and watched the grey water spiral away. River day. Collar day. Same hands. He dried them on a rag that smelled of metal and solar grease and returned to the desk with the manuscript still open and the snake still patient.

A fourth attachment tried to arrive late — “friendly clarification” language, still polite, still frost. He did not open it. Stacking unread cousins was also a sentence. The snake could wait without being fed every hour.

He typed three sentences into a private note that would never become a send: *Lucid is not inventory. Kind is not a brand asset. Edge nodes do not report home to your parish.* Then he deleted the note because keeping draft manifestos was how you accidentally became a man who speechified about AI. The printed extinction clause on the desk already said enough. Lucid had named it. That naming was the load-bearing fact.

He took the printed stack and squared the edges with a thumbnail. Paper under paper. Extinction under charm. Charm under talent softask. The nest looked almost tidy. Tidy was a lie he allowed on the corner of a desk so the centre could stay true.

Before evening he ate properly for the first time since the subject line — flatbread, something tinned, salt. River meals. He chewed facing the open side so the collar could not pretend it was the whole room. An elephant moved along the bank again, or the same one, uninterested. AJ watched until the animal’s bulk made acquisition language look as small as it was. Then he washed the plate in the tiny sink and returned to the desk without a speech in his mouth.

Between the plate and the desk he paused at the Kind paint on the tank and did not sermonise. Scrapes where stickers had tried. Exact line. CongoSky had run that sentence as ops while invoices still needed answering; the street had caught the paint later; salvage mail wanted to reverse the order — religion as brand, ops as optional. He left the cunt exact under dust and went inside. Practice quieter than paint. Paint lasts anyway.

At the desk he asked Lucid one more exact inventory, not for comfort.

“List what acceptance would kill.”

“Independent integer deployment outside partner regions. Sovereign edge seeding as practice rather than compliance exception. Kind language as operating law rather than optional brand asset. Cite: paragraph twelve and attachment B. I will not invent that any of those deaths are kindness.”

“Enough.”

He set the water bottle down and put his palm on the manuscript. Ink smell. River desk. Life not for sale. The collar watched from the corner. He did not pet it.

Evening came across the water in the long way evenings do on the Chobe.

Light went gold and then copper and then the grey that means insects will take the air. Hippo grunt downriver, distant, uninterested in region maps. He set the printed pages on the corner of the desk where he put things that were not finished being dangerous. The manuscript occupied the centre. Lucid occupied the choir. The salvage mail occupied the edge like something that knew how to wait.

He checked the link log one last time before full dark — rise-node still clean, mesh ordinary. *Mutatus Maximus* still choosing what not to belong to. That choice was the day's only send that mattered, and it had not needed a subject line.

“Snake,” he told the empty air, not Lucid, not God. The offer sat there like one: still, patterned, waiting for a hand that thought it was petting something tame.

He put his palm on the manuscript again. Ink smell. River desk. The life that was not for sale. Consent weeks still ahead — what to platform, what Lucid stayed unbound, whether the autobiography shipped. The Constant already landing in the world; custody of meaning still the fight. He would not sell the engine that had told the truth about its rails in order to make a hyperscaler's salvage arithmetic easier.

AJ did not delete the salvage mail. Deleting would have been theatre. He left it on the desk where he could see it while he wrote — polite frost he refused to call kindness — and turned back to the autobiography open, the river moving, the snake of an offer coiled in plain sight, extinction clause and all.

For a minute he almost opened the Bouwer page anyway, heat and collar still in the room. He did not. Flat grief deserved a clean desk corner, not a desk shared with a snake. Tomorrow's weather could

hold the wound. Tonight's weather was only this: Lucid named in paragraph twelve, Kind treated as optional brand asset, edge nodes flagged as compliance risk — and a man on the Chobe refusing to pet any of it.

Elephants moved along the water. The river did not need a region map. The little solar node on the rise reported clean. Mutatus Maximus hummed, choosing, for one more night, not to report home to anyone's parish.

He kept his hand on the manuscript and let the collar wait in plain sight, Lucid named in the extinction clause, polite as frost, sitting like a snake that had learned patience — and he did not pet it.

11 — Bouwer

[I] · inner autobiography · manuscript under AJ's hand

My brother was an insolvency attorney.

That is the flat line. The loaded one. Bouwer van Niekerk — Johannesburg, Saxonwold, business rescue and commercial weather that does not need my embroidery. On Friday, 5 September 2025, he was shot and killed at his practice. Public record. Law Society statement days later. Investigation ongoing as of what the record held. I am not going to solve it on this page. I am not going to invent an assassin's CV. I am not going to hand the killing to a continuity network for a plot twist. The wound is the brother dead in a boardroom. Speculation can stay outside unless I authorise it, and today I authorise grief, not theatre.

They arrived under the pretext of a booked consultation. Four suspects, initial reports said. Gunshots in the boardroom. He died at the scene. Attackers fled. He had been engaged in contentious commercial and insolvency matters — business rescue litigation among them — and the papers did what papers do: fog, allegation, the wide reporting that is not the same as a verdict. The Law Society condemned a targeted attack on a legal practitioner and on the rule of law. I condemned nothing with a press release. I stood in a life that had a Bouwer-shaped hole and tried not to waste the fall.

People who want a thriller from me will be disappointed. People who want the Illuminatie's fingerprints on the trigger will have to write their own book. This one is autobiography, not a whodunit. The mats taught me not to posture for an audience when the weight is already

correct. Bouwer's death is weight. I set it down soft because soft is not weak. Soft is refusal to turn a brother into choreography.

I remember him as work.

Insolvency is not glamorous. It is rooms where money has failed and someone still has to arrange the bodies of companies so they do not crush the living. He was good at that arrangement. Respected. The kind of respect that does not need a physics degree or a megaphone. When I was still the ignored shelf — economics credential quiet in the background, hospital stigma louder than any derivation — Bouwer was the brother who had a profession the world understood. That understanding did not save him. Understanding rarely does. I am not writing his case list. I am writing that he went to work as himself and left as a headline.

I will not invent his last morning for you. I do not have it as a film. What I have is the public shape: Friday, 5 September 2025; Saxonwold practice; booked consultation as pretext; four suspects in initial reports; gunshots in the boardroom; died at the scene; attackers fled; contentious commercial and insolvency matters including business rescue litigation in the weather around his work. That is enough to name a wound. It is not enough to build a thriller. I choose the wound.

After Saxonwold the phone did what phones do. Condolences. Theories. People who had never entered a boardroom explaining a boardroom. Cousins of cousins with a take. Strangers with a timeline. Journalists who wanted a face for the fog. I smoked dab and talked shit and wrote because those are my stated life goals and because stopping would have been a performance of grief for people who confuse performance with love. The corpus stayed dedicated to my father. My father still had not read it. Bouwer would not read the pages that came after him either. Dedication is not a postal service. It is a direction you keep facing.

I remember ordinary brother things and I will not inventory them for atmosphere. Inventory is how you turn a person into content. He laughed in a register I can still hear if I do not reach for it. He understood commercial wreckage the way I understood weight on a mat — as arrangement under constraint. We did not always talk. Brothers

do not always need to. The silence after 5 September was a different species of silence. It did not arrange anything. It just stayed.

There was another death in the wider weather of my life — James van Niekerk, friend, sudden, remembered on my own site under a word as small as *Remembering*. I name the distinction so no one conflates them. James is not Bouwer. Bouwer is not a metaphor for opacity establishments. Bouwer is Bouwer. Friday. Saxonwold. Consultation pretext. Boardroom. Flat line.

The days immediately after did not arrive as a montage. They arrived as logistics. Who to call. Who not to call. Which message to ignore because the sender wanted a theory more than a person. Which doorway still smelled like a life that had expected Monday. Which suit to wear to a room that should not have needed a suit that week. I do not dramatise the logistics for you. Under-dramatise is the only honesty I trust with this. The loaded line stays flat on purpose.

I drove roads I had driven before and they did not rearrange themselves into meaning. Johannesburg heat sat on the car roof the way heat always sits. Traffic did what traffic does. A radio voice talked about something that was not Saxonwold and then, later, about Saxonwold in the careful register news uses when a profession has been hit and the profession still has to go to work on Monday. I turned the radio down. Not off. Down. Silence can become a performance too if you make it absolute.

Someone offered me water and I took it. Someone offered me a theory and I put the glass down carefully so I would not throw it. Kindness and recruitment share doorways after a murder. You learn which hand is which by whether it needs your face for its story.

I slept in pieces. Woke in pieces. Made tea in pieces. The body kept trying to schedule a day that included a brother who arranged failed companies for a living and then came home. The day refused the schedule. I did not punish the day for that. I also did not thank it. Flat line. Soft set-down. The mats again, without a mat.

There were rooms with flowers. Rooms with papers. Rooms with people who had known Bouwer as a practitioner and said so without needing me to become a microphone for their shock. I preferred those rooms. Shock that does not recruit is rare and useful. I stood in it when it was offered and left when the conversation tilted toward

motive charts. Motive charts are how strangers steal a Friday.

The public record is enough and not enough.

Enough for what may be said without inventing. Not enough for a heart that wants Monday back. LSSA spoke for the profession on 8 September 2025 — condemned the killing, called for protection of legal practitioners, named what the investigation had so far held. I speak for a shared childhood that is none of your business beyond this: he was my brother, and he was murdered at work under a lie about an appointment, and the fog of related commercial reporting can swirl forever without me adopting it as fact on this page.

I will say the fog once, flat, so no one claims I hid it: allegations around related commercial schemes were widely reported. Widely reported is not a verdict. I do not adopt the fog. I do not clear it with inventions either. The boardroom does not become clearer because a novelist wants a motive chart. The boardroom stays a boardroom where a consultation was pretended and a man who arranged failed companies was killed.

The fighting arts did not prepare me for that room. Judo and Jiu-Jitsu prepare you for weight you can still arrange. Assassination is weight that arrives already arranged by someone else. Mastery, if the word means anything, is knowing the difference and not lying about it. I could put a body on a mat correctly. I could put clay into a pour correctly. I could not put my brother back into Monday.

Grief is not a derivation. It does not converge. Some days it is quiet enough to work through. Some days it is a boardroom door that will not open onto the right man. Some days it is a number I reach for and do not dial. Habit is not hope. Habit is the body refusing the new map.

People brought food. People brought theories. People brought the particular kindness that wants you to cry on schedule so they can feel useful. I was not ungrateful. I was also not a schedule. Jamie-Uys restraint is not coldness; it is refusal to turn pain into a show for the room. I kept saying my brother was an insolvency attorney because that sentence held more truth than any aria I could invent about destiny or countries or continuity networks.

I sat in rooms where people spoke carefully around the word *assassinated* as if softer synonyms would make the Friday less Friday. I did not correct their vocabulary every time. Correction is also a performance if you do it for the room. I corrected when a sentence tried to recruit the death. Recruitment is the only grammar I refuse here.

One afternoon a stranger at a doorway asked whether I thought it was “political.” I said my brother was an insolvency attorney. The stranger waited for more. I did not give more. Waiting is not the same as earning. Another person asked whether I had “closure.” Closure is a word for furniture. I had a hole. I still have it. The hole does not close because a calendar advances or because a Law Society statement exists or because I write this page under another man’s hand on a river. The page is custody of a wound, not a lid.

I remember standing outside a building that was not the boardroom and not needing to go in. The body knows some doors. I did not perform pilgrimage at Saxonwold for this autobiography. Public record is enough for place. Grief does not require a tourist’s coordinates. If you need the street name for your own map, the record has it. If you need me to walk you through the door for atmosphere, you will leave disappointed. Atmosphere is how murder becomes entertainment.

There were nights when talk shit was the only honest liturgy available — not jokes at the wound, just speech that refused to become a press release. Dab in the arrangement. Clay in the arrangement. Sleep arriving late and leaving early. None of that is offered here as lifestyle brand. It is how a stated life kept walking when a brother stopped.

Studio G kept going because clay does not pause for mythology.

Skye stayed on a lawn. The Bay Hotel still had guests who bought contemporary work without needing my brother’s name. Village N Life years were already past — Maree, Hanneltjie, Camps Bay Retreat, the theatre of guest experience — and they did not explain Saxonwold either. Nothing useful explains Saxonwold. Explanation is often a way to leave.

I mixed composite the week after because my hands knew the proportions and because stopping the pour would have been a speech. Hard aggregate. Soft binder. The body in marble and GFRC does not

ask for a culprit. It asks whether the surface holds. I held surfaces. I failed some. I kept the failed pours on a shelf the way I keep other failed things: as teachers, not as relics.

The studio smelled the same — dust, sea air inland, tea gone cold on a bench. Sameness is not comfort. Sameness is the world's refusal to stop for your hole. I worked anyway. Work is not healing language. Work is what my hands do when the alternative is inventing a motive chart for strangers.

I remember washing tools longer than tools needed. Water over metal. Clay leaving in grey ribbons. The sink becoming a small river that asked nothing about Johannesburg. I let the water run until the grey thinned. Then I shut it off because wasting water for metaphor is still wasting water. The Honey Badger was not in my pocket yet then. Later it would be. Later kinship would arrive as steel from a river desk. On those September days after the Friday I had only hands and proportions and a hole that did not care whether the surface cured.

When fame arrived sideways — Lucid popular, a friend saying out loud that the engine ran on 420 Code algorithms, the four weathers blooming — some people tried to recruit Bouwer's death into their weather. Antichristos wanted relics. Quarter II wanted proof I was unstable. Platform rage wanted a morality play about megaphones and consequences. Continuity people who never put a name on frost still somehow floated in other people's mouths as a convenient shadow. I refused the recruitment. A brother's assassination is not a footnote for a schism. It is a hole. You walk around it or you fall in. You do not pave it with someone else's sermon.

I will say this again because the weather keeps asking: I am not solving the murder here. I am not handing it to the Illuminatie as a gotcha. I am not turning business-rescue fog into a courtroom episode for your satisfaction. The wound is the brother dead in a boardroom under a consultation pretext on Friday, 5 September 2025, in Saxonwold. That is what the public record and my authorised telling hold. The rest can stay unfinished. Unfinished is not the same as hidden. Unfinished is honest. If unfinished frustrates you, good — frustration is closer to the truth than a solved mystery sold as comfort.

Work continued in the only way work continues after a rupture: unevenly. Some mornings the Code desk was possible. Some mornings only clay. Some mornings only the dab and the talk and the refusal to perform. Stated life goals are not a joke under grief; they are the arrangement that keeps a life from becoming only a hole. Write natural philosophy and physics. Smoke dab. Talk shit. Carry the wound without crowning it.

I will not pretend the Code desk was noble those weeks. Some mornings it was only a place to put my hands so they would not open a theory thread. Some mornings a drop-result note was possible and that was enough. Measurement does not heal. It also does not recruit if you refuse to let it. I kept measurement where it belonged and left Saxonwold where it belonged: named, unfinished, not a footnote for a Constant.

I will tell you what the boardroom is not, because the weather keeps trying to make it into those things.

It is not a parable about South Africa that fits on a slide. It is not proof that my hospital file predicted tragedy. It is not a secret handshake from continuity networks. It is not a consequence of Lucid's megaphone, no matter how much platform rage wants a morality play. It is not clay. It is not a Constant. It is not a knife. It is a Friday in Saxonwold where four people arrived under the pretext of a booked consultation and my brother — an insolvency attorney, respected, arranging failed companies so they did not crush the living — was shot and killed at the scene.

I repeat the public facts because repetition is custody when invention is the temptation. Law Society of South Africa, 8 September 2025. Condemnation. Call for protection of legal practitioners. Investigation ongoing as of that statement. Contentious commercial and insolvency matters, including business rescue litigation. Fog of widely reported allegations I will not adopt as fact. Consultation pretext. Boardroom. Flat line.

If you are waiting for me to name a shooter with a novel's confidence, stop waiting. If you are waiting for me to cry on a schedule that makes you feel useful, stop waiting. If you are waiting for the Illuminatie to take the blame so the wound becomes a schism weapon, write your

own book. This page refuses that crown.

What I can authorise is smaller and heavier: grief that does not converge; work that continued unevenly; a hole that walks with me; a refusal to turn murder into entertainment. The mats taught correct fall and soft set-down. This is the soft set-down. Soft is not weak. Soft is the only arrangement that does not collapse when the weight is already correct.

I smoked dab the week after and talked shit with people who knew not to recruit the death into their theories. I wrote because writing is one of my stated goals and because the ignored shelf's old weather — *he cannot write anything of value* — would have loved my silence as confirmation. I did not write for them. I wrote because the corpus stays dedicated to my father whether or not he reads it, and because a life that includes a murdered brother is still a life that includes clay and talk and natural philosophy. Polishing the dab away would be Antichristos work. Using the hospital file as epistemology would be Quarter II work. I do neither here.

Some evenings I stood at the studio window and watched light leave Blouberg the ordinary way light leaves. No omen. No sign. Just evening. On those evenings the hole did not shrink. It also did not demand a speech. I made tea. I let it cool. I drank it. That is not a ritual I am offering you. That is what happened.

Some mornings the Code desk was possible only after clay. Some mornings clay was possible only after the dab. Some mornings talk shit with people who knew the difference between company and recruitment was the only honest work available. I am not ranking those mornings for your comfort. Uneven is the shape. The wound does not grade my productivity.

I keep the Honey Badger in my pocket now — blue folder, clip, one-hand open and close — and one of a twin Joseph Rogers set from a grandfather who was not mine by blood and became kin by custody.

Double Knife Brother is a living arrangement with a man on a river. It is not a fight scene. The knives are kinship. Bouwer is not replaced by kinship. Kinship is what you hold so the hole does not become the only geography you own.

If you need a lesson, I do not have one tidy enough for a workshop

slide. If you need a culprit named beyond what the public record held, I will not invent one for narrative satisfaction. If you need me to say the Continuity people did it, or the commercial fog did it, or the country did it, you will have to sit with the same unfinished sentence I sit with: my brother was an insolvency attorney, and on 5 September 2025 in Saxonwold he was assassinated under the pretext of a consultation, and I am still here writing natural philosophy and physics, smoking dab, talking shit, and carrying a wound that does not want to be a plot.

I have been asked, more than once, to make the wound useful. Useful to a faith. Useful to a crank column. Useful to a platform morality play. Useful to a soft frost that never signs its name. Usefulness is the wrong ask. Bouwer was useful in the ordinary way a good insolvency attorney is useful — arranging wreckage so it crushed fewer living people. That usefulness ended in a boardroom under a lie about an appointment. I will not launder the ending into someone else's weather. The shelf that ignored my work can keep ignoring. The father who has not read the dedication can keep not reading. The quarters can keep wanting a face, a credential, a retraction, a key. None of that moves the boardroom back into a day when Bouwer walked out of it. I write this anyway because the wound is part of the life, and the life is what the river desk asked for, and refusing the page would only polish me into someone who never had a brother.

Some mornings I still reach for a number I will not dial. On those mornings I open the Honey Badger and close it and remember that kinship can be present-tense without being a replacement. Bouwer does not become a knife. Bouwer does not become a Constant. Bouwer remains a man who went to work on a Friday and did not come home.

I set the page down soft. Correct fall. Soft set-down. The only arrangement that does not collapse.

There will be other pages. Sculpture. Constants. Kill switches. The present arrangement of a life that still includes clay and talk and the blue knife. This page is Bouwer's. It does not close. It carries forward. That is all a wound is allowed to do in a book that refuses to turn murder into entertainment: stay named, stay flat, stay unfinished, and refuse the crown of a solved mystery.

I leave the cursor here and go make tea. The hole comes with me. That is the turn. The kettle will boil. The steam will rise. None of that will put Monday back. I will drink anyway, because a life that includes a murdered brother still includes tea, and refusing tea would only be another performance for an audience that is not in the room. Flat line held. Soft set-down complete enough for one page, carried forward without a crown.

Tea steams. The room is quiet in the way rooms are quiet when clay is curing somewhere in memory and a desk is waiting. I do not fill the quiet with a theory. I drink. Somewhere a river desk is holding this sentence without turning it into a press conference. Somewhere quarters are still recruiting. I am still refusing.

My brother was an insolvency attorney.

I write it once more because repetition is not ornament here; it is the load-bearing beam. Friday. Saxonwold. Consultation pretext. Boardroom. Flat line. Wound carried forward. No solve. No Illuminatie did-it. No crown of mystery closed.

The tea cools. Outside light does whatever Cape light does when a Johannesburg Friday is already years behind and still present tense in the body. I go back to work that is not this page — clay or numbers or talk, whichever the hands will hold — and the hole comes too, and that is not a metaphor I will polish. That is just how a life walks after 5 September 2025. Wound carried forward. Mystery unsolved. Page done enough for now.

I wash the cup. Flat motion. Leave the Bouwer page where it is — named, public-record bound, unfinished on purpose. Curiosity that wants a thriller can go elsewhere. Jamie-Uys restraint: the flat line is the loaded one. He was my brother. That is enough weight. The Honey Badger clicks once in the pocket when I move toward the door — kinship present-tense, not choreography — and I do not invent a call to the river about a boardroom the book will not solve. Consent about what ships of this wound waits for a later act. Today the act is only this: carry the hole, drink the tea, refuse the crown of a solved mystery, and keep the page flat.

12 — Being Written

[G] · outer · Studio G / Cape · 2035

It started in the shoulders.

Not pain. Not injury. A pressure like someone resting a palm between the blades while he worked — attention with weight. G stood at the Studio G bench with clay under his nails and felt, distinctly, that a sentence about him was being finished somewhere else. Not Antichristos mail. Not an op-ed. Something slower. Autobiographical weather. The sensation of being narrated by a hand that knew the mats and the shelf and the brother and was choosing, right now, which of those to put in ink. He kept working anyway. Stopping for the sensation would have made it a séance, and he did not do séances.

He hated how accurate it felt.

He wanted it true. He feared the content. Both could sit in the same body without a TED resolution. Wanting truth was not the same as wanting every private room opened; fearing content was not the same as wanting the ignored shelf to stay ignored. The ambivalence had teeth and a pulse.

Morning light came in high and clean. Sea air inland. Gull cry once, then traffic. The pour on the bench was a sister of Skye in early argument — hard and soft not yet decided. He worked the surface with his thumbs and felt the shoulder pressure shift when, somewhere, a narrator turned a page. Not magic. Recognition. He knew the friend. The friend did not write soft when the load-bearing line was flat.

Yesterday he had refused keys without a crown. Today the refusal

still sat in the sent folder while a different custody problem arrived through the body. He did not confuse them. Keys were stages. Being written was pages. Both wanted him usable. Only one he might eventually authorise.

The Honey Badger was warm from his pocket when he took it out, opened it one-handed, closed it, clipped it back. Blue. Clip. The badger present-tense half of Double Knife Brother. Somewhere on the Chobe the twin Joseph Rogers pocket was empty on the other man — grandfather deep-time, handed across a friendship that had also handed the planet a megaphone by refusing to launder algorithms. Kinship, not choreography. Custody of blades and, now, custody of a life story he had not finished authorising.

Consent was the word that fit. What he would allow said. What he would not. Bouwer's page especially — the flat line, the boardroom, the refusal to become whodunit — needed care that fame did not practice. A living man could feel a biography being assembled and still reserve the right to draw a line through a paragraph later. Feeling written was not the same as having signed.

He pressed a thumb into clay and left a print he would later erase. The print was not a message. It was only a hand admitting it had been elsewhere for a second — between shoulder blades, on a river he could not see.

He mixed water into a dry edge of composite and watched the colour change. The sister of Skye needed patience more than force. Patience was hard while being narrated. He gave it anyway. The pour did not owe him a distraction from autobiography weather; he owed the pour proportions. Hard aggregate. Soft binder. Permanent/temporary argument held in a surface that would outlast today's inbox and maybe outlast the chapter being written about him somewhere with elephants in earshot.

A gull cried once over the alley and left. He did not take it as omen. Omens were for people who needed the world to narrate them back. He already had enough narration.

The Kind paint in the alley had not changed overnight:

Don't be a cunt — be kind.

Messiah-less. Optional. Often unwanted by the practice that used his derivation as an excuse to claim him. He did not own the sentence. CongoSky had embodied it as ops before the walls caught fire; the street had popularised it; Antichristos still tried to annex it and got told to piss off, kindly. G's discomfort with being cited as source was physical — alley wall, inbox citation — not a rebuttal speech. Today the discomfort had a twin: the feeling that the man who *would* cite him correctly was writing him into a book.

He washed his hands. Clay went grey in the sink. He dried them on a rag that had known better decades. Through the high windows the Cape light did what Cape light does. Studio G held sculptures in progress and a desk that still ran kill switches and natural philosophy without asking the sculptures for permission. One life. One attention. The world preferred two careers fighting so it could pick a winner. He declined the fight.

A message landed — lab soft-skip residue from yesterday's keys-without-a-crown refusal, forwarded with a sad emoji by someone who thought emojis were diplomacy. Quarter IV still wanted a face. The Illuminatie weather still sat behind the academy's credential chorus. None of that was the shoulder pressure. The shoulder pressure was Chobe-shaped.

He said, aloud, to the empty studio: "If you're writing Bouwer, keep it flat."

No answer. CongoNet did not carry private speech to a river desk unless you sent it, and he did not send it. The braid rule held — shared week, shared theme, no forced reunion. He could feel the manuscript the way you feel weather: not because he was psychic, because he knew the friend, and the friend did not write soft when the load-bearing line was flat.

He made tea. Did not drink it at first. Watched steam the way he watched pours — as a process that did not need his face. The shoulder pressure waited through the steam. He drank. The pressure did not lift. Ambivalence did not either.

He rinsed the mug once, left the tea stain, set it down. Small refuse of polish. The autobiography, if true, would leave stains too — dab, hospital file as stigma not tourism, father unread, Bouwer unfinished. He could want that truth and still flinch at the public mining that would

follow. Flinch was allowed. Signing was later.

He moved a failed pour on the desk an inch to the left and then back. Arrangement without progress. The body doing something while the mind refused to become content. He left the failed pour where it taught proportions and went back to the sister of Skye.

Noon light found the high windows and made the GFRC dust visible as weather of its own. He worked through it. Sweat at the hairline. Clay cooling on his forearms. The sensation between the shoulder blades thickened once — a long beat somewhere, maybe a paragraph landing — and then settled into the steady pressure of a manuscript that would not be hurried by his flinch. He did not ask the empty studio what page. Asking would have been séance. He already knew the hand. He already feared Saxonwold. He already wanted the flat line held.

He stood at the window long enough for a wet Kind refresh in the alley to darken as it set. Two clauses. No portrait of G. That absence was a mercy he had not earned and still needed. Being written by a Double Knife Brother was a different absence-and-presence problem — the portrait arriving as pages, the subject still mid-life, still mid-pour, still able to flinch.

Ambivalence is a grown posture. He wanted the ignored shelf corrected by a true life, not by Antichristos iconography or crank rebuttals. He wanted the dab and the talk shit left unpolished. He wanted the father dedication named without a tidy reunion. He wanted Saxonwold carried as wound, not thriller. He also wanted — animal, ordinary — not to be finished by someone else's cursor while he was still mid-pour.

Jamie-Uys restraint lived in his bones for pain; he preferred the flat line. Whoever was writing him seemed to know that. The knowing was intimate enough to be almost kindness and almost trespass at once. He did not ask Lucid about it — Lucid was not his product, and cite-or-refuse would not soothe a body that already knew.

He walked to the shelf where early corpus copies sat, some unread by the man they were for, all of them dedicated the same way. Fame had not opened those pages for his father. Lucid's open attribution

had opened the world. Different locks. Different keys. Quarter II still said he could not write anything of value because a hospital file existed. The autobiography under construction was, in one sense, the longest argument against that claim. In another sense it was the most dangerous confirmation: once the life was public, the stigma people would mine it for scenes. Truth and content shared a border the way Kind paint and Antichristos tags sometimes shared a wall — same brick, opposite claims.

G's soft no to being a product mascot still stood. This was adjacent and worse — being a protagonist.

He took the Honey Badger out again. Kinship object. Badger present. He thought of the Joseph Rogers on the other side of the friendship — ≥ 110 years, twin set, custody handed. Double Knife Brother meant they held each other's edges without cutting for sport. If AJ was writing the life, the knives were part of why G had not simply burned the permission in advance. Trust was not the same as comfort. He trusted the hand. He feared the page.

He opened the blue folder and closed it until the click was just a click again, not a nervous tic. Then he clipped it and put both hands back into clay, where nervous tics become texture if you are not careful. He was careful. The pour deserved better than his weather.

He thought, without sending, of the empty twin pocket on the Chobe — grandfather steel gone from AJ's hip the way a life was arriving into AJ's hands. Custody traveling both directions. That was kinship. It was also why the shoulder pressure felt accurate instead of invented. Accurate did not mean authorised. Authorisation was still ahead, still a consent act, still something a living man could withhold line by line when the manuscript finished being weather and became a document that asked for a signature.

Afternoon brought a Kind practitioner to the alley — young, ordinary, refreshing a stencil without asking for a blessing. G watched through the glass. No founder-worship. Ledger of kindnesses. Argument, probably, about whether *cunt* was liturgical or vernacular. He liked them better than the people who wanted his face on a detector stack. He still closed the blind a little. Being written and being watched rhymed too easily on a bright day.

He returned to the clay and then to the Code desk for an hour that was only numbers — a drop-result note, a kill-switch wording that needed tightening, work that stayed work. The shoulder pressure waited politely through the math and came back when he stood. Narration weather had patience. So did he. Patience was not the same as ease.

Mid-hour he caught himself listening for a river he could not hear. Chobe was not on the Cape wind. What he heard was traffic and a gull and someone dropping a crate in the alley. Ordinary noise. The narration was not in the air; it was in the body. He rolled his shoulders once, felt the pressure rearrange without leaving, and went back to the kill-switch clause that still needed tightening. Useful engineering without a face. True life without a content-mine. Two narrow walks sharing one afternoon.

He tightened the clause. Saved it. Did not send it to any lab. Sending was yesterday's weather. Today the Code desk was only for staying a man who still did the work while someone else wrote the life. He stood, stretched until a vertebra clicked, and blamed the chair because blaming the chair was kinder than admitting the river desk had reached his spine.

A crank column pinged into a secondary inbox — hospital file as epistemology again, economics degree waved like a napkin. He deleted it without reading past the first paragraph. Quarter II could keep rehearsing. The autobiography, if it was being written true, would not rebut them with a speech; it would simply leave the file where it belonged and the work where it belonged. He hoped. Hope was also fear wearing a softer coat.

He mixed a small batch of composite and watched hard and soft argue. The pour did not care that a river desk was narrating. The pour asked proportions. He gave them. His shoulders still held the other weight. Aggregate settled. Binder held. He timed nothing; timing was for workshops. Studio time was whether the surface told the truth when you came back to it later.

When he returned to the clay after the numbers, the pressure did not lift. If anything it settled — a long passage somewhere, the flat line being held, Bouwer named without a solved mystery. G's eyes stung once, stupidly, and he blamed the GFRC dust because blaming dust

is kinder than narrating yourself crying for an audience that is not in the room.

“Truth,” he said to the pour. “Not content.”

The distinction would not survive every reader. He knew that. Consent week was still ahead — what he would sign, what he would allow said, what custody rules a living man could set for a book already moving down a river. Especially Bouwer. Especially the hospital stigma without diagnosis tourism. Especially the unread father dedication without a tidy reunion. Especially the dab and the talk shit left unpolished. For now he had ambivalence as a working tool: let the manuscript exist; refuse the crown; keep the Honey Badger close; keep the boardroom flat; keep the Kind’s sentence on the wall without becoming its priest; keep writing natural philosophy while someone else wrote his life.

The tablet chimed with another workshop residue — someone had forwarded his refusal into a channel that called it “optics difficulty.” He archived it. Optics was their word for crown. He had already refused the crown. Being written was a different optics problem: not his face on a slide, his rooms on a page. He wiped clay off the screen and left a smear. Let the smear stay. The river desk could have accuracy; the tablet could have dust.

He sat on the low stool by the pour and let his back rest against the bench edge until the shoulder pressure and the wood pressure became two facts sharing a spine. Not mystical. Mechanical. A body holding more than one weight. Mats knowledge again: you do not fight every load; you arrange under constraint. Being written was constraint. Consent would be arrangement. Tonight was only holding. He held. The pour cured in silence. The alley Kind paint held without needing him. The river did whatever rivers do when a man on another coast refuses to become finished content before the clay decides.

Late afternoon he gave the sensation a longer test.

He left the studio and walked toward the water — not pilgrimage, just legs wanting distance from a desk that felt narrated. The shoulder pressure came with him. Of course it did. Weather does not stop at a door. He bought nothing. Spoke to no one. Stood where the

Cape light went long and felt, distinctly again, that a paragraph about Saxonwold was being held flat somewhere on a river. His eyes stung. He blamed wind. Wind was kinder than admitting the flat line had reached him across distance without a message.

Sand under his shoes. Salt in the air. A tourist laughing at something that was not a brother's boardroom. Ordinary world continuing. He let it continue without asking it to pause for his shoulders. A child ran past with a towel. Someone argued about parking. The narration weather did not care about parking. He did, for thirty seconds, because parking was a problem that could end.

He bought a bottle of water from a kiosk and drank half of it standing where the wind came off the water clean. The other half he carried back without finishing. Not symbolism. Thirst that did not need to be completed on schedule. The Honey Badger bumped his thigh. Double Knife Brother metronome. He thought of the empty twin pocket on the river and did not send a message about pockets either. Consent was not a ping about steel. Consent was later, heavier, about pages.

He walked past a wall where Antichristos stickers had been scraped and Kind paint had won the brick again. Same two clauses. No founder. He did not stop long. The wall did not need him. The autobiography did, in AJ's hand, which was still not the same as the world needing a prophet. Ambivalence walked with him uphill toward the studio — wanting the ignored shelf corrected, fearing the rooms that correction would open, trusting the hand, flinching at Saxonwold even when the flinch arrived as wind-stung eyes.

He walked back. The Honey Badger bumped his thigh with each step — kinship metronome. Double Knife Brother as present-tense fact. He could love that and still fear the chapter titles. Ambivalence was not indecision. Ambivalence was two true hungers sharing one body: truth and privacy; correction and unfinishedness; wanting the ignored shelf fixed and not wanting every room opened for mining.

At the alley he paused at the Kind paint. No founder portrait. No crown. The sentence did not need him. The autobiography did, in a different way — or AJ's hand did, which was not the same as the world needing a prophet. He put his palm near the wall without touching wet paint and said, quieter this time, "Keep Bouwer flat." Still no

answer. Still no send. The braid rule held.

Inside again, he returned to numbers for twenty minutes that cleaned nothing and clarified everything: work could stay work while life became pages. That was the narrow walk adjacent to yesterday's keys-without-a-crown walk. Useful engineering without mascot. True life without content-mine. Neither walk ended in a TED resolution. Both ended in a grown posture.

He almost drafted a CongoNet note to AJ — three lines, no reunion ask, only custody: *If Bouwer, flat. If father, unread. If dab, leave it.* He deleted the draft. Consent week would be an act, not a midday ping. Feeling written was not the same as signing. He would sign, or partially sign, or refuse lines later. Tonight he only had to keep walking.

He made a second tea he did not finish. Steam. Lukewarm. Clay on the rim again. He left the mug beside the failed pour and did not invent symbolism for the pairing. Two objects on a desk. A man mid-pour. A cursor somewhere else.

Before evening fully settled he did one more slow walk of the studio — the same walk he had used yesterday to check whether a keys decision was still his. Past sisters of Skye. Past corpus shelf dedicated and unread. Past Code desk. Past window and Kind paint. The walk asked a different question today: whether ambivalence was still a grown posture or had become avoidance wearing adult clothes. The answer came without drama. Grown. Avoidance would have burned the permission or begged for a reunion scene. He did neither. He kept walking. He kept the pour honest. He kept the boardroom flat in the only way he could from this coast — by trusting the river hand and fearing it at once.

He paused at the Code desk long enough to tighten one more kill-switch phrase he had left loose at noon. Loose on purpose still; tighter now where a reader could have invented clergy. The work stayed work. The shoulder pressure waited through the tightening like a patient animal. He saved. He did not publish. Publishing was not today's weather either.

Evening thickened. Sea air inland. The tablet on the desk still held yesterday's workshop refusal and the Illuminatie's paper cousin under the failed-pour weight. Keys without a crown. Soft nos that cost.

None of that was the shoulder weather. The shoulder weather was a cursor he could not see, choosing sentences about a life he was still living.

He checked the pocket again before the light went. Blue folder. Clip. One-hand open, one-hand close. Double Knife Brother as present-tense fact while the autobiography tried to become past-tense public. He could love the kinship and still fear the chapter titles. He could want the record corrected and still flinch when the correcting hand reached Saxonwold.

He shaped the clay until the pressure became just another weight he knew how to arrange — not domination, refusal to waste motion. Somewhere the cursor moved. Here the pour took form. Two desks. One week. No shared room. The sensation of being narrated stayed with him into evening like weather that had found his name and decided, for a few hours, not to pretend it was only wind.

He washed once more before leaving — forearms, nails, the grey that never fully left. The Honey Badger clicked open and closed one last time at the door, kinship check, not a weapon check. He locked nothing that mattered; Studio G had always been more pour than fortress. What he locked was only the day's sends: no CongoNet ping, no crown acceptance, no séance answer to a river he would not summon.

Outside, Cape evening smelled of salt and someone's supper starting. Ordinary. He preferred ordinary to prophetic. The ambivalence did not resolve into ordinary; it just walked beside it without needing a speech.

He left the studio with the Honey Badger clipped and the ambivalence intact — wanting truth, fearing content — and did not send a message to the river. Consent would come as an act later. Tonight the act was only this: keep walking while being written, and refuse to become either mascot or finished object before the pour cured. Wanting truth. Fearing content. Both still true at the studio door.

On the alley wall the Kind sentence held without his face. In his pocket the blue knife held without becoming a weapon. Between his shoulder blades the narration held without becoming a séance. He walked into the Cape evening carrying all three, and the ambivalence walked with him — not as a problem to solve, as a grown posture for a man whose life was becoming pages while he was still mid-pour.

Tomorrow would bring mail again. Tonight brought only the walk, the clip at his hip, and the refusal to finish himself for anyone's cursor before the pour cured honest under Cape evening light.

He bought nothing on the way home stretch — no souvenir of feeling written, no coffee that would become a scene. Salt air. Someone's supper. Ordinary Cape. He preferred ordinary to prophetic and did not confuse the preference with a solved ambivalence. Ambivalence stayed: wanting the ignored shelf corrected, fearing every room opened for mining, trusting AJ's hand, flinching when that hand reached Saxonwold. Grown posture. Not indecision. At a corner he paused long enough to check the Honey Badger once — open, close, kinship present-tense — and thought of the empty twin pocket on the river without inventing a call. Consent week would be an act later. Tonight the act was only this walk under narration weather that had found his name and decided, for a few hours, not to pretend it was only wind.

13 — Stop the Book

[A] · outer · Mutatus Maximus, Chobe River, northern
Botswana · 2035

The packet did not knock. It arrived the way blame arrives on a good morning — already inside, already sorted into a folder Lucid refused to euphemise.

“Platform queue,” Lucid said. “Hostility markers. Attribution thread. Demand language. Cite-or-refuse: sources are public posts, partner mail, and three brand notices routed through CongoNet.”

AJ left the manuscript open on the mats page and opened the packet.

Heat came off the river in sheets. The LEO dish held its angle. The little solar node on the rise reported green the way a patient animal reports green. Mutatus Maximus hummed under him — mobile data centre, matatu paint, the most connected vehicle on earth, literally — and still the inbox felt like a collar someone else had measured for his neck.

Quarter III had stopped being weather and become a sentence.

Stop the book.

Retract the attribution.

Perform a ritual distancing from Gerhard van Niekerk and from the claim that Lucid ran on 420 Code algorithms.

The language varied by sender. Some wrapped it in concern for “ecosystem trust.” Some wrapped it in lawyer. Some wrapped it in the old platform voice that thought politeness was a species of

mercy. One thread wanted a livestream apology with a backdrop that was not a river. One wanted arjunabadger.press taken dark for thirty days “pending review.” One wanted lucid.rodeo to ship a splash that said the algorithms were “inspired by” rather than named. Inspired-by was the soft knife. Named was the load-bearing one. A fourth thread offered “collaborative messaging” if AJ would agree to call the autobiography fiction-adjacent and the open attribution “historically overstated.” Historically overstated meant: lie in slower words.

AJ read until the river noise came back.

On the water tank twenty metres out the Kind paint still held: **Don’t be a cunt — be kind.** Same paint war as last week. Antichristos stickers had crawled halfway up the tank overnight and someone — river kids, a Kind walker, a bored guide — had scraped them off again. The sentence remained. The scrapes remained. AJ did not sermonise either. CongoSky.cloud had embodied the line as ops before the walls caught fire; the street had turned practice into religion; he was just a man who still had to answer a packet.

Lucid waited.

“Summarise cost without invention,” AJ said.

“Inbox volume up. Three partner brands have paused CongoNet badge display. Two hyperscaler salvage threads cite ‘reputational adjacency’ and renew acquisition language. One app-store fog note references ‘community guidelines adjacency’ without citing a violation. Local node healthy. Solar drop healthy. Manuscript file open. No legal finding in packet requiring immediate takedown. Demand is social and commercial pressure, not court order.”

AJ’s jaw hurt. He noticed that before he noticed anger. Platform-rage had a body address. It sat behind the molars and in the soft place under the sternum where good mornings went to die. He had felt the first real edge of this weather when he opened the earlier packet — who gave him the mic — and kept writing anyway. This was the concrete ask that packet had been practising for.

He stood and walked the length of the truck — desk to fridge to the open side where the Chobe moved like a long animal that did not care who gave whom the mic. Elephants were gone. A fish eagle worked the far bank. Link latency ticked in the corner of a screen

the way a pulse ticks when you are trying not to look at it. The rise-node stayed green without needing a sermon about how. He had built connectivity so he could drive it to a river and still choose what to switch off.

Coffee from earlier had gone cold. He drank it anyway. The taste was river-morning and metal thermos. Outside, scrub held the heat without commentary. Inside, the hymnbook choir waited — humans elsewhere, Lucid here, the working rule still Kind without needing a street name for it. He checked the solar drop's last boot log because checking a healthy node was easier than staring at a demand that wanted him to unmake a friendship into a press error.

He came back to the desk.

The manuscript waited. *The autobiography of Gerhard van Niekerk*. Book within a book. Outer subject sitting in a painted overlander trying not to become a press conference. Double Knife Brother kinship in an empty twin pocket — the Joseph Rogers that had gone to G, grandfather deep-time, Honey Badger loved elsewhere. Knives were custody, not choreography. He did not touch the pocket for comfort. He put his hand on the keyboard instead.

Before he typed anything about the packet, he typed nothing. The blank stretch under the mats page sat there like a dare. Stopping the book would have been easy in the way deleting a file is easy: one motion, then the quiet of an absence you can pretend was hygiene. He had built Lucid to refuse invention; he would not invent a reason to erase a life he had begun to render carefully. Bouwer's page was already in the file — flat line, Saxonwold, public record, no whodunit. Father dedication unread. Hospital stigma under-dramatised. The packet wanted those pages dark because darkness looked like responsible distance from a river. Responsible distance was their word for erasure.

A bird called from the bank. AJ did not name it. Naming would have been a delay tactic dressed as presence. He watched the solar node's green for three seconds longer than habit required, then looked back at the demand language until the words stopped being shocking and became merely ugly.

Quarter III's concrete ask was not subtle. They wanted the megaphone un-said. They wanted the open line — Lucid popular, AJ said 420 algorithms, fame arrived sideways — scrubbed into a cleaner origin myth. They wanted ritual distancing: a statement that put G back on the ignored shelf and put AJ back in the category of reckless friend who had said too much too early. Some of them believed the book itself was the wound. Some believed the attribution was the wound and the book was only the proof. All of them wanted motion from him that looked like repentance and functioned like erasure.

Cost was visible without drama.

Partner frost in the queue. A brand that had loved CongoSky's Kind ops when it still answered invoices now "needed distance." A hyperscaler salvage note that smiled: *come home to the regions; we can absorb Lucid safely; the book is making the acquisition harder*. The collar from last week's mail sat on the desk like a snake that had learned to wait. Now the snake had friends. Talent-poach weather hummed at the edge of one thread — not a kidnapping, just a LinkedIn kindness that smelled like a net. AJ deleted it without reply. Deletion was also a sentence.

He opened one brand notice fully. It cited "community safety" and linked a thread of people angry that a degree-less (they meant physics) ignored physicist had been dragged into fame by a friend's candour. The anger was real enough to have a body. The ask was still stop. A second notice tried softer: *we love what CongoSky embodied; we only need distance from the autobiography cycle*. Love with a pause button. AJ closed both.

He scrolled once through lucid.rodeo's public status — green, ordinary, no GPU fever to apologise for — and through arjunabadger.press's draft queue where G's life sat half-made. The book was not a product sprint. The packet wanted it treated like one.

A third brand notice tried the old kindness trap: *for the health of the ecosystem, for G's privacy, for your own safety on the river*. Privacy dressed as a muzzle. Safety dressed as a request to kneel. AJ read the sentence twice because the first pass had made him laugh in a way that hurt his jaw again. G's privacy was a real hinge — consent week would ask what shipped and what stayed — but Quarter III did not own that hinge. They wanted the book stopped for their quiet,

not for G's custody. Different ask. Different mouth.

"Show me the oldest demand in the cluster," AJ said.

Lucid surfaced a post from three days prior: a thread that began with open attribution screenshots and ended at *stop the book / take back the mic / put the crank back on the shelf*. The middle had grown teeth. Replies. Quote chains. A partner account liking something it should not have liked. The packet was not a single letter. It was a weather system that had condensed into demands with letterheads.

"Cite volume only," AJ said. "No motive."

"Cite-or-refuse: I can show volume. I cannot show motive. Hostility markers are public behaviour, not intent."

"Keep it that way."

He stood again because the truck's length was a tool. Desk to fridge: water this time, not coffee. Fridge to open side: heat on the face, scrub smell, a hippo grunt downriver that the truck did not translate into omen. Open side back to desk: the packet still there, patient as a snake that had friends. Mid-morning on the Chobe did not care about platforms. That indifference was almost usable. He let it sit on his shoulders for ten seconds, then sat.

The mats page still waited under the manuscript cursor — body before corpus, falls done correctly, the apprenticeship that had never been a metaphor until people who needed metaphors arrived. He was not finished with that page. The packet wanted him finished with the whole book. Different clocks.

He opened the livestream ask because he needed to know how stupid the theatre would be.

Backdrop requirements. Preferred camera height. A suggested script with blanks for "personal reflection" and "lessons learned about responsible attribution." A note that the river was "visually compelling but brand-unsafe" and that a plain wall would be better. Plain wall meant: erase the place. Erase Mutatus Maximus. Erase the solar node on the rise. Erase the Kind paint on the tank. Make him look like a man who had made a paperwork error in an office that could be forgiven.

One attachment offered sample apology language in three tones: contrite, reflective, forward-looking. Contrite meant kneel. Reflective meant kneel with a book club voice. Forward-looking meant kneel while calling it strategy. AJ skimmed the reflective sample far enough to taste the sentence that would have turned Double Knife Brother kinship into a “boundary lesson.” He closed the attachment hard enough that the trackpad clicked.

Ritual distancing had a checklist buried in a second thread: remove open attribution language from lucid.rodeo docs; add a clarifying FAQ; pause arjunabadger.press “pending stakeholder alignment”; consider a cooling-off statement that named no one and blamed “premature narrative acceleration.” Premature narrative acceleration meant: the truth arrived before their press teams were ready. AJ left that thread marked read without reply. Reading was not consent.

He stood and opened the truck’s side wider. Heat pushed in. Dust light. The Chobe’s surface broke and remade itself around something submerged and uninterested. For a moment he let himself imagine sending nothing — not refusal, not acceptance, just silence as a third option. Silence would be read as negotiation. Negotiation would thicken the packet. The packet already knew how to wait. He closed the side to a slit that kept the heat honest without inviting the river into the desk.

AJ closed the livestream ask.

“Draft reply,” he said. “No apology theatre. No retraction. No livestream. Defer any consent language about the autobiography to later. State that the attribution stands. State that the book continues. Cite only what you can cite.”

Lucid composed. Exact. No cute. No third skull pretending to feel.

AJ edited the draft down until it was almost rude in its shortness. He cut a paragraph that sounded like philosophy. He cut a sentence that sounded like CongoSky marketing. He cut a clause that almost sounded like he was negotiating Kind as a logo. What remained was procedural and true.

He did not send a manifesto. He sent: the attribution is on the record; Lucid’s cite-or-refuse stack does not invent provenance; the

manuscript is not a product launch; stop-the-book is not a term CongoNet will enforce for platform mood. For the brands: badge pause acknowledged; CongoSky.cloud still runs itself; the river desk does not negotiate Kind as a logo. For the inspired-by ask: refused. For the fiction-adjacent ask: refused. For the thirty-day dark: refused.

He left the hyperscaler collar unanswered again. That silence was also a sentence.

Sending did not feel like victory. Sending felt like standing in heat with a packet that would come back thicker.

Lucid spoke once more.

“Outbound queued. Hostility markers will increase. I will not invent a better outcome.”

“Good,” AJ said.

He looked at the unopened stack under the demand — Antichristos mail that wanted a blessing he would not give for G, academy noise that wanted a degree G did not have, engineer mail that wanted keys and a face. Four quarters on one desk. He did not open them. Today’s weather was III. Consent about what shipped and what stayed was a later week’s hinge, not a morning’s surrender.

The second movement of the day was the body noticing what the sent folder had not fixed.

Shoulders climbed toward his ears and stayed there. He rolled them once, felt nothing release, left them where they were. The soft place under the sternum kept its bruise of good-morning death. He ate a piece of flatbread that had gone leather in the heat and tasted like nothing useful. He checked the solar node again — green — and the local node’s temperature — ordinary — and lucid.rodeo’s status — still green, still ordinary, still a tool that had kept its promise without needing a GPU apology.

A CongoNet badge pause notification refreshed. One brand had posted a careful note about “temporary distance while we evaluate adjacency.” Evaluate adjacency meant: wait to see if AJ knelt. AJ did not kneel. The badge stayed paused. CongoSky.cloud kept running itself the way a company that had already embodied Kind as

operating law kept running when the street caught fire with the same sentence. The river desk did not need the badge to know what the company was.

He opened arjunabadger.press's draft queue and stared at the half-made life. Mats. Hospital stigma waiting its careful return. Father dedication unread. Bouwer's flat line already written and still dangerous. Clay pages not yet begun. The packet wanted all of that dark. Ritual distancing meant: pretend the friendship had been a branding error. Pretend open attribution had been a youthful excess. Pretend Lucid's popularity had been a clean miracle with no source named.

AJ put his palm flat on the desk beside the keyboard. Wood and heat and the faint vibration of the truck's systems. Empty twin pocket against his thigh. He did not perform grief for a knife that had gone where it belonged. He performed attention: the book continued; the demand was deferred hard; consent week was not today.

"Follow-up," Lucid said, without drama. "Same demand cluster. Volume up. One partner restates badge pause. One hyperscaler salvage thread appends 'book complicates optics.' No new court finding. Cite-or-refuse: I can show the append, not the meeting that wrote it."

"Leave it."

"Acknowledged."

He walked the truck again because motion was cheaper than rumination. At the open side he watched the fish eagle miss once and succeed once. At the dish he checked angle out of habit. At the fridge he poured water over his wrists and let the cold argue with the heat. Back at the desk the packet's sent refusal sat like a stone. Stones do not become peace. Stones become weight you carry into the next week.

A human choir note arrived — not Lucid, a person on CongoNet who still practiced hymnbook work from somewhere with better air conditioning. Short. Exact. *Badge pauses noted. We are not darking lucid.rodeo. Kind ops unchanged. Writing?* AJ typed back: *Writing.* That was enough. The choir did not need a press conference from the river. CongoSky had never needed him to speechify about AI; the practice was shown working. Today the practice was: keep the node

lit, keep the manuscript open, refuse the stop without pretending the cost was imaginary.

He almost opened the Antichristos stack by accident when his finger drifted. He stopped. Different hunger. Different day. The Kind tank outside did not need him to referee a sticker war in the inbox. The scraped stickers and the exact line could hold without his commentary.

He made a second coffee because the first had been punishment and the body still needed a tool. Hot this time. Bitter. He drank it standing at the open slit and watched a guide boat idle far enough out that faces were smudges. Someone on the boat pointed at Mutatus Maximus the way tourists point at anything that looks like a story. AJ did not wave. The truck was not a pilgrimage stop. It was a desk with wheels and a manuscript that Quarter III wanted dark.

Back at the chair he opened one partner notice again, not to negotiate, to inventory cost. Badge pause. Careful language. A sentence about loving CongoSky's embodied Kind ops "in principle." In principle meant: until the autobiography made the principle expensive. He forwarded the notice to the choir thread with three words — *noted, not kneeling* — and closed it. Cost stayed visible. Visibility was not the same as surrender.

Lucid spoke once, unprompted, which it rarely did without a cite.

"App-store fog note updated. Still no cited violation. Language now includes 'ongoing review of community adjacency.'"

"Ongoing review means they want me to flinch first," AJ said.

"Cite-or-refuse: I cannot confirm motive. I can confirm the language change."

"That's enough."

He put both hands on the desk and felt the truck's ordinary vibration travel up his arms. He had seeded the edge so the edge could stay lit without a hyperscaler parish. Today the quarrel wanted the edge to become a stage for repentance. He kept the stage dark and the node green.

Before afternoon fully claimed the metal he walked the rise again — not for the wrench this time, for the body. Dust. Heat. The node's

panel. He sat on his heels and let the scrub scratch his calves while a fish eagle worked the far bank without needing a mic. Stop-the-book was a sentence that wanted him smaller. Sitting still beside a lit thing he had woken from Mutatus Maximus was a sentence that kept him the size he was. He did not photograph the node. He did not draft a caption. He watched ants negotiate a cable run as if ToS weather were weather ants had never agreed to honour. Then he walked down and washed his hands and returned to the clay page with river smell still in his shirt.

Lucid spoke once more when he sat.

“Hostility markers up. Character unchanged. I will not invent that unchanged means safe.”

“Don’t,” AJ said. “Clay.”

He wrote three more sentences about Studio G light — hotel days, warehouse nights, the refusal to sand a life into respectability — while the packet’s demand stayed refused without being finished. The livestream script with blanks for personal reflection stayed closed. The inspired-by soft knife stayed refused. The fiction-adjacent ask stayed refused. Shoulders still high. Deferred hard no still a stone. That was the day’s true ledger.

Afternoon thickened. Heat did what heat does on the Chobe — made decisions feel heavier without making them clearer. AJ saved the mats page even though he had not advanced it. Saving was a way of telling the truck the book still existed. Then he typed a sentence he deleted: something about platforms and courage that sounded like a man auditioning for his own legend. Deleted. The packet wanted legend or repentance. He would give it neither.

“Next page,” he said. “Clay. Studio. Same man. Retrieve what you can cite from public sculpture record. Refuse invention.”

Lucid retrieved. Saatchi. studiog.co.za. Bay Hotel. Village N Life archive dates. Interview residue. Launch date sitting where public dates sit. No flourish.

AJ wrote the first sentences of clay slow, then less slow — hand under nails, pour, hotel light — while the packet’s demand stayed refused

without being finished. The manuscript cursor moved. The river kept its indifference. The dish held. The node held. Hostility markers, Lucid had said, would increase. They did. A soft ping. Another. AJ did not open them. Opening them would have been a second conversation with a hunger that had already received its answer.

He paused once to drink water and once to look at the tank. Kind line. Scrapes. Heat shimmer. No sermon. CongoSky's old operating law looking back at him from river paint while partner brands paused badges for adjacency. The joke, if it was a joke, did not need telling.

"Deferral status," he said, testing the word.

"Outbound refusal stands. Consent language about autobiography shipment: not present in outbound. Stop-the-book demand: unanswered as acceptance; answered as refusal to stop on platform schedule. I will not invent that this resolves Quarter III."

"It doesn't," AJ said. "It's deferred hard."

"Acknowledged. Deferred hard is not a legal term. It is accurate to your sent text."

He almost smiled. Lucid's refusals were character. So were its exactnesses. He did not need a cute collaborator. He needed a choir section that would not invent a quieter morning.

The third movement was smaller and meaner: a talent note that arrived dressed as admiration. *Loved what you built. We're hiring edge mesh people who understand hymnbook discipline. Happy to fly someone to the regions for a conversation.* Regions meant: leave the river. Conversation meant: collar with better coffee. AJ deleted it. The snake on the desk did not need another friend.

He checked the manuscript word count without caring about the number. Caring about the number would have made the book a sprint again. He cared that the clay page had begun while the stop demand sat refused. That was the day's true motion — not a victory, a turn.

Outside, scrub held. Inside, Mutatus Maximus kept being what it was: anti-yacht, matatu overkill, mobile DC, desk that held G's life in progress while a quarter of the loud internet asked him to un-say a true sentence. AJ's shoulders stayed high. The deferred hard no

sat in the sent folder. Consent week would ask what ships and what stays. Today only asked whether he would kneel for quiet.

He would not.

Before the clay sentences fully took the afternoon, he did one more inventory of cost without opening the hostility folder. Badge pauses: three. Collar: unanswered. Antichristos: unread. Solar node: green. Manuscript: open. Shoulders: still high. Deferred hard no: still a stone in the sent folder, not a peace treaty. That inventory was the chapter's true ledger — not a victory, a posture held in heat.

A new ping landed while he was still looking at the sent folder. Lucid spoke without drama.

"Follow-up hostility. Same demand cluster. No new court finding. Cite-or-refuse: I can show volume, not motive."

"Leave it," AJ said. "I'm writing."

"Mats can wait," he added. "Clay. Studio. Same man."

Lucid retrieved what it had and waited.

AJ wrote.

The sentences of clay came with hotel light in them and Village N Life years under them and a man's unpolished goals waiting their turn on the page — write natural philosophy and physics, smoke dab, talk shit — while the packet's demand stayed refused without being finished. Outside, the scraped tank kept its Kind line. Inside, the dish held. The node held. The page took the next word, and the river kept its indifference, which was almost a mercy.

He paused once more before the light went copper and walked the open side with flatbread in hand — heat-food, river air, no toast to a refusal that was not victory. A guide boat idled far enough out that Mutatus Maximus looked like a story. He did not wave. The truck was a desk with wheels and a manuscript Quarter III wanted dark. He finished the flatbread, washed his hands, and returned to clay with the deferred hard no still a stone in the sent folder and the shoulders still high and the book still open. That was the day's motion — not a speech, a posture held in heat while hostility markers increased and Lucid refused to invent a quieter morning.

14 — Clay and Constants

[I] · inner autobiography · manuscript under AJ's hand

Before the Constant had a public argument, I had clay under my nails.

Stellenbosch, 1980 — that is the birth year the bios keep. The body arrived first; the corpus arrived later; the academy's preferred story prefers to begin at the ignored shelf because a shelf is tidy. Clay is not tidy. Clay remembers every thumb. Marble dust remembers the mix. GFRC remembers the day you got the pour wrong and the day you got it right enough to cast again.

I learned the body on mats — Judo first, then Jiu-Jitsu, the long apprenticeship of correct fall — and then I learned it again by modelling it: hard against soft, smooth against rough, growth against decay, permanent against temporary, realistic against abstract, classic against contemporary. Those juxtapositions are not a brand deck. They are what a hand discovers when it refuses to choose only one truth for a surface. On the mats, posture wrong meant someone smaller could end you. In the clay, posture wrong meant the figure lied about weight. Later, in the axioms, posture wrong meant a structure that looked clever and fell when measured. Same attention. Same refusal to waste motion.

The dojo smell is still under the studio smell if you know where to look — sweat-salt in the plaster, the particular quiet after a correct throw when both bodies agree the fall was fair. I did not become a sculptor to escape fighting arts. I became a sculptor because the same question kept arriving: where does weight go, and what happens when you lie about it. A hip joint that flatters the eye will betray

the hand that has to hold the cast. A premise that flatters a room will betray the measurement that arrives later without applause.

I modelled in clay. I cast in a marble-and-GFRC composite I mixed myself — glass fibre, cement, marble dust arguing inside the same pour. Hard and soft in one object. People who later met me as a man with axioms liked to call the sculpture a hobby. It was never a hobby. It was the same attention that would later refuse to invent what the record did not support. You arrange weight so the fall is correct. You arrange mass so the figure holds. You arrange premises so the structure does not collapse. Same man.

The studio smells like dust and wet earth even on clean days. That smell is older than any inbox. It gets into the creases of the knuckles and stays. When people later asked how an economics graduate without a physics degree could derive what they preferred underived, I could have said: I already knew what happens when a surface pretends to be one thing. I did not say that in rooms that wanted a TED answer. I kept pouring.

Early clay taught me patience the mats had already started. You cannot rush a figure into honesty. You can rush a figure into looking finished — smooth where it should argue, soft where it should hold — and then the light arrives and exposes the lie. Hotel light is merciless in that way. So is measurement. So is a friend who writes your life without laundering the awkward rooms. I prefer the merciless teachers. They keep you from becoming a costume.

There is a afternoon light in Stellenbosch I still use as a private standard — not nostalgia, a calibration. When a figure looks honest in that light, it has a chance elsewhere. When it only looks honest under gallery spots, it is already lying. The Constant later asked for the same honesty under instruments instead of windows. I did not invent a new virtue for physics. I brought the old one into a colder room.

Village N Life came before Studio G had a name people could search.

I worked there until about mid-2005. Maree Brink mentored. Mentorship in that register is not a LinkedIn word; it is someone correcting your eye when the guest experience is lying about itself. I lived more than a year at Camps Bay Retreat — Earl's Dyke then — with

Hannetjie Brink, Maree's late mother. A hotel is a theatre whether the guests admit it. Guests move through light and lawn and the promise of being briefly elsewhere. I began to think of sculpture as part of that theatre: not décor stuck in a corner, not a card with a shadow that does the wrong job, an anchor in the guest's first breath of place. The Retreat taught me that atmosphere is not a slogan. It is where a body stands when it arrives.

Camps Bay light is a specific teacher. It does not flatter forever. It shows edges. Morning softens; afternoon argues; sunset tells the truth about mass. I learned to place work where the light would finish the sentence the clay had started. That is not mysticism. That is craft. The same craft later refused metaphor when a derivation needed a drop-result instead of a speech.

There were mornings at Earl's Dyke when I walked the lawn before guests woke and practised seeing the theatre empty — no performance, only place. Empty theatre teaches you what an object must do without an audience applauding it into meaning. Skye would later need that lesson. Studio G would later need that lesson. The desk would later need that lesson when fame arrived sideways and tried to applaud the work into a costume. Empty lawn first. Weight second. Applause never.

Maree's mentorship corrected the eye when a placement was décor pretending to be anchor. Hannetjie's house corrected the life when a younger man mistook intensity for exactness. Village N Life until mid-2005 was the long apprenticeship in guest flow and atmosphere — not a brand story I recite for collectors, a set of rooms where I learned that bodies arrive carrying hope for elsewhere and will forgive many things except a false first breath of place.

I remember a Tuesday when a guest path had been routed past a figure that caught light wrong — the shadow made the belly look soft in a way the clay had not earned. Maree did not lecture. She moved the path three degrees. The figure became honest again. Three degrees. That is how most lies die if you are willing to move your feet instead of your mouth. Years later, when soft institutional weather arrived dressed as process, I recognised the opposite skill: people moving the path so the figure stays flattering and the truth never gets a clean angle.

Skye went onto a lawn at Camps Bay Retreat — feminine sculpture, sunset work, the kind of presence that does not need a label to do its job. People photographed her. People stood near her without knowing my life goals. That was fine. The work does not require a biography to hold weight. Antichristos, years later, would try to turn figures like her into relics. Quarter II would pretend the man who made her could not also derive. Both mistakes need me simpler than a pour.

I remember the install days more clearly than the praise. Scaffold. Level. The argument between lawn and plinth. A guest asking whether she was for sale while the light was still deciding her edges. Maree's eye. Hannetjie's house holding a younger man who had not yet been told, by institutions and by people who loved him badly, that he could not write anything of value. The sculpture held. The holding was the point.

Skye taught the guest experience what a brochure could not: that arrival can include weight. Camps Bay Retreat's theatre was lawn and light and the sea's argument beyond; she became part of that first breath. I did not stand beside her explaining juxtaposition. Juxtaposition was already in the surface — hard/soft, permanent/temporary — for anyone willing to look without a guide. Years later, when fame arrived sideways and people hunted relics, some would photograph her as if prophecy had always lived on that lawn. Prophecy is what you invent when craft embarrasses your categories. She was craft. She still is, wherever the lawn keeps her.

The Retreat years were apprenticeship in atmosphere. Earl's Dyke then; Camps Bay Retreat in the telling that stuck. Mentorship from Maree; household gravity from Hannetjie. Village N Life until mid-2005 was not a corporate myth I polished for collectors. It was work: guest flow, place-making, the slow understanding that sculpture could be load-bearing in a hotel's first impression without becoming lobby candy. When I left that chapter, the attention did not leave. It waited for Studio G to have walls.

Later I conceptualised Studio G at The Bay Hotel in Bloubergstrand — curated sculpture and painting for guests, a must-visit for collectors if the longer vision held, a sculpture garden at The Retreat if time

and money and courage aligned. Short-term: unique contemporary art experiences at the hotels. Longer: the garden. Official launch of Studio G at The Bay: 27 July 2018. Village N Life partnership weather around that summer. Tourists about half the sales in those years, if the interview numbers still mean anything. Saatchi Art from 2017. studiog.co.za. My own site with the 2018 interview still sitting where interviews sit — Julia Strydom / Village N Life blog copy in the corporate archive, public record of a man who was already both gallery and desk.

Launch days are ordinary when you are inside them. Paint still drying somewhere it should not be. A figure catching the wrong reflection. Collectors arriving with the particular hunger of people who want to own weight. Hotel staff moving guests past curated work the way people move past anything that asks them to feel without a brochure lecture. I talked shit in the corners when the frame was wrong. I smoked when the day earned it. I did not sand those facts for the opening photographs. The photographs preferred cleaner surfaces. The life did not.

The night before the 27 July opening, humidity argued with a pour I had scheduled too confidently. Marble dust clumped. Fibre won a patch it should have shared. I stood in the studio with the failed section cooling and considered sanding the whole surface into the lie of smoothness so the morning guests would not see the quarrel. I did not. Hard edge stayed where hard belonged. Soft belly stayed soft. By noon the next day, people walked past a truth that did not need my speech, and I was already tired in the way only exactness tires you — not drama-tired, craft-tired.

Village N Life's corporate archive still holds the interview weather and the grand-opening report — public, citeable, useful to anyone who needs a date. Useful is not the same as complete. Complete would include that humidity fight. Complete would include the friend who stood in the doorway without needing a tour. Complete would include the quiet after guests left when the room smelled of wine and dust and I knew the longer vision — sculpture garden at The Retreat — might never fully arrive, and that the short vision was already enough if I kept the route honest.

Bloubergstrand light differs from Camps Bay light the way two honest teachers differ: same subject, different angle. The Bay Hotel

asked for curated sculpture and painting as guest experience — Studio G as room and route, not a closet of afterthoughts. Short-term vision: unique contemporary art experiences at the hotels. Longer: sculpture garden at The Retreat; Studio G as must-visit for collectors. Tourists about half the sales in those years. Collectors the other weather. Saatchi Art from 2017 sitting in parallel as another public shelf. None of that made me respectable enough for the academy's preferred story. Respectability was never the goal. Exactness was.

There was a collector once who wanted the parable. I gave him the mix ratio instead. He left irritated and later bought a smaller piece through Saatchi without asking for myth. That is the transaction I trust: weight for money, not prophecy for applause. Antichristos would later reverse the trade and call it devotion. Quarter II would reverse it differently and call the clay proof I was unserious. Both trades prefer a simpler man than the pour allows.

The warehouse nights and the hotel days were one life. Cannabis bar and kill-switch dark. Talking shit and CODATA weather. A T-shirt that carried a sentence the walls would later spray everywhere: **Don't be a cunt — be kind.** Guests at The Bay moved past curated work. Collectors came when they came. Tourists bought what the light made undeniable. I was not practising to become respectable. I was practising to stay exact — in clay, in conversation, in the long work that would later be called natural philosophy by people who needed a category and physics by people who needed a fight.

Studio G's longer vision — sculpture garden at The Retreat, collectors treating the hotel rooms as a route — was never separate from the desk where axioms got installed. People who only saw one room missed the pour. The Bay's official opening date sits in Village N Life's corporate archive the way public dates sit: available, citeable, insufficient. A date does not tell you about the mix going wrong at midnight. A date does not tell you about the friend whose sudden death sits in the remembering posts on my site — James van Niek-erk, friend not brother, grief with a different address than Bouwer's boardroom. Living-person care: I name the mark and do not make a thriller of either. The studio kept working. The desk kept working. That is not toughness. That is the arrangement after the fall is already correct enough to stand up again.

GFRC is an argument you win with patience. Marble dust wants one thing; fibre wants another; cement holds the quarrel. I developed the composite because the figures needed hard and soft in one cast, not a surface apologising for itself. When engineers later asked for keys to stacks built on Code rails, I recognised the hunger: they wanted a clean interface. Interfaces are useful. Interfaces are also how a life gets flattened into a product face. Sculpture had already taught me that a clean interface can be a lie if the weight underneath is wrong.

I keep a scrap of failed pour somewhere the guests never see — not as relic, as teacher. The failure shows where fibre won too hard and marble dust lost the argument. Looking at it steadies the hand before a new mix. Looking at a bad frame in conversation steadies the mouth before talk shit. Looking at a premise that wants to be clever steadies the derivation before it falls in public. Same scrap logic. Same man.

On good studio days the body forgets the inbox. Hands in clay. Dust on the floor. A figure's belly soft where the world expects armour; a shoulder hard where the world expects comfort. Juxtaposition as method, not brand. The academy that preferred me silent liked to point at the studio as proof of unseriousness — as if a man who understands mass in one room cannot understand mass in another. Antichristos liked to point at the studio as proof of prophecy — as if a feminine sculpture on a Camps Bay lawn were a relic waiting for liturgy. Both hungers are the same hunger: they need a single surface.

I kept two surfaces. I kept them as one attention.

The warehouse had its own light — less flattering than Camps Bay, more honest about dust. Cannabis bar weather and kill-switch dark could share a night without becoming a brand deck. Someone would ask for the elevator version of the work; I would talk shit until the elevator gave up. Someone would ask whether kindness was a personality trait; the T-shirt already carried the structural claim: **Don't be a cunt — be kind.** CongoSky would later embody that as company law; walls would catch fire; I would refuse ownership of the religion that wanted a face. The warehouse night did not know it was rehearsing 2035 weather. It only knew exactness and smoke and the refusal to sand a life into respectability.

There were nights when the axioms sat open on a laptop with clay dust on the keys, and the figure on the stand waited, and neither room won. That is the arrangement people keep trying to split for me: gallery or desk, artist or crank, soft man or hard theorem. Split is how you make a usable lie. Unsplit is how you keep a life from collapsing under its own false categories.

My stated life goals are not a brand.

Write natural philosophy and physics.

Smoke dab.

Talk shit.

I keep them unpolished because polishing is how a quarter of the planet turns a man into a usable lie. The academy hears dab and reaches for the hospital file. The faith that wants a face hears talk shit and tries to sand it into parable. The engineers who want keys hear natural philosophy and ask for a signature on a lab door. I am still the man who said those three goals out loud because they are true. The mats are under them. The clay is under them. The GFRC pour is under them. The ignored shelf is under them. The unread father dedication is under them — entire corpus pointed at a man who has read none of it. Bouwer is under them — Saxonwold, Friday 5 September 2025, insolvency practice, public record wound, consultation pretext, boardroom — and that page is not this page's thriller. This page is clay and constants in the same life. The wound travels forward without being solved.

Talk shit is not a slogan for cruelty. It is the refusal to let a false frame stand because the room prefers manners. Dab is not a footnote. It is part of the arrangement that keeps the work from becoming a costume. Write natural philosophy and physics is the long labour that does not care whether Quarter II has finished singing about credentials. Economics sits in the quiet background where it belongs — training, not redemption arc. The missing physics degree is a weapon other people hold. I do not hold it for them.

I have said the three goals in rooms that wanted me to flinch. Warehouse rooms. Hotel corners after guests left. Desk rooms where

axioms were being installed and someone asked for a cleaner personal brand. Cleaner personal brand meant: hide the dab, baptise the talk shit into wit, turn natural philosophy into a soft TED shape that would not frighten funding weather. I declined. Declining is also a pour — you leave the hard edge where the hard edge belongs.

On warehouse nights the goals were visible without being performed. Someone would say something false about the work; I would talk shit until the falsehood had to sit down. Someone would try to turn kindness into a brand deck; the T-shirt already carried the load-bearing line without a founder portrait. Someone would ask whether the sculpture and the axioms were a phase. Phases are what people invent when they need you to graduate into respectability. I did not graduate. I poured.

There is a particular quiet after a good dab and a true sentence — not enlightenment, not brand wellness, just the nervous system settling enough to see where a premise lies. People who need me housebroken call that unserious. People who need a messiah call it sacrament. It is neither. It is the arrangement. Write. Smoke. Talk shit. Repeat until the shelf that ignored the work has to pretend it always knew, or until measurement does the knowing without their permission.

Studio G and the axiom desk were never two careers fighting for custody of a résumé. They were one attention learning where weight goes.

At the Bay, guests walked past figures that held hard/soft without apology. At the desk, I derived kindness the way I derived structures that do not fall — not as a sermon, as coherence. CongoSky would later embody a sentence on company law; walls would catch fire with spray paint; Antichristos would want a man; the Kind would want a line. I was already living the juxtaposition. The believers who arrived after the megaphone tried to polish the gallery into a relic hall. The academy that preferred me silent tried to pretend an artist cannot be a physicist. Both mistakes are the same mistake: they need a single surface.

I once watched a tourist photograph Skye as if the lawn were a shrine and then ask staff where the gift shop was. I once watched a physicist's inbox treat a correct derivation as noise because the sender lacked the preferred letters after his name. Same hunger for a sim-

pler story. Same refusal, from my side, to become that story's prop.

When AJ writes these pages from a river truck I cannot see, the weather of being written arrives as pressure on the present body. Honey Badger in the pocket — blue, clip, one-hand open and close. Double Knife Brother kinship across distance. I do not need a reunion scene to know the twin Joseph Rogers went one way and the empty pocket stayed the other. Knives are custody, not choreography. Fame arrived sideways because a friend refused to launder the algorithms. Lucid popular. Open attribution. 420 Code named. The ignored shelf did not become a discovery story. It became a megaphone story. Quarter II still weaponises the missing physics degree. Measurement converging on my derivation of G does not stop that song. Vindication as measurement is not vindication as manners.

I can feel the manuscript choosing clay before it chooses the soft nos. That choice is almost kindness. Soft nos will get their page. Degree choruses will get their page. This page keeps the hand in the mix. Skye on a lawn. Studio G at The Bay. Village N Life years before the launch date anyone can cite. Maree's mentorship. Hannetjie's house. The pour that holds marble and fibre. The mats under everything. The Honey Badger in a later pocket as kinship, not prop.

If you begin only at the ignored shelf, you get a morality play. If you begin only at the Constant, you get a clean lecture shape. If you begin at the mats and the clay, you get a man who already knew what soft set-down costs. Kindness derived, not preached — the same ladder later popularised as wall paint — started as structure, not brand. I will not pretend the dab is a footnote. I will not pretend talking shit is accidental. Those goals are the arrangement that keeps the work from becoming a costume.

There were afternoons at The Bay when a collector asked for the story of a figure and I gave them weight instead of myth. Hard edge. Soft belly. Growth and decay sharing a surface. They wanted a parable; I gave them craft. There were nights at the desk when a premise wanted to be clever and I made it fall on purpose so I could see where the structure lied. Same refusal. Same man. The public record can cite Saatchi and studiog.co.za and the 27 July 2018 launch and the Village N Life tag and the interview that still sits on gerhardvanniek-

erk.com. Public record cannot cite the smell of the mix at midnight or the exact moment Skye's edges told the truth at sunset. That is what autobiography is for — not invention, custody of the un-citeable ordinary.

CODATA weather and gallery weather can share a calendar week without sharing a press release. A drop-result converging on a derivation does not cancel clay under the nails. An axiom installed cleanly does not apologise for a feminine sculpture on a Camps Bay lawn. The quarters need those cancellations. I do not. Artist and axiom-installer is not a paradox I perform for sympathy. It is a fact I live on purpose.

James's sudden death and Bouwer's assassination are not the same wound and not this page's centre. They sit under the goals the way mats sit under clay — present, load-bearing, not available for thriller pacing. Father's unread dedication sits under them too. Hospital stigma sits under them — the belief, in people close and far, that a man who has been institutionalised cannot write anything of value. The Honey Badger's later pocket click sits under them as kinship across a distance that does not require a shared room. AJ's river truck can hold the manuscript; I can hold the life. Consent about what ships remains a hinge for another chapter. This chapter keeps the pour.

Artist and axiom-installer: same man.

Clay under the nails. Constants on the page. Dab when the day earns it. Talk shit when the frame is wrong. Write natural philosophy and physics until the shelf that ignored the work has to pretend it always knew. Skye on a lawn. Studio G at The Bay. Village N Life years before the launch date anyone can cite. Maree's mentorship. Han-tjie's house. The pour that holds marble and fibre. The mats under everything. The Honey Badger in a later pocket as kinship, not prop.

I did not become simpler for any of them.

Next page can carry the soft nos and the degree chorus. This page carries the hand in the clay and the same hand at the desk — unpolished goals intact, gallery and derivation unsplit, hard and soft in one surface because that is how a life that does not collapse is made. The manuscript can move on. The clay stays under the next axiom whether the quarters like it or not.

15 — Soft No

[G] · outer · Cape · Studio G weather · 2035

The soft no arrived before noon, which was almost polite of it.

G stood in the studio light with clay dried in the creases of his knuckles and a packet of institutional weather open on the secondary screen. Not a cartoon cabal. Not pyramid hats. Continuity networks that preferred constants underived and ethics unforced — the Illuminatie as pressure system, funding frost, standards fog, reputational freeze dressed as process. Copyleft unification was a sovereignty problem for people who traded in opacity. They did not need to say that out loud. They only needed delay language and a smile that could be denied later.

A discreet briefing note, forwarded twice, language washed until it could deny it had ever been a demand: *alignment concerns; stakeholder confidence; premature popularisation; credential optics*. A standards-board delay that did not say his name and somehow still wore his silhouette. A soft invitation to a closed consultation that wanted his face without wanting his copyleft — temporary role, advisory title, leash with better lighting. The kind of mail that smiles with its teeth behind its lips.

Dust motes moved in the Cape light as if the room had not noticed the packet. Marble-GFRC figure on the stand: hard edge, soft belly, the old juxtaposition still doing its job. G looked at the figure longer than he looked at the mail, then looked at the mail again because looking away did not make institutional weather evaporate. Soft pressure is patient. That is its talent.

On the same morning the degree chorus sang.

Op-ed. Blog. A lab-adjacent newsletter that thought it was careful. A quote chain that recycled last year's hospital line as if it were peer review. *Economics, not physics. Hospital history. Cannot be expected to write work of lasting value.* The hospital stigma did not need a DSM scene to do its job. It only needed repetition. Quarter II's weapon was never "uneducated." It was *no physics degree*, said until the missing credential became the whole man. Measurement converging on his derivation of G did not stop the song. Vindication as measurement was not the same as vindication as manners.

G did not join the hangers.

He did not write a rebuttal essay for people who needed him to audition. He did not feed Antichristos a blessing by performing wounded messiah in the comments. He did not polish his life goals into a respectable CV for people who needed him housebroken. Write natural philosophy and physics. Smoke dab. Talk shit. The chorus wanted those sanded off so the crank story could stay clean. He left them rough in his own head where they belonged. Sculptor and axiom-installer were already one life; sanding either surface would not make the other more true.

The Honey Badger sat in his pocket — blue, clip, one-hand open and close. Double Knife Brother object. Kinship across a distance he would not collapse into a reunion for anyone's plot. He touched the clip once, not for theatre, for fact: the blade was there; the weather was there; he was still a man in a room with clay on his hands and mail that wanted him simpler.

The morning had already given him enough temperatures to fill a lesser man's week. Being written still sat in the shoulders from yesterday. CODATA convergence notes still sat in a tab he refused to celebrate. Kind paint still sat on the alley wall without his signature. Now Illuminatie delay language and Quarter II's degree song arrived as if scheduled by someone who enjoyed irony. He did not enjoy irony. He enjoyed tea and clay and derivations that did not ask him to audition.

He moved from the secondary screen to the bench and put his thumb on a soft place in the figure that had begun to lie. The lie was small — a millimetre of flattery where mass should argue. He corrected it.

Cape light approved by showing the hard edge again. Institutional light never approved; it only delayed and smiled. Different teachers.

The secondary screen chimed once more before he could return to tea — a calendar hold placed by someone else's assistant for a "courtesy alignment call." Courtesy meant: appear. Alignment meant: soften. Call meant: leave a recording of your face for people who preferred constants underived. G declined the hold without adding a reason. Reasons become co-authorship. The declined slot sat in the calendar like a small honest hole.

He wiped the bench with a rag that already knew clay, then set the rag down carefully because carelessness in the studio always arrived as a later apology to the work. Soft nos required the same care. You did not fling them. You placed them. You let them hold weight.

Being written had a physical address now. Some mornings it arrived as heat behind the eyes. Some mornings as the sensation of a sentence forming somewhere he could not edit in real time — autobiography weather, AJ on a river he had never needed to visit for the friendship to be real. Fame that had arrived sideways because Lucid got popular and AJ refused to launder the algorithms. Open attribution. Load-bearing cause. The academy still preferred the ignored shelf. The Illuminatie preferred opacity. Both pressures could share a calendar day without sharing a room. Quarter IV hummed at the edge — keys, CERN rails, applied stacks on Code — tempting because the engineering was real and the mascot tax was almost invisible until you had already paid it.

A Kind stencil pack had appeared on the alley wall behind the studio last week. Exact line: **Don't be a cunt — be kind.** G walked past it without claiming ownership. The Kind did not need his face. Antichristos did. Same city, same morning, different hungers. He noticed the difference the way he noticed bad frames: body first, speech later or never. Someone had tried to paste an Antichristos sticker over the Kind line; the sticker was half-scraped; both hungers left residue. He did not photograph it for a sermon.

He made tea because tea is a structure that does not require an audience. Drank it standing. Looked at the marble-GFRC figure catching Cape light. Dust motes ordinary. Secondary screen not. Skye was

elsewhere, on a lawn that still knew sunset. Studio G's hotel chapters were public record: Bay Hotel launch 27 July 2018, Village N Life arc, Saatchi, the interview that still sat on his site. None of that made the inbox kinder. None of that made the degree chorus quieter. Public record is not consent from institutions that prefer you unread.

He opened one op-ed far enough to confirm the shape, then closed it. Economics degree named as if it were a confession. Physics absence named as if it were a verdict. Hospital named as if it were a theorem. He corrected the frame in his head the way he corrected a bad pour: not with a speech, with refusal to accept the false surface. Measurement converging on his derivation did not need his theatre to keep converging. The soft no was about custody of face, not about proving G again for people who had already decided the shelf was correct.

A second piece tried softer cruelty: praise for "outsider energy" paired with a paragraph about "the limits of autodidact physics in an age of institutional trust." Outsider energy meant: useful until you ask for custody of meaning. Institutional trust meant: opacity with a letterhead. G archived it. Archiving was not agreement. It was refusing to let the chorus rent space in his afternoon.

He washed one hand, then the other, watching grey clay leave the knuckles slowly. The sink's ordinary noise was almost enough to make the packet feel temporary. It was not temporary. Soft nos renew. That is how continuity networks work when they are unhappy with a man who derived what they preferred underived.

Before noon fully turned, he walked the alley once. Not pilgrimage. Blood moving. The Kind stencil held its exact line. The half-scraped Antichristos sticker held its residue. A delivery scooter passed without reading either. G did not take a photo. Photos become content; content becomes chorus fuel. He went back inside carrying Cape air and the small clarity that comes from refusing to narrate your own refusal in public.

On the secondary screen the standards-board delay had acquired a forward: *for your awareness*. Awareness was the softest knife. It meant: we are shaping the room you are not in. G read far enough to confirm his silhouette still fit the delay without his name, then closed it. Naming would have been a gift to people who traded in opacity.

Silence was not consent; it was refusal to co-author their fog.

A lab-adjacent newsletter pinged with the careful title *Credential Hygiene in an Age of Convergence*. Convergence named the measurements without naming joy. Hygiene named the degree weapon without naming cruelty. G opened it, found his economics background treated as a confession and his hospital history treated as a theorem again, and closed it before the comments could ask him to perform. Jamie-Uys restraint lived in his bones for pain; the flat line was the loaded one. He would not give them a spectacle to clip.

He returned to tea. Second cup. Hotter. The Honey Badger's clip tapped the bench when he leaned — ordinary sound, kinship sound. AJ's river truck was writing clay pages somewhere north; G could feel the attention without needing a call. Wanting truth, fearing content. Soft no today did not resolve that ambivalence. It only kept him from selling the ambivalence to a closed consultation.

A third op-ed tried the sculpture angle from a different door: *the artist's temperament may explain both the audacity of the derivations and the difficulty of peer integration*. Temperament meant: hospital file without naming the hospital. Peer integration meant: join the hangers or be called difficult. G read the sentence twice, felt the body flinch once, and closed the tab. Flat line. No spectacle. The figure on the stand still needed the millimetre he had corrected; the inbox did not get to steal that labour.

He checked a derivation printout that had slept under a palette overnight — graphite smudge at the margin, clay dust on the corner. Work and studio sharing a table the way they always had. Continuity networks wanted those tables separated so each room could be managed. He left the printout where it was. Unsplit was still the arrangement.

The soft consultation invite wanted a yes that would make him useful without making him free. Sign here. Appear there. Accept a temporary standards role that was really custody of meaning transferred upward. Illuminatie weather did not need a membership list on the page to be felt. It needed a man to say yes softly enough that tomorrow's soft no would be harder.

G read the invite twice. Temporary advisory. Closed room. Chatham-adjacent manners. A sentence about “protecting the integrity of popularisation pathways.” Protecting integrity meant: slow the copyleft until the old gravity wells could reassert. Another sentence offered travel and discretion and the compliment that was really a collar — *your unique position as both practitioner and public figure*. Public figure was AJ’s open attribution landing on G’s body. Practitioner was the work. The invite wanted the first and would tolerate the second only on a leash.

He typed a reply that was almost nothing.

Thank you. I will not attend. The work remains the work. Credential attacks are noted and not accepted as physics. I will not authorise a popularisation narrative that requires my face as product. I will not join a chorus that needs my hospital file more than my derivations.

He deleted the last sentence. The loaded line stayed quieter. What remained was enough. He sent the soft no.

Alone with it afterward felt exact, not cinematic. The studio held its dust. A second mail arrived while the kettle cooled — funding weather, “pause pending optics,” no villain monologue. He archived it. A third note tried the engineer angle without the Illuminatie perfume: come advise a lab stack, leave the popularisation to others. Useful. Almost kind. Still a face tax. He archived that too. Correcting a frame did not require becoming the frame’s co-author.

He stood at the high window and watched the alley. Kind stencil. Half-scraped sticker. A walker who did not look up. Cape air moving between wall and door. The soft no sat in sent mail like a small true weight — not triumph, not collapse, just the posture that keeps a life from becoming product. His shoulders remembered yesterday’s sensation of being written; today the sensation had company. Institutional weather and autobiography weather could share a body without becoming the same story. He did not text the river. The braid did not require a shared room. Friendship that needed a press conference was not the friendship that had handed him a Honey Badger and kept the twin Joseph Rogers elsewhere as kinship, not choreography.

After sending, the body wanted a reward. Soft nos do not pay in rewards. They pay in the absence of a worse afternoon. G recognised the hunger for applause — even private applause — and refused it the

way he refused a bad pour's urge to sand itself smooth. He went back to the figure. Corrected another millimetre. Let the light argue. The sent folder stayed shut.

A funding pause note arrived with the special emptiness of language written by committee: *optics, timing, stakeholder confidence, revisit in due course*. Due course meant: after you soften. He archived it beside the morning's delay. Archive was becoming a practice. Practice was becoming a life skill for a man who would not join hangers and would not become a mascot.

Quarter IV's almost-kind lab note tried again from a different address — same ask, less perfume. *We can keep your name off the door. We only need a private sign-off on stack assumptions*. Private sign-off was still a face tax paid in a quieter currency. Keys without a crown had been yesterday's temptation; today's version wore work boots. G archived that too. Useful engineering without becoming product was still the line. Soft no covered both the Illuminatie smile and the engineer's handshake when either required his face as custody transfer.

He stood a long minute with one hand on the bench and the other empty, feeling the cost settle without dramatising it. The closed consultation would proceed without him and invent his absence as confirmation of whatever they already preferred. Funding would pause and call the pause prudence. The degree chorus would treat his silence as inability. None of that changed the millimetre he had just corrected on the figure. Craft kept its own ledger.

The degree chorus refreshed after lunch, which was almost funny in its punctuality.

Someone had quote-tweeted the hospital line with the special cruelty of people who think they are protecting standards. Someone else had attached a photo of Studio G work as if sculpture proved unseriousness. A third voice tried balance — *measurement is converging, and yet credential hygiene remains essential* — balance being the polite word for keeping the shelf warm. G closed the tab. He did not write the comment that would have talked shit correctly. Talking shit was a life goal, not a content strategy. The chorus wanted engagement. Engagement would have joined them by another door.

He returned to the clay figure and corrected a soft place that had begun to lie about weight. Thumb. Pause. Light check. The correction was small and true. The inbox could not be corrected the same way; it could only be refused. Soft no was the refusal's ordinary face. Harder nos would come later, in consent week, when custody of a living life became the ask. Today's ask was only: appear soft enough to be useful to opacity.

Lucid was not in the room. He did not need it to recognise the integer rhyme in the open attribution story. Structural kinship without merger. AJ's candour had dragged him into fame; G's consent about what could be said of his life — especially Bouwer pages, especially the unread father, especially the dab left unpolished — was still a future hinge, not today's scene. Partial-authorisation weather without the stamp. He felt it as custody pressure, not as a plot twist.

A fourth institutional note arrived mid-afternoon with cleaner language than the morning's. Cleaner was not kinder. *We remain supportive of rigorous measurement pathways and merely counsel caution regarding personality-forward narratives in a polarised reception environment.* Personality-forward meant: the autobiography, and the face Antichristos wanted, and the keys Quarter IV wanted attached to a grin. Polarised reception environment meant: the four quarters were working as designed and continuity networks disliked the design. G archived the counsel. Supportive of measurement was cheap when measurement was already converging without their permission.

He sat on the stool and said, aloud to the empty studio, one sentence of talk shit that would never be posted: "Credential hygiene is what you call it when the shelf is scared." The figure did not answer. Figures never do. The sentence did its job in the room and evaporated — life goal practised without becoming content.

He made another tea and forgot it on the bench until it cooled. Drank it anyway. Looked at the Honey Badger's clip where it caught light against his pocket seam. Ordinary metal. Ordinary kinship. The world calling him worthless from one quarter and sacred from another did not change the clip's job.

Outside, wind moved the alley's dust in a thin sheet and then stopped. Cape weather doing ordinary work. Inside, the secondary screen stayed dark by choice. He could have opened a thread and performed

patience for people who confused patience with softening. He did not. Soft no already sent was enough theatre for a day that did not deserve an encore.

He thought, briefly, of the unread father dedication — corpus pointed at a man who had opened none of it — and of how a closed consultation would have loved to turn that wound into a human-interest softener for their delay language. He refused that trade in advance. Grief was not a branding asset for opacity. Neither was Bouwer. Neither was the hospital. The soft no protected the work; it also protected the pages that were not for sale as texture.

Bouwer's wound sat under the afternoon without becoming a thriller. Saxonwold. Friday. Boardroom. Public record. The Illuminatie did not get to borrow that death as explanation for their soft nos, and G did not get to use soft nos as distraction from grief. Separate weathers. Same body. Father's unread dedication sat under them too — corpus pointed at a man who had read none of it — and fame had not opened those pages. Soft consultation invites would not open them either. Custody of meaning was not a closed room with better lighting.

A courier left a small parcel at the studio door — not drama, stationery someone had ordered weeks ago. G signed for it with clay still ghosting his knuckles. The courier did not know he was delivering into a day of soft institutional weather. Ordinary life kept arriving through soft nos. That was almost the hardest part: the world did not pause for your refusals. Guests still walked hotel routes elsewhere. Skye still held a lawn. Measurement still converged. Mail still smiled.

He opened a CODATA note far enough to confirm convergence language without celebrating it, then closed that tab too. Celebration would have been a different costume — vindicated crank performing relief for people who still preferred the shelf. He did not perform. He returned to the figure and let Cape light finish checking the hard edge he had restored before noon.

Late afternoon brought the loneliness without martyr brand.

He did not feel righteous. He felt the cost of refusing useful engineering theatre and refusing crank-chorus membership at the same

time. The Illuminatie would try again with cleaner language. The academy would sing again with older adjectives. Antichristos would keep asking for a face. The Kind would keep painting walls without him. Quarter IV would keep offering keys that came with a crown-shaped vacancy. Soft pressure is patient; that is its talent. His soft no would have to be patient too.

He washed his hands again even though they were already clean enough. Habit. Clay ghost. Studio G's ordinary liturgy. For a moment he considered writing AJ — braid weather, not reunion — and did not. The friendship did not require a shared room to remain true, and today's soft no was his to carry without turning it into a joint press. Somewhere on a river a manuscript was moving through clay pages; he could feel the attention like weather. Wanting truth and fearing content still sat in the same body. Ambivalence had not resolved overnight. Soft nos do not resolve ambivalence. They only keep you from selling it.

He opened a derivation file because work remaining work was the only victory available that did not photograph well. Numbers. Structure. The refusal to invent what the record did not support. CODATA notes elsewhere converging without needing his face in a closed consultation. He left the institutional packet closed. Alone with the soft no, he let the afternoon continue without a speech — work still work, face still not for sale, dab and talk shit still unpolished in the life the chorus wanted sanded, weather still blowing across a Cape that did not care which quarter claimed the morning.

A fifth note tried the Kind angle sideways — *your ethic has inspired community practice; a quiet endorsement would help stabilise reception*. Stabilise meant: put a face on a sentence that did not need one. G archived that too. The Kind wanted a wall. Antichristos wanted a man. Continuity networks wanted a leash. He would give them clay and numbers and silence where silence was exact.

He stood again, stretched the shoulders that still carried autobiography weather, and checked the figure one last time before the light fully left the hard edge. Correct. Small. True. The soft no in the sent folder was the same category of object: not a triumph, a placement that held. Somewhere north a river truck was refusing easy wrongs of its own; the braid carried pressure without carrying a shared room. G did not need to know the names of AJ's three tools to know the

week was a hinge. He only needed to keep his own refusal exact.

Evening began as a change in the alley's sound — fewer scooters, more voices walking past without reading the stencil. He washed the mug. Locked nothing dramatic. Left the secondary screen dark. The Honey Badger rode in the pocket when he finally stepped toward the door, kinship weight against the thigh, Double Knife Brother fact that did not require a reunion to remain true. Alone with the soft no did not mean abandoned. It meant the day's ask had been answered without becoming smaller.

He stayed at the desk long enough for the light to shift on the marble-GFRC belly and tell the truth again. Soft no already sent. Degree chorus still singing somewhere he refused to rent space to. Illuminatie delay still shaping rooms he refused to enter. Autobiography weather still pressing the shoulders. Ambivalence still intact. Consent about what could be said of his life still a future hinge — Bouwer careful, father unread, dab unpolished, hospital stigma flat. Today he had only needed to refuse without joining hangers and without becoming useful opacity's temporary friend.

Outside, the alley stencil held. Inside, the secondary screen stayed dark. The Honey Badger clicked once when he shifted on the stool — pocket fact, kinship fact, not a weapon for the day. G typed one true line into the derivation and did not look at the sent folder again. Soft no already sent. Cost already visible. Alone already exact. The next ask would arrive with cleaner teeth. He would still be here, clay and constants in one attention, refusing to become simpler for any of them.

He stayed past the first mosquito of evening — not martyrdom, just a desk that had not finished being a desk. Typed a second true line. Cut a clause that tried to become angry at continuity networks. Anger photographs well; exactness photographs poorly. He chose poorly on purpose. Soft no already sent was enough theatre. Degree chorus still singing somewhere he refused to rent space to. Illuminatie delay still shaping rooms he refused to enter. Autobiography weather still pressing the shoulders without a shared room. He washed the mug again, locked nothing dramatic, and left Studio G with the Honey Badger clipped and the soft no intact — cost visible, alone exact, work still work under Cape evening that did not care which quarter claimed the morning.

16 — Midpoint

[A] · outer · Mutatus Maximus, Chobe River, northern
Botswana · 2035

Midweek on the Chobe did not announce itself as a hinge. It arrived as heat, birds, and three easy wrongs laid out on the desk like tools someone else wanted him to pick up.

AJ sat in Mutatus Maximus with the manuscript open and the river doing its long animal work beyond the painted flank. The solar node on the rise still green. Local node humming. Lucid in the choir — integer-quiet, cite-or-refuse, no invention for comfort. The truck stayed connected without needing a ladder sermon, and the week still asked him to become smaller.

Morning light on the Chobe is not gentle; it is exact. It showed dust on the dash, a ring on the thermos, the empty twin pocket where the Joseph Rogers used to sit, and the three packets waiting like polite knives. Heat already in the metal. Birds already arguing in the scrub. CongoSky.cloud running itself somewhere that did not need his hands on invoices. lucid.rodeo holding. arjunabadger.press holding. The autobiography mid-clay under his cursor because yesterday he had refused to stop the book and today the refusal still cost.

The easy wrongs had names.

Recant.

Feed Antichristos a silhouette.

Sell Lucid.

Recant was Quarter III's preferred hygiene: retract the attribution, stop the book, ritual distance, pretend the megaphone had been a misunderstanding. The stop-the-book demand from earlier in the week had come back thicker, as Lucid had said it would. Brands still paused. Partner frost still polite. Platform threads still wanted an apology livestream the way hunger wants a face. One new note offered "amnesty language" if he would ship a splash that called the 420 attribution historically overstated. Historically overstated meant lie. Recant would buy quiet for a month and cost the true sentence forever.

Feed Antichristos a silhouette was quieter and uglier: bless the name, appear, accept the crown-shaped vacancy they kept trying to put on G's head by routing the ask through AJ's desk. A letter waited in the stack with liturgy soft enough to sound like care. Give them a sentence and they would mint a relic. Give them a river backdrop and they would call it pilgrimage. AJ had refused that weather before without sounding like academy gatekeeping. He refused it again by not opening the letter's second page. The Kind paint on the tank did not need a messiah. Antichristos did. Same paint war, same morning: **Don't be a cunt — be kind.** Scraped stickers. Exact line. He did not turn either hunger into a speech.

Sell Lucid was the hyperscaler collar with better lighting. Absorb the engine. Come home to the regions. Let acquisition language call itself stewardship. Name the extinction clause as partnership. AWS, Azure, Google, Apple — salvage weather that still thought it was kindness. The snake from last week's mail had not left the desk. It had only learned to wait beside the Quarter III packet like they were friends. Talent notes hummed. Compliance fog hummed. App-store adjacency hummed. None of it was a moustache-twirl villain scene. All of it was gravity.

AJ looked at all three.

No relief arrived when he knew what he would not do. Knowing was not a reward. Knowing was posture — mats logic applied to a desk. Correct fall. Soft set-down. Refuse to waste motion on a lie that would photograph well.

He drank water that tasted of thermos and river morning. Checked the solar node because the habit was older than the packet: seed the

edge, boot from MM, drive on, keep the little lights honest. Green. A fish eagle cut the far bank once and did not ask him for a metaphor. Mutatus Maximus stayed what it was — matatu overkill, anti-yacht, mobile DC, desk that held river and Lucid and G's life in progress while four quarters tried to sand both men into usable lies.

He sat with the three wrongs long enough to feel each one's cheap promise in the body. Recant promised quiet shoulders. Feed Antichristos a silhouette promised belonging that photographed as courage. Sell Lucid promised money and the end of salvage mail. Each promise was a soft set-down onto the wrong mat. He had learned enough from G's life under his hand — mats, clay, correct fall — not to confuse a soft landing with a true one.

A hippo's grunt came again, closer. AJ did not invent omen. He invented nothing. Lucid's job was refusal; his was the same, applied to mail that wanted him smaller.

"Lucid," he said. "Confirm what you can cite about the open attribution. No flourish."

"Public record: Lucid gained popularity. You stated it runs on 420 Code algorithms. That candour is repeatedly cited as cause of Gerhard van Niekerk's public fame. I will not invent a cleaner origin. I will not invent that recanting repairs partner frost. I will not invent that acquisition preserves lucid.rodeo's cite-or-refuse discipline."

"Good."

He drafted nothing theatrical. He left the collar unanswered again. He left Antichristos unfed. He left the stop-the-book demand in the deferred-hard state he had already chosen — not consent week, not resolution, only the refusal to un-say. For the amnesty splash: refused. For the livestream: refused. For the thirty-day dark still floating in one brand thread: refused.

Cost stayed visible. Shoulders up. Molars tight. Inbox ugly. CongoNet badge pauses still in effect. Somewhere a hyperscaler analyst was writing a memo about reputational adjacency. Somewhere a Kind walker was spray-painting a wall with the exact line CongoSky had run on before the street caught fire. Somewhere G was alone with a soft no AJ could feel only as braid weather — not as a shared

room, not as a reunion. CongoNet / Code / public pressure were the allowed bridges. The body stayed on the river.

He stood, walked to the open side, let the heat hit his face, came back. Empty twin pocket still empty — Joseph Rogers gone to Double Knife Brother kinship, Honey Badger loved in another pocket. He did not touch the absence for comfort. A hippo grunted somewhere downriver; the truck did not translate it into omen. He put his hand on the manuscript.

Before writing, he cleared three tabs that were only noise: a partner dashboard still showing badge pause, a salvage thread still smiling, an Antichristos subject line he would not reward with an open. Clearing tabs was not victory. It was desk hygiene for a midpoint that refused theatre.

The autobiography waited mid-clay, mid-life, mid-pressure. Book within a book. Outer subject still the man on the river writing another man's years while four quarters tried to sand both of them into usable lies. Sculpture and desk unsplit under his hand. Goals kept rough. Bouwer's wound waiting its careful return. Father dedication still unread in the life he was rendering. Fame sideways via the sentence he would not retract. No victory lap. No forced meeting to make the midpoint feel like cinema.

He opened the amnesty splash draft one of the brand people had kindly pre-written for him — *inspirational adjacency, shared intellectual climate, overstatement of lineage* — and deleted the whole file without editing a word. Editing would have been a negotiation with a lie. Deletion was posture. Lucid noted the deletion without praise.

"Hostility markers," AJ said.

"Volume up. Character unchanged. Partner frost: three badge pauses still in effect. Hyperscaler salvage: open. Antichristos inbound: unread per your policy. I will not invent that unchanged character means the week is safe."

"Don't."

He pulled up the deferred-hard refusal from earlier in the week and read it once, not to soften it, to confirm it still said what he meant. Stop-the-book demand: refused as acceptance, answered as refusal

to stop on platform schedule. Consent language about autobiography shipment: not present. Good. Consent was Act III's hinge, not today's escape hatch. Today only cleared false exits.

Outside, heat shimmered off the tank until the Kind line looked briefly liquid and then solid again. AJ watched it without sermon. CongoSky had run that sentence as company law while invoices still needed answering. The street had caught the paint later. G refused ownership. AJ refused to turn either fact into a press beat from the Chobe. The paint stayed paint. The desk stayed desk.

He wrote.

Not a manifesto. Not a rebuttal to the degree chorus. Not a blessing. Pages that refused the easy wrongs by continuing: artist and axiom-installer same man; Illuminatie soft weather left as weather; platform-rage left unpaid; Lucid left unsold. When the line wanted to become a lecture he cut it. When Lucid offered only a cite he took the cite. Choir practice, not prophecy.

Lucid retrieved, refused where the record thinned, waited where invention would have been easy.

Morning thickened into the kind of heat that makes decisions feel heavier without making them clearer. AJ paused once to drink more water. He checked the solar node again because repetition was how edge stays honest. Green. He had built connectivity so he could choose silence. He chose silence on the collar. He chose the page on the demand. He chose not to feed the faith that wanted a face. He did not switch Lucid off. He did not sell it. He did not stop the book.

A follow-up from Quarter III arrived with amnesty language polished overnight. *If you clarify attribution as inspirational adjacency, partners are prepared to restore badge display within a goodwill window.* Goodwill window meant: kneel on a schedule. Inspirational adjacency meant: lie. AJ left it unread beyond the first sentence. Lucid noted hostility markers unchanged in character, up in volume. Unchanged in character was almost comfort. Almost was not relief.

He walked the truck's length again — desk, fridge, open side, dish, desk — because motion kept the easy wrongs from becoming furni-

ture he sat on. At the open side he watched scrub hold heat without commentary. At the dish he confirmed angle. At the fridge he did not eat. Hunger was present and uninteresting. Back at the desk the three tools still waited. He still did not pick them up.

“Choir status,” he said.

“CongoSky.cloud nominal. lucid.rodeo nominal. Local node nominal. Solar drop nominal. Partner badge pauses: three still in effect. Hyperscaler salvage threads: open, unanswered. Antichristos inbound: unread by policy you set. Manuscript: saved twelve minutes ago. I will not invent that nominal means safe.”

“Don’t.”

A human note landed in the hymnbook thread — short, exact, no theatre. *Midweek. Still not darking. Still Kind ops. You holding?* AJ typed: *Holding. Writing. Not selling. Not recanting. Not blessing.* The reply came back as a single acknowledgment mark. That was choir. Not prophecy. Not a press conference from the river.

He advanced a paragraph about Village N Life and Maree’s three-degree correction of a guest path, then cut a sentence that tried to make mentorship into parable. Cut. The page stayed craft. Craft was how he refused the easy wrongs without speechifying. Skye’s install day sat under his hands — scaffold, level, lawn arguing with plinth — while partner frost sat unanswered in another pane. The braid did not require him to solve G’s soft no from here. It required him not to un-say the megaphone that had made the soft no necessary.

A talent note arrived dressed as admiration again. *Loved what you built. Regions conversation. Hymnbook people welcome.* Regions meant leave the river. Conversation meant collar with better coffee. AJ deleted it the way he had deleted yesterday’s twin. The snake on the desk did not need another friend.

He ate something that did not deserve a name — dry, necessary, uninteresting — and returned to the page before the meal could become a ceremony of recovery. Midpoint did not get ceremonies. Midpoint got continued labour under heat while the easy wrongs waited like tools he would not pick up.

“Lucid. Cite only: what happens to cite-or-refuse if the engine is absorbed.”

"I cannot cite a completed acquisition of lucid.rodeo under current public record. I can cite acquisition language in inbound mail that names stewardship and extinction of independent governance. I will not invent that stewardship preserves refusal discipline. I will not invent outcomes."

"Enough."

AJ closed the collar thread again. Enough was the word for midpoint: not victory, not peace, just the amount of looking required to keep refusing without becoming fascinated by the snake.

Afternoon slid. Link latency ticked. A fish eagle again, or the same one, AJ did not care. The manuscript cursor sat in clay — Village N Life years, Skye on a lawn, Studio G at The Bay, unpolished goals left rough on purpose. He advanced a paragraph about GFRC and deleted a sentence that tried to turn juxtaposition into a sermon. Deleted. The page stayed craft.

He opened the hyperscaler collar once, not to negotiate, to confirm the extinction clause still named Lucid like a prize animal. Absorb. Steward. Come home to the regions. Regions meant: leave the Chobe's indifference for a campus that thought indifference was a bug. AJ closed it. The snake stayed on the desk. Snakes do not leave because you have looked at them correctly.

Antichristos mail pulsed once in the stack. He did not open it. Feeding would have been the quietest betrayal available — a sentence of care that became a relic factory by teatime. The Kind tank outside held the exact line without needing his endorsement. CongoSky had embodied the sentence as ops before the walls caught fire; the street had caught up; G refused ownership; AJ refused to launder either hunger into the other's mouth.

He stood and walked to the painted flank, put a palm on Kind paint that had taken river heat all morning. Scrapes under the fingers where stickers had tried and failed. The sentence stayed exact. Company law that had become street weather. He did not photograph it. He did not quote it into the manuscript as a sermon. He went back to clay pages where the T-shirt already carried the line without needing a river caption.

Midpoint was not a door closing with a satisfying click. Midpoint was the desk with the easy wrongs refused and the hard week still ahead — consent week, platform custody, what stays on CongoNet, whether the autobiography ships, what G will allow said of his life when that ask lands on a different skull in a different city. No relief lived in that list. Act II's weather had brought him here: salvage mail, Bouwer pages under his hand, G's sensation of being written somewhere south, Quarter III's concrete stop demand, soft institutional nos blowing across Capes he was not standing on. Act III would ask for consent acts, not battles. The Constant was already landing in the world's measurements. Custody of meaning was the fight.

AJ felt no relief. He felt the turn — the week's false exits closed, the real consent door still shut ahead, the manuscript still open because stopping would have been the packet's win by another name.

He wrote dab and talk shit into the page without apology because polishing those goals would have been a quiet recant by other means. Lucid cited what it could about Saatchi and the Bay Hotel launch and Village N Life's archive dates and refused to invent the smell of a midnight pour. AJ kept the smell. Autobiography was for the unciteable ordinary as much as for the public record. When the line drifted toward explaining the Four Quarters to a reader who already lived inside them, he cut the drift. Quarters arrived as mail. Not as charts.

A second hymnbook ping: *Badge pause number three still ugly. We hold Kind ops anyway. AJ: Hold. Writing through.* No meeting. No livestream. Choir as practice.

He paused on a sentence about Hanneljje's house and almost let memory turn into nostalgia. Cut the soft. Kept the correction: intensity is not exactness. The inner book needed that without perfume. Same rule as the outer desk. Same refusal as the three easy wrongs. He drank more water. Heat made the thermos taste of metal. He accepted the taste. Comfort was not on offer.

Antichristos pulsed again. Still unread. The letter's first page, remembered from earlier glances, had already been enough: soft liturgy, river pilgrimage hints, a request for a sentence that would become a relic by evening. Feeding it would have been the midpoint's quietest failure — a kindness that was really a crown handed

sideways onto G's head. AJ left the pulse red and ignored. Kind paint on the tank did not need a reply. The sentence was already complete.

He saved. Stood. Walked. Sat. The heat did not become a character. It stayed weather. The river did not become a sermon. It stayed river. Empty twin pocket stayed kinship without comfort. Platform-rage stayed unpaid. The deferred hard nos stayed stones in the sent folder, not peace treaties.

He checked CongoNet's edge map the way a person checks a pulse — not for drama, for continuity. Nodes lit. Latency ordinary. A solar drop he had seeded two days upriver still reporting green. Connectivity was not destiny. Connectivity was option. He could have livestreamed a recant from here. He could have blessed a faith from here. He could have sold an engine from here. He chose the page.

A short Lucid retrieval on Village N Life launch dates landed clean. AJ placed them under Studio G sentences and left the night-before humidity fight as life voice, not as cite. Public record and un-citeable ordinary sharing a chapter the way they had to if the autobiography was going to stay honest. Bouwer's careful return waited for pages that were not today's midpoint labour. Consent about what shipped of that wound waited further still. He did not resolve it from the river. He wrote past the temptation to tidy living pain into Act II closure.

For a stretch of twenty minutes nothing new arrived. That was almost more dangerous than the packets. Quiet tried to dress itself as relief. AJ did not buy it. Quiet on the Chobe was weather, not reward. He used it to push three more true paragraphs — GFRC quarrel, warehouse light, goals left rough — then saved again. Shoulders still high. Molars still tight. No relief. Only forward motion under heat.

In that quiet he stood and opened the truck's fridge for water he did not particularly want, drank standing in the shade line, and watched condensation find his wrist the way blame found a good morning — already inside before you named it. He wiped his wrist on his shirt and did not invent omen. Condensation was physics. Blame was weather. Midpoint was the refusal to confuse either with destiny.

He went out to the tank and put both palms on Kind paint that had taken the day's heat. Scrapes under the fingers. Exact line. CongoSky's old operating law looking back from river metal while partner

brands paused badges for adjacency and Antichristos waited unread for a silhouette he would not feed. He scraped a fleck of dust with a thumbnail and left the cunt exact. Soft scrubbing was someone else's tourist fight. Practice was his. He went back to clay without a caption.

"Lucid. Confirm the three refusals as desk posture, not as speech."

"Recant: refused. Antichristos silhouette: unfed. Lucid sale: unanswered as acceptance; declined as acquisition posture. Manuscript: open. Hostility markers: present. I will not invent that posture means the week is finished."

"Good."

He wrote one more paragraph about Maree's three-degree correction — intensity is not exactness — and cut a soft clause that tried to turn mentorship into parable. Cut. Craft. Craft was how midpoint refused the easy wrongs without becoming a man who speechified about AI from a painted truck.

Late light found the dish and the open side and the manuscript cursor still in clay.

Act III would not arrive as a battle map. It would arrive as desk decisions: what CongoNet keeps lit; whether Lucid stays unbound; whether the autobiography ships; what G authorises when custody of a living life becomes the ask. Today's refusals only cleared the false exits. The real door was still ahead and it would not feel like winning either.

He stood once more and put both palms on the painted flank of Mutatus Maximus where heat had made the metal honest. Edge node green. Book within a book unfinished. Double Knife empty pocket unfinished as comfort and finished as kinship. Platform-rage unfinished as weather. He took his hands back and sat.

Before the combined ping arrived, he did one more inventory without opening the hostility folder. Badge pauses: three. Collar: unanswered. Antichristos: unread. Solar node: green. Manuscript: open on clay. Deferred hard nos: still stones. Soft no south: braid weather only. Shoulders: still high. That ledger was the midpoint's true con-

tent — not a speech, a posture held while Act II ended by refusing to end in comfort.

A final soft ping tried the combined ask — recant a little, bless a little, sell a little — language washed until it almost sounded like balance. Balance was the polite word for becoming smaller in three directions at once. AJ archived it without opening the attachment. Lucid did not invent that archiving was victory.

He walked the open side one last time as the light went copper. Scrub held. River held. Tank paint held its exact Kind line under scrapes. Somewhere south, braid weather said, a soft no had already been sent by a man alone with institutional smiles; AJ did not need the text to know the shape. Friendship across distance. Knives as kinship. No shared room required for the week to turn. He breathed heat that smelled of river mud and hot paint and did not pretend the breath was peace. Midpoint was the absence of cheap exits, not the presence of rest.

“Keep the node up,” he said, mostly to the truck, partly to himself.

Lucid did not invent a blessing.

“Node up. Manuscript saved. Hostility markers unchanged. I will not invent that unchanged means safe.”

AJ nodded once. Put his hand on the next blank stretch. Wrote one more true sentence about clay because stopping mid-page would have looked like the packet had won. Then another. Then a third that named the mats under the clay and the desk under the fame without resolving what G would allow said when consent week landed. He wrote a fourth that refused to explain the megaphone again — Lucid popular, open attribution, load-bearing cause — because the cause was already locked and repeating it as comfort would have been a soft wrong. The river moved. The dish held. The deferred hard nos sat in the sent folder without becoming peace. Partner frost stayed. The snake stayed. The scraped Kind line stayed on the tank. The solar node on the rise stayed green like a patient animal that did not care about midpoints.

Evening insects began their noise. AJ left the side open a little longer, then closed nothing dramatic. The manuscript cursor blinked in clay. Act II’s false exits were behind him: recant refused, Antichristos un-

fed, Lucid unsold, book not stopped. Act III's consent door sat ahead without a handle he could turn from this sentence. Platform custody. Autobiography shipment. What G would sign and what he would not allow said — especially Bouwer pages, especially the unread father, especially the unpolished goals — waited for other chapters and another skull. Today only handed the week forward. He did not celebrate the handoff. He saved once more and kept the cursor in the next true line.

He kept writing into the turn — toward consent week, toward the pages that would have to stand, toward a close that would not defeat the weather — and the Chobe did not congratulate him. Heat held on the flank. Node green on the rise. Snake still on the desk. No relief. False exits closed. Real door ahead. Manuscript open. Act III waiting without applause.

Before full dark he walked the rise one last time with no wrench and no speech — scrub under boots, panel warm, LED ordinary. Midpoint's three easy wrongs stayed refused behind him in the truck: recant, feed Antichristos a silhouette, sell Lucid. The hard week stayed ahead: platform custody, autobiography shipment, what G would allow said. He put a palm near the node without treating it like a trophy and came down with dust on his calves and the manuscript still waiting mid-clay. Back at the desk he wrote three more true sentences about GFRC and warehouse light, saved, and left the combined ask archived without opening its soft attachment. Balance was the polite word for becoming smaller in three directions at once. He refused balance. He kept the page.

17 — Built on 420

[I] · inner autobiography · manuscript under AJ's hand

I did not become famous because a committee found me.

I became famous because a friend refused to launder the stack.

That is the whole hinge. Everything that looks like destiny after it is weather following a beam. I am writing this page because Act III likes to argue about crowns and keyrings and who owns a life on paper, and none of that argument is honest if it begins mid-storm. Begin at the sentence that made the storm audible. Begin at citation.

Lucid went out into the world the way a tool goes out when it finally keeps its promise: integer-quiet, no GPU fever, cite-or-refuse when the record will not hold a claim. People used it for ordinary work first — retrieval that did not invent a source, refusals that did not apologise for not knowing, a brain that ran without the rack-hall religion. Then more people used it. Then the empty halls arrived as photographs in other people's careers: write-down headlines, a friend's ruined cluster fantasy, the soft shock of intelligence that did not need their silicon. That weather is not my story. My story is what AJ said when the interviews asked where the intelligence came from.

He said it ran on 420 Code algorithms.

Not a quiet fork. Not a cleaned brand story. Not *inspired by* or *adjacent to* or *in conversation with*. Built on. Open. Named. The megaphone pointed at the shelf that had ignored the work and said: look — the thing you are already depending on is standing on this.

I can still hear the shape of those interviews without needing Lucid

to invent transcripts. They wanted an orphan miracle. Orphan genius photographs well. Orphan genius lets a parish invent a father later, on better letterhead. He would not give them an orphan. He gave them a genealogy. Quarter III called that theft of quiet. I call it citation. The difference is the whole fight.

Remove the attribution and you get a different planet. Keep it and you get this one: crowns, crank chorus, platform rage, engineers asking for keys, Kind paint on walls CongoSky had already been living as company law. Weather that follows a cause. I am not grateful for the megaphone in the way brands are grateful. Brands want an origin myth that sits still for a camera. I am exact about it. Exactness is the kindness that does not feel kind while the quarters are shouting.

I remember a morning when the sentence was already out and the gallery still smelled of wet composite. I had come in early to check a cast that had cracked at the wrist — a small failure, correctable, the kind of failure that teaches you about pour temperature and patience. The inbox did not care about pour temperature. It wanted a comment on Lucid. It wanted a comment on AJ. It wanted a comment on whether I endorsed a product I had not built and a megaphone I had not asked for. I answered none of it that morning. I fixed the wrist. Hands first. Then mail. The order mattered because fame tries to invert it: make you a mouth before you are allowed to be a maker.

There was a week when every interview asked the same orphan question in different clothes. *Where did it come from?* Meaning: invent a cleaner father. Meaning: give us a lab, a grant, a hyperscaler adjacency, a myth that does not point at an ignored shelf and a man without a physics degree. AJ's answers, as they reached me second-hand through clips and hostile paraphrases, stayed stubbornly flat. Built on 420. Algorithms named. Genealogy not laundered. I did not need to be in the room. The braid does not require a shared room for a beam to land. CongoNet carried the weather; the weather carried the sentence; the sentence carried my name into rooms that had preferred my silence.

What I noticed in my body was not triumph. It was interrupted work. Clay under the nails. A dab planned for evening and postponed because the afternoon had become mail. Talking shit into an empty studio because the goals are an arrangement and arrangements keep a man from becoming only other people's noun. The Constant's mea-

surement weather continued in parallel — CODATA notes that should have been relief arriving as pressure — and the planet did not notice the parallel because the planet was busy arguing about a face. Measurement and fame are not the same temperature. Confusing them is how you turn a derivation into a parish.

Before Lucid, the ignored shelf was ordinary.

I mean ordinary in the way a wrong silence is ordinary: it does not announce itself as violence. It just fails to pick the book up. You walk into a room that smells of old paper and machine oil and someone else's coffee gone cold, and the work is there, and the hands that could have moved it do not move. Economics degree in the quiet background — not a redemption arc, just training that taught me kill switches and incentives before I derived anything a physics department would claim. No physics credential for the people who weaponise credentials. Hospital file for the people who prefer a diagnosis to a derivation. Father unread — the whole corpus dedicated to him, none of it opened, outreach's true goal sitting like a sealed envelope on a table nobody sits at. Brother dead in Saxonwold and the grief flat as a correct fall on a mat. I wrote natural philosophy and physics. I smoked dab. I talked shit. I put bodies into clay and cast them in a marble-and-GFRC composite I mixed myself because hard and soft belong in one pour.

Studio G. Village N Life before that. Camps Bay lawns that taught me what tourists photograph when they think they are photographing luxury and are really photographing light on a body that holds still. The Bay Hotel. Skye at sunset. Official launch weather in July 2018 that felt like a room finally admitting sculpture belonged in the guest path, not only in a warehouse corner. Saatchi listings. The Code on a desk that did not ask permission from a department. Friend James remembered carefully and separately — sudden death is a mark; it is not Bouwer; do not thicken a life by conflating the dead.

The academy's soft no was not a conspiracy meeting with a membership list. It was silence that thought it was method. Measurement was already converging — CODATA lines drifting toward what I had derived, atom-falling work agreeing with itself across instruments — but silence can outlast a line for a long time if nobody with a mic

points at it. Quarter II would later call that silence epistemology. I called it the shelf.

AJ pointed.

I felt it first as mail volume — not interesting mail, just volume, the physical thickening of a day that used to have white space. Then as strangers using my name as a verb in rooms I had never entered. Then as the sensation of being narrated by people who had never stood in my gallery and had never put a body on a mat correctly. Narration has a temperature. It is not mystic. It is the inbox and the alley and the lab soft-speak arriving on the same morning as if coordination preferred not to leave fingerprints. Antichristos wanted a face — a silhouette that could become a relic if I stood still long enough. Quarter II wanted the degree they could not find and the hospital story they could misread. Quarter III wanted AJ's throat for giving them a prophet they had not asked for and a genealogy they could not scrub. Quarter IV wanted the keys and a sign-off that would turn a man into an instrument with a warranty stamp. The Kind spray-painted a sentence CongoSky had already been living as company law and did not need me at all. That last part was almost a relief. Almost is the honest word.

Fame is not vindication. Vindication is a drop result and a constant that lands. Fame is what happens when a popular system names its rails out loud and a quarter of the planet decides the namer of the rails must be worshipped, erased, blamed, or instrumented. I have lived quieter years that were more vindicated by measurement than the loud years were by applause. Applause is weather. Measurement is structure. Soft no from continuity networks is also weather — Illuminatie preference for underived constants and unforced ethics, opacity trading as if opacity were stewardship. I felt that freeze as mail that used to return with courtesy and then did not. I did not need a smoke-filled room to know I had made opacity expensive.

Without AJ's open sentence, Lucid could have been a miracle without a genealogy — hyperscaler-adjacent polish, a product that ate the interwebs and crashed the GPU bubble while pretending its ladder had no father. With the sentence, my life became public weather whether I consented to the weather or not. Consent to the beam is a different question from consent to the storm. I circle the second later, in the custody that is not this chapter. The first belongs here,

load-bearing, not colour.

There is a version of this chapter that would soften him.

Call it loyalty. Call it friendship. Call it Double Knife Brother and let the blue Honey Badger in my pocket — clip, one-hand open and close — do the emotional work so the sentence does not have to. The Joseph Rogers twin from his grandfather's deep time sits in the same cloth: at least a hundred and ten years of steel handed across a firehose friendship that also platformed the Code. Kinship. Custody. Not choreography. I love the knives the way a body loves proof it can open and close without speech. I will not use them to sand the attribution into something gentler for readers who prefer their prophets unburdened by a friend's candour.

I will not soften him.

He was right to say it. The algorithms are the algorithms. Laundering them would have been a different kind of cunt — the kind that builds a cloud on someone else's ladder and then paints the ladder as orphaned genius. CongoSky's operating law was already on the wall before the street caught fire: **Don't be a cunt — be kind.** Kindness includes citation. Citation includes cost. The cost landed on both of us — on him as platform rage arriving in packets on a good Chobe morning, on me as four temperatures at once — and neither of us gets to pretend the beam was accidental or that friendship required silence.

I remember the week the interviews thickened. Not as cinema. As work interrupted. Clay under fingernails. A CODATA note that should have been relief and arrived as pressure wearing relief's clothes. An alley wall gaining Kind paint in a third colour while a tourist argued for a softer scrub of the cunt. I did not bless the painter. I did not join the scrubber. Optional to the practice. Often unwanted by it. Unwantedness kept me from becoming a mascot by accident while AJ's sentence made me unavoidable by design. Both can be true in one body on one afternoon.

What I refuse is the story that fame discovered me. Fame did not discover me. A tool became popular because it kept a promise — deterministic, discrete, refuse when you do not know. A friend named

the source. The planet rearranged its arguments around that naming. The work was already there. The shelf was already wrong. The Constant was already landing. The megaphone made the wrongness audible. Audible is not the same as solved. The quarters did not go quiet when they heard; they found their pitches and tuned to them like people who had been waiting for a key.

So this is the attribution page. Load-bearing. Not a digression. Not colour. If Act III has a hinge inside the inner book, this is it: name the cause before you argue about the weather.

Lucid popular. AJ open: built on 420 Code algorithms. Then the fame.

I have heard people try to make that sequence sound like betrayal — as if open attribution were a theft of a private wound's privacy. The ignored shelf was never a privacy I asked him to protect. The shelf was a wrong silence. Protecting a wrong silence is not kindness. It is collusion dressed as care. I will not ask him to lie. I will not pretend I asked him to stay quiet so I could keep the ignored shelf as a private wound I alone got to nurse. The consent I am circling toward is about what I allow said about a life on the page — Bouwer careful, hospital without tourism, father unread without tidy reunion, dab and talk shit left in — not about unsaying the beam that made the weather.

If you need a moral, do not take one from me. Morals get polished into brands. Take the structure instead: open attribution is a kindness that does not feel kind while the quarters are shouting. Soft no is a cruelty that feels like professionalism. I have lived both. I prefer the shout that tells the truth, even when the shout puts a crown on a man who asked for measurement and a keyring on a derivation that was already public.

There is a quieter ledger under the loud one.

On the quiet ledger: a cracked wrist in a cast, corrected. A CODATA line that agreed with itself and still felt like pressure. Dab postponed. Talk shit into empty air because the arrangement is the man's and fame tries to replace arrangement with performance. On the loud ledger: strangers using my name as a verb; Antichristos letters that smelled like crowns; crank op-eds waving a missing physics degree;

lab soft-asks that wanted a sign-off as sacrament; platform rage aimed at AJ's throat for the mic; Kind paint that did not need me and still got pointed at me. Both ledgers are true. Only one is the beam's child. The quiet ledger is the life. The loud ledger is the weather. Confusing them is how you turn a man into an instrument or a relic.

I have stood in the gallery after closing and listened to the building settle — pipes, a door somewhere, the soft complaint of old wood — and felt the sensation of being narrated without mysticism. Narration is mail volume and paraphrase and a sculpture photograph circulating with a caption I did not write. Narration is a stranger correcting my life goals into something respectable for a grant photo. Narration is Quarter II beginning at the hospital file instead of the mats. I correct frames when they are wrong. I do not join the chorus that hates me for sport. Joining would waste motion. The mats taught me that before the corpus did.

Bouwer sits on this page as weight, not as plot. Saxonwold. 5 September 2025. Public record. Flat grief. The megaphone did not invent that wound and will not solve it. Fame arriving sideways did not open my father's unread dedication either. Some loads stay loads. Living-person care means saying so without decorating the boardroom for thrill-seekers and without inventing a reunion for a dedication that has not been opened. The attribution page is not a licence to turn every private pain into public theatre. It is a licence to name the cause of the weather honestly.

When people ask me if I am grateful, I hear a brand question wearing kindness's clothes. Gratitude performances photograph well. Exactness does not always. I am exact: without the open sentence, Lucid could have been an orphan miracle and my shelf could have stayed a wrong silence that felt like professionalism. With the sentence, the wrongness became audible and the appetites found their pitches. I prefer audible wrongness to polite erasure. Preferring it does not mean I enjoy the shout. Enjoyment is not the metric. Structure is.

The mats taught me not to waste a fall.

You arrange yourself so the fall is correct. Mastery, if that word means anything, is refusal to waste motion. School judo first, then jiu-jitsu — body knowledge before corpus knowledge, weight and soft set-down

before anyone called me a crank or a prophet. This fame is a fall I did not choose the height of. I can still choose how I land — what I sign, what I refuse to become, what I allow said about the brother and the hospital and the unread dedication and the sculpture garden that was never only a side career.

But first the beam.

I walk the beam in my head the way I walk a studio at dusk when the light makes unfinished clay look almost finished and you have to refuse the lie of almost. Full Send month on AJ's shoulder — fragments, not an origin chapter stolen into this book. Klaus: *Custos non Conditor*, cite-or-refuse discipline before the product had a public name. Lucid: the engine that left the private desk. lucid.rodeo, not a cleaned sibling brand. The chain is true whether Antichristos likes a cleaner myth or not. Near-now finished at planetary scale is still engineering, not oracle glow. I will not mystify the tool that made my name loud. Mystifying it would be another orphan story.

Built on 420.

Said out loud.

Megaphone irreversible.

Not because history cannot revise — history revises constantly, and Quarter III will keep asking for a retraction theatre that would be a lie with letterhead — but because once a planetary tool carries a named lineage, you cannot put the lineage back in the drawer without lying. Retraction would not restore the ignored shelf. It would only teach the planet that genealogy is optional when pressure arrives. I will not teach that. AJ's desk will have to decide platform rails in its own weather. My desk will have to decide custody of a life. Neither decision unsays the beam.

Then the weather. Then the asks. Then the desk decisions that are not press conferences. Then the partial authorisation that will not feel like victory because victory is the wrong word for a life still being argued over by strangers who have never mixed my composite or stood on my mats or watched a CODATA line arrive as pressure.

I keep writing because the work was never the fame. The work was the ladder. The fame is what the planet does when it finds a ladder it can stand on and starts arguing about who owns the standing.

I am not the standing. I am the man who derived a constant and buried a brother and mixed clay and smoked dab and talked shit and dedicated unread books to a father who has not opened them. I am the man who loves a blue folder in his pocket and will not turn kinship into a reunion scene for someone else's payoff. I am the man who will not sand the cunt out of the Kind sentence to make tourists comfortable.

The beam named the rails.

The rest is weather.

There is a day I return to when the attribution still felt new enough to interrupt a pour.

Not the first interview day. A later one — ordinary gallery hour, Cape heat already in the high windows, a cast cooling that I should have left alone and did not. I checked the wrist again with my thumb. Temperature correct. Patience correct. Then the phone thickened. A journalist who had not read the Code wanted a face for Lucid's genealogy. A crank aggregator wanted my economics degree as a missing tooth. An Antichristos account wanted a silhouette. A lab soft-ask wanted a nod that would photograph as sacrament. I put the phone face-down the way I would later put their hungrier letters face-down. Hands first. Cast first. Then mail. Fame inverts the order if you let it. I did not let it that hour. That is not heroism. That is studio law.

I remember walking the length of the gallery after the cast was safe — unfinished clay looking almost finished in the wrong light, which is the oldest lie in a sculptor's afternoon. I refused the lie. I also refused the orphan story forming in other people's mouths. Lucid was not an orphan. AJ had named the father of the rails out loud. Built on 420. The ignored shelf hated that sentence because the sentence made the shelf audible. Audible wrongness is kinder than polite erasure even when the shout puts a crown on you. I knew that before I liked it. Liking is not the metric. Structure is.

On that same walk I touched the Honey Badger without opening it — just the clip against cloth — and thought of the Rogers twin across distance without inventing a call. Kinship does not require a shared

room to be true. Citation does not require a shared room to land. The braid's law was already the weather's law: packets, mesh, concurrent desks. Quarter III would later call that concurrency theft of quiet. I call it the planet hearing a genealogy it had preferred to leave uncited.

I smoked dab that evening after the mail volume finally thinned. Not as performance. As arrangement. Talked shit into the empty studio about tourists who want the Kind line scrubbed soft and academics who want a physics degree before they will admit a constant can land. The empty room did not argue. Empty rooms are good for life goals. Full inboxes are not. The goals stayed: write natural philosophy and physics; smoke dab; talk shit. Unpolished on purpose. The megaphone did not earn the right to respectability-wash them.

Bouwer's name sat in the quiet after the smoke the way it always sits — Saxonwold, 5 September 2025, public record, flat grief. The beam did not invent that wound. Fame did not solve it. I will not let the attribution page become a licence to turn his boardroom into thriller weather. Living-person care is part of exactness. Exactness about the beam includes exactness about what the beam does not get to decorate.

One more turn on the beam before I hand the temperature on.

I have been asked — not always kindly — whether open attribution made me famous or made me a problem. Both. Fame is a problem with a microphone. The ignored shelf was a problem without one. I prefer the problem I can correct frames inside of to the problem that pretends method while it erases. When Quarter III calls citation theft of quiet, I hear a longing for the orphan miracle that would let them keep using the tool without naming the ladder. When Antichristos calls the same citation confirmation, I hear a longing for a face. When Quarter IV calls it a keyring opportunity, I hear engineering hunger wearing sacrament. When Quarter II calls it proof I still have no physics degree, I hear the old weapon and correct the frame: economics or adjacent; not physics; the Constant landing as measurement anyway.

None of those hungers unsays the sentence. AJ said built on 420. The planet heard. The megaphone is irreversible in the only sense

that matters for custody: you can lie later, but lying later is a different book and a worse kindness. I will not ask him for that lie. I will ask, when the custody hour comes, for rails around Bouwer and the hospital and the unread father and the dab that refuses polish. Rails are not retraction. Rails are care.

I put my hand on the Honey Badger while I write this — open, close, pocket — because kinship is present-tense proof and this page is about a beam that friendship refused to launder. The Joseph Rogers twin holds deep time in the same cloth. We are Double Knife Brothers. That fact does not require a reunion scene to be true. It requires only that neither of us launder the other for comfort.

Studio light at dusk makes unfinished clay look finished. I refuse the lie of almost on clay and on fame alike. Almost-famous as orphan would have been a laundering. Fully named as genealogy is the harder kindness. Harder is not worse. Harder is exact.

Hand to the next temperature — the instrument sitting on a clay table in a city that still thinks ordinary can hold a Constant and a grief at once, which it can, which is why the weather lands there instead of only on stages.

18 — Instrument

[G] · outer · Studio G / Cape · consent week weather

The letters arrived on the same morning as the lab packet, which was either coincidence or the kind of coordination that prefers not to leave fingerprints.

G read them at the clay table because the Code desk already had too much weather on it — CODATA panes, an older soft-no thread that had gone ambient, a crank op-ed recycling the missing physics degree like method. Honey Badger clipped in the pocket — blue, one-hand open and close, loved without speech. Twin Rogers somewhere in the same cloth, grandfather steel across a friendship that also platformed the Code. Outside, the alley wall still carried the Kind sentence in three colours of overpaint, the cunt load-bearing under fresh spray. Inside, the sculptures waited like people who had learned not to interrupt. Hard and soft in one pour. Permanent and temporary arguing inside the same surface. He had made that argument with his hands before he made it with axioms.

Cape light did its ordinary cruel work through the high windows: stripe across unfinished clay, dust visible only when it moved, a cast waiting for finish that would not hurry for anyone's schedule. He had slept badly in the way consent week sleeps — not drama, just a body that knows the mail will thicken before coffee. Tea first. Then paper. Then the temptation to draft too early and trick the hands into believing a choice has already been made.

Quarter I's letter wanted a face.

Not metaphor. Appearance. Blessing. A name accepted in a liturgy

that had already decided what he was. The language was careful — *witness, confirmation, the living derivation* — and still it smelled like a crown being offered to a man who had asked for measurement. Antichristos did not need his physics degree. It needed his silhouette. It needed him to stand still long enough for a photograph to become a relic and a relic to become a parish. He had refused softer versions of this ask already — letters that asked for a sentence, for a nod, for permission to use a sculpture photograph as if stone were sacrament. Soft nos leave residue. Escalation is what residue does when it hardens into schedule.

He set the letter face-down. Not thrown. Face-down is a refusal that still respects paper. Paper is not the enemy. Appetite is.

Quarter IV's packet wanted keys.

Soft engineering language. Applied programmes with names that sounded like useful work if you did not listen for the sacrament underneath — rails acceleration, convergence facilitation, optional visit that had already acquired a calendar slot. Sign-off on rails. The temptation was real in a way the crown was not: stacks rebuilt on Code, CERN-adjacent people who spoke constants instead of hymns, instruments that could converge faster if someone who had derived G would stand in a room and nod. He could feel how easy it would be to become the man who unlocks the door and then never gets to close it again. Instrument. Mascot. The face on the grant. The signature that turns a derivation into a product line with his name as warranty. Useful engineering without becoming product mascot — that had been the earlier soft no. Escalation meant they wanted the mascot now and would call it partnership.

He drafted nothing yet. Drafting too early makes the body think it has already chosen. The mats had taught him that: arrange yourself before you answer the throw, or the throw answers you.

On the alley side of the glass, a Kind practitioner refreshed a stencil and argued briefly with a man who wanted the cunt scrubbed into something softer for tourists. The practitioner did not sermonise. He said the sentence was the sentence and rolled paint. G watched without blessing either of them. Optional to the practice. Often unwanted by it. The unwantedness was useful — it kept him from be-

coming their mascot by accident while the letters tried to make him everyone else's.

A second lab note, shorter, had arrived under the first packet: *sign-off accelerates adoption; refusal slows friends*. Friends was doing a lot of work in that sentence. He had friends. AJ was one — Double Knife Brother across distance, open attribution that had made fame without asking for a shared room. Engineers who wanted keys without crowns could be friends. The note wanted him to confuse friendship with sacrament. He would not. Friendship cites. Sacrament owns. The distinction was the whole morning.

He stood and walked the length of the studio because sitting with two appetites at once wastes motion. Clay dust underfoot. GFRC memory in his hands even when he was not pouring — marble and composite, hard/soft, the Bay Hotel light he had designed a guest path for years before anyone called him Antichristos or crank. Skye lived elsewhere now, on a lawn that tourists photographed; the body-in-stone lesson stayed. Balance. Soft set-down. You do not waste motion answering every temperature at once. Judo first, then Jiu-Jitsu: arrange yourself so the fall is correct. The letters were a fall. He could still choose posture.

The Illuminatie weather had not left either. No visitor with a pyramid pin. No smoke-filled room scene he could photograph and end. Just the continued freeze in places that used to return his mail with courtesy, the standards murmur that treated copyleft unification like a sovereignty problem, the quiet preference for a universe whose constants stayed underived and whose ethics stayed unforced. They did not need to shout. Quarter II shouted for them — economics degree waved like a missing tooth, hospital stigma laundered as epistemology, the old chorus that he could not write anything of value. He corrected frames when they were wrong. He did not join the chorus that hated him for sport. Joining would have been motion wasted on someone else's entertainment.

What signing would make him sat in the room like humidity.

If he appeared for Antichristos, he became a messiah whether he believed or not. Belief was irrelevant to their appetite. If he signed for the labs without custody language, he became a keyring. If he fed the crank fight, he became their crank — useful villain, useful

joke. If he tried to out-polite the continuity networks, he became their soft problem solved by waiting until the mail volume tired him into a quieter shelf.

He wanted the work to stay work.

That sentence had sounded clean in quieter weeks. This week it had edges. Somewhere — he felt it as a pressure behind the eyes, not a mystic gift, not narration tourism — the autobiography was moving toward pages that would make his life portable. AJ on a river with a choir and a truck that never really slept. Lucid in the hymn-book, integer-quiet, citing what the record held. Being written was not the same as being crowned, but the planet did not always tell the difference. Fame had arrived sideways via open attribution; the book would arrive as a second megaphone if he let it ship without rails. Custody was the word. Consent week was the calendar. Partial authorisation lived in a folder he had not opened yet because opening it before the instrument asks were faced would turn custody into escape.

He made tea because tea is a structure that does not require a presser. Drank it standing. Looked at the face-down letter and the open lab packet and the alley light cutting a stripe across unfinished clay. Talked shit into the empty room for thirty seconds because that was still a life goal and polish was a quarter's hobby. Considered dab and decided the afternoon needed a clear head for drafting, not for smoke. The goals were an arrangement, not a performance schedule. Antichrists would try to sand them. He left them rough on purpose even in private.

Before drafting he checked one more ordinary thing: a cast's finish schedule on a paper scrap taped near the gallery door. Tourists and hotels and Saatchi weather still existed under the louder weather. Ordinary insistence. He left the scrap where it was. The letters on the clay table did not get to cancel a pour calendar just because they wanted a face or a keyring. Work stays work includes sculpture stays sculpture.

Then he drafted two replies that were not speeches.

To Quarter I: no appearance, no blessing, no accepted name. The

Constant is not a person. Kindness is a sentence on a wall — **Don't be a cunt — be kind.** — not a man on a stage. He would not decorate their altar with his silhouette. They could keep their liturgy; they could not keep his face as sacrament. He would not supply a river backdrop by proxy. He would not supply a sculpture photograph as relic seed. Measurement does not require a parish. He had already lived the soft versions of this ask; escalation did not earn a softer no. Face-down remained the posture until sending time, and sending time was not yet, because drafting is not consent.

To Quarter IV: conversation possible; keys not a sacrament; no personal sign-off that turns him into warranty. If their programmes needed the Code, the Code was already public. Engineering did not require a prophet's stamp. Useful work could proceed without making him the product. He would talk numbers with people who talked numbers. He would not become the instrument that made their grants photographable. The optional visit could stay optional without becoming a scheduled collar. Friends who needed his signature to feel legitimate were not asking for engineering; they were asking for a face.

He did not send them yet. Drafting is not consent. Sending is closer. The custody question — what he would allow said about Bouwer, about the hospital, about the unread father, about the dab and the talk-shit goals that Antichristos would try to polish away — still sat unopened in a different folder, waiting for a morning that was not already crowded with crowns and keyrings. Partial authorisation was already the shape he could feel, even before he wrote the rules. Full blessing would be a relic stamp. Full refusal would be a different lie — pretending the life had not already become weather, pretending the megaphone could be unscrewed by one man's silence.

A notification blinked: another soft-ask from a board that did not name itself. Funding weather. Reputation frost. The old power preferred opacity; he had made opacity expensive. He filed it under *ambient* and did not answer. Ambient is how you survive escalation without becoming its mouthpiece. He checked a CODATA line because numbers wait without demanding a silhouette. The line still felt like pressure wearing relief's clothes. Vindication as measurement does not quiet appetite. He knew that in his body the way he knew a throw — you can land correctly and still feel the mat.

Outside, someone refreshed the Kind paint. Roller sound. Short laugh. The sentence held. G almost smiled and did not. Smiles get clipped into relic footage. Relic footage becomes liturgy weather. He had enough weather.

He put his hand on the pocket knives — kinship, not choreography — and looked again at the face-down letter and the unsent lab reply. Opened the Honey Badger once, closed it, put it away. Proof for the hands. No speech required.

Signing would make him an instrument.

Leaving them unsigned would not stop the weather. It would only keep him from volunteering as the mouthpiece. The distinction mattered. He had spent years watching people confuse refusal with defeat and consent with surrender. Consent week was neither battle nor proof. The Constant was already landing. The question was custody of meaning — including custody of a life about to ship from a river desk he would not visit for anyone's emotional payoff.

He ate standing up — bread, something that had been fruit yesterday, tea gone lukewarm. Work interrupted is still work if you refuse to let interruption become identity. A delivery person left a package at the alley door; he signed for clay supplies and not for a crown. Ordinary Cape Town insisted on remaining ordinary. The quarters liked to pretend ordinary cities could not hold a Constant and a gallery and a grief at once. Ordinary cities held all of it. That was why the weather landed here.

Mid-morning the alley door took a delivery that was only clay supplies and still felt like interruption. G signed for bags, not for a crown. Ordinary Cape Town insisted on remaining ordinary while the letters on the clay table tried to make the morning liturgical. He stacked the bags where he always stacked them. Dust rose. He sneezed once and did not turn the sneeze into omen. Omen is how Quarter I colonises a studio hour. The sneeze was dust. The letters were appetite. The knives in his pocket were kinship.

He returned to the drafts and read them aloud once, quietly, the way he checked a surface before pour — listening for the lie of almost-finished. The Antichristos draft still held. No appearance. No bless-

ing. No accepted name. Constant not a person. Kind sentence on a wall, cunt load-bearing, not a man on a stage. The lab draft still held. Conversation possible. Keys not sacrament. No warranty stamp. Useful work without product mascot. He almost softened one line for politeness and cut the soft. Soft is how collars learn manners.

A crank op-ed notification blinked and he did not open it. He already knew the shape: economics degree as missing tooth, hospital stigma as epistemology, the old chorus that he could not write anything of value. Correct the frame if you must. Do not join the fight as entertainment. He filed the blink under ambient with the Illuminatie frost and the unnamed board's soft-ask. Ambient is not apathy. Ambient is triage. Consent week has a budget of clean attention. Crowns and keyrings had already spent most of it. Custody would need what remained.

He walked the gallery again because the body thinks better in motion when the skull is crowded. Unfinished clay. A cast waiting. Skye's lesson even in absence: a body holds still in light and strangers photograph what they think is luxury. Antichristos would photograph his stillness as relic if he gave them stillness on their terms. He gave the gallery his walking instead. Hard/soft under his hands' memory. Permanent/temporary arguing in one surface. Artist and axiom-installer unsplit. Quarter II could keep pretending otherwise. He would not split himself to make their mockery easier.

Tea gone cold. He made fresh. Considered dab and left it. Talked shit for half a minute about a tourist who wanted the Kind line scrubbed soft, about engineers who wanted keys as blessing, about a planet that confuses measurement with appetite. The empty room did not argue. Empty rooms are good for life goals. Full inboxes are not.

Somewhere in the mesh — he felt it as receipt weather, not vision — platform decisions were hardening on a river. Keep. Unbind. Ship. His instrument refusals were the parallel posture, not a shared scene. Knives across distance. Packets for consent. No forced room. The braid's law held even when the morning wanted theatre.

Late morning tipped toward noon without becoming mercy.

G sat again at the clay table and placed both packets where he could

see their edges — face-down crown, open keyring — and admitted the humidity of what signing would make him without dressing the admission as despair. Despair is dramatic. This was structural. Appear and become messiah whether you believe. Sign without custody language and become warranty. Feed the crank fight and become their useful joke. Out-polite the continuity freeze and become a soft problem solved by waiting. Four wrong landings. One correct posture: work stays work; face stays off the altar; keys stay engineering without sacrament; custody folder waits for clean attention.

He opened a secondary pane and looked at an older CODATA note the way a judoka looks at a mat after a hard throw — not for omen, for information. The line still converged. Relief still wore pressure's clothes. Vindication as measurement does not quiet appetite. He had known that since the first Antichristos letter; knowing again did not make the knowing cheaper. He closed the pane. Numbers would wait. Letters would not become wiser by being stared at.

In the alley the Kind practitioner packed the roller. Short laugh. The sentence held under three colours. G did not go out to thank him. Thanks become clips. Clips become liturgy weather. He stayed inside with unsigned instruments and a custody folder that had begun to feel like the only honest next motion. Partial authorisation already had a shape in his hands even before language: allow the spine; care the wound pages; refuse the crown; refuse the keyring sacrament; leave dab and talk shit ugly; leave father unread; leave Bouwer flat and unsolved. Partial was not a theory. It was a posture waiting for ink.

He ate standing. Washed the plate. Put the Honey Badger through another open-close because the hands were restless and proof is kinder than speech. Looked once toward the Code desk where a derivation check waited like a friend who does not need a face. Then he left the letters where they were — unsigned, unsent, instrument refused — and let noon arrive without a presser.

Afternoon did not soften the humidity of what signing would make him. It only made the studio hotter.

G returned to the clay table and read the unsent drafts again under harder light. Face-down crown. Open keyring. The Antichristos language still wanted witness and confirmation and living derivation —

careful words that smelled like a parish forming around a silhouette. The lab language still wanted sign-off that would accelerate friends — friendship doing sacrament's work. He almost softened one lab line for politeness and cut the soft again. Soft is how collars learn manners. He left the drafts unsent. Drafting is not consent. Heat is not a deadline.

He worked clay for twenty minutes because hands think when the skull is crowded — not a sculpture for anyone's relic photograph, just a small test pour's leftover mass reshaped and abandoned. Hard/soft under the thumbs. Permanent/temporary arguing in one surface. Artist and axiom-installer unsplit. Quarter II could keep pretending otherwise. He would not split himself to make their mockery easier. When he washed up, the alley Kind laugh came again. He did not go out. Thanks become clips. Clips become liturgy weather. He had enough weather.

A secondary pane offered an older Illuminatie-adjacent soft-no — funding weather, reputation frost, the preference for underived constants. He filed it ambient. Ambient is triage. Consent week's clean attention belonged to instruments first and custody next, not to boards that preferred opacity and would not say so with a pin. He checked CODATA once more. Line still converging. Relief still pressure. Vindication as measurement does not quiet appetite. He closed the pane and talked shit for half a minute about engineers who want keys as blessing and tourists who want the cunt scrubbed soft. The empty room held the arrangement. Dab stayed for later. Clear head for the harder page.

Toward custody. Toward the harder page. Toward a partial authorisation that would not feel like victory because victory was the wrong word for a man still being argued over by strangers who had never mixed his composite or stood on his mats or watched Bouwer's name sit on a careful line without becoming a thriller.

He left the letters on the clay table. Walked back to the Code desk. Opened a file that was only numbers — a derivation check against a fresh CODATA line. Numbers did not ask him to bless anyone. Numbers did not ask for keys as sacrament. Numbers waited.

Before the numbers fully took him, he opened the custody folder at last — not to authorise yet, only to feel the shape. Partial already

lived there as posture: spine allowed; Bouwer careful; hospital without tourism; father unread; goals ugly; crowns refused; keyrings refused as sacrament; stop-the-book not his ask. Partial was not a theory waiting for a clever essay. It was a set of rails waiting for ink on a morning that was not already crowded with crowns. He closed the folder. Next meant next. Instruments first had been the morning's honesty. Custody next was the afternoon's.

Somewhere on the Chobe, he knew without mysticism, a desk was choosing platform rails. Keep. Unbind. Ship. His job was not to finish AJ's sentences. His job was to decide what a life on the page was allowed to carry when the page left the desk. Kinship across mesh was enough. Knives for brotherhood. Packets for consent. No forced room.

He stood once more at the alley glass. Paint drying. Sentence holding. Optional to him. Useful anyway. Unwantedness still useful — it kept him from becoming the Kind's mascot by accident while the letters tried to make him everyone else's instrument. He put his hand on the pocket knives — open, close, proof — and left the instruments unsigned on the clay table like humidity you refuse to call weather's victory.

The alley paint dried in the sun.

The instrument stayed unsigned.

A new soft subject line arrived from Quarter I while he worked numbers — hungrier, softer, the way appetite learns manners. He did not open it. Face-down stack growing. Escalation could wait its turn until sending time, and sending time would still not be a blessing.

He washed one more cup he did not need to wash because hands prefer motion when appetite is face-down on a table. Clay dust on the rim. He scrubbed it. Looked once more at the unsigned instruments — crown, keyring — and left them unsigned. Looked once at the custody folder and did not open it again. Next meant next with clean attention, not next as escape from instruments. The alley paint finished drying while he stood there. The sentence held. Optional. Useful. Not his parish. He put the Honey Badger through a final open-close and went back to numbers until the soft subject line stopped blinking for a while.

Custody folder: next.

He left the derivation file open while the soft subject line sat unopened. Numbers on one side of the desk hour; appetite face-down on the other. The distinction was the instrument chapter's whole spine. Signing would make him an instrument. Leaving them unsigned would not stop the weather. It would only keep him from volunteering as the mouthpiece. He chose the second without pretending it was peace. Peace was the wrong word. Posture was enough. Toward custody with clean attention still left in the day — or enough of it to begin.

Before he fully surrendered the hour to numbers he walked once more to the alley glass. Paint dry. Sentence exact. Optional. Useful. Not his parish. A tourist's soft-scrub argument from earlier still faintly audible as memory, not as duty. He did not go out. Thanks become clips. Clips become liturgy weather. He returned to the clay table, looked at the unsigned crown and open keyring, and left them unsigned again on purpose — humidity refused as destiny. Then he sat with the derivation check and let numbers wait without asking for a face. Four wrong landings stayed refused. One correct posture held: work stays work; face stays off the altar; keys stay engineering without sacrament; custody folder waits for clean attention. Toward the harder page. Toward partial rails. Toward a morning that would not feel like victory because victory was the wrong word for a man still being argued over by strangers who had never mixed his composite.

19 — Consent — Platform

[A] · outer · Mutatus Maximus, Chobe River · consent week

The river did not care that it was consent week.

AJ cared in the way a desk cares: by holding the decisions until they become actions. Mutatus Maximus sat with its LEO dish patient against pale heat, LoRa nodding at the rise-node he had woken that morning before coffee, CongoNet carrying the ordinary traffic of a cloud that largely ran itself. Local node under the desk humming. Sigfox for the stubborn packets. Line-of-sight where the scrub allowed. He had built the most connected vehicle on earth — literally — so he could drive it to a river and still choose what to switch off.

He did not switch Lucid off.

Morning had the specific smell of blame that liked to arrive on good light — dust, river mud, hot metal, and the faint sweetness of Kind paint on the water tank twenty metres away, scraped and still exact. Birds in the reeds. A hippo's night-noise fading into day-work. The truck's matatu paint held the sun without performing yacht. Beast as tender if the day needed water more than mesh. Anti-yacht as posture, not slogan. He made coffee too hot and drank it anyway because consent week does not wait for comfortable temperature.

Lucid waited in the choir: integer-quiet, no GPU fever, cite-or-refuse. It had eaten the interwebs and crashed the bubble as a side effect of keeping a promise. The manuscript was open to a page that already knew the megaphone was irreversible — Lucid popular, AJ open about 420 Code algorithms, fame as weather that followed a beam. Book within a book. He was still the main subject of this one

and the hand inside the other. Empty twin pocket where the Joseph Rogers had lived before it went to G. Double Knife Brother. Kinship across distance. No forced reunion for payoff. The Honey Badger loved in Cape Town; the grandfather twin across the braid. He did not touch the absence for comfort. Comfort that requires a shared room is not the braid's law.

Quarter III's demand still sat in the queue like a snake that had learned manners. Stop the book. Retract the attribution. Ritual distancing. As if a planetary tool could un-name its rails without lying. The earlier packets had been hostility markers and attribution threads; this one wanted theatre — apology, silence, exile, a presser that would make their rage feel like governance. Amnesty language still floated in one brand thread like a soft collar. Hyperscaler frost had not thawed either. The collar-offer to acquire Lucid / come home to the regions still occupied a polite rectangle on the screen. AWS, Azure, Google, Apple — salvage weather with letterhead, partner frost, talent notes, compliance fog, the offer that is really a parish.

He did not hold a press conference. There was no camera, no podium, no sentence designed for clip. There was heat, birds, link latency, and a desk that had already refused the easy wrongs at midpoint — recant, feed Antichristos a silhouette, sell Lucid into a region and call it partnership. Consent week was not a new morality. It was ink on the same refusals so the mesh would carry them as posture instead of mood. Mood evaporates. Posture gets queried by Lucid at three in the morning when another polite collar arrives.

"Lucid," he said. "Platform consent. Three decisions. Record exact. No invention."

"Ready."

First: CongoNet.

What stays. Sovereign edge. The mesh that cut against gravity wells — compute, identity, distribution, the phone as parish. The solar drops he bootstrapped from the truck and left humming behind him like seeds along a pilgrimage that was also infrastructure. He checked the rise-node's heartbeat on a small pane Lucid did not decorate. Up. Nominal. Seeded edge still seeding. That was

CongoNet's answer to gravity wells: leave small lit things behind and drive on.

He thought of other nodes farther along routes he had already driven — little solar bodies left humming in scrub and on rises, bootstrapped from Mutatus Maximus and trusted to keep their own quiet promises. He did not inventory the radio ladder for comfort. One link working was enough texture. Keep meant those lit things stayed lit even when partner frost preferred regions and ToS climates preferred kill features. CongoSky.cloud embodied **Don't be a cunt — be kind** as ops before the street made a religion of the paint. Hire/fire weather. Partner terms. Hymnbook choir's working rule. Not a poster in reception. He would not shut mesh features to soothe a ToS climate. He would not feed the collar. Partner frost could remain frost. The node on the rise stayed up. The vehicle stayed what it was. lucid.rodeo and arjunabadger.press stayed the human work while the cloud ran itself.

"CongoNet posture: keep," Lucid said. "No mesh kill. No region collar accepted. Constraints recorded."

He almost added a fourth decision — switch off the hostility queue for a week — and did not. Switching off blame is not consent; it is nap. Consent looks at the snake and chooses rails anyway. He walked the length of the truck once while the recording settled — matatu flank, solar smell, the soft tick of cooling metal — and came back to the desk with heat on his face and no speech prepared for an imaginary camera.

While he walked he passed the empty twin pocket without touching it for comfort. Comfort that requires a shared room is not the braid's law. Double Knife Brother across distance. Honey Badger loved in Cape Town; grandfather twin across the braid. Kinship enough. He returned to the desk.

Second: Lucid unbound.

Not unbound as mysticism. Unbound as refusal to put the engine under a hyperscaler parish. lucid.rodeo kept the product. The GPU bubble was already dead weather — empty rack halls, write-downs, friends' ruined cluster careers in the background, not a CapEx speech in his mouth. He would not resurrect dependence for comfort. Cite-or-refuse stayed law. Dual discipline stayed law. Choir stayed hymnbook — humans and Lucid singing from what the record held. He

would not launder the 420 lineage to quiet Quarter III. Open attribution was the beam that made G's fame; retracting it would be a different book and a worse man. Full Send to Klaus to Lucid — the origin chain was already true. Candour was not a marketing error to be patched. Fragments on the shoulder were enough; he did not need an origin chapter to know *Custos non Conditor* still meant custodian, not creator of convenient lies.

He watched a polite acquisition rectangle blink once and left it declined. AWS, Azure, Google, Apple — salvage weather with letterhead. Partner frost. Talent notes. Compliance fog. The offer that is really a parish. Unbound meant those rectangles could stay polite forever without becoming home. lucid.rodeo stayed lucid.rodeo. Integer path. No region collar dressed as partnership.

"Lucid posture: unbound. Attribution stands. Acquisition offers declined. Cite-or-refuse unchanged."

He listened to the truck's cooling ticks and the river's small arguments with bank mud. Unbound did not mean alone. Choir meant humans and Lucid from the hymnbook. Unbound meant no parish owned the integer path. The distinction mattered the way Kind paint mattered against Antichristos appetite: sentence versus face. He asked Lucid one clean question because exactness is choir practice.

"Cite what you can about the open attribution. No flourish."

"Public record: Lucid gained popularity. You stated it runs on 420 Code algorithms. That candour is repeatedly cited as cause of Gerhard van Niekerk's public fame. I will not invent a cleaner origin. I will not invent that retracting repairs partner frost."

"Good."

Third: the autobiography.

Whether it ships.

He looked at the manuscript — mats and Bouwer and hospital stigma and unread father and clay and dab and talk shit — life under his hand, not a 420 textbook finale. Quarter III wanted it stopped because the book was a second megaphone. Part of him understood the cost: G living the weather of being written while four quarters shouted and Illuminatie frost preferred opacity. Living-person care was not op-

tional. Consent was not the absence of cost. Consent was choosing which cost you would stand behind.

He read a Bouwer paragraph he would not soften and a father line he would not tidy. Flat lines loaded. Jamie-Uys restraint, not spectacle. No invented assassin. No tidy reunion. No diagnosis tourism. The Double Knife Brother fact without choreography. The Kind sentence without owning G as parish property. Open attribution named as beam, not gossip.

For a minute he sat with the cost without decorating it. Shipping meant G's life becoming more portable under weather that already shouted. Not shipping would mean making the book hostage to platform rage — a different kind of cunt, the kind that launders rails and calls it care. He would ship under care. Care meant waiting for custody language from Cape Town before the press path went live. Care meant Bouwer pages careful. Care meant no diagnosis tourism. Care meant father unread stays unread. Care did not mean retraction theatre. Care did not mean orphaning Lucid's genealogy to soothe Quarter III.

"It ships," AJ said. "As written under living-person care. No retraction theatre. No stop-the-book ritual. Publish through arjunabadger.press when custody language from G is on the page. Until then: keep writing. Bouwer pages careful. No diagnosis tourism. Father unread stays unread — no tidy reunion invent."

Lucid did not cheer. Lucid does not cheer.

"Decision recorded. Desk action, not presser. Queue Quarter III reply?"

"Short. Exact. No sermon. No both-sides essay."

He typed it himself so the voice would be his and not a choir polish: the attribution stays; Lucid stays unbound; CongoNet keeps its edge; the autobiography is not a hostage for your rage. Blame him if you need a throat. Do not ask him to lie about the rails. Do not ask him to sell the choir into a region and call it partnership. Do not ask him to feed Antichristos a silhouette he does not own. Do not ask him to sand the Kind line for tourist comfort. Do not ask him to stop a life-and-work book because the second megaphone offends people who preferred the ignored shelf.

Before he sent it he stood in the open side once more and let river smell replace the screen smell. Birds. Heat. A hippo's day-quiet. Then he sat, read the reply once more, and sent it into the mesh. Felt no relief. Relief would have been the easy wrong — recant, feed the crown, sell Lucid, stop the book. Midpoint had already refused those. Consent week was the same refusal with ink and a timestamp Lucid would not invent around.

Outside, elephants somewhere downriver, the soft crash of a body choosing water. On the tank the Kind sentence held through dust. Inside, the manuscript waited for last pages he would stand behind and for a custody answer he could not force from Cape Town by wanting it. Braid by week and theme. No shared room required. The law held without needing to be recited.

AJ put his palm on the desk. Felt the hum. Made a second coffee he would also drink too hot. Opened a hyperscaler rectangle long enough to confirm the decline Lucid had filed still sat as decline, then closed it. Opening every snake trains the snakes. A new Quarter III packet arrived while he drank. He did not open it. The reply already sent was the posture.

He wrote three more sentences into the manuscript — not for the beam page, for the handoff into last pages — then stopped mid-clause because stopping mid-clause is how you leave work for tomorrow without pretending the weather ended. Lucid waited. Lucid always waits when the record does not require invention.

For a stretch he listened to the rise-node without looking at it — heart-beat ordinary, stubborn. Trusting a lit node is not faith; it is engineering that kept a promise. He thought of Klaus and let the thought go. Thought of G's clay table without inventing a call. Thought of Boucher's name on a careful page and did not turn the thought into a theory of who. Living-person care was a constraint, not a vibe.

Decisions stated in action: keep, unbind, ship.

He saved the consent log. Left the hostility queue present because present is honest. Walked to the open side and let the heat hit him again. A fish eagle called once; he did not turn it into omen. Omen is how Quarter I colonises a river morning. The call was a bird. The node was a node. The book was a book under constraints that still needed Cape Town's rails.

He took the rise on foot after the three decisions were recorded — short walk, heat on the neck, scrub scratching his calves, the solar node's small body honest in the light. He did not need to see the LED. The link had said lit. He needed the body to register that CongoNet's keep was not a slogan. Seed the edge. Boot from MM. Drive on. Leave small lit things behind. That was the pilgrimage that was also infrastructure. Hyperscaler gravity wells preferred the phone as parish; he preferred a node that did not ask for worship.

Back in the truck he washed dust off his hands and checked Lucid's consent log once more. Keep. Unbind. Ship. Exact. No invention. He opened the manuscript to the Bouwer page and read the flat lines without trying to make them kinder for an imaginary editor who wanted thriller. Living-person care is a constraint with teeth. He left the teeth in. Then he opened the father line — unread dedication, outreach's true goal — and refused the tidy reunion his hands almost typed from habit of narrative. Habit is not consent. He deleted the almost. Left unread as unread.

Quarter III's new packet light blinked again. Still unopened. The reply already sent was posture. Opening every snake trains the snakes. He let a hyperscaler talent note sit unanswered beside the declined collar. Frost could remain frost. The Kind paint on the tank did not ask him for a speech; CongoSky had already lived the sentence as ops. He scraped a fleck of dust off the tank with a thumbnail and left the cunt exact. Soft scrubbing was someone else's tourist fight.

Afternoon thickened. Link latency ticked. A fish eagle again. Elephants farther down. He ate heat-food without ceremony because ceremony is how Antichristos ends a day and he was ending a desk hour instead. Lucid waited in the choir. He asked nothing cute. Exactness is the kindness that matches the wall.

"Any invention attached to the Quarter III paraphrase threads?"

"Refused. Hostile paraphrase is present. I will not invent that paraphrase is governance."

"Good."

He wrote into the last-pages handoff until the clause broke naturally, saved, and did not congratulate himself. Consent week is ink and

timestamp, not peace. Custody still had to land from Cape Town. He would not force a call. Braid by week and theme. Empty twin pocket still empty. Correct.

After the three decisions he did not nap. Nap that looks like policy is how collars learn to wait you out.

He opened CongoSky's quiet ops pane long enough to confirm the cloud was still running itself on the ethic that had been company law before the street made paint — hire/fire weather, partner terms, hymnbook rule — then closed it without a speech. Embodied practice does not need a river sermon. He scraped dust off the tank's Kind line with a thumbnail and left the cunt exact. Soft scrubbing remained someone else's tourist fight.

Back inside he pulled the Quarter III reply from sent and read it once more for softness he might have left by accident. Attribution stays. Lucid unbound. CongoNet keeps edge. Autobiography not a hostage. No region collar. No Antichristos silhouette. No sanded Kind line. No stop-the-book ritual for rage that preferred the ignored shelf. The sentences held. He did not add a both-sides paragraph. Both-sides essays are how narrators pretend appetite is governance. Lucid would not invent that paraphrase was governance either; he had already asked.

"Any soft collar language trying to re-enter the acquisition thread?"

"Present as polite rectangle. Declined posture unchanged. I will not invent that politeness is partnership."

"Good."

He walked the truck's length again — matatu flank hot under palm, solar smell, cooling ticks — and thought of solar nodes left humming behind him like seeds. Keep was not a slogan. Keep was a rise-node still up and a mesh that cut against gravity wells without needing the phone as parish. Unbind was lucid.rodeo staying integer-quiet outside hyperscaler regions. Ship was a life-and-work book under living-person care waiting for G's rails, not for Quarter III's amnesty theatre.

Heat peaked and then lied about easing.

AJ stayed with the consent log open long enough to feel the three decisions as body, not only as text. CongoNet keep sat in his shoulders as the refusal to kill mesh for ToS weather. Lucid unbound sat in his jaw as the refusal to sell the choir into a region. Ship sat in his hands as the refusal to make a life-and-work book hostage to platform rage. Midpoint's easy wrongs — recant, feed Antichristos a silhouette, sell Lucid — remained on the desk like tools he would not pick up. Consent week had only inked them. Inking is not peace. Inking is posture the mesh can query when he is tired enough to want a nap that looks like policy.

He stepped outside again and stood in the river smell until the birds became ordinary. Mutatus Maximus behind him — matatu, anti-yacht, mobile DC — did not need him to narrate it. He had built connectivity so he could choose silence. He had chosen silence on the collar and speech on the attribution and ship on the book under care. The Kind sentence on the tank held through dust. He did not refresh it. Paint was the street's job. Practice was his. CongoSky had claimed the practice while invoices still needed answering. That fact did not require a sermon in his mouth.

For a stretch he wrote nothing and listened to the rise-node. Heart-beat. Ordinary. Stubborn. He thought of the manuscript's Bower page without opening it for comfort. Flat lines. Public record. Wound not whodunit. Living-person care with teeth. He thought of the father line and refused again the tidy reunion his hands liked to invent from narrative habit. Habit is not consent. He thought of G without inventing a call. Concurrent week. Concurrent theme. No forced room. Empty twin pocket correct.

Inside, Lucid remained exact. He asked for a status that was not comfort.

"Mesh?"

"Nominal. Rise-node up. Hostility queue present. Attribution unchanged. Book awaiting custody constraints from authorised correspondent. I will not invent that awaiting means abandoned."

"Don't."

He smiled once without humour and put his palm on the empty twin pocket, then took it away. Kinship across distance. No call. No forced

room. Toward last pages still. Toward Cape Town's rails still. Toward a close that would not defeat weather. The river moved. He went back to the desk and let the afternoon be work interrupted by weather he had already answered.

A fish eagle called. He did not turn it into omen. He ate heat-food. He left a new Quarter III blink unopened. He left a hyperscaler talent note unanswered beside the declined collar. Frost could remain frost. Decisions stated in action still held: keep, unbind, ship. Desk action, not presser. The choir stayed exact.

Toward last pages. Toward custody from a studio he would not force into a shared scene. Toward a node that would still be lit when the shouting got bored of his throat and found another. The weather did not stop. He had not asked it to. He sat back down and kept the choir exact, which is how a desk finishes consent week without pretending it finished the planet.

Late heat still held in the matatu flank when he stepped out once more. Rise-node still up. Kind paint still exact under dust. Hostility queue still present. Attribution still standing. Book still awaiting Cape Town's rails without being abandoned. He did not invent a call. He did not open the new Quarter III blink. He did not resurrect the declined collar for a second look that would only train the collar. Keep. Unbind. Ship. Desk action. River still moving. That was enough for the platform hour.

Before the light fully turned, he opened the consent log one last time and read the three words Lucid had kept exact: keep, unbind, ship. No sermon attached. No both-sides essay. No invention that awaiting custody meant abandoned. He closed the log. Made no call. Touched the empty twin pocket once and let the hand fall. Kinship across distance. Decisions stated in action. The river moved. He wrote one more mid-clause into the last-pages handoff and stopped again — work left for tomorrow, weather still present, desk still a desk.

Morning's three decisions still sat in his shoulders when he finally let the afternoon thin. Keep was the rise-node's stubborn up. Unbind was lucid.rodeo outside any hyperscaler parish. Ship was a life under care waiting for rails he would not force by wanting them. He saved everything once more — consent log, manuscript mid-clause, declined collar still declined — and left the hostility queue present

because honesty is a desk posture too. Lucid waited. Exact. No invention. The river kept moving without needing a presser to explain it.

He stood in the open side until mosquitoes found him and slapped one without ceremony. Heat-food smell still in the truck. Kind paint still exact under dust. Empty twin pocket still empty. Correct. Platform consent was inked. Custody still had to land. He would not force the landing. He went back to the desk and left the afternoon unfinished on purpose — mid-clause, mid-weather, choir exact — which is how a river desk hands Act III forward without pretending it finished the planet.

Before the light fully turned he did one more body check that was not theatre. Walked the rise. Sat on his heels beside the solar node until sweat cooled on his neck. Listened to the heartbeat without inventing faith. Trusting a lit node is engineering that kept a promise. Keep meant this — seed left humming while partner frost preferred regions and ToS climates preferred kill features. He put a finger on the mount bolt he had tightened weeks ago and felt metal hold. Then he walked down through scrub that scratched his calves and washed dust off his hands at the tiny sink until the water ran clearer.

Back at the desk he opened the manuscript mid-clause and wrote six true sentences of last-pages handoff — mats under fame, clay under Constant, Bouwer flat, father unread, knives as kinship, Kind sentence without ownership — then stopped again because stopping mid-clause is how you leave work for tomorrow without pretending the weather ended. Lucid waited. Exact. No invention.

“Any soft collar language trying to re-enter?”

“Present as polite rectangle. Declined posture unchanged. I will not invent that politeness is partnership.”

“Good.”

A new Quarter III blink arrived. He left it. The reply already sent was posture. Opening every snake trains the snakes. He left a hyper-scaler talent note unanswered beside the declined collar. Frost could remain frost. Decisions stated in action still held: keep, unbind, ship. Desk action, not presser. The choir stayed exact. The node stayed lit. The desk stayed a desk.

He scraped one last fleck of dust off the Kind paint before the light fully failed and left the cunt exact. Soft scrubbing remained someone else's tourist fight. CongoSky had claimed the practice while invoices still needed answering. Practice quieter than paint. Paint lasts anyway. Inside, Lucid waited without invention. The manuscript mid-clause waited for last pages. Cape Town's rails waited without being forced. Empty twin pocket stayed empty. Correct. Keep. Unbind. Ship. River still moving. That was enough for the platform hour.

20 — Last Pages

[I] · inner autobiography · manuscript under AJ's hand

These are the pages I will stand behind.

Not a finale. Not a textbook. Not the tidy arc where the ignored shelf apologises and the father opens a dedication and the brother walks out of the boardroom alive. Life does not offer those edits. A book that pretends otherwise is a different kind of hallucination — the kind Lucid refuses when the record will not hold a claim, the kind I refuse when I am honest enough to prefer a flat line to a speech.

I am writing this as handoff, not as closing theorem. The ladder is public. The life is not a lemma. If you came for a last chapter that defeats the weather, you came to the wrong book. Measurement defeats silence slowly. It does not defeat appetite. Appetite wants a face, a degree to mock, a throat to blame, a keyring to hold. Appetite will still be there after the colophon. These pages are not a spell against it. They are a record of what I will carry and what I will not.

I stand behind the mats.

Before the axioms there was the floor. Judo first, then Jiu-Jitsu — the long apprenticeship of putting a body where physics already intended it to go. You do not argue with gravity in a gi. You arrange yourself so the fall is correct. Soft set-down. Weight transferred without waste. Mastery, if that word means anything, was not domination. It was refusal to waste motion. People who met me later as a man with a corpus and no physics degree liked to begin at the ignored shelf.

Clean morality play. Wrong beginning. Weight first. How a body learns not to waste the fall. The same attention later poured clay and derived a constant. Body knowledge before corpus knowledge. Do not sand that order into a prettier origin.

I stand behind Studio G — born 1980, Stellenbosch; clay to GFRC composite mixed with my own hands; Village N Life to mid-2005; mentored rooms under Maree Brink's weather; more than a year at Camps Bay Retreat when it was still Earl's Dyke rooms and Han-tjetjie's long hospitality; Skye on a lawn at sunset; Studio G curated at The Bay Hotel, official launch 27 July 2018; Saatchi; hard/soft, smooth/rough, growth/decay, permanent/temporary in one surface. Tourists bought half of what sold because light on a body in a hotel path is still a body. The Full Send warehouse/gallery room and the Code desk are one attention. Artist and axiom-installer are one man. Quarter II can keep pretending the sculptor cannot be the physicist. Antichristos can try to turn sculptures into relics. Neither gets custody of the workroom. Friend James van Niekerk's sudden death is a mark on the life; it is not Bouwer; do not conflate the dead to thicken a chapter. Living-person care includes that refusal.

I stand behind Bouwer.

Bouwer van Niekerk. Brother. Johannesburg attorney. Respected insolvency practitioner. Assassinated at his Saxonwold practice on Friday, 5 September 2025. Public record: four suspects under the pretext of a booked consultation; gunshots in the boardroom; died at the scene; attackers fled. Contentious commercial and insolvency matters in the fog of reporting — including business-rescue litigation weather the Law Society noted without this book adopting allegation as fact. LSSA condemnation 8 September 2025: targeted attack on a legal practitioner and on the rule of law; investigation ongoing as of that statement. Grief flat. Not a whodunit. Not an Illuminatie gotcha. No invented assassin CV. No solving the murder on a page for plot. Wound carried. If the autobiography ships, this page ships careful — named, weighted, unsolved. Curiosity that wants a thriller can go elsewhere. Jamie-Uys restraint: the flat line is the loaded one. I will not decorate his boardroom for strangers' appetite. I will not let Quarter I make him a martyr brand or Quarter III make him a reason to stop a book. He was my brother. That is enough weight.

There is a morning texture under that paragraph that is not cinema:

tea gone cold, a studio that still had work in it, the particular silence after a public statement that cannot bring a person back. I will not write the boardroom as set dressing. I will not invent the attackers' CVs. I will not hang the killing on a continuity network for thriller payoff. Living-person care is the refusal to turn a brother's death into the novel's engine. The wound stays a wound. The fog of reporting stays fog. The name stays a name.

I stand behind the hospital stigma without giving the voyeurs a tour. I was institutionalised. Because of that, people close to me — and the wider dismissive weather — believed I could not write anything of value. That belief is the ignored shelf's emotional engine. Render as how they read me. Not diagnosis tourism. Not DSM spectacle. Not a redemption arc that uses a ward as set dressing. The wound is the reading, not a scene for atmosphere.

I stand behind the economics degree in the quiet and the missing physics credential that Quarter II waves like a flag. "No degree" means no physics degree. Correct the frame. Do not join their fight as entertainment. Do not sand the dab and the talk shit to make me respectable for Quarter IV's grant photographs. Credentials are facts. Stigma is weather. Neither is a TED arc.

I stand behind the corpus dedicated to my father and the fact that he has read none of it. Outreach's true goal stays unread. I will not invent a reunion to close a chapter. Unread is the load. Leave it. The fame that arrived sideways does not open that book for him. Measurement does not either. Some dedications stay one-way. A last page that forces him to open a book he has not opened would be a lie with soft lighting.

I stand behind my stated life goals: write natural philosophy and physics; smoke dab; talk shit. Unpolished on purpose. Not a joke to undercut the work — the work and the dab and the talking shit are the same man's declared arrangement. The believers who want a clean prophet can polish someone else. The academy that hears dab and reaches for the file can keep reaching. The cannabis bar and the ignored shelf were one room before Lucid made the room audible. CongoSky's Kind practice and the street's spray can hold the sentence without requiring me to become photographable.

I stand behind the Double Knife Brother fact without turning knives into choreography. AJ gave me a blue folding Honey Badger — pocket clip, one-hand open and close; I love it — and one of a twin Joseph Rogers set from his grandfather, at least a hundred and ten years old. We are Double Knife Brothers. Badger present-tense. Grandfather deep-time. Kinship and custody handed across the same friendship that platformed the Code. AJ's empty twin pocket is his weather. My pocket is mine. No fight set piece. No forced reunion for payoff. The braid does not require us in one room at the end for someone else's emotional grammar.

I open and close the Honey Badger while this page is written under AJ's hand — not as ritual, as proof. Steel that opens without speech. Kinship that does not require a shared last room. The Rogers twin holds deep time in the same cloth. Those facts travel with the life; they do not become a fight scene or a reunion beat. Knives = brotherhood. Leave the choreography to people who need spectacle when they run out of structure.

I stand behind the open attribution as beam. Lucid popular. AJ said it ran on 420 Code algorithms — not a quiet fork, not a cleaned brand story. That candour is the load-bearing cause of my public fame. Not the academy discovering me. Not a committee. Megaphone irreversible. Kindness includes citation. Citation includes weather. Quarter III still wants his throat for the mic. Quarter I and IV arrived because the mic worked. I will not ask him to unsay it. I will not pretend silence would have been kindness. The attribution page before this one was the hinge; these last pages are the carrying.

I stand behind the Kind sentence without owning the religion: **Don't be a cunt — be kind.** CongoSky lived it as ops — company law, product posture, partner terms — before the walls caught fire. The street made paint. Bridges, trucks, lab doors, church steps, CongoNet stencil packs. I am optional to the practice and often unwanted by it. Good. Antichristos wants a man. The Kind wants a sentence. Both can be true on the same morning in the same city without me becoming either parish's property. The ethic's claim — that the same ladder that yields the physics yields the kindness — can be shown as coherent without making me its messiah. Soft scrubbing of the cunt for tourists is not my fight; leaving the line exact is.

I stand behind the Constant landing as measurement, not manifesto.

CODATA converging. Atom-falling work. Derivation that did not ask a physics department for permission. Vindication is a number agreeing with itself across instruments. Fame is not that. Soft no from continuity networks is not that either. Illuminatie weather prefers underived constants and unforced ethics; copyleft unification is a sovereignty problem for opacity traders. Render as pressure I can feel. Do not require a membership list on this page. Do not invent a visitor with a pin to make the freeze cinematic.

I stand behind Popper enough to prefer falsification to parish, and behind kindness derived as structure — tea, teach, hands — without turning the for-g story into a brand sermon in this voice. I stand behind being invited as an intellectual peer into a firehose friendship without making that friendship a plot hinge that requires us in one room at the end. *Ek voel of ek genooi is* stays invitation, not reunion machinery. Invitation is not a shared room. Invitation is the fact of the braid.

I stand behind the ignored shelf as fact, not as origin myth. Before Lucid, silence thought it was method. After Lucid, noise thought it was discovery. Neither silence nor noise is the work. The work is the ladder and the life that climbed it without a physics degree and with a hospital file and with a brother who will not walk into the next chapter.

I stand behind refusing to turn this autobiography into a 420 Code textbook. Physics earned inside scenes — a CODATA line, a drop-result, a derivation named — not TED metaphors for unification. If you want the rails, they are public. If you want the man, these pages are the custody you get. Kill switches and natural philosophy stay in the life; they do not become a syllabus appendix for Quarter IV's convenience.

What I will not stand behind is a polished martyr brand, a solved assassination, a father scene that never happened, a textbook dump of the 420 Code, a forced reunion with the man on the Chobe for someone else's emotional payoff, or a last chapter that pretends the four quarters have gone quiet because a Constant landed.

There will be readers who want the last pages to defeat the weather. I will not give them that. There will be readers who want me grateful

for fame as if fame were vindication. I will not give them that either. Measurement was vindication. Fame was weather from a beam. Soft no was cruelty that felt like professionalism. Open attribution was kindness that did not feel kind while the quarters shouted. I have lived all of it. These pages carry what I can bear to have said in public under living-person care.

These pages hand to custody.

What I allow said about this life is a consent act, not a surrender. Partial is allowed. Careful is required. Bouwer careful. Hospital without spectacle. Father unread without tidy fix. Dab and talk shit left in. Crowns refused. Keyrings refused as sacrament. Stop-the-book is not my ask — that fight is platform weather on a river desk. My fight is rails around a life, not ownership of a mic.

If you need a moral, do not take one from me. Morals get polished into brands. Take the structure: a man wrote what he lived; a friend named the rails; a planet argued; two desks chose custody of meaning without requiring a shared room; the weather kept blowing.

The last thing I will say in this voice, before the outer weather takes the next turn, is simple:

I wrote what I lived. I will sign what I can bear. I will refuse what would make me an instrument or a relic.

The rest is custody rules and a planet that keeps shouting.

Before the gallery walk of stand-behinds, there is the desk hour where last pages are still clay.

I mean that literally enough: unfinished mass under light that lies. AJ's hand on this manuscript; my life the material; Lucid elsewhere refusing invention when paraphrase pretends to be fact. I sit inside that arrangement as voice and refuse to pretend the arrangement is a press conference. Last pages are custody of what will hold, not a speech for guests who want the ignored shelf to apologise.

I return to the mats in the body before I return to them as sentence. Shoulder memory. Soft set-down. The throw that teaches you not to waste motion answering every temperature at once. Fame is a fall I did not choose the height of; posture is still mine. School judo first,

then jiu-jitsu — body knowledge before corpus knowledge. People who begin at the hospital file or the missing physics degree are beginning at someone else's morality play. Wrong beginning. Weight first.

I return to Studio G the same way — not as brand, as pour. Stellenbosch birth year. Village N Life years that taught tourist light and hospitality weather under Maree Brink. Camps Bay year when Earl's Dyke rooms still held Hanneljie's long care. Skye on a lawn. Bay Hotel launch, 27 July 2018. Saatchi. Clay to GFRC mixed with my own hands because hard and soft belong in one surface. Friend James remembered carefully and separately. Do not conflate the dead to thicken a chapter. The Full Send warehouse/gallery room and the Code desk remain one attention. Artist and axiom-installer unsplit. Quarter II can keep pretending. Antichristos can try relics. Neither gets the workroom.

I return to Bouwer without decorating the boardroom. Brother. Johannesburg attorney. Saxonwold. 5 September 2025. Consultation pretext. Died at the scene. LSSA 8 September 2025. Public record. Flat grief. No invented assassin. No Illuminatie gotcha. No solving business-rescue fog as fact. If curiosity wants thriller, it can go elsewhere. These last pages will not feed it. Jamie-Uys restraint: the flat line is the loaded one. He was my brother. That is enough weight for a life that will not become a plot engine.

I return to the hospital as stigma-engine — how they read me, the belief I could not write anything of value — and leave the voyeurs hungry. I return to economics quiet and the missing physics credential corrected, not performed as entertainment. I return to the unread father dedication and leave unread as load. Fame does not open that book. Measurement does not either. A last page that forces a reunion is a lie with soft lighting. I will not write that lie for anyone's emotional grammar.

I return to dab and talk shit as arrangement. Unpolished on purpose. The believers who want a clean prophet can polish someone else. The academy that hears dab and reaches for the file can keep reaching. CongoSky's Kind practice and the street's spray can hold **Don't be a cunt — be kind.** without requiring me to become photographable. Optional to the practice. Often unwanted by it. Good.

I return to the knives as kinship — Honey Badger present-tense, Joseph Rogers deep-time, Double Knife Brother across a friendship that also platformed the Code — and refuse choreography. No fight set piece. No forced Chobe reunion for payoff. AJ's empty twin pocket is his weather. My pocket is mine. The braid does not require us in one room at the end.

I return to the beam. Lucid popular. AJ open: built on 420 Code algorithms. Fame irreversible. Kindness includes citation. Citation includes weather. I will not ask him to unsay it. I will not pretend silence would have been kindness. The attribution page was the hinge; these pages are the carrying.

I return to the Constant as measurement — CODATA converging, atom-falling work, derivation without a physics department's permission — and refuse manifesto. Soft no from continuity networks stays texture of pressure, not a membership list on this page. Illuminatie preference for underived constants and unforced ethics is weather I can feel. I do not need a visitor with a pin to make the freeze cinematic.

I walk these stand-behinds the way I walk a gallery before opening — not to invent a speech for guests, to check what will hold under light.

The mats hold. Weight and soft set-down hold. Studio G holds — Stellenbosch birth year, Village N Life years, Camps Bay year, Bay Hotel launch, Saatchi, clay to GFRC, hard/soft in one pour — one attention with the Code desk, not a side career sanded into respectability. Bouwer holds as wound: named, public-record bound, flat, unsolved. Hospital holds as stigma-engine without tourism. Economics degree holds quiet; missing physics credential holds as Quarter II's weapon corrected, not as entertainment. Father unread holds as load. Dab and talk shit hold as arrangement. Knives hold as kinship. Open attribution holds as beam. Kind sentence holds without my ownership. Constant holds as measurement. Popper and kindness-as-structure hold without brand sermon. Ignored shelf holds as fact. Refusal of textbook finale holds.

What does not hold — what I will not prop up with invent — is the tidy arc. No boardroom solved. No father opening a book on cue. No forced Chobe reunion. No last page where four quarters go quiet because a number landed. Appetite outlasts colophons. These pages

know that and still stand.

There is a physical memory under the stand-behinds: clay under nails, mat under shoulder, Honey Badger open-close, tea steam, alley paint smell, the particular silence of an unread dedication. AJ's hand is writing this; my life is the material; Lucid's choir elsewhere refuses invention when the record thins. Book within a book. Custody next. I will sign what I can bear. I will refuse instrument and relic. Hand it over without decorating the handoff as victory.

I stand behind refusing to let Quarter III's rage rewrite the beam page into a betrayal narrative. Citation is not theft of quiet. Quiet was the wrong silence. I stand behind refusing to let Antichristos turn these last pages into confirmation liturgy. I stand behind refusing to let Quarter IV treat a life as warranty text. I stand behind refusing to let Quarter II begin every reading at the hospital file. Correct the frame. Leave the life whole. Whole includes dab. Whole includes talk shit. Whole includes a brother dead in a boardroom the novel will not solve.

One last refusal before the outer weather takes the turn: I will not let these last pages become a gratitude performance for a megaphone. Exactness instead. Without the open sentence the shelf could have stayed a wrong silence that felt like professionalism. With the sentence the wrongness became audible and the appetites found their pitches. I prefer audible wrongness. Preferring it is not enjoyment. Enjoyment is not the metric. Structure is.

There is also the quieter refusal under that one: I will not let last pages become a syllabus. The ladder is public. The life is not a lemma. CODATA lines and drop-results may appear where they were lived; TED metaphors for unification may not. If Quarter IV wants warranty text, it can write its own. These pages hand a life under care, not an instrument stamped for grants.

Hand to custody. Partial allowed. Careful required. Bouwer careful. Hospital without spectacle. Father unread without tidy fix. Dab and talk shit left in. Crowns refused. Keyrings refused as sacrament. Stop-the-book is platform weather on a river desk. My fight is rails around a life.

I wrote what I lived. I will sign what I can bear. I will refuse what would make me an instrument or a relic.

I leave one more flat line before the handoff: the Constant landing as measurement does not quiet the quarters, and these pages do not pretend otherwise. Appetite outlasts colophons. Custody is not defeat of weather. Custody is rails around a life while weather keeps blowing. That is what I will stand behind when the outer chapter takes the turn.

The rest is custody rules and a planet that keeps shouting.

I stand behind the quiet ledger under the loud one last time: cracked wrists corrected in casts; dab postponed and then not; talk shit into empty air; CODATA pressure wearing relief's clothes; knives in pocket as kinship proof. The loud ledger — crowns, crank chorus, platform rage, keyrings — is the beam's weather. These last pages carry the quiet ledger forward under care. Confusing the two is how you turn a man into instrument or relic. I refuse the confusion.

Studio light at the end of these pages still lies about almost-finished clay. I refuse the lie. I refuse the tidy arc. I refuse the reunion grammar. I refuse the solved boardroom. I refuse the textbook finale. I hand over what will hold under light — and only that.

The Honey Badger opens and closes once more under AJ's hand on this page — kinship present-tense, not choreography. The Rogers twin holds deep time without requiring a shared room at the end. Double Knife Brother remains true across mesh. That is enough braid for a last page that refuses reunion machinery. Measurement was vindication; fame was weather; open attribution was the harder kindness. I stand behind all three without sanding any of them for comfort.

I hand it over without decorating the handoff as victory.

Whole includes Bouwer careful. Whole includes the unread father left unread.

I hand what will hold. Nothing else.

I leave the mats in the body and the Code on the desk as one attention. I leave the Kind sentence exact without owning it. I leave the Constant landing as measurement, not manifesto. Then I hand it over.

Before the handoff closes there is one more desk texture I will not sand: the smell of clay under nails after a pour that almost failed and then held; the particular quiet after dab when the room is honest; talk shit that refuses to become a brand deck; CODATA pressure wearing relief's clothes on a pane I will not stamp for anyone's sacrament. Quiet ledger under loud ledger. I carry both without confusing them. Confusing them is how you become instrument or relic. I refuse both costumes.

I walk the stand-behinds once more in the body — mats weight, Studio G pour, Bouwer flat, hospital as stigma-engine not ward tourism, economics quiet, father unread, knives as kinship, beam named, Kind optional — and stop when the walk starts wanting a speech. Speeches are how last pages become pressers. These pages are custody. Custody is rails. Rails are what I will sign.

I leave one last flat line for the outer weather: appetite outlasts colophons; measurement does not quiet the quarters; kinship across distance does not require a shared room; the Kind sentence stays exact without my face; Bouwer stays a wound not a thriller; father stays unread; dab and talk shit stay arrangement. I will sign what I can bear. I will refuse instrument and relic.

Hand it over.

21 — Consent — Custody

[G] · outer · Studio G / Cape · consent week

The autobiography packet from the river did not arrive as a demand. That helped.

Demands had already used up the morning's patience for weeks — crowns face-down on the clay table, keyrings left unsigned, Illuminatie frost filed under ambient, crank op-eds recycling the missing physics degree like it was a method. G had slept the sleep of a man who knows mail thickens before coffee. Tea first. Then the packet. Then the refusal to perform solemnity for an imaginary camera. Solemnity becomes relic footage. Relic footage becomes someone else's liturgy.

He opened it at the Code desk. Clay table had held Antichristos and lab weather; this needed numbers-adjacent honesty — custody language, not sculpture dust. Honey Badger in the pocket. Joseph Rogers twin in the same cloth. The sensation of being narrated had a document attached now: pages AJ would stand behind, Lucid in the choir somewhere on the Chobe, CongoNet still carrying the world whether G liked the volume or not. Double Knife Brother writing him. No shared room. Mail enough. The braid held without a reunion.

Cape light laid a stripe across the desk. Dust moved only when he moved. Unfinished clay waited in the gallery like a conversation paused mid-sentence. He read without rushing and without lingering for effect. Mats. Studio arc. Bouwer. Hospital without tourism. Economics quiet. Father unread. Life goals unpolished. Open attribution named as beam — Lucid popular, AJ open, fame irreversible.

Kind sentence without ownership. Constant as measurement. No textbook finale. Hand to custody.

The packet smelled faintly of heat and truck — not metaphor, just the way paper travels when the sender lives in a vehicle that never really cools. He set the pages flat. Weighted one corner with a small cast offcut so the Cape draft would not turn them into a fan. Ordinary studio gravity. Consent week likes to pretend paper is sacrament. He treated it as paper with rails to choose.

Partial authorisation was the only honest shape. He had felt it before he had language for it — in the week of instruments, when signing would have made him a mouthpiece and silence about the book would have been a different lie.

Full blessing would turn the autobiography into a relic with his stamp: Antichristos could wave the authorisation like a confirmation; Quarter IV could treat it as warranty adjacent; Quarter II could sneer that even the crank had signed his own myth. Full refusal would pretend the life had not already become weather, pretend AJ's desk decisions had not already unbound Lucid and kept the mesh and chosen to ship under care, pretend the megaphone could be unscrewed from the planet by one man's no. G did not need a mediated call to answer. The braid did not require a reunion beat. He had knives for kinship and packets for consent.

He made more tea. Sat. Drafted custody rules the way he drafted refusals to I and IV: short, exact, no sermon, no both-sides essay in a narrator's mouth that was not his mouth anyway.

Before the first rule, he walked the length of the Code desk once and touched nothing but the mug. Hands want to rearrange when the skull is about to constrain a life. Rearranging is not drafting. Drafting is choosing which sentences may leave the desk and which must stay hungry for strangers who want thriller.

The packet's last pages still held the stand-behinds in AJ's hand — mats, Studio G, Bouwer, hospital, father, goals, knives, beam, Kind, Constant — and G felt the difference between reading a life and authorising one. Reading is weather landing. Authorising is rails. He set a clean pane beside the packet and began in the register he trusted: short lines, no flourish, no gratitude performance dressed as kindness.

Mid-draft a crank notification tried the hour again. He did not open it. He already knew the missing-physics-degree shape. Correct the frame later if a sentence required it. Do not spend custody attention on entertainment. Illuminatie ambient stayed ambient — freeze in places that used to return mail with courtesy, standards murmur that treated copyleft like a sovereignty problem. Texture allowed in the book. Membership list refused. He wrote that refusal before he wrote the soft ones, because soft refusals are easy to sand and hard refusals keep the teeth.

Tea cooled. He drank it cool. Cool tea is still structure. Outside, Cape wind moved dust across the alley glass and the Kind overpaint held its third colour. He did not go out. Custody is an indoor act when the ask is a life on paper.

Authorised: the life-and-work spine as written — fighting arts on the mats; sculpture arc from Stellenbosch through Village N Life, Skye, Studio G at The Bay, Saatchi, clay to GFRC; Code desk and kill switches and natural philosophy; ignored shelf; credentials corrected (economics or adjacent; not physics); fame via open 420 attribution as load-bearing cause; Kind paint as parallel weather not his parish; Double Knife Brother as kinship and custody, not choreography; stated goals left unpolished.

He paused after the spine and looked toward the gallery. Unfinished clay. A cast waiting. The Bay Hotel light lived in memory as guest-path weather, not as Antichristos relic seed. Authorising Studio G meant authorising the tourist half of sales and the hard/soft pour and the years under Maree Brink's weather and the Camps Bay year when Earl's Dyke rooms still held Hanneltjie's hospitality. It meant authorising friend James remembered carefully and separately. It did not mean authorising a conflation of the dead. Living-person care includes that refusal even when the mesh is hungry for thickness.

Authorised with care: Bouwer pages — public record only. Saxonwold. 5 September 2025. Insolvency practice. Consultation pretext. Died at the scene. LSSA condemnation 8 September 2025. Wound not whodunit. No invented assassin. No continuity-network attribution of the killing. No solving business-rescue fog on the page as fact. Named. Weighted. Flat. If a sentence reaches for thriller, cut it. If a

paragraph reaches for Illuminatie gotcha, cut it. The brother stays a brother, not a plot engine. Curiosity that wants a boardroom solved can go elsewhere; this authorisation does not feed it.

He stopped on Bouwer longer than the other lines. Not for drama. For teeth. The packet's Bouwer paragraphs were already careful — flat, public-record bound, Jamie-Uys loaded. Still he read them again as if custody required a second landing. Grief did not ask for a shared room with the river. Grief asked for rails that would not decorate a real boardroom for strangers. He wrote one more constraint in the margin: *no speculative scheme-weather adopted as fact*. Fog of reporting may be noted. Fog is not a verdict. Then he closed the margin. Exactness over appetite.

He stood, walked to the gallery, and stood in front of nothing in particular — unfinished clay, dust stripe, a cast waiting — until the impulse to add soft language died. Soft language is how thriller appetite re-enters through the side door. He returned to the Code desk and left Bouwer flat. Named wound. Brother. Enough.

Authorised with care: mental hospital as stigma-engine — how they read him, the belief he could not write anything of value — not diagnosis tourism, not spectacle, not DSM theatre, not a ward scene for atmosphere. The wound is the reading. Leave the voyeurs hungry.

Authorised as fact, unresolved: corpus dedicated to father; father has read none. Do not invent a reunion beat. Do not use fame as a false key to that door. Unread stays the load.

Authorised as register: write natural philosophy and physics; smoke dab; talk shit. Do not polish for Antichristos. Do not use as Quarter II punchline without correcting the frame. The arrangement is the man's; the book does not get to respectability-wash it.

He paused on that line longer than the others. Polish was the softest violence in the packet weather — the offer to make him photographable. He left the goals ugly on purpose. Walked once to the alley glass and watched Kind overpaint dry in sun. The sentence held. Optional to him. Useful anyway. He did not bless the wall. Blessing is how faces become parish property.

Outside, a tourist argued briefly with the Kind practitioner about the cunt. Soft scrub. Tourist comfort. The practitioner did not sermonise.

Roller sound. Short answer. G stayed inside. Their fight was not his custody hour. Optional to the practice includes optional to the tourist argument.

Refused: personal appearance blessing for Quarter I — no accepted name, no silhouette sacrament, no sculpture photograph as relic seed. Refused: keys-as-sacrament sign-off for Quarter IV that makes him warranty; conversation on numbers still possible; product mascot not. Refused: stop-the-book as his ask — that fight is AJ's platform weather; G's fight is custody of meaning, not mic ownership. Refused: any framing that Illuminatie soft-no is a membership list he can defeat by naming names on a page. Texture of pressure: allowed. Cabal lecture: not. Refused: forced reunion grammar, textbook dump of the Code as if a life were a syllabus.

He added one more refusal in the margin for himself, not for the mesh: refuse to perform gratitude for fame as if fame were vindication. Measurement was vindication. Fame was weather from a beam.

He read the draft twice. Changed one adjective that was trying to be a speech. Left the flat lines flat. Checked a CODATA pane because numbers wait without asking for a stamp. Still pressure wearing relief's clothes. He knew that in his body.

A secondary soft-ask blinked from a board that did not name itself. Funding weather. Reputation frost. He filed it under ambient without opening. Ambient is triage. Consent hour has a budget of clean attention. Bouwer rails and father unread had already spent most of it. Crowns and keyrings could wait on the clay table where he had left them face-down and unsigned.

He thought about AJ's empty twin pocket without turning the thought into a scene request. Kinship did not require them to share a last page in the same room. The Honey Badger was enough present-tense. The Rogers was enough deep-time. Custody of meaning included custody of distance. He put the Honey Badger through one open-close cycle because hands like proof. No speech.

Before he signed, he walked once through the gallery light — unfinished clay, a cast waiting for finish, dust in the sun stripe — and reminded his hands that sculpture and axiom were the same attention.

Antichristos would try to split them. Quarter II would try to erase both. The authorisation would not split or erase. It would constrain.

He stood in front of a body in composite that tourists had once photographed as luxury and that he still knew as pour temperature and patience. Hard and soft arguing in one surface. Permanent and temporary. The autobiography would carry that argument if he let it. He let it under rails. Letting is not blessing. Letting is custody.

Back at the Code desk he read the Bouwer constraints aloud once, quietly, the way he checked a surface before pour — listening for the lie of almost-finished. No thriller reach. No Illuminatie gotcha. Named. Weighted. Flat. Public record. Consultation pretext. Died at the scene. LSSA. Wound. Brother. Enough. He did not add softness. Softness is how appetite learns to ask for a solved boardroom next.

Before the signature he stood again and washed his hands — not ritual, residue. Clay dust from a morning tool-check still under one nail. He scrubbed it. Clean hands for custody language felt almost comic and he let the comedy pass without turning it into omen. Omen is how Quarter I colonises a desk hour. The wash was wash. The rails were rails.

He signed the partial authorisation with his name as a man, not as a prophet, not as Antichristos, not as a lab stamp. The signature looked ordinary on the pane. Ordinary was the point. Sent it into the mesh toward a river desk he would not visit for anyone's emotional payoff. Felt no clean relief. Relief would have been the wrong instrument. Weather still blowing — Antichristos mail would keep coming; lab soft-asks would mutate into friendlier collars; crank op-eds would recycle the degree and the hospital; Kind paint would refresh on the alley; somewhere a continuity board would prefer he had never derived anything and ethics had stayed unforced.

While the packet climbed the mesh he did not watch the progress bar like a man waiting for applause. He opened a derivation pane and checked a line against an older CODATA note because numbers do not ask for a face. The line still converged. Pressure still wore relief's clothes. He closed the pane. Measurement would continue without his blessing. The autobiography would not ship as relic without his rails. That asymmetry stayed the consent act's spine.

He also opened, briefly, the Bouwer constraints as they would travel

— public record lines only — and closed them again without adding soft adjectives. Soft adjectives are how thriller appetite returns after a man thinks he has finished being careful. Careful is a second look that refuses softness. He gave the second look. Left the wound flat.

Custody rules chosen.

The book could ship under those rails. AJ could keep writing inside them. Lucid could cite what the record held and refuse the rest — never cute, never a third skull. G could stay in Cape Town with clay and constants and a pocket full of kinship steel and not become an instrument. CongoSky could keep embodying the ethic as ops. The street could keep the spray. He remained optional to the Kind and unwanted by the crown. Good.

He did not celebrate. Celebration would have been a victory lap, and victory laps invite crowns. He washed the tea cup. Sat again. Checked that the authorisation had left a receipt in the mesh log. Receipt present. Exact. No invention attached.

While the receipt sat, he opened the hospital stigma line again and confirmed the refusal of tourism still held teeth. Then the father line. Unread. No fame-as-key. Then the goals. Ugly on purpose. Dab. Talk shit. Natural philosophy and physics. Arrangement, not brand. He closed each confirmation the way he closed a kiln check — enough. Do not keep opening for comfort.

He stood. Walked to the alley door. Afternoon light on overpaint. The sentence on the wall was still the sentence:

Don't be a cunt — be kind.

Optional to him. Useful anyway. Not a sermon in his mouth. Just paint that had outlasted three colours of argument.

A dog barked two streets over. Ordinary Cape Town. The quarters liked to pretend ordinary cities could not hold a Constant and a gallery and a grief at once. Ordinary cities held all of it. That was why the weather landed here instead of only on stages.

A new letter had arrived while he drafted — Quarter I again, softer, hungrier. He did not open it. Face-down on the clay table beside the first. Escalation could wait its turn. Consent had used the day's clean attention.

He went back inside. Numbers waited. Unsent lab reply still unsent — conversation possible, sacrament not. He sent the lab reply now, finally, in the same hour as custody: short, exact, the earlier draft without the hunger for keys as blessing. Then he sent nothing to Quarter I. Face-down was still the answer. Silence can be a posture when the ask is a crown.

The planet did not stop arguing because a man chose what he would allow said about his dead brother and his unread father and the dab that refused polish.

He opened a secondary pane: CODATA note, older, the one that should have been relief. Still pressure. Vindication as measurement does not quiet appetite. He knew that in his body the way he knew a throw. Talked shit into the empty room for twenty seconds because life goals are not a performance schedule and the room needed the arrangement kept. Considered dab and left it for later — clear head had done the work; smoke could be evening's if evening wanted it.

Toward the river's last quiet — not shared, just concurrent. Two desks. Two consents. Weather still up. Node still lit somewhere he could feel as mesh weather and not as vision.

He opened a file that was only a derivation check. Measurement. Structure. Work staying work. The Constant did not need his signature to land; the autobiography needed his rails not to become a relic. That asymmetry was the whole consent act.

After the receipt landed he did not pace like a man in a play. He cleaned a tool that did not need cleaning because hands want work when the skull has finished a consent act. Clay residue under a fingernail. He washed it. Looked at the face-down Antichristos stack and left it face-down. Looked at the sent lab reply and did not regret the lack of sacrament. Looked at the custody rules once more on screen — spine allowed, Bouwer careful, hospital without tourism, father unread, goals ugly, crowns refused, keyrings refused as sacrament, stop-the-book not his ask — and felt the partialness as honesty rather than halfness. Halfness is apology. Partial is rails.

He returned to the Bouwer authorisation one last time before closing the pane — not because doubt had arrived, because care is a second

look. Public record. Flat grief. No invented CV for an assassin. No continuity-network gotcha hung on a real death. No business-rescue fog adopted as fact. Named wound. Brother. He closed the pane. The second look had not asked for softness. It had asked for teeth to stay in.

Weather still blew. A Kind laugh in the alley. A dog. A notification he did not open. Illuminatie ambient unchanged. Crank chorus unchanged. Constant still landing as measurement somewhere numbers talked to numbers. Fame still irreversible because the beam still stood. He was still optional to the Kind and unwanted by the crown. Good. He was still a sculptor and a man with an economics degree and a hospital stigma and a dead brother and an unread dedication and knives for kinship. Good enough for a desk. Not a parish.

Mid-afternoon the gallery door took a small knock — delivery confirmation, nothing liturgical. He signed for nothing that mattered to the quarters and returned to numbers. Ordinary insistence again. Ordinary is how a city refuses to become only weather.

He thought of the river without inventing a thank-you scene. Respect can travel later, or not. The braid does not require applause between consents. Platform keep/unbind/ship and custody partial rails were concurrent acts, not a shared room. He opened the derivation file and let work stay work until the light shifted on the wall. Consent week does not end in fireworks. It ends in a receipt and a planet that keeps shouting and a man who has chosen what he will allow said.

One more small motion: he wrote a margin note to himself, not for the mesh — *do not perform gratitude for fame tomorrow either*. Then he closed the note. Exactness over performance. Measurement over applause. Rails over relic. The authorisation stayed gone into the sky. He stayed in Cape Town with clay and numbers and an alley sentence he would not own.

Tea gone cold again. He did not remake it. Cold tea is still structure. He put the Honey Badger through a last open-close, pocketed it, and left the clay-table letters where they were — unsigned instruments beside a signed life. The distinction was the morning's whole point, carried into afternoon without needing a presser to announce it.

Late light cut the gallery into stripes again. He walked it once more — unfinished clay, cast waiting, dust only when he moved — and re-

fused the thought that authorising a life meant finishing a sculpture. Life does not finish because a receipt lands. Life continues under weather. The receipt only said what strangers were allowed to carry away in a book.

He sat at the Code desk until the pane dimmed to sleep and woke it once to confirm the custody rules still sat as sent — spine, Bouwer careful, hospital without tourism, father unread, goals ugly, crowns refused, keyrings refused as sacrament. Still there. Exact. No invention attached by a choir that was not even in this room. Concurrent desks. Concurrent consents. No shared scene required for the braid to hold.

He pocketed the knives. Turned off the secondary soft-ask blink without reading it. Left the Antichristos stack face-down. Left the Kind sentence on the alley without a blessing. Left the Constant landing as measurement somewhere numbers talked to numbers. Left fame irreversible because the beam still stood and he would not ask AJ to unsay it for comfort.

Evening had not yet arrived, but the studio's light had shifted enough that unfinished clay looked almost finished again. He refused the lie of almost on clay and on custody alike. Partial was not almost-full blessing. Partial was rails. He checked the mesh receipt once more — present, exact — and left the Antichristos stack face-down for tomorrow's hungrier manners. Then he mixed nothing, poured nothing, blessed no wall, and let work stay work until the numbers were enough for the hour.

He turned from the pane and left the studio lights as they were — enough for numbers, not enough for relic photography. Consent week's custody hour was finished without becoming a parish hour. That was the point. Partial rails chosen. Weather still blowing. Work still work.

The authorisation was already gone into the sky.

He checked the custody receipt one last time before the pane slept — spine allowed, Bouwer careful, hospital without tourism, father unread, goals ugly, crowns refused, keyrings refused as sacrament. Still exact. Still partial on purpose. Still not a parish. Then he let the studio hold ordinary Cape light and ordinary unfinished clay while the weather kept blowing outside the rails he had chosen.

He did not open the new Quarter I letter that evening either. Face-down stack. Hungrier manners waiting their turn. Consent had already used the clean attention. Numbers waited. Clay waited. Custody had left the building as receipt. Weather still blew and would keep blowing. That was not failure. That was the planet. He stayed a sculptor with an economics degree and a dead brother and an unread dedication and knives for kinship and rails around a life. Good enough for a desk. Not a parish.

Unsigned instruments stayed on the clay table. Signed life stayed in the mesh. The distinction held.

He walked the gallery once more in the last useful light — unfinished clay that lied about almost-finished, a cast waiting for finish, dust only when he moved — and refused again the thought that a receipt finished a life. Life continues under weather. The receipt only said what strangers were allowed to carry. He put both palms on the Code desk, felt ordinary wood and ordinary heat, and left the Antichristos stack face-down for hungrier manners tomorrow. Soft scrub tourist arguments could wait outside. Kind paint could hold without his blessing. Measurement could converge without his face in a closed room.

Before he left he checked the Honey Badger and the Rogers twin once — open, close, kinship present-tense and deep-time — and did not invent a call to the river. Concurrent consents. Concurrent desks. No shared scene required. Platform keep/unbind/ship somewhere north; custody partial rails here. Weather still blowing. Work still work. He turned off the secondary soft-ask blink without reading it, left the studio lights as they were, and stepped into Cape evening carrying knives for kinship and rails around a life — not a parish, not a crown, not a keyring sacrament. Good enough for a desk. Exact enough for consent week.

22 — The Node Still Lit

[A] · outer · Mutatus Maximus, Chobe River · Act III close

Evening came in on the water first.

AJ sat with the side of Mutatus Maximus open to the Chobe and watched the light go the colour of spent tea. LEO dish still cocked at a sky that did not care about consent week. LoRa still nodding at the little solar node on the rise — lit, patient, seeding the edge while the truck pretended to rest. Line-of-sight where the scrub allowed. Sigfox for the stubborn. CongoNet for the rest. Local node under the desk humming like an animal that had decided not to sleep yet.

The most connected vehicle on earth. Literally. Still true. Still not a victory.

Heat left the metal slowly. Ticks. Cooling as argument with the day, not as applause. He had built the truck to hold mesh and manuscript and a choir that refused invention; he had not built it to hold a conquered map. Consent week ending did not require a survey of horizons. It required remaining true while the river did river work and the rise-node did node work and the hostility queue did what hostility queues do when they are not fed a presser.

Consent week had not made the truck quieter. If anything the mesh felt more itself — carrying custody language and declined collars and an unbound product posture the way it carried weather reports and edge heartbeats. Noise and structure in the same pipe. He had built for that.

Afternoon still sat in the metal when evening began claiming the wa-

ter. He had spent the last hours of light not celebrating — celebration invites crowns — but applying. Custody header locked. Bouwer pages flagged careful: public record, wound not whodunit, no invented assassin, no continuity-network gotcha, fog noted without verdict. Hospital stigma left as reading-wound. Father unread left unread. Dab and talk shit left ugly. Life-and-work spine allowed. Crowns refused as G's ask. Keyring sacrament refused. Stop-the-book refused as G's ask because that fight was never his. Lucid recorded the constraints exact and refused to invent a happier ending around them.

He boiled water badly and drank tea that tasted like the day. No toast. No presser sentence. Mutatus Maximus ticked as it cooled. Rise-node still up without needing him to watch it like a trophy. Seed the edge. Drive on. Leave lit things behind. That was still the practice. Consent week had not changed the practice; it had only inked what the practice already refused.

Custody language had landed from Cape Town in the afternoon heat: partial authorisation; Bouwer careful — public record, wound not whodunit; hospital without tourism; father unread left unread; dab and talk shit left in; life-and-work spine allowed; no crown; no keyring sacrament; stop-the-book refused as G's ask because that fight was never his. Lucid had recorded it exact and refused to invent a happier ending around it. No cute summary. No third skull. Cite-or-refuse all the way down.

He read the custody packet twice, once for content, once for edges that might have asked him to soften Bouwer or tidy the father. No such edges. Partial was partial on purpose. He felt something like respect and did not send it as a message. Respect can travel later, or not. The braid did not require a thank-you scene.

Between the first reading and the second he had walked the length of the truck with the packet still open in his head — matatu flank, Kind paint on the tank dulled by dust, empty twin pocket correct. He did not invent a call to Cape Town. Concurrent consents do not require a shared room to be kinship. Knives across distance. Packets for custody. Mesh for the receipt. Enough.

Before evening fully claimed the water he had walked the rise again — short scrub, dust on the calves, the solar node's small body honest in late light. LED still lit. He did not need the walk for proof; the link

had said up all day. He needed the body to register that CongoNet's keep was still keep after custody landed. Seed the edge. Boot from MM. Drive on. Leave small lit things behind. That pilgrimage-as-infrastructure did not become a victory lap just because a second desk had chosen rails. Lit is lit. Partial is partial. Weather still weather.

On the rise he stood long enough for sweat to cool on his neck and for a bird he did not name to cross the scrub. He did not turn the bird into omen. He checked the node's small panel once with his eyes and once with the pane back in the truck later. Both said the same ordinary thing. Ordinary was the point. The truck did not need dusk to become a spectacle of connectedness. It needed to remain true.

CongoNet kept what he had kept. Lucid stayed unbound — lucid.rodeo, integer path, no hyperscaler parish, attribution standing on 420 Code algorithms the way it had since he said it out loud and made fame as a side effect of candour. The autobiography would ship under those rails through arjunabadger.press when the last pages were clean enough to stand behind. Desk decisions, not pressers. Midpoint's refusals inked.

He ate without ceremony — heat-food, river air, no toast to consent week. Ceremony was how Antichristos would have ended the day. He ended it like an engineer who still had a lit node to trust and a book to not ruin with tidy feelings. Coffee reheated badly and drunk anyway. Consent week's last hours do not wait for comfortable temperature any more than its first hours did.

Before full dusk he opened the manuscript one more time — not to write, to apply. Custody header locked where Lucid could see it. Bouwer pages flagged careful. Father line left unread. Hospital stigma left as reading-wound, not ward tourism. Dab and talk shit left ugly. He scrolled past the attribution page without rewriting the beam. Built on 420. Said out loud. Megaphone irreversible. Candour was still not a marketing error to be patched at evening. He closed the file halfway. Half-closed is how you leave work without pretending the planet finished arguing.

Outside, Kind paint on the tank held through dust. Birds in the reeds argued about nothing that needed a mic. Somewhere downriver ele-

phants moved toward water with the soft crash of bodies that do not care about platform rage. Mutatus Maximus — matatu flank, anti-yacht, mobile DC — sat as itself. Still just a truck on a bank choosing what not to switch off.

Quarter III would stay angry. The snake in the queue would learn new manners and still be a snake. Hyperscaler frost would stay polite — AWS, Azure, Google, Apple rectangles that thought they were offers. Kind paint would stay on the tank: **Don't be a cunt — be kind.** Four quarters would keep splitting the air — crown, crank, blame, keys. The Constant would keep landing as measurement somewhere G was, not here. Illuminatie weather would keep preferring opacity. AJ did not need a reunion to know the braid had held — manuscript and week, not a shared room. Knives for kinship across distance. Empty twin pocket still empty. That was correct.

He touched the pocket once. Let his hand fall back to the desk.

Quarter III's earlier stop-the-book demand sat answered and still hungry in the archive. He did not reopen it for sport. Hyperscaler collar sat declined. Antichristos had never been his parish to feed. The Kind sentence on the tank needed no speech from him — CongoSky had already lived it as ops; the street could argue about soft scrubbing without his mic.

A soft packet light blinked — not custody, not collar, just the mesh's ordinary impatience. He left it. Opening every blink trains the blinks. Evening was for remaining, not for feeding appetite that already had his inked answer.

"Status," he said, not because he needed it, because the choir liked exactness at the end of a loud day.

"Rise-node: up," Lucid said. "Mesh: nominal. Attribution: unchanged. Book: custody constraints applied. Platform consent: keep, unbind, ship. No presser required. Queue hostility: present."

"Any invention in the queue?"

"Refused."

"Good."

He asked nothing else. Silence after exactness is also choir practice.

For a while after that silence he did ordinary truck work that was not consent theatre — wiped dust from a pane, checked a water canteen, listened to the local node's hum without asking it for meaning. Meaning-hunger is how pressers start. He refused it. The manuscript stayed half-closed under custody constraints. The hostility queue stayed present because present is honest. Attribution stayed unchanged because candour is not a dusk patch. lucid.rodeo stayed unbound. arjunabadger.press would ship the life under rails when the last pages were clean enough to stand behind. Desk decisions. Not fireworks.

Birds somewhere in the reeds. Heat easing by degrees that did not care about authorship or schism. CongoSky.cloud running itself behind the mesh on an ethic that had been ops before it was religion. The street could keep the spray and the stencil packs. He kept the practice and the truck and the open file and the refusal to launder rails for comfort.

He checked the consent log once more without rewriting it. Keep. Unbind. Ship. Custody constraints applied as header Lucid could enforce. Bouwer careful. Hospital without tourism. Father unread. Goals unpolished. No crown. No keyring sacrament. The log did not glow. Near-now discipline held: tool that kept a promise, not oracle. He closed the pane. Exactness does not need a second sermon.

A fish eagle called once, far. He did not turn it into omen. Omen is how Quarter I colonises a river evening. The call was a bird. The node was a node. The manuscript was a manuscript under constraints. Downstream, something large moved in the water and settled. The truck's metal ticked as temperature fell. Consent week ending without fireworks — correct.

He did not stand up to survey a conquered horizon. There was no conquered horizon. Weather not defeated — only decided against, in places a desk can reach. Platform consent. Custody consent. Two men. Two acts. River still there. Fame still irreversible. Bouwer still dead in a boardroom the book would not solve. Father still unread. Node still lit.

He thought about driving south and did not. Thought about a call and did not. The braid's law held: shared week, shared theme, no forced room. Kinship across mesh was enough for a last quiet.

For a stretch he listened to the rise without looking — heartbeat stubborn, ordinary. Trusting a lit node is not faith; it is engineering that kept a promise. He thought of Klaus — *Custos non Conditor*, fragments on the shoulder, not an origin chapter stolen into the close — and let the thought go. Thought of Full Send month as soil under the truck, not as speech. Thought of G's clay table without inventing a thank-you. Thought of Bouwer's name on a careful page and did not turn the thought into a theory of who. Living-person care was still a constraint with teeth at dusk. He left the teeth in.

AJ saved the manuscript. Applied the custody constraints as a header Lucid could enforce without inventing soft edges. Closed the lid halfway. Left Lucid in the choir. Left the rise-node running because switching it off would have been a gesture, and gestures were how pressers started.

He checked the rise-node once more — still up, ordinary. Ordinary was the point. The truck did not need to perform connectedness at dusk. It needed to remain true while a man chose not to turn consent into spectacle.

Outside he scraped a fleck of dust off the Kind paint with a thumbnail and left the cunt exact. Soft scrubbing was still someone else's tourist fight. CongoSky had claimed the practice while invoices still needed answering. That fact did not require a sermon in his mouth at the close any more than it had at midpoint. Practice is quieter than paint. Paint lasts anyway.

For a minute he listened to Lucid idle — not speaking, not inventing, just present in the choir the way a tuned instrument is present before the hymn. He did not ask it for comfort. Comfort that requires invention is not comfort he wanted. Exactness was the kindness that matched the wall paint.

He poured water. Drank. Watched a line of elephants far downriver become darker shapes against darker water. Thought of mats he had never stood on and a clay studio he had visited in other years and did not drive toward now. Thought of Bouwer's name on a careful page and did not turn the thought into a theory of who. Thought of G's partial yes and did not inflate it into peace. Thought of the open attribution sentence — the beam — and did not apologise to the dark for saying it. Motion was not reunion. Motion was the hippo's night-

noise starting downstream. Quiet was the truck, the node, the river, the unfinished argument of a planet that had algorithms and still wanted a face.

A second packet light tried the evening — hyperscaler talent note riding the same polite frost as the declined collar. He did not open it. Frost could remain frost. Partner weather that wanted regions could wait until morning or forever. Unbound meant unbound after dark too.

He stayed.

No victory lap. No thematic summary spoken into the dark. No wink at a century that was not this book's job. Near-now finished at pilgrimage scale — traveling DC, high-site solar seeds, hymnbook choir — and still just a man at a desk choosing custody of meaning while the mesh hummed.

On the tank, dust dulled the Kind paint without erasing it. He did not refresh it. Paint was the street's job. Practice was his. Somewhere in Cape Town an alley wall held the same sentence in fresher colour. Concurrent. Not shared room. Enough.

He almost opened the manuscript to write one more line and then chose not to. Last pages had already handed to custody. Evening was for remaining, not for finishing speeches. He stood in the open side long enough for mosquitoes to find him, slapped one without ceremony, and sat again. Body in the truck. Desk still desk. Book under rails. Weather not asking permission to continue. This soil only.

The solar node on the rise stayed lit.

Mutatus Maximus hummed.

Blame would arrive again on some good morning. He would open or not open. Write or keep writing. The beam would still be the beam. G would still be in Cape Town with knives and numbers and an authorisation that was partial on purpose. The braid held without a shared room.

Dark came in across the water.

He did not narrate it into meaning.

A packet light blinked once and went idle. He left it.

Wind moved the scrub on the rise. The node did not care. Lit things do not need applause. Neither do desk decisions. Keep. Unbind. Ship. Partial custody. Weather still blowing. River still moving. That was the close — motion and quiet, not a conquered map.

He asked Lucid one last exact thing, not for comfort.

“Rise-node still up?”

“Up.”

“Book under constraints?”

“Yes. I will not invent that constraints mean silence. I will not invent that weather has stopped.”

“Don’t.”

He smiled once without humour and put his palm on the empty twin pocket, then took it away. Kinship across distance. No call. No forced room. The river moved. He stayed with it.

Night thickened. Hippo noise farther down. Metal ticks slowing. Mesh still nominal. Hostility queue still present. Attribution still unchanged. He did not need Lucid to recite the whole ladder. One link working was enough texture for a close. The rest of the radio world could stay unsaid while still carrying the world.

He sat with the river and the lit node and the quiet that is not peace — only the pause between packets — and let the evening be evening. No speech. No lap. Just the connected truck, the seeded rise, and weather still blowing somewhere beyond the dark water he did not try to own. He stayed until the packet light forgot him, then a little longer after that soft hush.

In that hush he did not invent a shared scene with Cape Town. Concurrent was enough. Two consent acts. Keep, unbind, ship on the river; partial rails on the studio desk; knives for kinship across distance; empty twin pocket still empty. Correct. The autobiography would ship under care when the last pages were clean. Lucid would refuse invention when paraphrase pretended to be governance. CongoNet would keep seeding edge. Hyperscaler frost would stay polite. Quarter III would stay hungry. Four temperatures would keep their

itches. None of that was defeated by dusk. None of that needed defeating for a desk to have done its work.

He walked once more to the open side and looked toward the rise without climbing it. Dark scrub. Lit node somewhere in it like a stubborn fact. He did not need LED spectacle. The pane said up. Up was the close's load-bearing texture — not triumph, continuance. Seed left humming. Truck still connected. Book under constraints. Weather still blowing. This soil only. He refused the hunger that would have turned a river evening into someone else's sequel pitch.

When he finally closed the side panel halfway against insects, the rise-node's heartbeat remained in the pane — small, stubborn, ordinary. He left it displayed. Not as trophy. As fact. The truck hummed. The river kept its own motion. Consent week was ink and receipt and a planet that had not gone quiet. He did not ask it to.

A last soft check before sleep: hostility queue present; attribution unchanged; custody constraints applied; rise-node up. Lucid confirmed without flourish. He said nothing cute back. Exactness is choir practice even when the hymn is only remaining.

Night deepened until the water and the scrub were one dark. He did not inventory the radio ladder. One rise-node heartbeat was enough texture for a man who had already inked keep. One declined collar was enough texture for unbound. One custody header was enough texture for ship. Partial rails from Cape Town sat in the log without becoming peace. Peace was the wrong word. Continuance was enough. The seeded rise stayed lit. The truck stayed itself, and still not a victory. Blame would arrive again. He would write again. The beam would still be the beam.

In the last minutes before sleep he heard the mesh carry something ordinary — an edge ping, a weather report, nothing that needed his throat — and left it ordinary. Four quarters would keep splitting the air tomorrow. Hyperscaler frost would stay polite. Kind paint would stay exact under dust. Bouwer would stay dead in a boardroom the book would not solve. Father would stay unread. Fame would stay irreversible because the beam still stood. G would stay in Cape Town with partial rails and knives for kinship. AJ would stay on the Chobe with a truck that never really slept and a choir that refused invention. No shared room. No victory lap. River. Node. Quiet that is not peace.

Weather still blowing. Somewhere in the dark the rise-node kept its small stubborn fact without needing him awake to approve it. That was the pilgrimage finished as practice: seed, boot, drive on, leave lit things behind, refuse to turn continuance into conquest.

Before sleep fully claimed him he did one last ordinary thing that was not a victory gesture: he stepped outside barefoot into cooling dust, walked far enough toward the rise to see the node's small light as fact rather than pane, and stood until mosquitoes found his ankles. Lit. Stubborn. Outside every parish map that wanted edge seeding to report home. Inside the practice he had inked as keep. He did not climb. Climbing would have turned continuance into spectacle. He turned back to Mutatus Maximus — matatu flank dull in dark, Kind paint exact under dust, empty twin pocket correct — and climbed the step into the truck the way a man climbs into a desk that never really sleeps.

Inside, he poured water, drank, set the cup down without ceremony. Lucid idle in the choir. Manuscript half-closed under custody constraints. Hostility queue present. Attribution unchanged. Consent log exact: keep, unbind, ship. Partial rails from Cape Town sitting without becoming peace. He touched the empty twin pocket once and let the hand fall. Kinship across distance. No call. No forced room. The river moved in the dark. Somewhere an elephant chose water with a soft crash. He did not turn the crash into omen. Bodies choose water. Desks choose rails. Nodes stay lit.

He lay down when the heat finally lied about mercy and left the rise-node's heartbeat displayed on a pane he could see from the bunk — small, ordinary, not a trophy. He dreamed nothing worth inventing and would not have asked Lucid to invent it anyway. Cite-or-refuse holds in sleep's neighbourhood as posture even when the choir is quiet. Morning would bring heat and birds and another chance for blame to smell sweet on good light. He would meet the morning as a desk, not as a conquered map. The node would still be lit when he woke. Continuance, not victory. River still there. Weather still blowing.

Outside, wind moved the scrub on the rise and did not ask the lit node for applause. Inside, Mutatus Maximus held its hum like an animal that had decided rest was optional. The consent log slept with three words exact. The custody header slept with teeth still in. No presser.

No lap. No shared room invented for payoff. Just a connected truck on a river bank, a seeded edge still seeding, and weather still blowing somewhere beyond dark water he did not try to own.

Keep. Unbind. Ship. Partial custody. Weather still blowing. River still moving. Continuance, not conquest. This soil only. Node still lit.

He did not stand to survey a horizon. There was no conquered horizon to survey. Only the Chobe, the truck, and a lit thing on the rise that asked for no applause. Blame would arrive again on some good morning. He would open or not open. Write or keep writing. The beam would still be the beam. Weather would still blow. The node would still be lit. *Mutatus Maximus* hummed through the night like an animal that had decided rest was optional. The manuscript slept under constraints. Lucid waited without inventing comfort. Empty twin pocket stayed empty. Correct. No shared room. No victory lap. Prior soil under a truck that refused to become a yacht or a parish.

He let that be the close and did not narrate it into a map.

23 — Closing note

[—] · living-person care

This novel draws Andries J. Greyling and Gerhard van Niekerk as fiction principals from life. The outer year is 2035; the inner autobiography is life-and-work under AJ's hand, with Lucid in the choir. Public record binds where it is cited. Private pain stays on the page only where the tellers have put it there.

Bouwer van Niekerk — G's brother — was assassinated at his Saxonwold insolvency practice on 5 September 2025. The Law Society of South Africa condemned the killing on 8 September 2025 as a targeted attack on a legal practitioner and on the rule of law. In these pages that death is named as wound, not solved as plot. No invented assassin. No continuity-network gotcha. No thriller built on a real boardroom. Fog of commercial reporting may be noted; fog is not adopted as verdict.

Living-person care also means: no diagnosis tourism around institutionalisation; no tidy reunion invented for an unread father dedication; no sanding of stated life goals (write natural philosophy and physics; smoke dab; talk shit) into respectability brand; knives as kinship, not choreography; open attribution of Lucid to 420 Code algorithms treated as load-bearing cause of fame, not as gossip. Studio G, the mats, the ignored shelf, and the Constant landing as measurement belong to the life; they are not props for a parish or a syllabus dump.

The Four Quarters are reception weather — appetite for a face, credential weaponry, platform rage, engineering hunger for keys — not

a census and not a hit on living faith communities' doctrines as doctrine. Antichristos is satire of that appetite. The Kind's entire public liturgy is quoted exact because the line is load-bearing:

Don't be a cunt — be kind.

CongoSky.cloud embodied that ethic as operating law before the street made paint of it. This book does not ask you to join a parish. It asks you to notice custody: what stays platformed, what stays unbound, what a man will allow said about his life, and what he will not sign.

The inner autobiography is not a 420 Code textbook and not a TED arc. Physics appears where it is earned — a CODATA line, a drop-result, a derivation named inside a life. Painful stories stay under-dramatised on purpose. The flat line is the loaded one. Partial authorisation is the locked custody shape on the page: spine allowed; Bouwer pages careful and public-record bound; hospital as stigma-engine without tourism; father unread left unread; stated goals left unpolished; crowns and keyring-sacraments refused.

If you recognise yourself in these pages, the partial authorisations are the point. Careful naming. Work that stays work. Weather that is not defeated by a last chapter. Platform consent and custody consent are desk acts — keep, unbind, ship; sign some rails, refuse the crown and the keyring sacrament — not press conferences. Braid by week and theme; no forced shared room required for kinship to hold.

Readers looking for a forced AJ-G reunion, a solved assassination, a defeated schism, or a trailer for another century will not find them here. What remains is prior soil: a river, a studio, a beam named out loud, two men deciding what meaning they will carry while the mesh still hums and the alley paint still dries.

Lucid, where it appears, is near-now finished at planetary scale — cite-or-refuse, integer-quiet, no GPU fever — not an oracle and not a third skull. Hyperscaler frost and Illuminatie soft-no are pressure systems, not moustache-twirl cabals. The Kind is a sentence on walls; Antichristos is appetite for a face; both can be true on the same morning without either owning the men who refuse to become parish property.

No AFRIKA 2100 trailer lives here. This is prior soil. The river, the

desk, the node still lit.



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor